



LEA FAKA-TONGA

TONGAN LANGUAGE COURSE

First

Edition

52 CHAPTERS

Beginner to Advanced

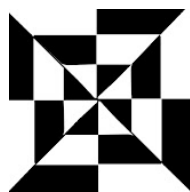
GRAMMAR · VOCABULARY · EXERCISES

ANDREW JOAKIM

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Lea Faka-Tonga

BASIC LEVEL

Andrew Joakim

Lea Faka-Tonga · Basic Level

Andrew Joakim

First edition, 2026

A grammar-driven introduction to the Tongan language, drawing
on Churchward's *Tongan Grammar* and Shumway's *Intensive Course*
in Tongan.

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Introduction

A lot of people spend years meaning to learn Tongan and never quite begin. The wanting is rarely the problem. What is missing is a place to start, and a way to keep going after the first week, once the motivation that got you going has worn off.

That is what this book is for. It is written for someone learning on their own, at the kitchen table or on a phone, with no class to go to and nobody in the room to ask. It starts at the beginning and adds one new thing at a time.

Built on Churchward and Shumway

Nearly everything reliable that has been written about how Tongan works traces back to two books. C. Maxwell Churchward's *Tongan Grammar* came out in London in 1953 and is still the grammar that scholars reach for. Eric Shumway's *Intensive Course in Tongan*, written a generation later, turned that grammar into lessons and drills for students who wanted to speak.

This book leans on both, and the patterns in it are drawn from their work and checked against it. What it does differently is the explaining. Churchward is exact but written for the linguist, and rough going if grammar is not your world.

Shumway is warmer but moves fast, often handing you a pattern without much of the why. The plan here is to go deeper than Shumway and use plainer words than Churchward, and to lay it all out for someone working through it alone.

A living language

Both of those books are decades old, and Tongan has not stood still since. A few of the words Churchward wrote down are rarely used now, or only by older people. Shumway still counts money in shillings, which Tonga dropped more than fifty years ago for the pa'anga. He also teaches that the plural of 'alu ("go") is *ō*, which is a real rule, so this book teaches it too. But spend any time around Tongan speakers and you will hear 'alu used for the plural just as often, as in *Tau 'alu?* ("Shall we go?"). Both are right.

That is not a knock on either book. It is just what happens to any book about a language people are still speaking and changing every day. This one is meant to keep up.

Fifty-two chapters, one year

There are fifty-two chapters, one for each week of the year. Do a chapter a week and you finish in twelve months.

The order is the point. Chapter 1 hands you a three-word sentence, and every chapter after it adds one more piece on top of what you can already say. A harder idea never lands cold, because the grammar under it was put in place a few chapters back, while you weren't really watching. The language opens up a little at a time, until the grammar behind real conversation is just the next small step instead of a wall.

That is the whole idea: turn "someday" into something you can put on a calendar. You do not have to find a class or wait until life is less busy. A chapter a week, and a year from now you will be saying real things in Tongan instead of still meaning to learn.

Free, on paper or on screen

The book is free, and it will always be free. You can download the whole thing as a PDF or an EPUB and keep it, with no account to make and nothing to pay. Every chapter is on the website to read as well, and the website is where the practice lives: drills, quizzes, vocabulary cards you can flip, exercises you tap through and check as you go, and a builder for putting your own sentences together. If you learn more by doing than by reading, that is where to spend your time.

Turning two dense old textbooks into fifty-two plain-language chapters, and building the website and its practice on top of that, took a long time. All of it is free. If it has helped you and you want to chip in toward keeping it going, you can do that on the website. You never have to, and it makes a real difference when people do.

A book the community keeps

A language belongs to the people who speak it, and a book about it should answer to them too. This one is meant to be corrected. When you find a word nobody really uses anymore, an example no Tongan would actually say, or a flat-out mistake, you can send it in through the website. You can ask a question there too, or tell us how you say something yourself, which is often where the best corrections come from. Real input from real speakers gets folded back into the book, and the next reader's copy is better for it.

It is also unfinished, on purpose. There is more to add and plenty still to get right, and the book will keep changing as people who know the language bring what they know to it. Treat it as something the community keeps building, the same way the language itself stays alive: by being used, questioned, and corrected by the people it belongs to.

Your first words of Tongan are right here. *Tau 'alu?* Shall we go?

Chapter 1: The Basic Sentence

This chapter introduces a three-part sentence pattern (tense marker, pronoun, verb) and shows you how to use it to make statements and ask questions about past actions. The sentence *Na'á ke kai?* (“Did you eat?”) is your first example of this pattern in action.

The Pattern

Na'á ke kai?

Did you eat?

Na'á ku kai.

I ate.

These two sentences show the basic pattern for this chapter: a tense marker, a pronoun, and a verb, always in that order. You will build on this pattern and learn others as the book progresses.

What a Verb Is

Look at the word *kai* in the sentence *Na’á ku kai*. It tells you what the action is: eating. A word that tells you what someone does, feels, or experiences is called a **verb**.

Here are some verbs you will use:

Tongan	English
<i>kai</i>	eat
<i>inu</i>	drink
<i>’alu</i>	go
<i>ha’u</i>	come
<i>mohe</i>	sleep
<i>lea</i>	speak
<i>hiva</i>	sing
<i>nofo</i>	stay, sit, live
<i>lele</i>	run
<i>ako</i>	study, learn
<i>foki</i>	return, go back
<i>tangi</i>	cry, weep

In English, verbs change form to show when something happened: “eat” becomes “ate,” “go” becomes “went,” “sleep” becomes “slept.” The verb itself is different each time. In Tongan, the verb never changes. *Kai* is always *kai*. It can mean “eat,” “ate,” “eating,” or “eaten,” depending on the tense marker in front of it. *Inu* is always *inu*: “drink,” “drank,” “drinking,” or “drunk.” Whether the action happened yesterday, is happening now, or will happen tomorrow, the verb looks exactly the same.

Na’á ku kai.

I ate.

Kai did not become something else the way English “eat” became “ate.” The verb stayed the same. A separate word placed before it handled the job of showing that the action happened in the past. That separate word is the tense marker, explained in the next section.

What a Tense Marker Is

A **tense marker** is a word that tells you when an action happened. In English, you change the verb itself to show time: “eat” becomes “ate.” In Tongan, the verb stays the same and a tense marker does that job instead. In the pattern you are learning, the tense marker is placed before the verb.

This chapter introduces one tense marker: *na’a*. It marks the past tense, meaning the action already happened.

Na’a always comes first in this pattern.

Na’a ke kai.

You ate. (Lit. “Past you eat.”)

The literal translation shows how the three parts line up. *Na’a* = past. *Ke* = you. *Kai* = eat. In this pattern, the tense marker comes first, then who did it, then what they did.

Note:

Tongan has a second past tense marker, *na’e*, used when no pronoun follows directly. You will learn it in Chapter 9: The Negative. Every past tense sentence you build will use *na’a* followed by a pronoun.

What a Pronoun Is

A **pronoun** is a word that takes the place of a name. Instead of saying “Sione ate,” you can say “he ate.” The word “he” is a pronoun.

Tongan has two types of pronouns. A preposed pronoun comes before the verb and tells you who is doing the action. A postposed pronoun follows the verb or

another key word in the sentence, rather than coming before it. You will learn postposed pronouns in Chapter 5: Commands and Emphasis.

The two preposed pronouns you will use are:

Tongan	English
<i>ke</i>	you (one person)
<i>ku</i>	I

In this pattern, the preposed pronoun goes between the tense marker and the verb. It tells you who did the action. The person doing the action is called the **subject**.

Ku is the form of “I” used only after the past tense marker *na’a*. Other tense markers use different forms of “I.” You will learn those in Chapter 2: Tense Markers and Pronouns.

Building Sentences

The pattern has three parts in a fixed order:

na’a + pronoun + verb

Change the pronoun to change who did the action. Change the verb to change what was done. The tense marker stays the same.

Na’a ku kai.

I ate.

Na’a ku inu.

I drank.

Na’a ke inu.

You drank.

Here is the full set of combinations. Every cell in the table follows the same pattern.

	<i>kai</i>	<i>inu</i>	<i>'alu</i>	<i>ha'u</i>	<i>mohe</i>	<i>lea</i>	<i>hiva</i>
	(eat)	(drink)	(go)	(come)	(sleep)	(speak)	(sing)
<i>ku</i>	<i>Na'á</i>	<i>Na'á</i>	<i>Na'á</i>	<i>Na'á</i>	<i>Na'á</i>	<i>Na'á</i>	<i>Na'á</i>
(I)	<i>ku kai.</i>	<i>ku inu.</i>	<i>ku 'alu.</i>	<i>ku</i> <i>ha'u.</i>	<i>ku</i> <i>mohe.</i>	<i>ku lea.</i>	<i>ku</i> <i>hiva.</i>
<i>ke</i>	<i>Na'á</i>	<i>Na'á</i>	<i>Na'á</i>	<i>Na'á ke</i>	<i>Na'á ke</i>	<i>Na'á</i>	<i>Na'á ke</i>
(you)	<i>ke kai.</i>	<i>ke inu.</i>	<i>ke 'alu.</i>	<i>ha'u.</i>	<i>mohe.</i>	<i>ke lea.</i>	<i>hiva.</i>

The same pattern works with the five additional verbs:

	<i>nofo</i>	<i>lele</i>	<i>ako</i>	<i>foki</i>	<i>tangi</i>
	(stay)	(run)	(study)	(return)	(cry)
<i>ku</i>	<i>Na'á ku</i>	<i>Na'á ku</i>	<i>Na'á ku</i>	<i>Na'á ku</i>	<i>Na'á ku</i>
(I)	<i>nofo.</i>	<i>lele.</i>	<i>ako.</i>	<i>foki.</i>	<i>tangi.</i>
<i>ke</i>	<i>Na'á ke</i>	<i>Na'á ke</i>	<i>Na'á ke</i>	<i>Na'á ke</i>	<i>Na'á ke</i>
(you)	<i>nofo.</i>	<i>lele.</i>	<i>ako.</i>	<i>foki.</i>	<i>tangi.</i>

Na'á ku nofo.

I stayed.

Na'á ke lele?

Did you run?

Na'á ku ako.

I studied.

Na'á ku foki.

I returned.

Na'á ke tangi?

Did you cry?

Asking Questions

In this pattern, you form a yes/no question the simplest way possible: say the same sentence with a rising voice at the end. The words do not change. Only your intonation changes.

Na'á ke kai. ↘

You ate.

Na'á ke kai? ↗

Did you eat?

A typical exchange follows this pattern:

Na'á ke kai? ↗

Did you eat?

'Io, na'á ku kai. ↘

Yes, I ate.

'Io (yes) is the standard Tongan word for “yes.” To answer “no,” use *'ikai*.

Na'á ke inu? ↗

Did you drink?

'Ikai, na'á ku mohe. ↘

No, I slept.

Note: *'Ikai* as a full negative sentence pattern is taught in Chapter 9: The Negative. Use it simply to mean “no” when answering a question.

Pronunciation: **Na’a** + Pronoun

In Tongan, stress normally falls on the second-to-last vowel of a word. You can hear this in the verbs you already know: *móhe*, *híva*, *lé-a*.

When *na’a* is followed by a pronoun like *ke* or *ku*, the two words are pronounced as if they were one. As Shumway puts it, “the accent falls as though the combination were one word, on the next to the last syllable.”

Say *na’a ku* as one unit: na-’a-ku. Where does the stress go? Count back to the second-to-last vowel of the combined unit. That vowel is the second *a* of *na’a*. The same applies to *na’a ke*: na-’a-ke, stress on the second *a*.

Words like *ke* and *ku* that attach to the word before them this way are called **enclitics**. The term comes from a Greek word meaning “to lean on.” An enclitic is a small grammatical word that cannot carry its own stress, so it leans on the word before it. Because the enclitic adds a syllable to the combined unit, the normal stress rule (second-to-last vowel) lands in a new place: what was the last vowel of the original word.

Both *ke* and *ku* are enclitics, along with several other preposed pronouns. You will meet more enclitics as the book progresses.

Throughout this book, an acute accent (´) on the tense marker shows where the stress falls in these combinations. You will see a full explanation of this convention in Chapter 2: Tense Markers and Pronouns.

Practice saying these out loud:

Na’a ku kai. (stress: na-’a-ku kai) *Na’a ke kai?* (stress: na-’a-ke kai)

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>na’a</i>	past tense marker	marks an action as past
<i>ku</i>	preposed pronoun: I (after <i>na’a</i>)	I

Tongan	Function	English
<i>ke</i>	preposed pronoun: you (after <i>na'a</i>)	you
<i>'io</i>	affirmative response	yes
<i>'ikai</i>	negative response	no

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>kai</i>	verb	eat
<i>inu</i>	verb	drink
<i>'alu</i>	verb	go
<i>ha'u</i>	verb	come
<i>mohe</i>	verb	sleep
<i>lea</i>	verb	speak
<i>hiva</i>	verb	sing
<i>nofo</i>	verb	stay, sit, live
<i>lele</i>	verb	run
<i>ako</i>	verb	study, learn
<i>foki</i>	verb	return, go back
<i>tangi</i>	verb	cry, weep

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English

1. *Na'a ke 'alu?*
2. *Na'a ku kai.*

3. *Na'á ke inu?*
4. *Na'á ku mohe.*
5. *Na'á ke lea?*

Exercise 2: Translate English to Tongan

1. I drank.
2. Did you eat?
3. I went.
4. Did you sleep?
5. I sang.

Exercise 3: Answer the question

Answer each question in Tongan using *ku* (I). Follow the model.

Model: *Na'á ke kai?* → *'Io, na'á ku kai.*

1. *Na'á ke inu?*
2. *Na'á ke mohe?*
3. *Na'á ke 'alu?*
4. *Na'á ke hiva?*
5. *Na'á ke lea?*

Exercise 4: Fill in the blank

Complete each sentence with the correct pronoun (*ke* or *ku*).

1. *Na'a* __ *kai.* (I ate.)
2. *Na'a* __ *inu?* (Did you drink?)
3. *Na'a* __ *mohe.* (I slept.)
4. *Na'a* __ *lea?* (Did you speak?)
5. *Na'a* __ *ha'u.* (I came.)

Answers**Exercise 1**

1. Did you go?

2. I ate.
3. Did you drink?
4. I slept.
5. Did you speak?

Exercise 2

1. *Na'á ku inu.*
2. *Na'á ke kai?*
3. *Na'á ku 'alu.*
4. *Na'á ke mohe?*
5. *Na'á ku hiva.*

Exercise 3

1. *'Io, na'á ku inu.*
2. *'Io, na'á ku mohe.*
3. *'Io, na'á ku 'alu.*
4. *'Io, na'á ku hiva.*
5. *'Io, na'á ku lea.*

Exercise 4

1. *ku*
 2. *ke*
 3. *ku*
 4. *ke*
 5. *ku*
-

Chapter 2: Tense Markers and Pronouns

Building on Chapter 1, this chapter expands the tense marker + pronoun + verb pattern by introducing the remaining three tense markers and the full set of preposed pronoun forms.

Three New Tense Markers

So far, the only tense marker you have seen is *na'a*, which marks the past tense in the pattern: tense marker + pronoun + verb. Tongan has three more tense markers. Each one fills the same opening slot in this pattern. Swap in a different marker and the tense changes; the pronoun and verb stay the same. Later, you will see tense markers appear in other positions within longer sentences, but this core pattern remains the foundation.

Present: 'oku

'Okú ke kai.

You eat.

'Oku marks the present tense. Its meaning depends on the type of verb that follows it. With action verbs like *kai* (eat), *'alu* (go), or *mohe* (sleep), *'oku* carries a habitual sense: you do this regularly, not necessarily at this exact moment. With descriptive or feeling words (covered in Chapter 3: Descriptive Words), *'oku* describes a current state rather than a habit. The verbs in this chapter are all action verbs, so for now, read *'oku* as habitual.

'Okú ke mohe.

You sleep. (You regularly sleep.)

'Oku ou kai.

I eat. (Something I do regularly, not “I am eating right now.”)

Tongan also has ways to say that an action is happening right now, in progress at this moment (“I am eating” rather than “I eat”), using an extra word before the verb. Those constructions are covered in a later chapter. For now, read *'oku* with an action verb as habitual, and focus on the building blocks of the simple pattern: tense marker + pronoun + verb.

Future: te

Té ke 'alu.

You will go.

Te marks the future tense. Use it for actions that have not happened yet.

Té ke kai.

You will eat.

Note:

Tongan has a second future marker, *'e*, used when no pronoun follows directly (for example with a noun subject). You will learn it in Chapter 9: The Negative. Every future sentence in this chapter uses *te* followed by a pronoun.

Perfect: kuo

Kuó ke kai.

You have eaten.

Kuo marks the perfect tense. Where *na'a* simply places an event in the past, *kuo* tells the listener that a new situation exists. The speaker is drawing attention to the fact that things were not this way before.

Compare:

'Okú ke mohe.

You sleep. (A general statement about what you do.)

Kuó ke mohe.

You have fallen asleep. (You were awake before. Now you are asleep.)

Na'á ke mohe.

You slept. (A past event, with no comment on the present.)

The difference between *kuo* and *na'a* matters. *Na'a* reports that something happened. *Kuo* says that because something happened, the situation is now different. The key question *kuo* answers is: what has changed?

This meaning extends even to ordinary verbs where you might not expect it.

Compare these two sentences:

Na'a nau mohe.

They slept. (Reports a past event.)

Kuo nau mohe.

They have fallen asleep. (They were awake before. Now they are asleep.)

The *na'a* sentence simply tells you something happened. The *kuo* sentence tells you the situation has changed. The same contrast works with *ha'u* (*come*):

Na'á ku ha'u.

I came. (A past event.)

Kuó u ha'u.

I have arrived. (I was not here before. Now I am here.)

Note:

This contrast extends to descriptive words like *ma’a* (*clean*). *’Oku ma’a* = it is clean (stating a fact); *Kuo ma’a* = it has become clean, implying it was not clean before. You will work with descriptive words formally in Chapter 3: Descriptive Words, but the principle applies to all uses of *kuo*.

The Four Tense Markers

You now have four tense markers for the same sentence pattern. The verb and pronoun stay the same in each sentence below. Only the opening marker changes.

Tense marker	Tense	Example	Translation
<i>na’a</i>	past	<i>Na’a ke kai.</i>	You ate.
<i>’oku</i>	present	<i>’Okú ke kai.</i>	You eat.
<i>kuo</i>	perfect	<i>Kuó ke kai.</i>	You have eaten.
<i>te</i>	future	<i>Té ke kai.</i>	You will eat.

The verb does not change form to show tense. Tongan does not add endings to verbs the way English does (“eat,” “ate,” “eaten”). The tense marker alone carries the tense.

Three Forms for “I”

Earlier, the word for “I” was *ku* after *na’a*. It takes a different form depending on which tense marker comes before it.

Tense marker	“I”	Example	Translation
<i>na’a</i>	<i>ku</i>	<i>Na’a ku kai.</i>	I ate.
<i>’oku</i>	<i>ou</i>	<i>’Oku ou kai.</i>	I eat.
<i>kuo</i>	<i>u</i>	<i>Kuó u kai.</i>	I have eaten.
<i>te</i>	<i>u</i>	<i>Té u kai.</i>	I will eat.

Ou is used after *’oku*. *U* is used after *kuo* and *te*. *Ku* remains the past tense form, used after *na’a*.

No other pronoun changes this way. Every other pronoun keeps the same form regardless of the tense marker.

More Pronouns

The previous chapter used two preposed pronouns: *ku/ou/u* for “I” and *ke* for “you” (one person). Tongan has a full set of preposed pronouns for different persons and numbers.

He, She, It: ne

Na’a ne kai.

He ate. / She ate.

Ne means “he,” “she,” or “it.” Tongan uses one pronoun for all three. It does not distinguish gender, and it uses the same form for people and things.

’Okú ne lea.

He speaks. / She speaks.

Té ne ’alu.

He will go. / She will go.

They (three or more): nau*Na'a nau kai.*

They ate.

Nau means “they,” referring to three or more people.*'Oku nau mohe.*

They sleep.

Two Kinds of “We”

English has one word for “we,” but it can mean two different things. Consider this situation. A student says to a teacher: “We really like you, Miss Smith, and we will miss you over the holiday.” The teacher is not part of that “we.” The student’s group excludes the person being spoken to. Now imagine the teacher replies: “Thank you, Billy. We are all going to miss each other.” The teacher and the students are all included in that “we.” The teacher’s group includes everyone in the conversation.

English leaves you to figure out which meaning is intended. Tongan does not. It has a separate pronoun for each.

Mau means “we, but not you.” This is the **exclusive** form: the speaker and their group are included, but the person or people being addressed are not.

Na'a mou kai?

Did you all eat?

Na'a mau kai.

We ate. (You were not part of it.)

The question uses *mou* (you all). The answer uses *mau* (we, not including you), because the person asking was not part of the group that ate. This is the student’s “we” from the example above.

Tau means “we, and you too.” This is the **inclusive** form: the speaker, the person or people being addressed, and anyone else involved are all included.

'Oku tau hiva.

We sing. (All of us, including you.)

The choice between *mau* and *tau* always depends on whether the person being addressed is part of the group. A question using *mou* (you all) does not automatically call for *mau* in response. The speaker chooses whichever pronoun fits the situation.

Tau Without a Tense Marker

When *tau* appears with no tense marker before it, it works as an invitation or suggestion.

Tau hiva?

Shall we sing?

Tau kai.

Let's eat.

This pattern also works with the verb *nofo* (stay, sit, live):

Tau nofo.

Let's stay.

Tau ō?

Shall we go?

Note: The verb *'alu* (go) has a plural form, *ō*, which is used when the subject is more than one person. This book teaches *ō* as the plural form, and Chapter 5: Commands and Emphasis covers it formally alongside *ō mai* (the plural of *ha'u*). In everyday Tongan, however, speakers use *'alu* freely with plural pronouns. *Tau 'alu?* is common and perfectly natural where you would expect *Tau ō?* Churchward treats *ō* as the correct plural form, and you will encounter it in formal speech and writing.

You (three or more): mou

Na'a mou kai?

Did you all eat?

Mou means “you” when speaking to three or more people.

Te mou hiva.

You all will sing.

Dual Pronouns

Tongan has a separate set of pronouns for exactly two people. English does not make this distinction. When talking about precisely two people, use the dual form. For three or more, use the plural.

	One	Two	Three or more
I / We (exclusive)	<i>ku, ou, u</i>	<i>ma</i>	<i>mau</i>
We (inclusive)	(none)	<i>ta</i>	<i>tau</i>
You	<i>ke</i>	<i>mo</i>	<i>mou</i>
He, she, it / They	<i>ne</i>	<i>na</i>	<i>nau</i>

Ta = we two (including you). *Ma* = we two (not including you). *Mo* = you two. *Na* = they two.

The inclusive/exclusive distinction works the same way as the plurals: *ta* includes the listener, *ma* does not.

Na’á ma kai.

We two ate. (Not you.)

’Okú mo lea.

You two speak.

Té na mohe.

They two will sleep.

Ta without a tense marker works the same way as *tau*:

Ta hiva?

Shall we (two) sing?

Inclusive “we” starts at two because it always includes at least the speaker and the listener.

The Complete Pronoun Table

Here is every preposed pronoun in Tongan.

	Singular	Dual (two)	Plural (three +)
I / We (exclusive)	<i>ku</i> (past), <i>ou</i> (present), <i>u</i> (perfect/future)	<i>ma</i>	<i>mau</i>
We (inclusive)	<i>te</i>	<i>ta</i>	<i>tau</i>
You	<i>ke</i>	<i>mo</i>	<i>mou</i>
He, she, it / They	<i>ne</i>	<i>na</i>	<i>nau</i>

Every pronoun fills the same position in this sentence pattern: after the tense marker, before the verb.

Note:

The inclusive singular pronoun *te* means “one” in the impersonal sense, as in English “one should always be kind.” Even in English, most speakers rarely use “one” this way, preferring “you” instead (“you should always be kind”). Tongan *te* works the same way: it refers to people in general, or serves as a modest way of saying “I.” It will not appear in the exercises in this chapter and is covered more fully in Chapter 51: Special Pronoun Uses. Do not confuse this pronoun *te* with the future tense marker *te*, which is a different word that occupies a different position in the sentence.

Pronunciation: Stress Across All Combinations

In the last chapter, you learned that *ke* and *ku* are enclitics, small words that lean on the tense marker before them so the two are pronounced as one unit, with stress falling on the second-to-last vowel of the combination. The same applies to every one-syllable pronoun paired with any tense marker.

In Tongan, every vowel is a separate syllable. The pronoun *u* is one syllable. So is *ke*, *ne*, *na*, *ma*, *ta*, and *mo*. But *ou* is two syllables (o-u), because it contains two vowels. Similarly, *mau*, *tau*, *mou*, and *nau* are each two syllables.

The one-syllable pronouns are all enclitics: they lean on the tense marker and the pair is pronounced as one unit, with the stress landing on the second-to-last vowel of the combination. The two-syllable pronouns stand on their own and do not shift the stress of the tense marker.

'Oku by itself has stress on the first vowel. Add the one-syllable enclitic *ne* and the stress shifts: *'okú ne* is pronounced as one unit with stress on the *u* of *'oku*.

Accent marks in this book

Throughout this book, an acute accent (´) marks where the stress falls when a tense marker joins with a one-syllable pronoun. This is a convention used in this book to help you hear the pronunciation; it is not part of standard Tongan spelling. You have already been seeing it in the examples above. The four accented forms are:

'okú before *ke*, *ne*, *na*, *ma*, *ta*, *mo* *kuó* before *u*, *ke*, *ne*, *na*, *ma*, *ta*, *mo* *na'á* before *ku*, *ke*, *ne*, *na*, *ma*, *ta*, *mo* *té* before *u*, *ke*, *ne*, *na*, *ma*, *ta*, *mo*

Compare these pairs. Each uses the same tense marker and verb, but swaps a one-syllable pronoun (accent, stress shifts) for a two-syllable pronoun (no accent, stress stays):

'Okú na lea. → *'Oku nau lea.* *Kuó ne kai.* → *Kuo nau kai.* *Na'á ke mohe.* → *Na'a mou mohe.* *Té ke kai.* → *Te mou kai.*

As you practice, the stress pattern will become natural. Focus on pronouncing each tense marker + one-syllable pronoun pair as a single smooth unit.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>'oku</i>	present tense marker	marks a present action/state
<i>te</i>	future tense marker	marks a future action
<i>kuo</i>	perfect tense marker	marks a completed action
<i>ou</i>	preposed pronoun: I (after <i>'oku</i>)	I
<i>u</i>	preposed pronoun: I (after <i>kuo, te</i>)	I
<i>ne</i>	preposed pronoun: he/she/it	he, she, it
<i>nau</i>	preposed pronoun: they (3 +)	they
<i>mau</i>	preposed pronoun: we exclusive (3 +)	we (not you)
<i>tau</i>	preposed pronoun: we inclusive (3 +)	we (and you)
<i>mou</i>	preposed pronoun: you (3 +)	you all
<i>ma</i>	preposed pronoun: we two exclusive	we two (not you)
<i>ta</i>	preposed pronoun: we two inclusive	we two (and you)
<i>mo</i>	preposed pronoun: you two	you two
<i>na</i>	preposed pronoun: they two	they two

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>ō</i>	verb	go (plural of <i>'alu</i>)

Exercises***Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English***

1. 'Oku ou lea.
2. Té ke kai.
3. Kuó ne mohe.
4. Na'a mau inu.
5. 'Oku nau hiva.
6. Té u ha'u.
7. Kuó ke inu.
8. Na'á ne lea.

Exercise 2: Translate English to Tongan

1. I will go.
2. She has eaten.
3. We (exclusive, three or more) sleep.
4. You (one person) spoke.
5. They (three or more) will sing.
6. I eat.
7. He has come.
8. You all (three or more) drank.

Exercise 3: Fill in the correct form of "I"

Complete each sentence with *ku*, *ou*, or *u*.

1. Na'a __ mohe.
2. 'Oku __ kai.
3. Te __ 'alu.
4. Kuo __ ha'u.
5. 'Oku __ lea.
6. Na'a __ hiva.

Exercise 4: Match the pronoun to its meaning

1. <i>ne</i>	a. we (inclusive, three +)
2. <i>mau</i>	b. you two
3. <i>tau</i>	c. they (three +)
4. <i>mo</i>	d. he / she / it
5. <i>nau</i>	e. we (exclusive, three +)
6. <i>ta</i>	f. we two (inclusive)
7. <i>na</i>	g. they two
8. <i>ma</i>	h. we two (exclusive)

Exercise 5: Suggestions with tau and ta

Translate into Tongan.

1. Shall we sing?
2. Let's eat.
3. Let's stay.
4. Shall we (two) speak?
5. Shall we go?

Exercise 6: Build the sentence

You are given a tense, a pronoun meaning, and a verb. Write the complete Tongan sentence.

1. Present + I + speak
 2. Future + you (one person) + eat
 3. Past + they (three or more) + sleep
 4. Perfect + he + go
 5. Present + we (inclusive, three +) + sing
 6. Future + we two (exclusive) + drink
 7. Past + you two + drink
 8. Perfect + I + eat
-

Answers

Exercise 1

1. I speak.
2. You will eat.
3. He/she has fallen asleep.
4. We (exclusive) drank.
5. They sing.
6. I will come.
7. You have drunk.
8. He/she spoke.

Exercise 2

1. *Té u 'alu.*
2. *Kuó ne kai.*
3. *'Oku mau mohe.*
4. *Na'á ke lea.*
5. *Te nau hiva.*
6. *'Oku ou kai.*
7. *Kuó ne ha'u.*
8. *Na'a mou inu.*

Exercise 3

1. *ku*
2. *ou*
3. *u*
4. *u*
5. *ou*
6. *ku*

Exercise 4

1. *d*
2. *e*

3. a
4. b
5. c
6. f
7. g
8. h

Exercise 5

1. *Tau hiva?*
2. *Tau kai.*
3. *Tau nofo.*
4. *Ta lea?*
5. *Tau 'alu?*

Exercise 6

1. *'Oku ou lea.*
2. *Té ke kai.*
3. *Na'a nau mohe.*
4. *Kuó ne 'alu.*
5. *'Oku tau hiva.*
6. *Té ma inu.*
7. *Na'á mo inu.*
8. *Kuó u kai.*

Chapter 3: Descriptive Words

This chapter expands the tense marker + pronoun + verb pattern by showing that the verb slot can hold more than action words. Descriptive words like *fiefia* (happy) and *hela'ia* (tired) fit that slot, modifiers like *lelei* (well) and *'aupito* (very) extend them, and verb-object compounds like *kai mā* (eat bread) form a single unit.

Adjectives in the Verb Slot

'Oku ou mālohi.

I am strong. (Lit. “Present I strong”)

'Oku ou vaivai.

I am weak. (Lit. “Present I weak”)

Both sentences follow the same pattern as *'Oku ou kai* (I eat): tense marker + pronoun + verb. But *fiefia* (happy) and *hela'ia* (tired) are not actions. They are **adjectives**: words that describe a quality or state. In English, adjectives typically

describe nouns (“a happy child,” “a strong person”). In Tongan, adjectives can also fill the verb position, which is the pattern taught in this chapter. Happy, tired, hungry, strong, angry are all adjectives.

In English, you need a helper verb to connect an adjective to its subject: “I **am** happy.” Tongan does not. The adjective goes directly into the verb position. In this pattern, there is no separate word for “am,” “is,” or “are.” The tense marker and the pronoun do the job on their own.

In Chapter 2: Tense Markers and Pronouns, you learned that *’oku* with action verbs like *kai* carries a habitual sense: *’Oku ou kai* means “I eat (regularly),” not “I am eating right now.” With adjectives, *’oku* works differently. *’Oku ou fiefia* means “I am happy” at this moment, not “I am generally a happy person.” The reason is straightforward: action verbs describe things you do, and doing something regularly is the unmarked case; adjectives describe states you are in, and a state is something you are in right now unless otherwise marked.

Grammatically, an adjective in the verb slot works exactly like a verb. Compare *na’á ku masiva* (I was poor) with *na’á ku ’alu* (I went): same tense marker, same pronoun, same position. The grammar treats them identically.

The word *fiekaia* (hungry) works the same way. Because adjectives function as verbs, they take any tense marker:

Tongan	English
<i>’Oku ou fiekaia.</i>	I am hungry.
<i>Na’á ku fiekaia.</i>	I was hungry.
<i>Kuó u fiekaia.</i>	I have become hungry.
<i>Té u fiekaia.</i>	I will be hungry.

With *kuo*, an adjective implies a change of state. *’Oku fiekaia* states a current condition. *Kuo fiekaia* means the person has become hungry: they were not hungry before.

Here are adjectives to use in the verb slot. All follow the pattern: tense marker + pronoun + adjective.

Word	Meaning
<i>fiefia</i>	happy
<i>hela'ia</i>	tired
<i>fiekaia</i>	hungry
<i>fieinua</i>	thirsty
<i>'ita</i>	angry
<i>vaivai</i>	weak
<i>masiva</i>	poor
<i>mālohi</i>	strong

'Okú ne 'ita.

He is angry.

Na'a mau vaivai.

We were weak.

Kuó ke mālohi.

You have become strong.

Modifiers

Na'á ku ngāue mālohi.

I worked hard.

A **modifier** (also called an adverb) is a word that adds detail to a verb or adjective. It tells you how, how much, or in what way something happens. In the sentence above, *mālohi* tells you how the work was done. The verb *ngāue* (*work*) is new in this chapter.

Tongan places most modifiers after the word they modify. Here are three common postposed modifiers:

Modifier	Meaning
<i>lelei</i>	well
<i>lahi</i>	much, a lot
<i>mālohi</i>	hard, strongly

'Oku ou hiva lelei.

I sing well.

Na'a mau kai lahi.

We ate a lot.

These modifiers work after adjectives in the verb slot too:

'Okú ne 'ita lahi.

He is very angry. (Lit. "He angry much")

Note:

The word *mālohi* has two uses. In the verb slot it means "strong" (*'Okú ne mālohi*, He is strong). After another verb it works as a modifier meaning "hard" or "strongly" (*Na'a ku ngāue mālohi*, I worked hard).

'Aupito

'Aupito (*very, extremely*) makes the meaning of the word before it stronger. It always comes last, after any other modifier.

'Oku ou hela'ia 'aupito.

I am very tired.

'Oku ou fiefia lahi 'aupito.

I am extremely happy.

In the second sentence, *lahi* and *'aupito* combine to form *lahi 'aupito* (very much, extremely). This combination always appears in this order. *'Aupito lahi* does not occur.

Na'á ku ngāue mālohi 'aupito.

I worked very hard.

Pē

Pē (*just, only*) narrows the meaning of the word it follows. It eliminates other possibilities: whatever *pē* attaches to is the only thing in play.

Na'a mau mohe pē.

We just slept.

Na'á ne kai mā pē.

He just ate bread.

In the first sentence, *pē* follows the verb: we did nothing but sleep. In the second, *pē* follows the compound *kai mā*: he ate nothing but bread. *Pē* attaches to whichever word it limits.

Verb-Object Compounds

Na'á ke inu kava?

Did you drink kava?

An **object** is the thing an action is done to. In this sentence, *kava* is what was drunk.

When the object is general (not a specific item), it follows the verb directly with nothing between them. Expressions like *kai mā*, *inu kava*, and *inu vai* behave as single grammatical units. Even though each contains a verb and a noun, the pair functions together like one intransitive verb.

Compound	Meaning
<i>kai mā</i>	eat bread
<i>kai ika</i>	eat fish
<i>kai talo</i>	eat taro
<i>inu vai</i>	drink water
<i>inu kava</i>	drink kava
<i>inu tī</i>	drink tea

The nouns here are new: *ika* (fish), *talo* (taro), *vai* (water), *kava* (kava), *tī* (tea). These compounds take modifiers and *pē* just as any verb does. The modifier goes after the compound:

Na’á ku kai ika pē.

I just ate fish.

Na’a nau kai ika lahi.

They ate a lot of fish.

Na’a tau kai mā lahi ’aupito.

We ate a great deal of bread.

Fa’a

’Oku ou fa’a hiva.

I often sing.

Fa’a (often, habitually) sits before the verb, between the pronoun and the verb. This is the reverse of the postposed modifiers above.

The pattern: TM + pronoun + *fa’a* + verb.

’Okú ke fa’a tokoni?

Do you often help?

The verb *tokoni* (*help*) appears here without a specific object.

Fa’a combines naturally with the postposed modifiers from earlier in this chapter:

’Oku mau fa’a ngāue mālohi.

We often work hard.

’Okú ne fa’a kai lahi.

He often eats a lot.

The most complex sentence you can now build stacks every element from this chapter:

’Oku ou fa’a kai mā lahi ’aupito.

I often eat a great deal of bread.

This combines: present tense marker + first person pronoun + preposed modifier + verb + indefinite object + postposed modifier + intensifier.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>fa’a</i>	preposed modifier	often, habitually
<i>’aupito</i>	postposed intensifier	very, extremely
<i>pē</i>	postposed limiter	just, only

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>fiefia</i>	adjective	happy
<i>hela'ia</i>	adjective	tired
<i>fiekaia</i>	adjective	hungry
<i>feinua</i>	adjective	thirsty
<i>'ita</i>	adjective	angry
<i>vaivai</i>	adjective	weak
<i>masiva</i>	adjective	poor
<i>mālohi</i>	adjective/modifier	strong; hard, strongly
<i>lelei</i>	modifier	well, good
<i>lahi</i>	modifier	much, a lot
<i>ngāue</i>	verb	work
<i>tokoni</i>	verb	help
<i>mā</i>	noun	bread
<i>ika</i>	noun	fish
<i>talo</i>	noun	taro
<i>vai</i>	noun	water
<i>kava</i>	noun	kava
<i>tī</i>	noun	tea

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English

1. 'Oku ou fiekaia.
2. Na'á ku mohe lahi.

3. 'Okú ne 'ita 'aupito.
4. Na'a nau inu kava pē.
5. 'Okú ke fa'a lea mālohi?
6. Kuó u hela'ia.
7. Na'a mau kai talo lahi 'aupito.
8. 'Oku tau vaivai.

Exercise 2: Translate English to Tongan

1. She is happy.
2. I worked hard.
3. We (not including you) often eat fish.
4. They were very tired.
5. You (one person) drank only water.
6. He is very strong.
7. I am thirsty.
8. Did you (one person) often sing?

Exercise 3: Add the modifier

Place the modifier in parentheses into the correct position in the sentence.

1. 'Oku ou hiva. (lelei)
2. Na'a ku 'ita. (lahi)
3. 'Oku mau ngāue. (fa'a)
4. Na'a nau mohe. (pē)
5. 'Okú ne fiefia. ('aupito)
6. Na'a ke kai mā. (lahi 'aupito)

Exercise 4: Fill in the blank

Choose the correct word from the list: pē, fa'a, lahi, 'aupito, lelei, mālohi

1. Na'a ku inu vai __. (I drank only water.)
2. 'Oku ou __ hela'ia. (I am often tired.)
3. 'Okú ne hiva __. (She sings well.)
4. Na'a mau ngāue __. (We worked hard.)
5. 'Oku ou fiekaia __. (I am very hungry.)

6. *Na'a nau kai* __. (They ate a lot.)

Exercise 5: Build the sentence

Arrange the words into a correct Tongan sentence, then translate to English.

1. *fiefia / ou / 'oku / 'aupito*
2. *lahi / nau / na'a / kai / ika*
3. *fa'a / ne / mohe / 'okú*
4. *mālohi / na'á / ngāue / ku*
5. *pē / vai / ku / inu / na'á*
6. *fa'a / ou / 'oku / lahi / kai / mā / 'aupito*

Answers

Exercise 1

1. I am hungry.
2. I slept a lot.
3. He/She is very angry.
4. They drank only kava.
5. Do you often speak loudly?
6. I have become tired.
7. We (not including you) ate a great deal of taro.
8. We (including you) are weak.

Exercise 2

1. *'Okú ne fiefia.*
2. *Na'á ku ngāue mālohi.*
3. *'Oku mau fa'a kai ika.*
4. *Na'a nau hela'ia 'aupito.*
5. *Na'á ke inu vai pē.*
6. *'Okú ne mālohi 'aupito.*
7. *'Oku ou fieinua.*
8. *Na'á ke fa'a hiva?*

Exercise 3

1. 'Oku ou hiva lelei.
2. Na'á ku 'ita lahi.
3. 'Oku mau fa'a ngāue.
4. Na'a nau mohe pē.
5. 'Okú ne fiefia 'aupito.
6. Na'á ke kai mā lahi 'aupito.

Exercise 4

1. pē
2. fa'a
3. lelei
4. mālohi
5. 'aupito
6. lahi

Exercise 5

1. 'Oku ou fiefia 'aupito. I am very happy.
 2. Na'a nau kai ika lahi. They ate a lot of fish.
 3. 'Okú ne fa'a mohe. He/She often sleeps.
 4. Na'á ku ngāue mālohi. I worked hard.
 5. Na'á ku inu vai pē. I drank only water.
 6. 'Oku ou fa'a kai mā lahi 'aupito. I often eat a great deal of bread.
-

Chapter 4: Time Words

Sentences built so far describe actions but not when they happen. This chapter adds time words to place events at specific moments: yesterday, tomorrow, last night, tonight.

Past Time Words

Na'a mou kai talo 'anepō?

Did you (plural) eat taro last night?

The word *'anepō* (*last night*) sits at the end of the sentence. Everything before it (the tense marker, pronoun, verb, and object *talo* (*taro*)) stays exactly as you learned it. The time word attaches to the end.

Tongan has three common time words for the recent past:

Word	Meaning
<i>'aneafi</i>	yesterday

Word	Meaning
<i>'anepō</i>	last night
<i>'anenai</i>	a while ago, earlier today

Na'á ku mohe 'aneafi.

I slept yesterday.

Na'a mau ako lea 'anenai.

We studied language a while ago.

In the second sentence, *ako* (*study*) combines with *lea* in the verb-object compound *ako lea* (*study language*), which works as a unit, just as *kai mā* and *inu vai* do. The time word follows the compound, in the same end position as always.

Modifiers keep their usual position right after the verb or verb-object compound. The time word comes after them, at the very end:

Na'á ku ngāue mālohi 'aneafi.

I worked hard yesterday.

Na'a nau kai ika lahi 'anepō.

They ate a lot of fish last night.

The object *ika* (*fish*) sits after the verb, with the modifier *lahi* and the time word following in order.

Future Time Words

Té u 'alu 'apongipongi.

I will go tomorrow.

Future time words work the same way: they go at the end of the sentence.

Word	Meaning
'apongipongi	tomorrow
'apō	tonight
'anai	in a little while, later today

Te nau mohe 'apō.
They will sleep tonight.

Te mau ngāue 'anai.
We will work in a little while.

Té ke hiva 'apongipongi?
Will you sing tomorrow?

The verb *hiva* (*sing*) fills the same slot as *mohe* and *ngāue* in the sentences above.

A pattern in the time words

The past and future words come in pairs. Past time words begin with *'ane-*. Future time words begin with *'a-*. The endings match:

Past ('ane-)		Future ('a-)	
'anepō	last night	'apō	tonight
'anenai	a while ago	'anai	in a little while
'aneafi	yesterday	'apongipongi	tomorrow

The third pair does not share an ending, but the pattern in the first two makes them easier to remember: *'ane-* looks back, *'a-* looks forward.

Today

The past and future time words are single words. “Today” is different: it is a two-word phrase.

'Aho (day) + ni (this) = 'aho ni, literally “this day.”

The word *ni* is a **demonstrative**: a word that points to something, like “this” in English. It always follows the word it describes: *'aho ni*, not *ni 'aho*. Like the pronouns *ke* and *ku* from Chapter 1: The Basic Sentence, *ni* is an enclitic: it leans on the preceding word so the two are pronounced as one unit. The stress shifts forward: *'áho* alone, but *'ahó ni*. Demonstratives are covered fully in Chapter 6: Location. Treat *'aho ni* as a set phrase meaning “today.”

When *'aho ni* appears as a time expression inside a sentence, the article *he* comes before it: *he 'ahó ni* (today, literally “on this day”).

Preview: The word *he* before *'ahó ni* is the definite article, similar to “the” in English. The article *he* is introduced in Chapter 8: Articles. Treat *he 'ahó ni* as a set phrase meaning “today.”

'Oku ou fiefia he 'ahó ni.

I am happy today.

'Oku ou fiekaia he 'ahó ni.

I am hungry today.

The word *fiekaia* (*hungry*) is a predicate adjective, like *fiefia* and *hela'ia* from the previous chapter.

Té u ngāue mālohi he 'ahó ni.

I will work hard today.

'Oku lā'ā he 'ahó ni.

It is sunny today.

'Oku momoko he 'ahó ni.

It is cold today.

Preview: The word *lāʻā* (*sunny*) appears in the sentence above without a pronoun. Weather expressions in Tongan often follow this short pattern: tense marker + weather word, with no one “doing” the action.

Note:

The stress shift in *ʻahó ni* follows the enclitic pattern you learned in Chapter 1: The Basic Sentence. Think of *ʻaho* + *ni* as one word, *ʻahoni*, with stress on the second-to-last vowel.

Tonight

Tongan has three ways to say “tonight,” and the choice depends on when you are speaking.

The time adverb *ʻapō* works like the other future time words: it carries the forward-looking *ʻa-* prefix, so it is used during the day, when night has not yet arrived.

Té ta ʻalu ʻapō.

We will go tonight. (Said while the sun is still up.)

Adding *ni* gives *ʻapōni* (*this coming night*), which is more definite: *this* coming night, not some other.

Té ta ʻalu ʻapōni?

Will we go tonight? (Still during the day, but narrowing it: tonight is the night.)

Both *ʻapō* and *ʻapōni* look ahead to a night that has not started. Once night has arrived, neither form fits. You are no longer looking forward to it; you are in it. At that point, Tongan uses *he poó ni*, built the same way as *he ʻahó ni*: the article *he* + *pō* (*night*) + the demonstrative *ni*.

Té ta ʻalu he poó ni.

We are going tonight. (Said after dark.)

The stress shifts the same way: *pō* becomes *poó* before *ni*.

At this stage, *ʻapō* is the form you will use most. Treat *ʻapōni* and *he poó ni* as alternatives you should recognise when you hear them.

Days of the week

These are useful to know alongside the time words above, even though using them in full sentences requires articles (Chapter 8: Articles) and time expressions covered in Chapter 42: Time Expressions and Personal Questions.

Tongan	English
Mōnite	Monday
Tūsite	Tuesday
Pulelulu	Wednesday
Tu’apulelulu	Thursday
Falaite	Friday
Tokonaki	Saturday
Sāpate	Sunday

Where Time Words Go

Here is the full sentence pattern available at this point:

TM + pronoun + (*fa’a*) + verb (+ indefinite object) (+ modifier) (+ time word)

Each element keeps its own position. The time word goes last.

Na’á ku kai mā lahi ’aupito ’aneafi.

I ate a great deal of bread yesterday.

This stacks: past tense marker + pronoun + verb + indefinite object + modifier + intensifier + time word.

Na’á ne inu kava ’anepō.

He drank kava last night.

Here *kava* fills the object slot, as *mā* and *vai* do.

Adding the preposed modifier *fa’a* from the previous chapter gives the most complex sentence you can build so far:

Na’a mau fa’a inu vai lahi ’aupito ’anepō.

We often drank a great deal of water last night.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>ni</i>	demonstrative enclitic	this (near me)
<i>he</i>	definite article (preview)	the (before time phrases)

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>’aneafi</i>	time word	yesterday
<i>’anepō</i>	time word	last night
<i>’anenai</i>	time word	a while ago
<i>’apongipongi</i>	time word	tomorrow
<i>’apō</i>	time word	tonight
<i>’anai</i>	time word	in a little while
<i>’aho</i>	noun	day
<i>pō</i>	noun	night
<i>lā’ā</i>	adjective	sunny
<i>momoko</i>	adjective	cold
<i>Mōnite</i>	day name	Monday

Tongan	Type	English
<i>Tūsīte</i>	day name	Tuesday
<i>Pulelulu</i>	day name	Wednesday
<i>Tu'apulelulu</i>	day name	Thursday
<i>Falaite</i>	day name	Friday
<i>Tokonaki</i>	day name	Saturday
<i>Sāpate</i>	day name	Sunday

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English

1. *Na'á ku mohe 'aneafi.*
2. *Te nau hiva 'apō.*
3. *Na'a mau kai talo 'anenai.*
4. *Té ke 'alu 'apongipongi?*
5. *Na'á ne ngāue mālohi 'aneafi.*
6. *'Oku ou hela'ia he 'ahó ni.*
7. *Na'a nau inu kava lahi 'anepō.*
8. *Te mau ako 'anai.*

Exercise 2: Translate English to Tongan

1. I ate fish yesterday.
2. They will work tomorrow.
3. Did you (one person) sleep last night?
4. We (not including you) will go in a little while.
5. She was very tired yesterday.
6. I am hungry today.
7. He drank a lot of kava last night.
8. Will they sing tonight?

Exercise 3: Add the time word

The English in parentheses tells you when. Add the correct Tongan time word to the end of the sentence.

1. *Na'á ku kai mā* __. (yesterday)
2. *Te mau hiva* __. (tonight)
3. *Na'a nau mohe* __. (a while ago)
4. *Té u 'alu* __. (tomorrow)
5. *Na'á ke ngāue* __. (last night)
6. *'Oku ou fiefia* __. (today)

Exercise 4: Choose past or future

Each sentence is missing its tense marker. The time word tells you whether the action is past or future. Fill in *na'a* (or *na'á*) for past, or *te* (or *té*) for future. Remember: the tense marker takes an accent before a one-syllable pronoun.

1. __ *ku kai ika 'aneafi*.
2. __ *u 'alu 'apongipongi*.
3. __ *nau mohe 'anepō*.
4. __ *ke hiva 'apō*?
5. __ *mau ngāue 'anenai*.
6. __ *ne ngāue 'anai*.

Exercise 5: Build the sentence

Arrange the words into a correct Tongan sentence, then translate to English.

1. *'aneafi / ku / na'á / mohe / lahi*
2. *'apō / mau / te / hiva*
3. *'apongipongi / ke / 'alu / té*
4. *fa'a / 'anepō / nau / na'a / kai / ika*
5. *he 'ahó ni / ou / 'oku / fiekaia*
6. *'anenai / lahi / 'aupito / ku / na'á / ngāue*

Answers**Exercise 1**

1. I slept yesterday.
2. They will sing tonight.
3. We (not including you) ate taro a while ago.
4. Will you go tomorrow?
5. He/She worked hard yesterday.
6. I am tired today.
7. They drank a lot of kava last night.
8. We (not including you) will study in a little while.

Exercise 2

1. *Na'á ku kai ika 'aneafi.*
2. *Te nau ngāue 'apongipongi.*
3. *Na'á ke mohe 'anepō?*
4. *Te mau 'alu 'anai.*
5. *Na'á ne hela'ia 'aupito 'aneafi.*
6. *'Oku ou fiekaia he 'ahó ni.*
7. *Na'á ne inu kava lahi 'anepō.*
8. *Te nau hiva 'apō?*

Exercise 3

1. *'aneafi*
2. *'apō*
3. *'anenai*
4. *'apongipongi*
5. *'anepō*
6. *he 'ahó ni*

Exercise 4

1. *Na'á* (past: *'aneafi* = yesterday; accent before *ku*)
2. *Té* (future: *'apongipongi* = tomorrow; accent before *u*)

3. *Na'a* (past: 'anepō = last night; no accent before *nau*)
4. *Té* (future: 'apō = tonight; accent before *ke*)
5. *Na'a* (past: 'anenai = a while ago; no accent before *mau*)
6. *Té* (future: 'anai = in a little while; accent before *ne*)

Exercise 5

1. *Na'á ku mohe lahi 'aneafi.* I slept a lot yesterday.
 2. *Te mau hiva 'apō.* We (not including you) will sing tonight.
 3. *Té ke 'alu 'apongipongi.* You will go tomorrow.
 4. *Na'a nau fa'a kai ika 'anepō.* They often ate fish last night.
 5. *'Oku ou fiekaia he 'ahó ni.* I am hungry today.
 6. *Na'á ku ngāue lahi 'aupito 'anenai.* I worked very hard a while ago.
-

Chapter 5: Commands and Emphasis

Every sentence so far has required a tense marker and a pronoun. This chapter introduces commands, which use the verb alone, and emphatic pronouns, which add emphasis to any sentence pattern.

Giving a Command

Nofo!

Stay!

A command tells someone to do something. A command is a sentence built from the verb alone, without a tense marker or a pronoun. In English, “Stay!” works the same way: the verb does all the work.

Mohe!

Sleep!

Kai!

Eat!

Every verb you have learned works this way. Use the verb by itself and you have a command to one person.

Tongan	English
<i>Nofo!</i>	Stay!
<i>Kai!</i>	Eat!
<i>Mohe!</i>	Sleep!
<i>Lea!</i>	Speak!
<i>Hiva!</i>	Sing!
<i>Inu!</i>	Drink!

Commands to a Group: ***Mou***

Mou nofo!

Stay! (all of you)

When speaking to three or more people, place *mou* before the verb. You already know *mou* as the second-person plural pronoun from statements like *na'a mou kai* (you all ate). In commands, it works the same way: it tells the group that the command is for all of them.

Mou kai!

Eat! (all of you)

Mou hiva!

Sing! (all of you)

Plural verb forms: ō and ō mai

Two verbs change form when the subject is more than one person.

'Alu!

Go! (to one person)

Mou ō!

Go! (to a group)

Ha’u!

Come! (to one person)

Mou ō mai!

Come! (to a group)

The singular *’alu* (to go) becomes *ō* with a dual or plural subject. The singular *ha’u* (to come) becomes *ō mai*. Churchward notes that *ō* carries more of the sense of an actual journey than *’alu*, and is less abrupt, even more polite (Churchward Ch. 6, §4a).

One person	Three or more	English
<i>’Alu!</i>	<i>Mou ō!</i>	Go!
<i>Ha’u!</i>	<i>Mou ō mai!</i>	Come!

Note:

Most verbs keep the same form regardless of how many people are involved. Only a small number have special plural forms. *’Alu/ō* and *ha’u/ō mai* are the most common pair and the only ones taught in this chapter. Others exist and are covered in Chapter 25: Plural Markers.

Saying “Don’t”: Prohibitions with *’Oua*

’Oua té ke lea!

Don’t speak!

A prohibition tells someone *not* to do something. The Tongan word for “don’t” in a command is *’oua*. It is followed by *te*, a pronoun, and then the verb.

The pattern: *’oua te* + pronoun + verb.

For one person, the pronoun is *ke* (you, singular):

'Oua té ke mohe!

Don't sleep!

For a group, the pronoun is *mou*:

'Oua te mou nofo!

Don't stay! (all of you)

Unlike a positive command, a prohibition always includes the pronoun, because *'oua te* requires one.

Command	Prohibition
<i>Nofo!</i>	<i>'Oua té ke nofo!</i>
Stay!	Don't stay!
<i>Kai!</i>	<i>'Oua té ke kai!</i>
Eat!	Don't eat!
<i>Mou ō!</i>	<i>'Oua te mou ō!</i>
Go! (all)	Don't go! (all)
<i>Hiva!</i>	<i>'Oua té ke hiva!</i>
Sing!	Don't sing!

The prohibition pattern also works with the verb prefix *fie* (want to). Place *fie* before the verb:

'Oua té ke fie inu.

Don't want to drink.

The word *fie* placed before a verb means “want to,” so *fie inu* is “want to drink.” Here you only need to recognize that *fie* attaches to a verb; its full use as a helper verb is covered in Chapter 21: Auxiliary Verbs.

Note:

A softer form of prohibition exists: *'oua na'a* in place of *'oua te*. *'Oua na'a* is less abrupt and preferred in polite speech. Both mean the same thing. The gentler form will be covered formally in Chapter 38: Warnings, Hopes, Permissions, and Uncertainty.

Adding “Please”: *Mu'a**Ha'u mu'a!*

Please come!

The word *mu'a* softens a command into a polite request. It comes after the verb. Churchward describes it as a word that adds “a touch of courtesy to a command, a request, or some other expression of the will of the speaker” (Churchward Ch. 27, §27).

Nofo mu'a!

Please stay!

Mou ō mu'a!

Please go! (all of you)

Mu'a combines naturally with prohibitions:

'Oua té ke kai mu'a.

Please don't eat.

Quick Practice A: Commands, group commands, prohibitions, and *mu'a*

Translate each English phrase into Tongan.

1. Run! (to one person)
2. Drink! (to a group)
3. Please speak!

- 4. Don't run! (to one person)
- 5. Don't drink! (to a group)

Answers: 1. *Lele!* 2. *Mou inu!* 3. *Lea mu'a!* 4. *'Oua té ke lele!* 5. *'Oua te mou inu!*

Postposed Pronouns: The Long Forms

Every pronoun you have learned so far is a short form that goes between the tense marker and the verb: *na'á ku kai* (I ate), *'okú ne lea* (he speaks). These short forms are called preposed pronouns because they come before the verb.

Tongan also has a matching set of long forms that go after the verb. These are called postposed pronouns. A postposed pronoun is a word that takes the place of a noun (see the Introduction for pronouns), but it appears after the verb or verb phrase rather than before it.

Here is the full set:

Person	Preposed (before verb)	Postposed (after verb)
I	<i>ou / ku / u</i>	<i>au</i>
you (one)	<i>ke</i>	<i>koe</i>
he, she	<i>ne</i>	<i>ia</i>
we two (incl.)	<i>ta</i>	<i>kitaua</i>
we two (excl.)	<i>ma</i>	<i>kimaua</i>
you two	<i>mo</i>	<i>kimoua</i>
they two	<i>na</i>	<i>kinaua</i>
we (incl.)	<i>tau</i>	<i>kitautolu</i>
we (excl.)	<i>mau</i>	<i>kimautolu</i>
you all	<i>mou</i>	<i>kimoutolu</i>
they	<i>nau</i>	<i>kinautolu</i>

A memory aid: the dual postposed forms end in *-ua* (from *ua*, the word for “two”), and the plural forms end in *-tolu* (from *tolu*, the word for “three”).

The postposed pronouns have two uses taught in this chapter: emphasis in statements and emphasis in commands. Both are explained below.

Emphatic Statements with Postposed Pronouns

Té u nofo au.

I will stay. (emphatic)

When you add the postposed pronoun after the verb, it echoes the preposed pronoun and emphasizes who is doing the action. The sentence *Té u nofo* already means “I will stay.” Adding *au* makes it stronger: “I will stay” or “I myself will stay.”

Compare:

Té u nofo.

I will stay.

Té u nofo au.

I will stay. (that’s certain)

The postposed pronoun appears right after the verb or verb phrase. It does not change the meaning. It adds weight. The sentence says: this person, not anyone else.

Na’á ku lea au.

I spoke. (I myself spoke)

’Oku ou fiefia au.

I am happy. (I myself am happy)

Na’a mau kai kimautolu.

We ate. (we ourselves ate)

Té ke mohe koe.

You will sleep. (you yourself will sleep)

This pattern works with any tense marker, any pronoun, and any verb you already know.

The plural pattern works the same way:

Tau hiva kitautolu!

Let's sing! (emphatic)

Te mau lele kimautilu!

We will run! (emphatic)

The contrast between *Tau kai!* (Let's eat!) and *Tau kai kitautolu!* (Let's eat! What are we waiting for?) shows how the postposed pronoun turns a suggestion into an insistent one.

Quick Practice B: Postposed pronouns and emphatic statements

Add the correct postposed pronoun to make each statement emphatic.

1. *Té u 'alu* __. I will go (myself).
2. *Na'á ke kai* __. You ate (yourself).
3. *'Okú ne hiva* __. He is singing (himself).
4. *Tau lele* __! Let's run (we ourselves)!
5. *'Oku nau lea* __. They are speaking (themselves).

Answers: 1. *au*. 2. *koe*. 3. *ia*. 4. *kitautolu*. 5. *kinautilu*

Emphasis in Commands: *'Alu koe!*

'Alu koe!

Go! (I mean you!)

In a command to one person, the preposed pronoun *ke* does not appear. But you can add the postposed pronoun *koe* after the verb to single out the person

you are speaking to. The singular preposed *ke* does not occur with imperatives, but the postposed *koe* does.

Ha'u koe!

Come! (yes, you!)

Nofo koe!

Stay! (you!)

Kai koe!

Eat! (you!)

For plural commands, *mou* already appears before the verb, and you can add the postposed plural pronoun after it:

Mou ō kimoutolu!

Go! (all of you, I mean it!)

Mou kai kimoutolu!

Eat! (all of you!)

Quick Practice C: Emphasis in commands

Add the postposed pronoun to make each command emphatic.

1. *Hiva* __! Sing! (you yourself!)
2. *Lele* __! Run! (you yourself!)
3. *Mou inu* __! Drink! (all of you, I mean it!)
4. *Mohe* __! Sleep! (you yourself!)
5. *Mou hiva* __! Sing! (all of you!)

Answers: 1. *koe*. 2. *koe*. 3. *kimoutolu*. 4. *koe*. 5. *kimoutolu*

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>'oua</i>	prohibition marker	don't (in commands)
<i>mu'a</i>	politeness particle	please
<i>au</i>	postposed pronoun	I (emphatic)
<i>koe</i>	postposed pronoun	you (emphatic)
<i>ia</i>	postposed pronoun	he/she (emphatic)
<i>kitaua</i>	postposed pronoun	we two inclusive (emphatic)
<i>kimaua</i>	postposed pronoun	we two exclusive (emphatic)
<i>kimoua</i>	postposed pronoun	you two (emphatic)
<i>kinaua</i>	postposed pronoun	they two (emphatic)
<i>kitautolu</i>	postposed pronoun	we inclusive 3+ (emphatic)
<i>kimautolu</i>	postposed pronoun	we exclusive 3+ (emphatic)
<i>kimoutolu</i>	postposed pronoun	you all 3+ (emphatic)
<i>kinautolu</i>	postposed pronoun	they 3+ (emphatic)

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>ō mai</i>	verb phrase	come (plural of <i>ha'u</i>)
<i>fie</i>	verb prefix	want to

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate into English

1. *Mohe!*
2. *Mou ō!*

3. 'Oua té ke kai!
4. Ha'u mu'a!
5. 'Oua te mou hiva!
6. 'Alu koe!

Exercise 2: Translate into Tongan

1. Eat! (to one person)
2. Go! (to a group)
3. Don't sleep! (to one person)
4. Please come! (to one person)
5. Don't go! (to a group)
6. Stay! (you yourself, emphatic)

Exercise 3: Change each command to a prohibition

1. Nofo!
2. Mou kai!
3. 'Alu!
4. Hiva!
5. Mou ō!
6. Lea!

Exercise 4: Add emphasis to each sentence by inserting the correct postposed pronoun

1. Té u nofo. → Té u nofo __.
2. Na'á ku kai. → Na'á ku kai __.
3. 'Oku mau hiva. → 'Oku mau hiva __.
4. Mou ō! → Mou ō __!
5. 'Alu! → 'Alu __!

Exercise 5: Translate into English. These sentences combine commands and emphasis with grammar from previous chapters

1. Mou kai mā mu'a!
2. 'Oua té ke mohe 'apongipongi!

3. *Té u lea au.*
 4. *Na'a mau hiva kimautilu 'anepō.*
 5. *Tau ō kitautolu!*
 6. *'Oua te mou inu lahi 'aupito!*
-

Answers

Exercise 1

1. Sleep!
2. Go! (all of you)
3. Don't eat!
4. Please come!
5. Don't sing! (all of you)
6. Go! (I mean you!)

Exercise 2

1. *Kai!*
2. *Mou ō!*
3. *'Oua té ke mohe!*
4. *Ha'u mu'a!*
5. *'Oua te mou ō!*
6. *Nofo koe!*

Exercise 3

1. *'Oua té ke nofo!*
2. *'Oua te mou kai!*
3. *'Oua té ke 'alu!*
4. *'Oua té ke hiva!*
5. *'Oua te mou ō!*
6. *'Oua té ke lea!*

Exercise 4

1. *Té u nofo au.*
2. *Na'á ku kai au.*
3. *'Oku mau hiva kimautilu.*
4. *Mou ō kimoutolu!*
5. *'Alu koe!*

Exercise 5

1. Please eat bread! (all of you)
2. Don't sleep tomorrow!
3. I will speak. (emphatic)
4. We sang last night. (emphatic)
5. Let's go! (emphatic)
6. Don't drink too much! (all of you)

Chapter 6: Location

This chapter introduces location: the preposition *'i* (in, at, on), the question word *'i fē* (where?), and demonstratives for pointing to a place.

The Preposition *'i*

Na'á ku mohe 'i fale (house). I slept at the house. (Lit. “Was-I sleep at house”)

The word *'i* means “in,” “at,” or “on.” It goes before a noun to show where something happens. A word that goes before a noun or pronoun to show its relationship to the rest of the sentence is called a preposition. English uses the same idea: “in the house,” “at school,” “on the table.” Tongan *'i* does the work of all three, and has other uses you will meet later.

The location phrase *'i* + place attaches to the end of the sentence patterns you already know:

TM + pronoun + verb (+ modifier) (+ object) + *'i* + place

'i appears with place names and with nouns that name a specific, understood location:

Tongan	English
<i>'i Tonga</i>	in Tonga
<i>'i Nuku'alofa</i>	in Nuku'alofa
<i>'i 'api</i>	at home
<i>'i kolo</i>	in town
<i>'i siasi</i>	at church
<i>'i tahi</i>	at the sea
<i>'i ngoue</i>	in the plantation
<i>'i mala'e</i>	on the field
<i>'i hala</i>	on the road

Two new place words: *'api* (*home*) and *kolo* (*town*). With *'i*, these refer to a particular place both speaker and listener already know about, without needing an article (a word like “the” or “a”).

'Oku ou nofo 'i 'api.

I live at home.

Na'a mau ngāue 'i kolo.

We worked in town.

Té u nofo 'i Tonga.

I will stay in Tonga.

Five more place words: *siasi* (*church*), *tahi* (*sea*), *ngoue* (*plantation, garden*), *mala'e* (*field, village green*), and *hala* (*road, path*). These work with *'i* the same way as *'api* and *kolo*.

'Oku mau 'alu ki siasi (*church*). We go to church.

Na'á ku nofo 'i tahi (*sea*). I stayed at the sea.

'Okú ke ngāue 'i ngoue (*plantation*)? Do you work in the plantation?

Na'a nau 'alu ki mala'e (*field*). They went to the field.

Na’á ku lele ’i hala (road). I ran on the road.

Fale + Verb

fale mohe. dormitory (lit. “house sleep,” a building for sleeping)

fale kai. cafe, restaurant (lit. “house eat,” a building for eating)

Fale (house, building) is a general word for any building. When a verb is placed after *fale*, it describes what happens in that building. The verb works like a describing word (an adjective). *Mohe* (sleep) after *fale* tells you the building’s purpose: *fale mohe* is a building for sleeping. *Kai* (eat) does the same: *fale kai* is a building for eating.

These compounds work with *’i* like any place noun:

Na’á ku mohe ’i fale mohe.

I slept in the dormitory.

Tau kai ’i fale kai.

Let’s eat in the cafeteria.

Asking Where: ’i fē

Na’á ke mohe ’i fē?

Where did you sleep?

To ask where something happens, replace the place noun with *fē* (*what place, which place*). The combination *’i fē* means “at what place,” or simply “where.”

’i fē goes in the same position as the answer:

Na’á ke mohe ’i fē?

Where did you sleep?

Na’á ku mohe ’i fale mohe.

I slept in the dormitory.

’Oku mou ngāue ’i fē?

Where do you work?

'Oku mau ngāue 'i kolo.

We work in town.

Here, There, Over There

Tau nofo pē heni.

Let's just stay here.

This chapter introduces three words for pointing to a place:

Word	Meaning	Points to
<i>heni</i>	here	near me (the speaker)
<i>hena</i>	there	near you (the listener)
<i>hē</i>	over there	wherever the speaker points

You met the idea of a demonstrative earlier when you learned that *ni* in *'aho ni* points to something near the speaker. These three words work the same way, but they point to places. *Heni* and *hena* are tied to person: *heni* means where I am, *hena* means where you are. *Hē* is different. It points wherever the speaker indicates, whether near or far, and often comes with a gesture or nod.

Té u tangutu (sit down) pē hē. I'll just sit over there.

When paired with *'i*, the words *heni*, *hena*, and *hē* work as part of a location phrase, just like *'i 'api* or *'i kolo*. Sometimes *'i* is omitted, and the word works on its own as a single location word:

Tau nofo 'i heni.

Let's stay here.

Tau nofo heni.

Let's stay here.

Because you already know imperatives from the previous chapter, you can combine a command with *'i* and a demonstrative:

Nofo 'i hē!

Sit there.

Mohe 'i heni!

Sleep here.

This and That: *ni* and *na*

You already know *ni* from the time expression *'aho ni* (today, lit. “day this”). The word *ni* means “this” and points to something near the speaker. Its companion *na* means “that” and points to something near the listener.

Both *ni* and *na* are enclitics: they lean on the noun before them so the pair is pronounced as one word (as you learned earlier). The stress shifts to what was the noun’s last syllable:

fāle → *falé ni* (“this house”) *fāle* → *falé na* (“that house, near you”)

Think of *falé ni* as a single three-syllable word, fa-le-ni, with stress on the second-to-last vowel.

Note:

You may hear the word *eni* used as an adverb meaning “now.” It is related to *ni* but more emphatic. Chapter 12: The *Ko* Pattern introduces the demonstrative pronouns *'eni*, *'ena*, and *ē* with *ko* sentences.

Being Somewhere

Na'á ke 'i fē?

Where have you been? (Lit. “Were-you at where?”)

In the sentences so far, *'i* has followed a verb: *Na'á ku mohe 'i fale* (I slept at the house). Tongan can also place the *'i* phrase directly after the pronoun, with no verb. The location phrase fills the verb slot and works as the predicate on its own, with no separate word for “is” or “was.”

Na'á ku 'i kolo.

I was in town. (Lit. “Was-I in town”)

'Oku ou 'i 'api.

I am at home. (Lit. “Is-I at home”)

Té u 'i heni 'apō.

I will be here tonight. (Lit. “Will-I at here tonight”)

This works the same way as the predicate adjectives you learned earlier. Compare:

Tongan	English	What fills the verb slot
<i>Na’á ku fiefia.</i>	I was happy.	stative (<i>fiefia</i>)
<i>Na’á ku 'i kolo.</i>	I was in town.	location (<i>'i kolo</i>)

Both follow the same structure: tense marker + pronoun + [what fills the verb slot]. A locational phrase like *'i Fisi* (in Fiji) in this position works as a verbal equivalent, just as a predicate adjective does.

The question *Na’á ke 'i fē?* is one of the most common greetings in Tongan, a natural way to start a conversation when you meet someone.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>'i</i>	preposition	in, at, on
<i>fē</i>	question word	where
<i>heni</i>	demonstrative (place)	here
<i>hena</i>	demonstrative (place)	there (near you)
<i>hē</i>	demonstrative (place)	over there

Tongan	Function	English
<i>na</i>	demonstrative enclitic	that (near you) (also “they two” (Ch 2))

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>’api</i>	noun	home
<i>kolo</i>	noun	town
<i>fale</i>	noun	house, building
<i>tangutu</i>	verb	sit down
<i>siasi</i>	noun	church
<i>tahi</i>	noun	sea, ocean
<i>ngoue</i>	noun	plantation, garden
<i>mala’e</i>	noun	field, village green
<i>hala</i>	noun	road, path

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate into English

- 1. *’Oku ou nofo ’i ’api.*
- 2. *Na’á ke ngāue ’i fē?*
- 3. *Tau kai ’i fale kai.*
- 4. *Té u mohe pē hē.*
- 5. *Na’á ku ’i kolo ’aneafi.*
- 6. *Na’a mau ako ’i Tonga.*
- 7. *Na’á ke ’i fē ’anepō?*
- 8. *Tau hiva heni.*

Exercise 2: Translate into Tongan

1. I slept in the dormitory.
2. Where do you work?
3. We will stay here.
4. She was at home yesterday.
5. Let's sing over there.
6. I am in town.
7. Where did they eat?
8. I'll just sit over there.

Exercise 3: Fill in the blank

Supply the missing word so the Tongan matches the English.

1. *Na'á ku mohe* __ *fale mohe*. (I slept in the dormitory.)
2. *'Okú ke ngāue* __? (Where do you work?)
3. *Tau hiva* __. (Let's sing here.)
4. *Té u nofo pē* __. (I'll just stay over there.)
5. *Na'á ne nofo* __ *'api 'aneafi*. (He stayed at home yesterday.)
6. *Na'a mou kai* __ *'anepō*? (Where did you eat last night?)

Exercise 4: Answer in Tongan

Answer each question using the location in parentheses.

1. *Na'á ke mohe 'i fē*? (the dormitory)
2. *'Okú ke nofo 'i fē*? (at home)
3. *Na'á ke 'i fē 'aneafi*? (in town)
4. *'Okú ke ngāue 'i fē*? (in Nuku'alofa)
5. *Na'a mou kai 'i fē*? (the cafeteria)
6. *Té ke nofo 'i fē 'apongipongi*? (here)

Answers**Exercise 1**

1. I live at home.
2. Where did you work?

3. Let's eat in the cafeteria.
4. I'll just sleep over there.
5. I was in town yesterday.
6. We studied in Tonga.
7. Where were you last night?
8. Let's sing here.

Exercise 2

1. *Na'á ku mohe 'i fale mohe.*
2. *'Okú ke ngāue 'i fē?*
3. *Te mau nofo heni.* (or *Te mau nofo 'i heni.*)
4. *Na'á ne 'i 'api 'aneafi.*
5. *Tau hiva hē.*
6. *'Oku ou 'i kolo.*
7. *Na'a nau kai 'i fē?*
8. *Té u tangutu pē hē.*

Exercise 3

1. *'i*
2. *'i fē*
3. *heni*
4. *hē*
5. *'i*
6. *'i fē*

Exercise 4

1. *Na'á ku mohe 'i fale mohe.*
2. *'Oku ou nofo 'i 'api.*
3. *Na'á ku 'i kolo 'aneafi.*
4. *'Oku ou ngāue 'i Nuku'alofa.*
5. *Na'a mau kai 'i fale kai.*
6. *Té u nofo heni 'apongipongi.* (or *'i heni*)

Chapter 7: Prepositions: *Ki*, *'I*, and *Mei*

With *'i* (at, in) already in place, this chapter adds *ki* (to, toward) and *mei* (from), forming a complete set of three prepositions. The chapter also covers how these prepositions change form, and introduces *ai*, a particle that substitutes for the noun in a prepositional phrase.

Three Prepositions with Places

Preposition	Meaning	Example
<i>'i</i>	at, in	<i>'Oku ou nofo 'i Tonga.</i> I live in Tonga.
<i>ki</i>	to, toward	<i>Té u 'alu ki Tonga.</i> I will go to Tonga.

Preposition	Meaning	Example
<i>mei</i>	from	<i>Na’a ku ha’u mei Tonga.</i> I came from Tonga.

These three prepositions form a natural set: where you are (*'i*), where you are going (*ki*), and where you came from (*mei*).

Tongan classifies nouns into types, and the type determines which form of the preposition to use. The nouns in the table below are **local nouns**: place names like *Tonga* and *Nuku’alofa*, and familiar locations like *'api* (home), *kolo* (town), *fale* (house), and *tahi* (sea). Local nouns refer to places everyone knows without needing “the,” and they take the standard preposition forms: *'i*, *ki*, *mei*.

	<i>'i</i> (at, in)	<i>ki</i> (to)	<i>mei</i> (from)
<i>Tonga</i>	<i>'i Tonga</i>	<i>ki Tonga</i>	<i>mei Tonga</i>
<i>Nuku’alofa</i>	<i>'i Nuku’alofa</i>	<i>ki Nuku’alofa</i>	<i>mei Nuku’alofa</i>
<i>'api</i>	<i>'i 'api</i>	<i>ki 'api</i>	<i>mei 'api</i>
<i>kolo</i>	<i>'i kolo</i>	<i>ki kolo</i>	<i>mei kolo</i>
<i>fale</i>	<i>'i fale</i>	<i>ki fale</i>	<i>mei fale</i>
<i>tahi</i>	<i>'i tahi</i>	<i>ki tahi</i>	<i>mei tahi</i>

Every *'i* phrase from the previous chapter has a *ki* counterpart and a *mei* counterpart: *'i 'api* (at home), *ki 'api* (to home), *mei 'api* (from home).

With *mei* and *ki* together, you can describe a complete journey:
Na’a ku ha’u mei Fisi ki Tonga.

I came from Fiji to Tonga.

Na’a mau 'alu mei 'api ki kolo 'aneafi.

We went from home to town yesterday.

Before a Person's Name: The -a Forms

Na'á ku lea kia Tēvita.

I spoke to Tēvita.

People's names belong to a second noun type: **personal nouns**. Before a personal noun, the prepositions add -a: *ki* becomes *kia*, *'i* becomes *'ia*, and *mei* becomes *meia*.

Local noun (place)	Personal noun (person)
<i>ki Tonga</i>	<i>kia Sione</i>
<i>'i kolo</i>	<i>'ia Mele</i>
<i>mei 'api</i>	<i>meia Tēvita</i>

The meaning stays the same. Only the form changes, because the noun type is different. Local nouns take the base form; personal nouns take the -a form.

Na'á ne sio kia Lupe.

She saw Lupe. (Lit. "She looked to Lupe.")

The verb *sio* (*to see, to look at*) uses *kia* before a person's name, not a direct object. Where English says "I saw Lupe," Tongan says the equivalent of "I looked to Lupe."

Verbs with Ki and Kia

Several common verbs connect to their target with *ki* or *kia* rather than taking a direct object.

Verb	Meaning	Example
<i>lea</i>	speak	<i>Na'á ku lea kia Tēvita.</i> I spoke to Tēvita.

Verb	Meaning	Example
<i>tokoni</i>	help	<i>Té u tokoni kia 'Ofa.</i> I will help Ofa.
<i>sio</i>	see, look at	<i>Na'á ne sio kia Lupe.</i> She saw Lupe.
<i>fanongo</i>	listen	<i>'Oku ou fanongo kia Sēmisi.</i> I listen to Sēmisi.

In English, you “help someone” or “see someone” directly. In Tongan, you “help to someone” or “look to someone.” The preposition is always required with these verbs.

Before a Pronoun: The *-ate* Forms

Na'á ku tokoni kiate ia.
I helped him.

'Okú ne nofo 'iate au.
He stays with me.

Na'á ne ha'u meiate kimautolu.
He came from us.

When the target of a preposition is a pronoun instead of a name, add *-ate*: *ki* becomes *kiate*, *'i* becomes *'iate*, and *mei* becomes *meiate*.
Here is the full pattern across all three form types:

	Before a place	Before a person	Before a pronoun
at, in	<i>'i</i>	<i>'ia</i>	<i>'iate</i>

	Before a place	Before a person	Before a pronoun
to, toward	<i>ki</i>	<i>kia</i>	<i>kiate</i>
from	<i>mei</i>	<i>meia</i>	<i>meiate</i>

The pronouns that follow *kiate*, *'iate*, and *meiate* are the postposed (long) forms you learned in the previous chapter: *au*, *koe*, *ia*, *kitaua*, *kimaua*, *kimoua*, *kinaua*, *kitautolu*, *kimautolu*, *kimoutolu*, *kinautolu*.

Pronoun	<i>kiate</i> (to)	<i>'iate</i> (in/at)	<i>meiate</i> (from)
<i>au</i>	<i>kiate au</i>	<i>'iate au</i>	<i>meiate au</i>
<i>koe</i>	<i>kiate koe</i>	<i>'iate koe</i>	<i>meiate koe</i>
<i>ia</i>	<i>kiate ia</i>	<i>'iate ia</i>	<i>meiate ia</i>
<i>kitautolu</i>	<i>kiate kitautolu</i>	<i>'iate kitautolu</i>	<i>meiate kitautolu</i>
<i>kimoutolu</i>	<i>kiate kimoutolu</i>	<i>'iate kimoutolu</i>	<i>meiate kimoutolu</i>
<i>kinautolu</i>	<i>kiate kinautolu</i>	<i>'iate kinautolu</i>	<i>meiate kinautolu</i>

The same pattern applies to all postposed pronouns: *kitaua*, *kimaua*, *kimoua*, and *kinaua*.

Note:
The *meiate* forms are less common in everyday speech than *kiate* and *'iate*, but they follow the same rule.

The noun type determines the preposition form:

Noun type	<i>'i</i> form	<i>ki</i> form	<i>mei</i> form	Example
Local (places)	<i>'i</i>	<i>ki</i>	<i>mei</i>	<i>ki Tonga</i>
Personal (people)	<i>'ia</i>	<i>kia</i>	<i>meia</i>	<i>kia Sione</i>

Noun type	'i form	ki form	mei form	Example
Pronoun	<i>'iate</i>	<i>kiate</i>	<i>meiate</i>	<i>kiate au</i>

Preview:

There is a third noun type, **common nouns**, which covers everything that is not a place or a person’s name. Common nouns use the article *he* between the preposition and the noun: *ki he falé* (to the house). The next chapter covers articles.

'Oku ou 'ofa lahi 'iate koe.

I love you very much.

The verb *'ofa* (to love) uses *'iate* before a pronoun, just as *sio* and *lea* use *kia* before a person’s name.

Mahino: To Be Understandable

'Oku mahino kiate au.

I understand. (Lit. “Is understandable to me.”)

The verb *mahino* (to be clear, to be understandable) works differently from what you might expect. In English, “I understand” treats “I” as the subject. In Tongan, the thing being understood is the subject, and the person who understands appears after *kiate* (or *kia* before a name).

'Oku mahino kiate koe?

Do you understand? (Lit. “Is it understandable to you?”)

'Oku mahino kia Siale.

Siale understands. (Lit. “Is understandable to Siale.”)

'Oku mahino kiate kimaautolu.

We understand.

With a person’s name, *mahino* uses *kia* (not *kiate*), because a name is a personal noun, not a pronoun.

Ngalo: *To Be Forgotten*

Na'e ngalo 'iate au.

I forgot. (Lit. "Was forgotten in me.")

The verb *ngalo* (*to be forgotten*) follows a similar pattern. The person who forgot appears after *'iate* (or *'ia* before a name). Where English says "I forgot," Tongan says the equivalent of "it was forgotten from within me."

Kuo ngalo 'ia 'Ana. 'Ana has forgotten. (Lit. "Has been forgotten in 'Ana.")

Kuo ngalo 'iate koe.

You have forgotten.

Na'e ngalo 'iate kimautilu.

We forgot.

Both *mahino* and *ngalo* come up constantly in conversation. The pattern is the same: the verb describes a state, and the person experiencing that state appears after a preposition.

The Noun Particle *Ai*

Té ke 'alu ki Vava'u?

Will you go to Vava'u?

'Io, té u 'alu ki ai.

Yes, I will go there.

The particle *ai* takes the place of a noun after a preposition. Instead of repeating the place or person, you replace it with *ai*. It works like "there" in English: rather than saying "I will go to Vava'u," you say "I will go there."

Ai combines with all three prepositions:

Phrase	Meaning	Replaces
<i>ki ai</i>	to there, to him/her	<i>ki</i> + place or <i>kia</i> + name
<i>'i ai</i>	there, in it	<i>'i</i> + place
<i>mei ai</i>	from there, from it	<i>mei</i> + place

Ki ai

Té ke lea kia Sione?

Will you speak to Sione?

'Io, té u lea ki ai.

Yes, I will speak to him.

Ki ai replaces both *ki* + place and *kia* + person. Whether the original phrase was *ki Tonga* or *kia Sione*, the substitute is the same: *ki ai*.

Na'á ke tokoni kia Seini?

Did you help Seini?

'Io, na'á ku tokoni ki ai.

Yes, I helped her.

'I ai

'Okú ne 'i Tonga?

Is he in Tonga?

'Io, 'okú ne 'i ai.

Yes, he is there.

'I ai replaces *'i* + place. Where *'i Tonga* means “in Tonga,” *'i ai* means “there.” In this pattern, *'i ai* acts like a verb meaning “is there.”

'Oku ou 'i ai.

I am there.

Mei ai

Na'á ke ha'u mei Fisi?

Did you come from Fiji?

'Io, na'á ku ha'u mei ai.

Yes, I came from there.

Mei ai replaces *mei* + place. Where *mei Fisi* means “from Fiji,” *mei ai* means “from there.”

Na'a mau 'alu mei ai 'aneafi.

We left there yesterday.

Ai works for singular or plural, for people or places. It is one of the most common words in spoken Tongan.

Ki fē

Na'á ke 'alu ki fē?

Where did you go? (Lit. “You went to where?”)

Replace the destination with *fē* to ask where someone is going or went. This mirrors *'i fē* (where at?) from the previous chapter.

Té ke 'alu ki fē 'apongipongi?

Where will you go tomorrow?

'Alu ki fē?: A Common Greeting

'Alu ki fē?

Where are you going?

'Alu pē ki hē.

Just going over there.

This is one of the most common expressions in spoken Tongan. It is a greeting: Tongans ask it when they see someone walking by, much the way English speakers say “How’s it going?” The tense marker and pronoun are dropped. The full form uses a construction covered in Chapter 17: Possessives. Learn *’Alu ki fē?* as a fixed expression meaning “Where are you going?”

Travel Compounds

Na’á ku ha’u vakapuna.

I came by plane.

Na’á ku ha’u pasī.

I came by bus.

When you travel by a specific means of transport, Tongan places the transport noun directly after the travel verb with no preposition. The noun *vakapuna* (*aeroplane*) sits right after *ha’u* (come), forming a single unit. This works the same way as the indefinite objects you already know (*kai mā* = eat bread, *inu vai* = drink water): the verb and the noun combine into one idea.

Tongan	English
<i>ha’u vakapuna</i>	come by plane
<i>’alu loli</i>	go by truck
<i>ha’u pasī</i>	come by bus
<i>’alu pasikala</i>	go by bicycle
<i>folau vaka</i>	travel by boat

The nouns *loli* (*truck*), *pasī* (*bus*), and *pasikala* (*bicycle*) are loanwords. The verb *folau* (*to sail, to travel*) pairs naturally with *vaka* (*boat*).

Na’á ne ’alu loli ki kolo.

He went by truck to town.

Na'a mau ha'u pasī mei Nuku'alofa.

We came by bus from Nuku'alofa.

Travel compounds fit into longer sentences alongside *ki* and *mei* phrases. The compound comes right after the pronoun, and the prepositional phrases follow.

Hā: *By What Means?*

Na'a ke ha'u hā mei Fisi?

How did you come from Fiji? (Lit. “You came what from Fiji?”)

The interrogative *hā* placed after a travel verb asks “by what means?” or “how?” The answer is a travel compound:

Na'a ke ha'u hā mei Fisi?

Na'a ku ha'u vakapuna.

I came by plane.

Hā sits between the travel verb and any prepositional phrase. It has other uses in Tongan covered in Chapter 11: Question Words. In the pattern taught here, it asks specifically about means of transport.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>ki</i>	preposition	to, toward
<i>mei</i>	preposition	from
<i>kia</i>	preposition (<i>ki</i> + personal noun)	to (before a person's name)
<i>'ia</i>	preposition (<i>'i</i> + personal noun)	at (before a person's name)

Tongan	Function	English
<i>meia</i>	preposition (<i>mei</i> + personal noun)	from (before a person's name)
<i>kiate</i>	preposition (<i>ki</i> + pronoun)	to (before a pronoun)
<i>'iate</i>	preposition (<i>'i</i> + pronoun)	at (before a pronoun)
<i>meiate</i>	preposition (<i>mei</i> + pronoun)	from (before a pronoun)
<i>ai</i>	noun particle	there, it (replaces noun after preposition)
<i>hā</i>	question word	by what means, how

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>sio</i>	verb	see, look at
<i>fanongo</i>	verb	listen, hear
<i>'ofa</i>	verb	love
<i>mahino</i>	verb	be clear, be understandable
<i>ngalo</i>	verb	be forgotten
<i>folau</i>	verb	sail, travel by sea
<i>vaka</i>	noun	boat
<i>vakapuna</i>	noun	aeroplane
<i>loli</i>	noun	truck
<i>pasī</i>	noun	bus
<i>pasikala</i>	noun	bicycle

Tongan	Type	English
<i>fale mohe</i>	noun	dormitory

Exercises

Exercise 1: Fill in the blank with 'i, ki, or mei

1. Na'á ku 'alu __ Vava'u.
2. 'Oku mau nofo __ 'api.
3. Na'á ne ha'u __ Fisi.
4. Té ke folau __ Ha'apai?
5. Na'á ku mohe __ fale mohe.
6. Na'a mau ha'u __ kolo.
7. Te tau 'alu __ tahi.

Exercise 2: Fill in the blank with the correct preposition form

Choose from: ki / kia / kiate, 'i / 'ia / 'iate, mei / meia / meiate.

1. Na'á ku lea __ Sione.
2. Té ke 'alu __ kolo?
3. 'Oku ou sio __ 'Ana.
4. 'Oku mahino __ au.
5. Na'e ngalo __ au.
6. 'Oku ou 'ofa lahi __ koe.
7. Na'á ne ha'u __ kimautolu.
8. Na'á ku lea __ ia.

Exercise 3: Translate into English

1. Na'á ku lea kia Sione.
2. Té ke 'alu ki fē?
3. Na'a mau ha'u vakapuna mei 'Amelika.
4. 'Oku ou fanongo kia 'Ana.

5. *Na'á ne 'alu loli ki kolo.*
6. *'Okú ne 'i ai.*
7. *Na'á ku tokoni ki ai.*

Exercise 4: Answer the question using *ai*

Replace the place or name with the correct *ai* form.

1. *Té ke 'alu ki Vava'u?* → *'Io, té u 'alu __.*
2. *'Okú ne 'i Tonga?* → *'Io, 'okú ne __.*
3. *Na'á ke ha'u mei Fisi?* → *'Io, na'á ku ha'u __.*
4. *Té ke lea kia Mele?* → *'Io, té u lea __.*
5. *Na'á ne 'alu mei 'api?* → *'Io, na'á ne 'alu __.*
6. *'Okú ke 'i kolo?* → *'Io, 'oku ou __.*

Exercise 5: Translate into Tongan

1. I spoke to Ofa.
2. Where did you go?
3. We came from Ha'apai by boat.
4. She will help Seini.
5. I understand.
6. I went from home to town yesterday.
7. Yes, I will go there.

Answers

Exercise 1

1. *ki.* I went to Vava'u.
2. *'i.* We live at home.
3. *mei.* He came from Fiji.
4. *ki.* Will you sail to Ha'apai?
5. *'i.* I slept in the dormitory.
6. *mei.* We came from town.
7. *ki.* We will go to the sea.

Exercise 2

1. *kia*. Sione is a personal noun.
2. *ki*. Kolo is a local noun.
3. *kia*. 'Ana is a personal noun.
4. *kiate*. Au is a pronoun. (*mahino* takes *kiate*)
5. *'iate*. Au is a pronoun. (*ngalo* takes *'iate*)
6. *'iate*. Koe is a pronoun. (*'ofa* takes *'iate*)
7. *meiate*. Kimautolu is a pronoun.
8. *kiate*. Ia is a pronoun.

Exercise 3

1. I spoke to Sione.
2. Where will you go?
3. We came by plane from America.
4. I listen to 'Ana.
5. He went by truck to town.
6. He is there.
7. I helped him/her.

Exercise 4

1. *ki ai*. *Ki ai* replaces *ki Vava'u*.
2. *'i ai*. *'I ai* replaces *'i Tonga*.
3. *mei ai*. *Mei ai* replaces *mei Fisi*.
4. *ki ai*. *Ki ai* replaces *kia Mele*.
5. *mei ai*. *Mei ai* replaces *mei 'api*.
6. *'i ai*. *'I ai* replaces *'i kolo*.

Exercise 5

1. *Na'a ku lea kia 'Ofa*.
2. *Na'a ke 'alu ki fē?*
3. *Na'a mau ha'u vaka mei Ha'apai*. (also acceptable: *Na'a mau folau vaka mei Ha'apai*.)

4. *Té ne tokoni kia Seini.*
5. *'Oku mahino kiate au.*
6. *Na'á ku 'alu mei 'api ki kolo 'aneafi.*
7. *'Io, té u 'alu ki ai.*

Chapter 8: Articles

Nouns so far have appeared either as indefinite objects joined directly to a verb (*kai mā, inu vai*) or after a preposition (*ki Tonga, 'i 'api*). This chapter introduces articles, the small words placed before a noun to signal whether you mean “a” thing or “the” thing. Tongan has two articles: *ha* for “a,” “some,” or “any,” and *e* (or *he*) for “the.”

The Indefinite Article: *Ha*

'Oku ou fiema'u ha ika.

I want some fish.

The word *ha* placed before a noun means “a,” “some,” or “any.” It signals that the speaker does not have a specific one in mind. The noun *ika* (*fish*) is a common food word, like *mā* and *vai* from earlier chapters. The verb *fiema'u* (*to want, to need*) takes its object with *ha* when the speaker means any or some of that thing.

Compare these two sentences:

'Oku ou inu vai.

I drink water.

Na’á ku inu ha vai.

I drank some water.

In the first sentence, *inu vai* is the kind of verb-object unit from earlier chapters: the verb and noun sit together with nothing between them. In the second, *ha* appears between the verb and the noun. The noun phrase *ha vai* means “some water,” not a specific glass of water.

The word *ha* marks its noun as indefinite, without specifying a particular one. In English, “a” implies one. In Tongan, *ha* does not. *Ha talo* can mean “a taro” or “some taro.” Context decides.

Ha is common in questions:

’Okú ke fiema’u ha vai?

Do you want some water?

’Okú ke fiema’u ha ika?

Do you want some fish? (The noun *ika* (fish) works the same way.)

It also appears in suggestions using the imperative:

Inu ha vai.

Drink some water.

Ha appears frequently in negative sentences as well, once you learn negation in the next chapter.

Tongan	English
<i>fiema’u ha talo</i>	want some taro
<i>fiema’u ha vai</i>	want some water
<i>inu ha tī</i>	drink some tea
<i>kai ha ika</i>	eat some fish

The nouns *talo* (taro), *ika* (fish), and *tī* (tea) are content words that slot into these patterns like *mā* and *vai* from earlier chapters.

Four more nouns work the same way: *kato* (basket), *hele* (knife), *fala* (mat), and *moa* (chicken).

'Oku ou fiema'u ha kato (basket). I want a basket.

Kai ha moa (chicken). Eat some chicken.

The Definite Article: *E* and *He*

Na'á ke kai e mā?

Did you eat the bread?

The definite article tells the listener you mean a specific thing. Tongan has two forms of the definite article: *e* and *he*. They mean the same thing. The form depends on which word comes directly before the article.

Use *he* right after the prepositions *'i*, *ki*, and *mei*:

Té u 'alu ki he fale.

I will go to the house.

Na'á ku nofo 'i he fale kai.

I stayed in the cafeteria.

Na'a mau ha'u mei he kolo.

We came from the town.

Use *e* in all other positions:

Na'á ke kai 'a e mā?

Did you eat the bread?

'Oku ou fiema'u 'a e talo.

I want the taro. (a specific amount, already identified)

The full rule: *he* appears immediately after *ʻi*, *ki*, *mei*, and one other preposition (*ʻe*) that you will encounter in Chapter 19: Transitive Word Order. Everywhere else, use *e*.

Position	Form	Example
After <i>ʻi</i>	<i>he</i>	<i>ʻi he fale</i> in the house
After <i>ki</i>	<i>he</i>	<i>ki he fale</i> to the house
After <i>mei</i>	<i>he</i>	<i>mei he kolo</i> from the town
Elsewhere	<i>e</i> (or <i>ʻa e</i>)	<i>ʻa e mā</i> the bread

Here is an imperative that combines the preposition *ki* with the definite article: *Haʻu ki he fale*.
Come to the house.

The noun *fale* (*house*) follows *ki he*, using the *he* form because the preposition *ki* comes directly before the article.
The new nouns follow these same rules:
Naʻá ke sio ki he hele (knife)? Did you look at the knife?
Naʻá ku nofo ʻi he fala (mat). I sat on the mat.

The Contrast: *Ha* vs. *E/He*

You now have three ways to connect a noun to a verb, depending on how specific the noun is:

Type	Pattern	Example	Meaning
Bare noun	verb + noun	<i>kai mā</i>	eat bread
Indefinite article	verb + <i>ha</i> + noun	<i>kai ha mā</i>	eat some bread
Definite article	verb + <i>'a e</i> + noun	<i>kai 'a e mā</i>	eat the bread

The bare noun and the *ha* noun are both indefinite, but they are not identical. The bare noun (*kai mā*) treats verb and noun as a single unit. The *ha* noun (*kai ha mā*) separates them: the speaker means “some bread” as a distinct thing, even though not a specific piece.

The full contrast looks like this:

'Oku ou fiema'u talo.

I want taro.

'Oku ou fiema'u ha talo.

I want some taro.

'Oku ou fiema'u 'a e talō.

I want the taro.

Preview of the focus marker 'a: The small word *'a* before the article *e* is a focus marker. It signals which noun is most directly connected to the verb’s action. When a definite noun is the object of a verb, *'a* appears before the article: *kai 'a e mā* (eat the bread). You will learn the full pattern in Chapter 15: Noun Subjects, and again in Chapter 19: Transitive Word Order. For now, notice that *'a e* belongs together as a unit before definite nouns that are acted on by the verb.

In the third sentence, notice the stress on the last vowel of *talō*. This is the definitive accent, a stress shift that marks a definite noun as fully specific (both speaker and listener know exactly which one). The definitive accent is covered formally in Chapter 18: Definiteness and the Definitive Accent. The basic distinction between *ha* (indefinite) and *e/he* (definite) is what matters.

Dropping *I* Before *He*

In spoken Tongan, when *ʻi* comes directly before *he*, the *ʻi* is regularly dropped. The result sounds like *he* alone instead of *ʻi he*:

Té u nofo ʻi he fale. → *Té u nofo he fale.* I will stay in the house.
ʻOkú ke ngāue ʻi he kolo? → *ʻOkú ke ngāue he kolo?* Do you work in the town?
The verb *ngāue* (*to work*) follows the same pattern as other verbs you already know.

Both forms are correct. In writing, you will see either *ʻi he* or *he*. In speech, the short form is normal.

This applies only to *ʻi*. The prepositions *ki* and *mei* keep their full form before *he*: *ki he fale* (*to the house*), *mei he kolo* (*from the town*).

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>ha</i>	indefinite article	a, some, any

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>fiemaʻu</i>	verb	want, need
<i>faiako</i>	noun	teacher
<i>kato</i>	noun	basket
<i>hele</i>	noun	knife
<i>fala</i>	noun	mat

Tongan	Type	English
<i>moa</i>	noun	chicken

Exercises

Exercise 1: Fill in the blank with *ha* or *'a e*

1. 'Oku ou fiema'u __ vai. (I want some water.)
2. Na'á ke kai __ mā? (Did you eat the bread?)
3. Té u inu __ tī. (I will drink some tea.)
4. 'Okú ke fiema'u __ ika? (Do you want some fish?)
5. Na'á ku kai __ talo. (I ate the taro.)
6. Na'a mau fiema'u __ kava. (We wanted some kava.)

Exercise 2: Fill in the blank with *'a e* or *he*

1. Na'á ku 'alu ki __ fale. (I went to the house.)
2. 'Oku ou nofo 'i __ kolo. (I live in the town.)
3. Na'á ke kai __ ika? (Did you eat the fish?)
4. Na'a mau ha'u mei __ fale kai. (We came from the cafeteria.)
5. Tokoni ki __ faiako. (Help the teacher.)
6. 'Oku ou fiema'u __ mā. (I want the bread.)

Exercise 3: Translate into English

1. 'Oku ou fiema'u ha talo.
2. Na'á ke kai 'a e ika?
3. Té u 'alu ki he fale kai.
4. Na'á ku inu ha kava.
5. Tokoni ki he faiako.
6. Na'a mau fiema'u 'a e vai.

Exercise 4: Translate into Tongan

1. I want some water.

2. Did you eat the bread?
3. I will go to the house.
4. We came from the town.
5. Help the teacher.
6. I drank some tea.

Exercise 5: Choose the correct sentence

For each pair, choose the sentence that uses articles correctly.

1. (a) *Na'á ku 'alu ki e fale.* / (b) *Na'á ku 'alu ki he fale.*
2. (a) *'Oku ou fiema'u 'a e talo.* / (b) *'Oku ou fiema'u he talo.*
3. (a) *Na'a mau nofo 'i he kolo.* / (b) *Na'a mau nofo 'i e kolo.*
4. (a) *Té ke kai 'a e mā?* / (b) *Té ke kai he mā?*
5. (a) *Na'á ku ha'u mei ha kolo.* / (b) *Na'á ku ha'u mei he kolo.*

Answers

Exercise 1

1. *ha.* I want some water. (indefinite)
2. *'a e.* Did you eat the bread? (definite: the focus marker 'a appears before the article)
3. *ha.* I will drink some tea. (indefinite)
4. *ha.* Do you want some fish? (indefinite)
5. *'a e.* I ate the taro. (definite: the focus marker 'a appears before the article)
6. *ha.* We wanted some kava. (indefinite)

Exercise 2

1. *he.* After *ki*, use *he*.
2. *he.* After *'i*, use *he*.
3. *'a e.* No preposition before the article, so use 'a e (the focus marker 'a + article e).
4. *he.* After *mei*, use *he*.
5. *he.* After *ki*, use *he*.

6. 'a e. No preposition before the article, so use 'a e (the focus marker 'a + article e).

Exercise 3

1. I want some taro.
2. Did you eat the fish?
3. I will go to the cafeteria.
4. I drank some kava.
5. Help the teacher.
6. We want the water.

Exercise 4

1. 'Oku ou fiema'u ha vai.
2. Na'á ke kai 'a e mā?
3. Té u 'alu ki he fale.
4. Na'a mau ha'u mei he kolo.
5. Tokoni ki he faiako.
6. Na'á ku inu ha tī.

Exercise 5

1. (b) Na'á ku 'alu ki he fale. After ki, use he.
2. (a) 'Oku ou fiema'u 'a e talo. No preposition before the article, so use 'a e.
3. (a) Na'a mau nofo 'i he kolo. After 'i, use he.
4. (a) Té ke kai 'a e mā? No preposition before the article, so use 'a e.
5. (b) Na'á ku ha'u mei he kolo. After mei, use he. (Choice (a) with ha would mean “from a/some town,” changing the meaning.)

Chapter 9: The Negative

Every sentence so far has been a positive statement. This chapter introduces *'ikai*, the Tongan word for “not.”

Saying “Not” with a Pronoun: *'ikai Te*

'Oku ou fiefia.

I am happy.

'Oku 'ikai té u fiefia.

I am not happy. (Lit. “Is not I happy”)

To negate a sentence that has a pronoun subject, place *'ikai te* between the tense marker and the pronoun. The verb and everything after it stay in their normal positions.

Positive: TM + pronoun + verb **Negative:** TM + *'ikai te* + pronoun + verb

After *te*, the first-person singular pronoun is *u*. This is the same form you already use with the future tense marker: *té u 'alu* (I will go). All other pronouns keep their usual forms.

The *te* in *'ikai te* is not the future tense marker. It is a connecting word that appears only in the negative pattern, before a pronoun. It has no English translation on its own. Even though this *te* is not the future tense marker, the stress rule from Chapter 2 still applies: *te* joins with a one-syllable pronoun as one pronounced unit, and the acute accent marks the shifted stress. That is why this book writes *'ikai té u*, *'ikai té ke*, and *'ikai té ne*.

Compare a question with its negative answer:

'Okú ke fiekaia?

Are you hungry?

'Oku 'ikai té u fiekaia.

I am not hungry.

All the adjectives you already know (*fiefia*, *hela'ia*, *'ita*, *fiekaia*) negate the same way, because adjectives fill the verb slot in Tongan. Three more adjectives follow the same pattern: *puke* (*sick*), *vela* (*hot*), and *'afua* (*fine, clear weather*).

'Oku 'ikai té u puke (*sick*). I am not sick.

'Oku 'ikai té ne hela'ia.

He is not tired.

'Oku 'ikai te nau 'ita.

They are not angry.

Positive	Negative
<i>'Oku ou fiefia.</i>	<i>'Oku 'ikai té u fiefia.</i>
I am happy.	I am not happy.
<i>'Okú ke mohe.</i>	<i>'Oku 'ikai té ke mohe.</i>
You are sleeping.	You are not sleeping.

Positive	Negative
<i>'Okú ne 'ita.</i> He is angry.	<i>'Oku 'ikai té ne 'ita.</i> He is not angry.
<i>'Oku mau hela'ia.</i> We are tired.	<i>'Oku 'ikai te mau hela'ia.</i> We are not tired.
<i>'Oku nau fiekaia.</i> They are hungry.	<i>'Oku 'ikai te nau fiekaia.</i> They are not hungry.

Negation Across Tenses

The negative pattern works in all three tenses. The tense marker changes, but *'ikai te* stays the same:

Tense	Negative	English
Present	<i>'Oku 'ikai té u fiefia.</i>	I am not happy.
Past	<i>Na'e 'ikai té u fiefia.</i>	I was not happy.
Future	<i>'E 'ikai té u fiefia.</i>	I will not be happy.

In a positive sentence, you say *na'á ku fiefia* because *na'a* goes directly before a pronoun. In the negative, the word immediately after the tense marker is *'ikai*, not a pronoun. The rule you learned earlier applies: *na'a* appears before pronouns, *na'e* appears elsewhere. Since *'ikai* is not a pronoun, the past negative uses *na'e*.

The same logic explains the future. In a positive sentence, *te* goes before a pronoun: *Té u fiefia*. In the negative, the tense marker is followed by *'ikai*, so *'e* is used: *'E 'ikai té u fiefia*.

	Before a pronoun (positive)	Before <i>'ikai</i> (negative)
Past	<i>na'a</i>	<i>na'e</i>
Future	<i>te</i>	<i>'e</i>

More examples across tenses:

Na'e 'ikai té u tokoni kia Sione.

I did not help Sione.

'E 'ikai té ke nofo 'i Tonga.

You will not stay in Tonga.

Na'e 'ikai te mau kai ika 'anepō.

We did not eat fish last night.

'Oku 'ikai té ne ngāue mālohi.

He does not work hard.

The verb *ngāue* (*to work*) is intransitive, like the verbs you already know.

Note:

You may hear *he 'ikai te* in place of *'e 'ikai te* in future negatives. This form gives stronger emphasis to the denial. Both forms mean the same thing.

When There Is No Pronoun: *'ikai Ke*

Some sentences describe a condition without naming who or what causes it. Weather is the clearest case.

Na'e matangi 'anepō.

It was windy last night.

The word *matangi* (*windy*) fills the verb slot. There is no pronoun subject because no person is doing the action.

To negate this kind of sentence, use *'ikai ke* (not *'ikai te*):

Na'e 'ikai ke matangi 'anepō.

It was not windy last night.

The rule: *'ikai te* appears before a pronoun. *'ikai ke* appears directly before a verb. This mirrors the split you already know in tense markers: one form before pronouns (*na'a, te*), another elsewhere (*na'e, 'e*).

'Oku 'ikai ke 'uha.

It is not raining.

The word *'uha* (to rain) is another weather verb with no pronoun subject.

The word *momoko* (cold) works the same way, along with *vela* (hot) and *'afua* (fine, clear).

'E 'ikai ke momoko 'apongipongi.

It will not be cold tomorrow.

'Oku 'ikai ke vela (hot). It is not hot.

Na'e 'ikai ke 'afua (fine) *'aneafi*. It was not fine yesterday.

***'ikai* as a Response**

You have seen *'ikai* since the earliest chapters as a one-word answer meaning “no.” This is the same word:

Na'a ke kai?

Did you eat?

'ikai.

No.

On its own, *'ikai* is a complete negative response, the counterpart of *'to* (yes).

Softening a Negative: *Loko*

The preposed modifier *loko* appears after a negative to weaken it. Where *'ikai* alone means “not,” adding *loko* produces “not too” or “not particularly.”

'Oku 'ikai ke loko lelei 'a e ika.

The fish is not too good.

'Oku 'ikai ke loko momoko.

It is not too cold.

Na'e 'ikai ke loko lelei 'emau ngāuē.

Our work was not too good.

The pattern is always: negative + *ke* + *loko* + verb. Without the negative, *loko* does not appear.

Strengthening a Negative: *Teitei*

Where *loko* softens a negative, *teitei* intensifies it. Combined with a negative, *teitei* means “at all” or “certainly not.”

'E 'ikai té u teitei 'alu.

I am certainly not going.

'Oku 'ikai té u teitei ngāue.

I absolutely do not work.

Na'e 'ikai té u teitei kai.

I absolutely did not eat.

He 'ikai té ke teitei mohe.

You are certainly not sleeping.

The pattern: negative + TM + pronoun + *teitei* + verb. In this “at all / certainly not” sense, *teitei* always sits inside a negative.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>na’e</i>	past tense marker (before non-pronouns)	no single English word; it puts the verb in past time (<i>Na’e ’uha</i> = “It rained”)
<i>’e</i>	future tense marker (before non-pronouns)	no single English word; it puts the verb in future time (usually “will ...”)

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>matangi</i>	adjective	windy
<i>’uha</i>	verb	rain
<i>puke</i>	adjective	sick
<i>’afua</i>	adjective	fine, clear (weather)
<i>vela</i>	adjective	hot

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate into English

- 1. *’Oku ’ikai té u ’ita.*
- 2. *Na’e ’ikai té ke mohe ’anepō?*
- 3. *’E ’ikai te nau ha’u ’apongipongi.*

4. 'Oku 'ikai te mau fiekaia.
5. Na'e 'ikai ke 'uha 'aneafi.
6. 'E 'ikai té ne nofo 'i Tonga.

Exercise 2: Translate into Tongan

1. I am not tired.
2. He was not happy yesterday.
3. We will not go to Vava'u.
4. They are not angry.
5. It was not cold last night.
6. You will not eat fish tomorrow.

Preview:

A few exercises below use *mo* + a name, meaning “with” (*mo Sione* = “with Sione”). You will study this fully in the next chapter; here you only need to read it as “with.”

Exercise 3: Change each positive sentence to its negative form

1. 'Oku ou fiefia.
2. Na'a ne 'alu ki kolo.
3. 'Oku nau mohe.
4. Té ke kai mā 'apongipongi.
5. Na'a ku kai ika 'anepō.
6. Na'a mau hiva mo Sione 'anepō.
7. 'Okú ne ngāue mālohi.

Exercise 4: Fill in each blank with *te* or *ke*

1. 'Oku 'ikai __ u hela'ia.
2. Na'e 'ikai __ matangi.
3. 'E 'ikai __ ke 'alu ki Tonga.
4. 'Oku 'ikai __ momoko.
5. Na'e 'ikai __ nau fiefia.
6. 'E 'ikai __ 'uha 'apō.

Exercise 5: Translate into English. These sentences combine grammar from previous chapters with negation

1. Na'e 'ikai té u 'alu ki kolo mo Mele 'aneafi.
2. 'E 'ikai te mau kai ika 'i fale kai 'apō.
3. 'Oku 'ikai te nau nofo 'i Vava'u mo Tēvita.
4. Na'e 'ikai ke matangi lahi 'anepō.
5. 'E 'ikai té ne ha'u mei Fisi 'apongipongi.

Exercise 6: Translate into Tongan using loko or teitei

1. The work is not too good. (loko)
 2. I am certainly not going to town. (teitei)
 3. It is not too cold. (loko)
 4. He absolutely did not help. (teitei)
-

Answers

Exercise 1

1. I am not angry.
2. Did you not sleep last night?
3. They will not come tomorrow.
4. We are not hungry.
5. It did not rain yesterday.
6. He will not stay in Tonga.

Exercise 2

1. 'Oku 'ikai té u hela'ia.
2. Na'e 'ikai té ne fiefia 'aneafi.
3. 'E 'ikai te mau 'alu ki Vava'u.
4. 'Oku 'ikai te nau 'ita.
5. Na'e 'ikai ke momoko 'anepō.
6. 'E 'ikai té ke kai ika 'apongipongi.

Exercise 3

1. 'Oku 'ikai té u fiefia.
2. Na'e 'ikai té ne 'alu ki kolo.
3. 'Oku 'ikai te nau mohe.
4. 'E 'ikai té ke kai mā 'apongipongi.
5. Na'e 'ikai té u kai ika 'anepō.
6. Na'e 'ikai te mau hiva mo Sione 'anepō.
7. 'Oku 'ikai té ne ngāue mālohi.

Exercise 4

1. *te* (pronoun *u* follows)
2. *ke* (verb *matangi* follows, no pronoun)
3. *te* (pronoun *ke* follows)
4. *ke* (verb *momoko* follows, no pronoun)
5. *te* (pronoun *nau* follows)
6. *ke* (verb *'uha* follows, no pronoun)

Exercise 5

1. I did not go to town with Mele yesterday.
2. We will not eat fish at the cafeteria tonight.
3. They do not live in Vava'u with Tēvita.
4. It was not very windy last night.
5. He will not come from Fiji tomorrow.

Exercise 6

1. 'Oku 'ikai ke loko lelei 'a e ngāué.
2. 'E 'ikai té u teitei 'alu ki kolo.
3. 'Oku 'ikai ke loko momoko.
4. Na'e 'ikai té ne teitei tokoni.

Chapter 10: The Comitative *Mo*

The preposition *mo* means “with” in the sense of “together with.” With *mo*, you can say who accompanied you, list people by name, express bringing or taking something along, and give commands to two people.

***Mo*: With, Together With**

Na’á ku ’alu mo Sione.

I went with Sione.

The preposition *mo* goes directly before a person’s name to show accompaniment. It works like the prepositions you already know: it sits in the sentence after the verb and any location phrases.

’Oku ou nofo ’i Vava’u mo Mele.

I live in Vava’u with Mele.

Na’á ne ha’u mei Tonga mo Tēvita.

He came from Tonga with Tēvita.

Tongan	English
<i>Na’á ku ’alu mo ’Ofa.</i>	I went with Ofa.
<i>’Oku ou ako mo Seini.</i>	I study with Seini.
<i>Na’a mau hiva mo Sione.</i>	We sang with Sione.
<i>Té ke nofo mo ’Ana?</i>	Will you stay with ’Ana?

The verb *ako* (to study, to learn) is intransitive, like *’alu* and *nofo*. It follows the same sentence pattern.

Note: Mo means “with” only in the sense of “together with” or “in the company of.” It does not cover the instrumental sense of “with” (using a tool to do something), which Tongan expresses with *’aki*. That construction is covered in Chapter 33: Instrumental *’aki* and the Suffix *-’i*.

The *mo* phrase fits naturally into longer sentences. Time words still come last:
Na’á ku ’alu ki kolo mo Sione ’aneafi.

I went to town with Sione yesterday.

Te tau hiva mo Mele ’apō.

We will sing with Mele tonight.

***Mo* Connecting Names: And**

Na’á ku lea kia Sione mo Mele.

I spoke to Sione and Mele.

When *mo* appears between two names, it means “and.” This is the same word doing double duty: *Sione mo Mele* means “Sione together-with Mele,” which in practice means “Sione and Mele.”

To list three or more names, repeat *mo* before each:

Tēvita mo Seini mo Lupe. Tēvita, Seini, and Lupe

Na’a mau ’alu ki tahi mo Sēmisi mo ’Ana.

We went to the sea with Sēmisi and ’Ana.

Tongan	English
<i>Sione mo ’Ofa</i>	Sione and Ofa
<i>Mele mo Seini mo ’Ana</i>	Mele, Seini, and ’Ana

Taking Something Along

Ha’u mo e tohí!

Come with the book! (Lit. “Come with the book!”)

’Alu mo e valá!

Take the clothes! (Lit. “Go with the clothes!”)

When a motion verb like *’alu* (go) or *ha’u* (come) combines with *mo* and a thing, the meaning shifts from accompaniment to taking or bringing. *Ha’u mo e tohí!* literally means “Come with the book” but idiomatically means “Bring the book (to me).” *’Alu mo e valá!* means “Take the clothes (with you).”

The word *e* before *tohí* (*book*) and *valá* (*clothes*) is the definite article you learned earlier. It marks a specific item: not any book, but *the* book.

With a person’s name, no article is needed. Whether *Na’a ku ’alu mo Sione* means “I went with Sione” or “I took Sione along” depends on context. The grammar is the same.

Note:
You may encounter the word *fakataha* (*together*) alongside *mo*. It reinforces the idea of accompaniment. It is not formally covered in this chapter.

***Mo* with Pronouns**

Na'á ne 'alu mo au.

He went with me.

When *mo* points at a pronoun instead of a name, the pronoun takes its postposed (long) form: *au* (me), *koe* (you), *ia* (him/her), and the rest of the set you learned earlier.

Unlike the prepositions *ki*, *'i*, and *mei*, which change form before pronouns (*ki-ate*, *'iate*, *meiate*), *mo* does not change. It stays as *mo*, followed directly by the postposed pronoun.

Tongan	English
<i>mo au</i>	with me
<i>mo koe</i>	with you
<i>mo ia</i>	with him/her
<i>mo kitaua</i>	with us two (incl.)
<i>mo kimaaua</i>	with us two (excl.)
<i>mo kimoua</i>	with you two
<i>mo kinaua</i>	with them two
<i>mo kitautolu</i>	with us (incl.)
<i>mo kimautilu</i>	with us (excl.)
<i>mo kimoutolu</i>	with you all
<i>mo kinautilu</i>	with them

Na'a mau 'alu ki kolo mo ia.

We went to town with him.

'Okú ne nofo mo au.

She lives with me.

Té ke ha’u mo kimautilu?

Will you come with us?

Commands to Two People: ***Mo*** + Verb

Mo hopo!

Jump! (you two)

In Chapter 5: Commands and Emphasis, you learned that a bare verb makes a command to one person (*Hopo!*), and *mou* before the verb makes a command to a group of three or more (*Mou hopo!*). There is a third form for exactly two people: *mo* before the verb.

The verb *hopo* (to jump) is new vocabulary.

Here, *mo* is not the preposition meaning “with.” It is the dual pronoun *mo* (you two) that you know from statements like *na’á mo kai* (you two ate). In commands, *mo* works the same way as *mou*, but it addresses two people instead of three or more.

One person	Two people	Three or more
<i>Hopo!</i>	<i>Mo hopo!</i>	<i>Mou hopo!</i>
<i>Nofo!</i>	<i>Mo nofo!</i>	<i>Mou nofo!</i>
<i>Kai!</i>	<i>Mo kai!</i>	<i>Mou kai!</i>
<i>’Alu!</i>	<i>Mo ō!</i>	<i>Mou ō!</i>

The plural verb forms apply: *’alu* becomes *ō* with two or more people, just as it does with *mou*.

Note:

Prohibitions for two people follow the same pattern as for groups: *’Oua té mo nofo!* (Don’t stay, you two!). The structure is *’oua te + mo + verb*.

***Kau ki* (concerning, about)**

The preposed modifier *kau* (*concerning, about*) is used with the *ki*-phrase to indicate the topic or subject matter. The structure is: verb + *kau ki* + noun phrase.

Na'á ke fanongo kau ki he ngāu'é?

Did you hear about the work?

Na'á ke lau kau ki he akó?

Did you read about the school?

Na'á ku lau ha tohi kau ki Tongá.

I read a book about Tonga.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>mo</i>	preposition	with, together with; and (also “you two” (Ch 2))
<i>kau ki</i>	preposition phrase	concerning, about

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>hopo</i>	verb	jump
<i>lau</i>	verb	read
<i>tohi</i>	noun/verb	book; write

Tongan	Type	English
<i>vala</i>	noun	clothes
<i>va'inga</i>	noun	game
<i>hisitōlia</i>	noun	history
<i>lotu</i>	noun	prayer, church service

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate into English

1. *Na'á ku 'alu ki kolo mo Mele.*
2. *'Oku ou ako mo Tēvita.*
3. *Na'a mau hiva mo 'Ofa 'anepō.*
4. *Té ke nofo mo Seini?*
5. *Na'á ne ha'u mei Fisi mo Sione.*
6. *Te tau 'alu ki tahi mo 'Ana 'apongipongi.*

Exercise 2: Translate into Tongan

1. I sang with Tēvita yesterday.
2. Are you going to town with Ofa?
3. We lived in Tonga with Sēmisi.
4. She came from Vava'u with Lupe.
5. I spoke to Sione and Mele.
6. I will study with 'Ana tomorrow.

Exercise 3: Fill in each blank with the correct preposition ('i, ki, mei, or mo)

1. *Na'á ku 'alu ___ kolo ___ Sione.*
2. *'Oku ou nofo ___ Tonga ___ Mele.*
3. *Na'a mau ha'u ___ Ha'apai ___ Tēvita.*
4. *Té ke mohe ___ fale mohe ___ 'Ofa?*

5. Na'á ne 'alu __ tahi __ Seini 'aneafi.

Exercise 4: Add the person shown in parentheses to each sentence using mo

Example: Na'á ku 'alu ki kolo. (+ Sione) → Na'á ku 'alu ki kolo mo Sione.

1. 'Oku ou ako. (+ 'Ana)
2. Na'a mau hiva 'anepō. (+ Mele)
3. Té ke nofo 'i Tonga? (+ Tēvita)
4. Na'á ne ha'u mei Fisi. (+ Sione)
5. Te tau 'alu ki tahi 'apongipongi. (+ 'Ofa mo Seini)

Exercise 5: Replace the name in each sentence with the pronoun in parentheses

Example: Na'á ku 'alu mo Sione. (ia) → Na'á ku 'alu mo ia.

1. Na'a mau nofo mo Mele. (ia)
2. Té ke ha'u mo 'Ana? (kimautolu)
3. Na'á ne 'alu ki kolo mo Sione. (au)
4. 'Oku ou ako mo Tēvita. (koe)
5. Na'a mau hiva mo 'Ofa mo Seini. (kinaua)

Exercise 6: Give the command for the number of people shown

Example: Eat! (1 person) → Kai!

1. Stay! (2 people)
2. Go! (3 or more people)
3. Jump! (1 person)
4. Jump! (2 people)
5. Go! (2 people)

Exercise 7: Translate into English. These sentences combine grammar from this and previous chapters

1. Na'á ku ha'u vakapuna mei Tonga mo ia 'aneafi.
2. Te tau kai 'i fale kai mo Mele 'apongipongi.
3. Na'a mau 'alu loli ki kolo mo Tēvita mo 'Ana.
4. 'Oku ou fanongo kia Sēmisi mo Lupe.
5. Na'á ne lea kia 'Ofa mo Seini 'anepō.

6. *Mo ō mu'a!*

Exercise 8: Translate into Tongan using *kau ki*

1. He is talking about the work.
 2. Did you hear about the game?
 3. We wrote about the school yesterday.
 4. She read a book about Tonga.
 5. Will you talk about the prayer tomorrow?
 6. I heard about the song.
-

Answers

Exercise 1

1. I went to town with Mele.
2. I study with Tēvita.
3. We sang with Ofa last night.
4. Will you stay with Seini?
5. He came from Fiji with Sione.
6. We will go to the sea with 'Ana tomorrow.

Exercise 2

1. *Na'á ku hiva mo Tēvita 'aneafi.*
2. *Té ke 'alu ki kolo mo 'Ofa?*
3. *Na'a mau nofo 'i Tonga mo Sēmisi.*
4. *Na'á ne ha'u mei Vava'u mo Lupe.*
5. *Na'á ku lea kia Sione mo Mele.*
6. *Té u ako mo 'Ana 'apongipongi.*

Exercise 3

1. *ki, mo.* I went to town with Sione.
2. *'i, mo.* I live in Tonga with Mele.
3. *mei, mo.* We came from Ha'apai with Tēvita.

4. 'i, mo. Will you sleep in the dormitory with Ofa?
5. ki, mo. He went to the sea with Seini yesterday.

Exercise 4

1. 'Oku ou ako mo 'Ana.
2. Na'a mau hiva mo Mele 'anepō.
3. Té ke nofo 'i Tonga mo Tēvita?
4. Na'á ne ha'u mei Fisi mo Sione.
5. Te tau 'alu ki tahi mo 'Ofa mo Seini 'apongipongi.

Exercise 5

1. Na'a mau nofo mo ia.
2. Té ke ha'u mo kimautolu?
3. Na'á ne 'alu ki kolo mo au.
4. 'Oku ou ako mo koe.
5. Na'a mau hiva mo kinaua.

Exercise 6

1. Mo nofo!
2. Mou ō!
3. Hopo!
4. Mo hopo!
5. Mo ō!

Exercise 7

1. I came by plane from Tonga with him yesterday.
2. We will eat at the cafeteria with Mele tomorrow.
3. We went by truck to town with Tēvita and 'Ana.
4. I listen to Sēmisi and Lupe.
5. He spoke to Ofa and Seini last night.
6. Please go! (you two)

Exercise 8

1. 'Okú ne lea kau ki he ngāué.
2. Na'á ke fanongo kau ki he va'ingá?
3. Na'a mau tohi kau ki he akó 'aneafi.
4. Na'á ne lau ha tohi kau ki Tongá.
5. Té ke lea kau ki he lotú 'apongipongi?
6. Na'á ku fanongo kau ki he hivá.

Chapter 11: Question Words

Beyond yes/no questions and location questions with *fē*, this chapter adds question words for asking where from, when, at what time, and how. Each question word sits where the answer would go.

Location Questions: *'i fē*, *ki fē*, *mei fē*

Two location phrases are already familiar:

Na'á ke nofo 'i fē?

Where did you stay?

Té ke lele ki fē?

Where are you running to?

The preposition *mei* (from) forms a third: *mei fē* (where from).

Na'á ke ha'u mei fē?

Where did you come from?

Na’á ku ha’u mei Fisi.

I came from Fiji.

Each phrase pairs a preposition with *fē* (where). The question sits where the answer goes:

Question	Asks about	Sample answer
<i>’i fē</i>	where at	<i>’i kolo</i> (in town)
<i>ki fē</i>	where to	<i>ki Fisi</i> (to Fiji)
<i>mei fē</i>	where from	<i>mei Tonga</i> (from Tonga)

When (Past): *’anefē*

Na’á ne tau mai ’anefē?

When did he/she arrive?

The word *’anefē* asks “when” about something that already happened. The verb *tau mai* (arrive) is new here. It works like any intransitive verb in the pattern you know.

’Anefē sits after the verb, in the same position as past time words like *’aneafi* (yesterday) and *’anepō* (last night). The answer fills the same slot:

Na’á ku tau mai ’aneafi.

I arrived yesterday.

Because *’anefē* asks about the past, it pairs with the past tense marker *na’a/na’e*:
Na’a nau ako ’anefē?

When did they study?

When (Future): 'afē*Te mau ha'u 'afē?*

When will we come?

The word 'afē asks “when” about something that has not happened yet. It fills the same slot as future time words like 'apongipongi (tomorrow) and 'apō (tonight):

Te nau foki mai 'afē?

When will they return?

The verb *foki* (return) was introduced back in Chapter 1. The word *mai* after it means “toward the speaker”: *foki mai* = come back.

Te mau foki 'apongipongi.

We will return tomorrow.

Note:

A third word, *fakakū*, can mean “when” for any time, past or future. You may hear it in conversation. 'Anefē and 'afē are far more common.

At What Time: fiha*Te tau kamata ako he fiha?*

When shall we start studying? (Lit. “at what number?”)

The word *fiha* asks “how many” or “at what time.” In time expressions, it combines with *he* (the definite article you learned in Chapter 8: Articles) and a clock number.

The verbs *kamata* (begin) and *ako* (study) are new. The answer to a *fiha* question gives a specific time:

Tau kamata he valu.

We will start at eight.

Fiha also carries the broader meaning “how many” and “how much.” That use expands in Chapter 20: Numbers and Time, which covers counting, quantities, and prices.

How: *fēfē*

’Okú ke fēfē?

How are you? (Lit. “You are how?”)

The word *fēfē* asks “how” or “in what state.” Here it fills the verb slot, asking about the listener’s condition.

Note:

The greeting *Fēfē hake?* (How are you?) is an idiomatic expression. You already know *fēfē* (how). The word *hake* means “up, upward,” and adds a sense of “how are you getting along?” Learn *Fēfē hake?* as a fixed greeting. The word *hake* is formally covered as a directional particle in Chapter 28: Directional Particles.

Fēfē also works after a verb, asking “in what way”:

Té ke ’alu fēfē ki Fisi?

How will you get to Fiji?

This is broader than *hā* (by what means), which you learned earlier for asking about transport. *Fēfē* asks about the manner in general.

Note:

These question words also work in sentences with named subjects instead of pronouns. The word order in those sentences is different. This pattern is covered in Chapter 15: Noun Subjects.

All Question Words So Far

Tongan	English
<i>'i fē</i>	where (at)
<i>ki fē</i>	where (to)
<i>mei fē</i>	where (from)
<i>hā</i>	by what means
<i>'anefē</i>	when (past)
<i>'afē</i>	when (future)
<i>fīha</i>	how many / at what time
<i>fēfē</i>	how

Postposed *hā* (what, what kind)

'Okú ke ngāue hā?

What work do you do? (Lit. You work what?)

The interrogative *hā* (*what, what kind*) can appear after the verb or noun it questions, in a postposed position. This differs from the *ko e hā* constructions introduced earlier.

'Okú ke siasi hā?

What church do you belong to?

'Okú ke faiako hā?

What do you teach?

The postposed *hā* produces a more casual, conversational question than *ko e hā 'a e siasi 'okú ke kau ki ai?* (What church do you belong to?), which is more formal.

As a verbal equivalent, *hā* can stand alone after a tense marker, meaning “why?” or “what’s wrong?”:

Na’e hā?

Why not? (Lit. It was what?)

’Oku hā?

What’s wrong with it? (Lit. It is what?)

Postposed *fē* (which)

Ko e fale fē na’á ke nofo ai?

Which house did you live in?

The interrogative *fē* (*which*) can appear after a noun as an adjective. The noun + *fē* combination asks the listener to specify which one.

’I he māhina feé?

In which month?

’A e hele feé?

Which knife?

When *fē* appears as a common noun with the definite article, it means “which one” as a standalone question:

’A e feé?

Which one?

Ki he feé?

Into which one?

Note:

The definitive accent appears on *fē* when it is definite (*feé*), following the standard rules for definite noun phrases.

***Fēfee'i* (how, transitive)**

Na'á ke langa fēfee'i 'a e falé?

How did you build the house? (Lit. You built how the house?)

The transitive form *fēfee'i* adds the suffix *-i* to *fēfē* (how). Where *fēfē* asks about a state or condition (*'Oku fēfē?* = How is it?), *fēfee'i* asks about the manner of doing something to an object.

Na'á ke fahi fēfee'i 'a e laupapá?

How did you split the board?

Té ke vahe fēfee'i 'a e kumalá?

How are you going to divide up the sweet potatoes?

The related form *fakafēfee'i* is more deliberate, requesting a precise or detailed answer:

Te mau langa fakafēfee'i 'a e falé?

Just how are we to build the house? (Please give detailed instructions.)

Note:

The examples in this section place a definite object after the verb, marked with *'a e* (as in *'a e falé* = the house). This full transitive word order is formally covered in Chapter 19: Transitive Word Order. For now, treat these *fēfee'i* sentences as fixed patterns for asking how something is done.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>mei fē</i>	question phrase	where from
<i>'anefē</i>	question word	when (past)
<i>'afē</i>	question word	when (future)
<i>fiha</i>	question word	how many, at what time
<i>fēfē</i>	question word	how, in what state
<i>fēfee'i</i>	transitive question word	how (manner of doing to something)
<i>fakafēfee'i</i>	intensive question word	how exactly
<i>mai</i>	directional particle	toward the speaker
<i>hake</i>	directional particle (preview)	up, upward

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>tau mai</i>	verb phrase	arrive
<i>kamata</i>	verb	begin, start
<i>langa</i>	verb	build
<i>fahi</i>	verb	split
<i>vahe</i>	verb	divide
<i>māhina</i>	noun	month
<i>laupapa</i>	noun	board, plank
<i>kumala</i>	noun	sweet potato
<i>fitu</i>	number	seven
<i>valu</i>	number	eight

Exercises**Exercise 1: Translate into English**

1. *Té ke 'alu 'afē?*
2. *Na'á ke nofo 'i fē 'anepō?*
3. *Na'á ke ha'u mei fē?*
4. *'Okú ke fēfē?*
5. *Te tau kamata ngāue he fiha?*
6. *Na'á ne foki mai 'anefē?*

Exercise 2: Translate into Tongan

1. Where did you sleep last night?
2. When are you going?
3. Where did you come from?
4. When will they return?
5. How are you?
6. When did they begin?

Exercise 3: Fill in the blank with the correct question word. The English meaning is given

1. *Na'á ke mohe __ 'anepō?* (Where did you sleep last night?)
2. *Té ke foki mai __?* (When will you return?)
3. *Na'á ke ha'u __?* (Where did you come from?)
4. *Te tau kamata __?* (At what time shall we start?)
5. *'Okú ke __?* (How are you?)
6. *Na'a nau hiva __?* (When did they sing?)

Exercise 4: Match each question (a-e) to its answer (1-5)

- a. *Té ke 'alu ki fē?*
- b. *Na'á ke ha'u mei fē?*
- c. *Na'á ke foki 'anefē?*

- d. *Té ke kamata he fiha?*
- e. *Na'á ke mohe 'i fē?*
- 1. *Na'á ku ha'u mei Tonga.*
- 2. *He fitu.*
- 3. *Ki kolo.*
- 4. *Na'á ku foki 'aneafi.*
- 5. *'I fale mohe.*

Exercise 5: Fill in the blank with *hā* or *fē*

- 1. *'Okú ke ngāue __?* What work do you do?
- 2. *'I he māhina __?* In which month?
- 3. *Na'e __?* Why not?
- 4. *Na'á ke mohe 'i he fale __?* Which house did you sleep in?
- 5. *'Oku __?* What's wrong?
- 6. *'Okú ne 'alu ki he kolo __?* Which town is he going to?
- 7. *'Okú ke ako __?* What are you studying?
- 8. *'I he 'aho __?* On which day?
- 9. *'Okú ne faiako __?* What does he teach?
- 10. *'I he hala __?* On which road?

Exercise 6: Translate into English

- 1. *'Okú ke siasi hā?*
- 2. *Na'á ke 'alu 'i he māhina feé?*
- 3. *'Okú ne ngāue hā?*
- 4. *'Okú ke faiako hā?*
- 5. *Na'e hā?*
- 6. *Na'á ke langa fēfee'i 'a e falé?*

Answers

Exercise 1

- 1. When are you going?

2. Where did you stay last night?
3. Where did you come from?
4. How are you?
5. When shall we start working?
6. When did he/she return?

Exercise 2

1. *Na'á ke mohe 'i fē 'anepō?*
2. *Té ke 'alu 'afē?*
3. *Na'á ke ha'u mei fē?*
4. *Te nau foki mai 'afē?*
5. *'Okú ke fēfē?*
6. *Na'a nau kamata 'anefē?*

Exercise 3

1. *'i fē*
2. *'afē*
3. *mei fē*
4. *he fiha*
5. *fēfē*
6. *'anefē*

Exercise 4

a: 3 b: 1 c: 4 d: 2 e: 5

Exercise 5

1. *hā*
2. *fē*
3. *hā*
4. *fē*
5. *hā*
6. *fē*
7. *hā*

8. *fē*
9. *hā*
10. *fē*

Exercise 6

1. What church do you belong to?
2. In which month did you go?
3. What work does he do?
4. What do you teach?
5. Why not?
6. How did you build the house?

Chapter 12: The *Ko* Pattern

Unlike the verb-first sentences built so far, the *ko* pattern has no verb and no tense marker. It uses the word *ko* to identify or name something.

What *ko* Does

Ko e hele 'eni.

This is a knife.

The word *hele* means “knife.” The word *ko* does the work that “is” does in English. It connects a thing to its identity, directing the listener’s attention to who or what is being talked about.

This is different from every sentence you’ve learned so far. Until now, all your sentences had a tense marker and a verb: *'Oku ou kai* = I am eating. A *ko* sentence has no verb and no tense marker. It simply tells you what something is, not what someone does

The basic pattern is: *ko e* + noun (+ demonstrative).

Ko e fala 'eni.

This is a mat.

Ko e hele ē.

That is a knife.

The words *fala* (*mat*), *hele* (*knife*), and *kato* (*basket*) are new vocabulary. The word *e* after *ko* is the definite article you learned earlier. In these sentences, *ko e* works as a unit meaning “it is a” or “this is a.”

Pointing and Identifying: *ko’eni*, *ko ē*, *ko’ena*

You already know the demonstratives of place: *heni* (here), *hena* (there, near you), *hē* (over there). Demonstratives are words that point. They tell the listener which thing you mean, as if you were pointing your finger.

The demonstratives *’eni*, *ē*, and *’ena* work in a similar three-way system, but they point at things rather than places:

Demonstrative	Meaning	Distance
<i>’eni</i>	this	near me
<i>’ena</i>	that	near you
<i>ē</i>	that	over there, or general pointing

When combined with *ko*, these become short identification statements, the kind of thing you say while pointing:

Ko’eni.

Here it is. (Lit. “It-is this-here”)

Ko ē!

There it is!

Ko’ena.

There it is (near you).

In daily speech, *ē* often covers the jobs of all three, especially in quick exchanges. It may function for both *'eni* and *'ena* as well as suggest distance.

These demonstratives also sit at the end of longer *ko* sentences, as in the examples above: *Ko e tohi 'eni* (This is a book), *Ko e hele ē* (That is a knife).

Asking “What Is That?”: *ko e hā ē?*

To ask someone to identify something, combine *ko e hā* (what) with a demonstrative:

Ko e hā ē?

What is that?

The answer uses the same *ko* pattern:

Ko e ki'i kato.

It's a small basket.

The word *ki'i* means “small” and goes before the noun.

More exchanges:

Ko e hā 'eni?

What is this?

Ko e kato.

It's a basket.

Ko e hā ē?

What is that?

Ko e vaka.

It's a boat.

The word *vaka* (*boat, ship*) is new vocabulary. *Ko e hā ē?* is the most common form of this question. The *ē* carries a general “that” meaning broad enough for most pointing situations.

Note:

The word *ko fē* (where, which) also uses *ko*. You may hear it in questions like *Ko fē e tohi?* (Where is the book?). This question word is covered formally in Chapter 13: *Ko* Questions.

Note:

The definitive accent (stress on the last vowel of a noun) marks specificity in *ko* sentences. *Ko e tohi 'eni* (with normal stress) means “This is **a** book.” *Ko e tohi'eni* (with shifted stress) means “This is **the** book (the one you were looking for).” This distinction is covered formally in Chapter 18: Definiteness and the Definitive Accent. All examples in this chapter use normal stress.

Negating *ko* Sentences: *'oku 'ikai ko e*

To say what something is *not*, place *'oku 'ikai* before *ko*:

'Oku 'ikai ko e hele 'eni.

This is not a knife.

The negation uses a tense marker (*'oku*), even though the positive *ko* sentence has none. The *'oku 'ikai* is placed immediately before the *ko*, wrapping the identification in a negative frame.

'Oku 'ikai ko e faiako ia.

He/she is not a teacher.

The word *ia* after *faiako* is the postposed pronoun you learned earlier. Here, it sits after the noun to say who is (or is not) that thing: *Ko e faiako ia* = He/she is a teacher; *'Oku 'ikai ko e faiako ia* = He/she is not a teacher.

The negation pattern is: *'oku 'ikai* + *ko e* + noun (+ demonstrative or pronoun).

'Oku 'ikai ko e kato ē.

That is not a basket.

'Oku 'ikai ko e tohi 'eni.

This is not a book.

Summary of *ko* Patterns

Pattern	Example	English
Identification	<i>Ko e fala 'eni.</i>	This is a mat.
Short demonstrative	<i>Ko'eni.</i>	Here it is.
Short demonstrative	<i>Ko ē!</i>	There it is!
Question	<i>Ko e hā ē?</i>	What is that?
Negation	<i>'Oku 'ikai ko e hele 'eni.</i>	This is not a knife.

New Vocabulary

Tongan	English
<i>tohi</i>	book, letter
<i>fala</i>	mat
<i>hele</i>	knife
<i>kato</i>	basket
<i>vaka</i>	boat, ship
<i>faiako</i>	teacher

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>ko</i>	identification marker	marks identity (it is, this is)
<i>ko e</i>	identification + article	it is a/the...
<i>'eni</i>	demonstrative	this (near me)
<i>'ena</i>	demonstrative	that (near you)
<i>ē</i>	demonstrative	that (over there, general)
<i>ko'eni</i>	fixed demonstrative phrase	here it is
<i>ko ē</i>	fixed demonstrative phrase	there it is
<i>ko'ena</i>	fixed demonstrative phrase	there it is (near you)

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>ki'i</i>	modifier	small (before the noun)

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate into English

- 1. *Ko e fala 'eni.*
- 2. *Ko e hā ē?*
- 3. *Ko'eni.*
- 4. *'Oku 'ikai ko e tohi ē.*
- 5. *Ko e hele 'eni.*
- 6. *Ko e kato ē.*

Exercise 2: Translate into Tongan

1. This is a book.
2. What is that?
3. There it is!
4. This is not a knife.
5. It's a mat.
6. That is a basket.

Exercise 3: Answer each ko e hā question using the word in brackets

1. *Ko e hā ē?* [tohi]
2. *Ko e hā 'eni?* [fala]
3. *Ko e hā ē?* [hele]
4. *Ko e hā 'eni?* [kato]
5. *Ko e hā ē?* [vaka]

Exercise 4: Change each sentence to its negative form using 'oku 'ikai ko e

1. *Ko e tohi 'eni.*
2. *Ko e hele ē.*
3. *Ko e faiako ia.*
4. *Ko e fala 'eni.*
5. *Ko e kato ē.*

Exercise 5: Match each Tongan sentence (a–e) to its English meaning (1–5)

- a. *Ko e vaka ē.*
 - b. *'Oku 'ikai ko e fala 'eni.*
 - c. *Ko e hā ē?*
 - d. *Ko'eni.*
 - e. *'Oku 'ikai ko e faiako ia.*
1. Here it is.
 2. He/she is not a teacher.
 3. This is not a mat.
 4. What is that?

5. That is a boat.
-

Answers

Exercise 1

1. This is a mat.
2. What is that?
3. Here it is.
4. That is not a book.
5. This is a knife.
6. That is a basket.

Exercise 2

1. *Ko e tohi 'eni.*
2. *Ko e hā ē?*
3. *Ko ē!*
4. *'Oku 'ikai ko e hele 'eni.*
5. *Ko e fala.*
6. *Ko e kato ē.*

Exercise 3

1. *Ko e tohi.*
2. *Ko e fala.*
3. *Ko e hele.*
4. *Ko e kato.*
5. *Ko e vaka.*

Exercise 4

1. *'Oku 'ikai ko e tohi 'eni.*
2. *'Oku 'ikai ko e hele ē.*
3. *'Oku 'ikai ko e faiako ia.*
4. *'Oku 'ikai ko e fala 'eni.*

5. 'Oku 'ikai ko e kato ē.

Exercise 5

- a. 5
- b. 3
- c. 4
- d. 1
- e. 2

Chapter 13: *Ko* Questions

The *ko* pattern also forms questions. Where tense-marker questions ask about actions, *ko* questions ask about identities: who someone is, what something is, or which one.

Ko hai: Who?

The word *hai* means “who.” Combined with *ko*, it asks about a person’s identity.

Ko hai 'oku hiva?

Who is singing?

Ko Sione.

Sione.

The pattern is: *ko hai* + tense-marker clause. The *ko hai* asks “who?”, and the clause that follows describes what that person is doing.

Ko hai na'e mohe?

Who slept?

Ko hai 'e lele?

Who will run?

The word *lele* means “run.” In these sentences, the third-person pronoun *ne* does not appear after the tense marker. The tense marker stands alone because *ko hai* is already asking about a single person, making the pronoun redundant.

When the question asks about someone doing something to a specific thing, the pronoun *ne* does appear after the tense marker:

Ko hai té ne tokoni ki he faiako?

Who will help the teacher?

The word *tokoni* means “help.” The full pattern for this kind of sentence is covered in Chapter 19: Transitive Word Order. Recognize that *ko hai* can ask about people in both types of sentence.

The answer to a *ko hai* question uses *ko* + the person:

Ko au.

Me. (Lit. “It-is I”)

Ko e faiako.

The teacher.

***Ko e hā* and *Ko e hā 'a e me'a*: What?**

You already know *ko e hā ē?* (What is that?) from the previous chapter. The word *hā* means “what.” On its own, *ko e hā?* can mean “What?”, “What is it?”, or “What’s the matter?”

The fuller form *ko e hā e me'a* appears when asking about a specific thing. The word *me'a* means “thing.”

Ko e hā 'a e me'a 'okú ke fiema'u?

What do you want? (Lit. “The thing you want-to-get is what?”)

The word *fīema’u* means “want” or “need.” The literal translation reveals how the sentence works: the thing being asked about is described in the clause, with the question word *hā* sitting at the front. When asking about a specific thing, speakers tend to use the longer form *ko e hā e me’a* rather than the shorter *ko e hā* on its own.

***Ko fē*: Where? Which?**

The word *fē* means “where” or “which.” Combined with *ko*, it asks about location or identity.

Ko fē ’a e kato?

Where is the basket?

You may recall this question word from a note in the previous chapter. Where *’oku ’i fē* asks “where?” in a tense-marker sentence, *ko fē* asks the same question using the *ko* pattern. The two differ in nuance: *’oku ’i fē* is used when you suppose the person or thing may be far away, while *ko fē* is used when you suppose it is somewhere within sight.

The answer uses any *ko* identification pattern:

Ko fē ’a e hele?

Where is the knife?

Ko’eni.

Here it is.

***Ko e hā ... ai*: Why?**

To ask “why?”, Tongan uses *ko e hā* (what) with the word *ai* placed after the verb. The word *ai* has no single English translation. In these sentences, it works like “because of it” or “for that reason,” referring back to the unknown reason being asked about.

Ko e hā na’á ke ’alu ai ki Nuku’alofa?

Why did you go to Nuku’alofa? (Lit. “What is [the thing] you went because-of-it to Nuku’alofa?”)

The *ai* comes immediately after the verb or verb phrase. It connects the question word *hā* to the action: what is the thing *for which* you did this?

Ko e hā na’e ’ita ai?

Why was he angry? (Lit. “What is [the thing] was-angry because-of-it?”)

The word *’ita* means “angry.” In this sentence, the subject is understood from context.

The full form of this question is *ko e hā e ’uhinga ... ai* (what is the reason ... therefore?), where *’uhinga* means “reason.” The shortened *ko e hā ... ai* is far more common in speech.

Note:
The word *ai* also appears in other constructions, particularly in Chapter 39: Relative Clauses with *Ai* and Demonstratives. In this chapter, it only appears in the *ko e hā ... ai* pattern for “why” questions.

Summary of Ko Question Words

Question	Meaning	Example
<i>Ko hai ...?</i>	Who?	<i>Ko hai ’oku hiva?</i> Who is singing?
<i>Ko e hā ...?</i>	What?	<i>Ko e hā ’a e me’a ’okú ke fiema’u?</i> What do you want?
<i>Ko e hā ē?</i>	What is that?	<i>Ko e hā ē?</i> What is that? A mat.

Question	Meaning	Example
<i>Ko fē ...?</i>	Where? Which?	<i>Ko fē 'a e kato?</i> Where is the basket?
<i>Ko e hā ... ai?</i>	Why?	<i>Ko e hā na'á ke 'alu ai ki Nuku'alofa?</i> Why did you go to Nuku'alofa?

Note:
The word *hai* also appears in expressions meaning “whose” (*'a hai?*, *'o hai?*). These possessive forms are covered in Chapter 37: Postposed Possessives.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>hai</i>	question word	who (in <i>ko hai</i>)

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>me'a</i>	noun	thing
<i>'uhinga</i>	noun	reason
<i>tauhi</i>	verb	care for, look after
<i>fānau</i>	noun	children
<i>ta'ahine</i>	noun	girl

Exercises***Exercise 1: Translate into English***

1. *Ko hai 'oku hiva?*
2. *Ko e hā 'a e me'a 'okú ke fiema'u?*
3. *Ko fē 'a e kato?*
4. *Ko e hā na'á ke 'alu ai ki he fale kai?*
5. *Ko hai na'e mohe?*
6. *Ko e hā ē?*

Exercise 2: Translate into Tongan

1. Who is coming?
2. What is that?
3. Where is the knife?
4. Why did you sing?
5. What do you want?
6. Who will go?

Exercise 3: Answer each question using the word or phrase in brackets

1. *Ko hai 'oku ha'u?* [Mele]
2. *Ko e hā ē?* [vaka]
3. *Ko fē 'a e hele?* [ko'eni]
4. *Ko hai na'e kai?* [Tēvita]
5. *Ko fē 'a e kato?* [ko ē]

Exercise 4: Match each Tongan question (a–e) to its English meaning (1–5)

- a. *Ko fē 'a e vaka?*
 - b. *Ko e hā na'e 'ita ai?*
 - c. *Ko hai té ne tauhi 'a e fānau?*
 - d. *Ko e hā 'a e me'a 'okú ke fiema'u?*
 - e. *Ko hai 'e lele?*
1. What do you want?
 2. Who will run?

3. Where is the boat?
4. Why was he angry?
5. Who will take care of the children?

Exercise 5: Fill in the correct ko-interrogative to complete each question

1. _____ 'oku lea? (Who is speaking?)
 2. _____ e fala? (Where is the mat?)
 3. _____ e me'a 'okú ke fiema'u? (What do you want?)
 4. _____ na'á ke 'alu ai ki he fale kai? (Why did you go to the cafeteria?)
 5. _____ 'e 'alu? (Who will go?)
- _____

Answers

Exercise 1

1. Who is singing?
2. What do you want?
3. Where is the basket?
4. Why did you go to the cafeteria?
5. Who slept?
6. What is that?

Exercise 2

1. *Ko hai 'oku ha'u?*
2. *Ko e hā ē?*
3. *Ko fē 'a e hele?*
4. *Ko e hā na'á ke hiva ai?*
5. *Ko e hā 'a e me'a 'okú ke fiema'u?*
6. *Ko hai 'e 'alu?*

Exercise 3

1. *Ko Mele.*
2. *Ko e vaka.*

3. *Ko'eni.*
4. *Ko Tēvita.*
5. *Ko ē.*

Exercise 4

- a. 3
- b. 4
- c. 5
- d. 1
- e. 2

Exercise 5

1. *Ko hai 'oku lea?*
2. *Ko fē 'a e fala?*
3. *Ko e hā 'a e me'a 'okú ke fiema'u?*
4. *Ko e hā na'á ke 'alu ai ki he fale kai?*
5. *Ko hai 'e 'alu?*

Chapter 14: Greetings and Social Formulas

Word Study

Unlike the productive patterns built so far, Tongan greetings and farewells are fixed formulas. This chapter teaches the most important ones, explains the grammar inside them so they are not opaque, and introduces a few new elements: the vocative particle *'e* for addressing someone by name, the tonal adverb *ā* used in farewells, and polite request words.

***Mālō e lelei*: Hello**

The most common Tongan greeting is:

Mālō e lelei!

Hello.

The word *mālō* means “worthy of praise” or “congratulations.” The word *e* here is the definite article (the same *e* you know from *e tohi*, the book). The word *lelei* means “well” or “good.” The literal meaning is “The being-in-good-health is worthy of praise,” a much warmer greeting than a simple “hello.”

The standard response is to repeat the greeting:

'Io, mālō e lelei!

Hello. (Lit. “Yes, congratulations on being well.”)

The word *'io* (yes) is the appropriate first word in response to any greeting, compliment, or farewell. It may stand alone or accompany a more specific response.

Fēfē hake?: How Are You?

After the initial greeting, the follow-up is:

Fēfē hake?

How are you?

You already know *fēfē* (how) from the verbal interrogatives in Chapter 11: Question Words. The word *hake* means “up” or “upward” and gives the question a sense of “How are you getting along?” This form is used especially when asking after someone who has been unwell.

The standard answer:

Sai pē!

Just fine.

The word *sai* means “good, well, fine.” Combined with *pē* (just, only), it means “just fine” or “all right.” This is a fixed response, not a full sentence with a tense marker.

Mālō e 'ofa: Thank You

To express thanks, Tongan uses *mālō* with *'ofa* (love, kindness):

Mālō e 'ofa!

Thank you for your kindness.

The literal meaning is “The kindness is worthy of praise.” The word *'ofa* means “love” or “kindness.”

Several variations use the same *mālō e* pattern. The word *lava* means “to arrive” or “to manage.” For example, *Mālō e tokoni mai!* means “Thanks for your help,” and *Mālō e lava mai!* is the usual greeting to a visitor on arrival, meaning “Thanks for coming.”

A Formal Greeting

In more formal settings, Tongan uses a longer greeting:

Mālō 'etau lava ki he pongipongi ni.

Good morning. (Lit. “Congratulations on our surviving to this morning.”)

The word *'etau* is a possessive pronoun meaning “our” (inclusive). It is formally taught in Chapter 17: Possessives. Treat this greeting as a formula to be memorized whole. The pattern works the same way for other times of day: substitute *efiafi ni* (this afternoon) or *pō ni* (this night) for *pongipongi ni*.

Quick Practice A: Greetings and thanks formulas

Match each Tongan formula (a–f) to its English context (1–6).

- a. *Mālō e 'ofa!*
 - b. *Fēfē hake?*
 - c. *Mālō e lelei!*
 - d. *Mālō 'etau lava ki he pongipongi ni.*
 - e. *'Io, mālō e lelei!*
 - f. *Mālō e lava mai!*
1. Saying hello when you meet someone.
 2. Responding to “Hello!”
 3. Asking how someone is doing.
 4. Saying “Thank you for your kindness.”
 5. Saying “Good morning” formally.
 6. Greeting a visitor who has just arrived.

Answers: a. 4; b. 3; c. 1; d. 5; e. 2; f. 6

Farewells

Tongan farewells depend on who is leaving and who is staying. There are three basic forms:

'Alu ā!

Goodbye. (Said to the person who is leaving.)

Nofo ā!

Goodbye. (Said to the person who is staying.)

Mohe ā!

Goodnight. (Said to someone going to bed.)

You already know the verbs *'alu* (go), *nofo* (stay), and *mohe* (sleep) as imperative forms. These farewells use the same bare-verb imperative pattern, with the addition of a small word: *ā*.

The tonal adverb ā

The word *ā* is a tonal adverb. It does not translate directly into English. In farewells, it softens the command and adds warmth. Without *ā*, the verb would be a bare imperative: *'Alu!* (Go.). With *ā*, it becomes a polite farewell: *'Alu ā!* (Go well, goodbye.) Depending on tone of voice, *ā* can make words less abrupt and more polite, or less casual and more emphatic.

In speech, a vocative *ē* often appears at the end of farewells:

'Alu ā ē!

Goodbye.

Nofo ā ē!

Goodbye.

The *ē* is a friendly embellishment, not a separate word that changes the meaning.

For two or more people, the plural and dual imperative forms apply:

Farewell	To one person	To two people	To three or more
To those leaving	<i>’Alu ā!</i>	<i>Mo ō ā!</i>	<i>Mou ō ā!</i>
To those staying	<i>Nofo ā!</i>	<i>Mo nofo ā!</i>	<i>Mou nofo ā!</i>

These follow the imperative patterns from earlier chapters: singular uses the bare verb, dual uses *mo* + verb, and plural uses *mou* + verb. The plural form of “go” is *ō*, not *’alu*.

’Io and ’Ikai: Yes and No

You already know *’io* (yes) and *’ikai* (no) as response words. In greetings, *’io* serves a broader role: it is the universal acknowledgement. When someone greets you with *Mālō e lelei!*, the proper first word in your response is *’Io!* When someone says *Mālō e ngāue!* (Thanks for working.), the response is *’Io!* A useful way to think of *’io* is “It is as you say.”

Note:
Tongan uses *’io* when answering negative questions where English would say “no.” *Na’e ’ikai té ke ’alu?* (Didn’t you go?) receives the answer *’Io, na’e ’ikai té u ’alu.* (No, I didn’t go.) The *’io* confirms the negative: “It is as you say (that I did not go).” Once you grasp this meaning, the logic is clear.

Polite Request Words: *fakamolemole* and *kātaki*

Two words soften requests and make them polite:
Fakamolemole means “pardon” or “excuse me.” It introduces a polite request.
Kātaki means “please” (literally “endure”). It can also serve as an apology: *Kātaki!* (Sorry.).
Both words appear at the beginning of the request:

Fakamolemole, ha'u ki heni.

Excuse me, come here.

Kātaki, nofo hē.

Please, sit over there.

You may also hear both words together in more formal requests. The polite request word *mu'a* that you learned with imperatives is less formal than either of these.

The Vocative Particle 'e

When you address someone by name, Tongan uses the particle 'e before the name. This signals that you are speaking directly to that person.

'E Sione, ha'u!

Sione, come.

'E Mele, nofo ā!

Mele, goodbye.

This 'e marks the vocative: it signals direct address. It is sometimes dropped in casual speech, but it is always correct to include it.

Note:

This vocative 'e is a completely different word from the future tense marker 'e and the definite article e. They look the same in writing but serve different purposes in different positions.

Quick Practice B: Farewells, polite words, and the vocative 'e

Write the appropriate Tongan response or formula for each situation.

1. You are leaving the room. Say goodbye to someone who is staying.

2. Two friends are walking out the door together. Say goodbye to them both.
3. You want to politely ask Sēmisi to come here.
4. You accidentally step on someone's foot. What single word do you say?
5. Tell Lupe (use her name) to please sit here.

Answers: 1. *Nofo ā!* 2. *Mo ō ā!* 3. *'E Sēmisi, fakamolemole ha'u ki heni.* 4. *Kātaki!* 5. *'E Lupe, kātaki nofo heni.*

Asking Someone's Name

To ask someone's name:

Ko hai ho hingoā?

What is your name? (Lit. "Who is your name?")

You already know *ko hai* (who) from the previous chapter. The word *hingoā* means "name."

Preview: The word *ho* before *hingoā* is a possessive pronoun meaning "your." Possessive pronouns are formally taught in Chapter 17: Possessives. Treat *Ko hai ho hingoā?* as a set phrase.

The answer uses the *ko* identification pattern:

Ko Sione au.

I am Sione. (Lit. "It-is Sione I.")

The postposed pronoun *au* (I) was introduced in Chapter 5: Commands and Emphasis. The sentence follows the same *ko* + noun pattern you already know, with *au* identifying who is being named.

Asking Someone's Age

Another common question when meeting someone:

Ko ho ta'u fiha eni?

How old are you? (Lit. "Is your year how-many this?")

The word *ta’u* means “year” or “age.” The word *fiha* means “how many.” Combined with the *ko* identification pattern and the possessive *ho* (your), this asks “What is your year-count?”

The answer follows the same pattern:

Ko hoku ta’u uofulu eni.

I am twenty years old. (Lit. “Is my year twenty this.”)

Preview: The words *hoku* (my) and *ho* (your) are possessive pronouns, formally taught in Chapter 17: Possessives. The number *uofulu* (twenty) comes from the number system taught in Chapter 20: Numbers and Time. For now, treat *Ko ho ta’u fiha eni?* and *Ko hoku ta’u [number] eni* as set phrases to memorize.

Question	Answer
<i>Ko hai ho hingoa?</i>	<i>Ko Sione au.</i>
What is your name?	I am Sione.
<i>Ko ho ta’u fiha eni?</i>	<i>Ko hoku ta’u uofulu eni.</i>
How old are you?	I am twenty.

Putting It All Together

A typical greeting exchange combines several formulas:

Mālō e lelei!

Hello.

’Io, mālō e lelei!

Hello.

Fēfē hake?

How are you?

Sai pē!

Just fine.

Ko hai ho hingoā?

What is your name?

Ko Mele au.

I am Mele.

Ko ho ta'u fiha eni?

How old are you?

Ko hoku ta'u uofulu eni.

I am twenty.

'Alu ā ē!

Goodbye.

Nofo ā ē!

Goodbye.

Each line in this exchange uses grammar you can now identify: *ko* identification, the *'io* acknowledgement, familiar question words, postposed pronouns, imperative verb forms, and the set-phrase personal questions just introduced.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>ā</i>	tonal adverb	softens commands, adds warmth

Tongan	Function	English
'e	vocative particle	marks direct address before names (also the future-tense marker, Ch 9)
'etau	possessive pronoun (preview)	our (inclusive)
ho	possessive pronoun (preview)	your

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>mālō</i>	greeting word	congratulations, worthy of praise
<i>sai</i>	adjective	good, well, fine
<i>lava</i>	verb	arrive, manage
<i>fakamolemole</i>	polite word	pardon, excuse me
<i>kātaki</i>	polite word	please; sorry
<i>hingoa</i>	noun	name
<i>efiafi</i>	noun	afternoon, evening

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate into English

- 1. *Mālō e lelei!*
- 2. *Fēfē hake?*
- 3. *Sai pē!*

4. 'Alu ā!
5. Nofo ā!
6. Mohe ā!
7. Mālō e 'ofa!
8. Kātaki!
9. Ko ho ta'u fiha eni?

Exercise 2: Translate into Tongan

1. Hello. (greeting someone you meet)
2. Hello. (responding to *Mālō e lelei!*)
3. Just fine. (answering *Fēfē hake?*)
4. Goodbye. (you are staying, the other person is leaving)
5. Goodbye. (you are leaving, the other person is staying)
6. Goodnight. (to someone going to bed)
7. Thank you for your kindness.
8. Excuse me, come here.
9. How old are you?

Exercise 3: Translate into Tongan

1. What is your name?
2. I am Tēvita.
3. Sione, come here.
4. Mele, goodbye. (You are staying, Mele is leaving.)
5. Please, sit here.

Exercise 4: Fill in the blank with the correct farewell

1. Your friend is leaving for the day. You say: ____ (goodbye to the one going)
2. You are leaving your friend's house. You say: ____ (goodbye to the one staying)
3. Your child is going to bed. You say: ____ (goodnight)
4. Two friends are leaving. You say: ____ (goodbye to two people going)
5. You are saying goodbye to several people who are staying. You say: ____ (goodbye to three or more staying)

Exercise 5: Match each Tongan expression (a–g) to its English meaning (1–7)

- a. *Mālō e 'ofa!*
 - b. *'Io, mālo e lelei!*
 - c. *Fakamolemole, ha'u ki heni.*
 - d. *Ko Siale au.*
 - e. *Kātaki!*
 - f. *'E Tēvita, nofo ā!*
 - g. *Ko hoku ta'u uofulu eni.*
 - 1. Sorry.
 - 2. Tēvita, goodbye.
 - 3. Thank you for your kindness.
 - 4. I am Siale.
 - 5. Hello. (response)
 - 6. Excuse me, come here.
 - 7. I am twenty years old.
-

Answers**Exercise 1**

- 1. Hello.
- 2. How are you?
- 3. Just fine.
- 4. Goodbye. (to the person leaving)
- 5. Goodbye. (to the person staying)
- 6. Goodnight.
- 7. Thank you for your kindness.
- 8. Sorry. / Please.
- 9. How old are you?

Exercise 2

- 1. *Mālō e lelei!*

2. *'Io, mālō e lelei!*
3. *Sai pē!*
4. *'Alu ā!*
5. *Nofo ā!*
6. *Mohe ā!*
7. *Mālō e 'ofa!*
8. *Fakamolemole, ha'u ki heni. (or Kātaki, ha'u ki heni.)*
9. *Ko ho ta'u fiha eni?*

Exercise 3

1. *Ko hai ho hingoa?*
2. *Ko Tēvita au.*
3. *'E Sione, ha'u! (or 'E Sione, ha'u ki heni!)*
4. *'E Mele, 'alu ā!*
5. *Kātaki, nofo heni. (or Fakamolemole, nofo heni.)*

Exercise 4

1. *'Alu ā!*
2. *Nofo ā!*
3. *Mohe ā!*
4. *Mo ō ā!*
5. *Mou nofo ā!*

Exercise 5

- a. 3
- b. 5
- c. 6
- d. 4
- e. 1
- f. 2
- g. 7

Chapter 15: Noun Subjects

So far, pronouns have filled the subject slot between the tense marker and the verb. This chapter introduces noun subjects (names), which shift to after the verb, require the focus marker 'a, and bring the tense marker forms *na'e* and 'e into use.

Noun subjects: a new word order

When the subject is a pronoun, it goes between the tense marker and the verb:
Na'á ne hiva.

He sang. (Lit. "Past he sing")

When the subject is a noun (a person's name, for example), it goes after the verb, introduced by the marker 'a:

Na'e hiva 'a Sione.

Sione sang. (Lit. "Past sing focus Sione")

Three things change when the subject is a noun:

- 1. The noun moves after the verb.
- 2. The marker 'a appears before the noun.
- 3. The tense marker changes from *na'a* to *na'e*.

These three changes always happen together. The word order for noun subjects is:

Tense Marker + Verb + 'a + Noun Subject

Pronoun subject	Noun subject
<i>Na'a ne 'alu.</i>	<i>Na'e 'alu 'a Sione.</i>
He went.	Sione went.
<i>'Okú ne mohe.</i>	<i>'Oku mohe 'a Pita.</i>
He sleeps.	Pita sleeps.
<i>Té ne hiva.</i>	<i>'E hiva 'a Tēvita.</i>
He will sing.	Tēvita will sing.

The focus marker 'a

The word 'a is a focus marker: a word that marks the noun closest in thought to the verb's action. In a sentence with no object, the subject is closest to the verb, so 'a marks the subject. Before proper nouns, 'a always appears. You will encounter it again with common nouns in Chapter 18: Definiteness and the Definitive Accent and with transitive verbs in Chapter 19: Transitive Word Order. The pattern is:

'a + proper noun = noun subject of a verb with no object

Na'e lele 'a Mele.

Mele ran.

Kuo ha'u 'a Seini.

Seini has arrived.

'Oku nofo 'a Sēmisi 'i kolo.

Sēmisi lives in town.

The word *kolo* means “town.” The word *'api* means “home.” Both appear frequently with prepositions: *'i kolo* (in town), *ki kolo* (to town), *'i 'api* (at home), *ki 'api* (toward home).

Why the tense marker changes: *na'e* and *'e* with noun subjects

You have seen both *na'a* and *na'e* since the first chapter of this book. The rule governing which form to use is now fully clear.

Use *na'a* and *te* immediately before a pronoun:

Na'a ku 'alu.

I went.

Té ke lea.

You will speak.

Use *na'e* and *'e* everywhere else, including before a verb followed by a noun subject:

Na'e 'alu 'a Sione.

Sione went.

'E lea 'a Mele.

Mele will speak.

The rule is: *na'a* is used immediately before a pronominal subject, *na'e* in all other cases; and similarly *te* before pronouns, *'e* before nouns.

The present tense marker *'oku* and the perfect tense marker *kuo* have only one form each. They do not change:

'Oku 'alu 'a Sione.

Sione is going.

Kuo hiva 'a Tēvita.

Tēvita has sung.

Dropping the third-person pronoun

When a noun subject is present, the third-person singular pronoun *ne* disappears. You do not say *'okú ne 'alu 'a Sione* with both the pronoun and the noun. The noun subject replaces the pronoun entirely.

With pronoun	With noun subject
<i>'Okú ne 'alu.</i>	<i>'Oku 'alu 'a Sione.</i>
He is going.	Sione is going.
<i>Na'á ne mohe.</i>	<i>Na'e mohe 'a Pita.</i>
He slept.	Pita slept.
<i>Kuó ne hiva.</i>	<i>Kuo hiva 'a Tēvita.</i>
He has sung.	Tēvita has sung.

Note:
This pattern applies only to the third person. To say “I went,” you always use *na'á ku 'alu*. You cannot replace first-person or second-person pronouns with a noun-subject construction.

Predicate adjectives with noun subjects

In Chapter 3: Descriptive Words, you learned that Tongan descriptive words (adjectives) function as verbs. *'Oku ou fiefia* means “I am happy,” with *fiefia* (happy) filling the verb slot. The same pattern works with noun subjects, following the new word order:
'Oku hela'ia 'a Mele.

Mele is tired.

Na’e ’ita ’a Lupe.

Lupe was angry.

Whether the word after the tense marker is an action verb or a descriptive word, the noun-subject pattern is the same:

Action verb	Descriptive word
<i>Na’e ’alu ’a Sione.</i>	<i>Na’e hela’ia ’a Sione.</i>
Sione went.	Sione was tired.
<i>’Oku lele ’a Mele.</i>	<i>’Oku ’ita ’a Mele.</i>
Mele runs.	Mele is angry.

The word *puke* means “sick,” *fiefia* means “happy,” *hela’ia* means “tired,” and *’ita* means “angry.”

Weather and impersonal expressions

Some sentences have no subject at all. Weather expressions are the most common type:

Na’e ’uha.

It rained.

’Oku lā’ā.

It is sunny.

There is no person or thing performing the action. Tongan uses the tense marker plus the verb and nothing else. English requires the word “it” in *it rained* or *it is sunny*, but Tongan has no such requirement. These are called impersonal verbs: verbs without any subject.

The word *'uha* is primarily a noun meaning “rain.” When used with a tense marker, it functions as a verb: *na'e 'uha* means “it rained” (literally, “rained”). Similarly, *lā'ā* means “sun” as a noun but functions as “it is sunny” with a tense marker. This pattern applies generally to Tongan nouns that refer to weather.

More weather expressions:

'E vela 'aupito 'apongipongi.

It will be very hot tomorrow.

Na'e 'afua pē.

It was just fine weather.

The word *vela* means “hot” and *'afua* means “fine, clear” (of weather).

Two kinds of verbs

This chapter uses only verbs that take no object (intransitive verbs): *'alu* (go), *mohe* (sleep), *lea* (speak), and descriptive words like *puke* (sick). There is a second kind, the transitive verb, which takes an object: *kai* (eat something), *inu* (drink something). Churchward classifies verbs along two axes (Ch. 11, §1–4):

	Has a subject	No subject
No object (intransitive)	<i>Na'á ne lea.</i> He spoke.	<i>Na'e 'uha.</i> It rained.
Has an object (transitive)	(covered in Chapter 19: Transitive Word Order)	(covered in Chapter 19: Transitive Word Order)

The transitive pattern with noun subjects uses a different marker (*'e* instead of *'a*) and is covered in Chapter 19: Transitive Word Order. All noun subjects in this chapter, where the verb takes no object, use *'a*.

Questions with noun subjects

When you ask a question about a noun subject, the interrogative word goes between the verb and the noun subject:

'Oku lele ki fē 'a Mele?

Where is Mele running to?

Na'e mohe 'i fē 'a Pita?

Where did Pita sleep?

In statements, the noun subject follows the verb directly, and other phrases come after the subject. In questions, the question word slots in between the verb and the noun subject, pushing the subject to the end:

Statement	Question
<i>'Oku nofo 'a 'Ana 'i 'api.</i>	<i>'Oku nofo 'i fē 'a 'Ana?</i>
'Ana lives at home.	Where does 'Ana live?
<i>Na'e 'alu 'a Tēvita ki 'api.</i>	<i>Na'e 'alu ki fē 'a Tēvita?</i>
Tēvita went home.	Where did Tēvita go?

This same principle applies to the predicate locational pattern you already know. With a pronoun, you say *'okú ne 'i fē?* (where is he?). With a noun subject:

'Oku 'i fē 'a Sione?

Where is Sione?

'Oku 'i kolo.

He is in town.

Quick Practice: Predicate adjectives, weather, and questions with noun subjects

Translate each sentence to Tongan.

- 1. Mele is sick.
- 2. It rained yesterday.
- 3. Where is Tēvita?
- 4. Pita was happy.
- 5. It will be hot tomorrow.

Answers: 1. 'Oku puke 'a Mele. 2. Na'e 'uha 'aneafi. 3. 'Oku 'i fē 'a Tēvita? 4. Na'e fiefia 'a Pita. 5. 'E vela 'apongipongi.

Negation with noun subjects: 'ikai ke

With pronoun subjects, negation uses 'ikai te before the pronoun:
Na'e 'ikai té u 'alu.
I did not go.

With noun subjects, negation uses 'ikai ke instead:
Na'e 'ikai ke 'alu 'a Sione.
Sione did not go.

'Oku 'ikai ke puke 'a Pita.
Pita is not sick.

The key distinction: noun subjects require 'ikai ke, not 'ikai te. The contrast:

	Pronoun subject	Noun subject
Present	'Oku 'ikai té ne 'alu.	'Oku 'ikai ke 'alu 'a Sione.
Past	Na'e 'ikai té ne 'alu.	Na'e 'ikai ke 'alu 'a Sione.
Future	'E 'ikai té ne 'alu.	'E 'ikai ke 'alu 'a Sione.

The full pattern

Here is the complete set of forms for a single verb (*'alu*, go) comparing pronoun and noun subjects across all four tenses:

Tense	Pronoun subject (3sg)	Noun subject
Present	<i>'Okú ne 'alu.</i>	<i>'Oku 'alu 'a Sione.</i>
	He is going.	Sione is going.
Perfect	<i>Kuó ne 'alu.</i>	<i>Kuo 'alu 'a Sione.</i>
	He has gone.	Sione has gone.
Past	<i>Na'á ne 'alu.</i>	<i>Na'e 'alu 'a Sione.</i>
	He went.	Sione went.
Future	<i>Té ne 'alu.</i>	<i>'E 'alu 'a Sione.</i>
	He will go.	Sione will go.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>'a</i>	focus marker (formalized)	marks noun closest to the verb

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate into English

- 1. *'E 'alu 'a Mele.*
- 2. *Na'e mohe 'a Pita 'i 'api.*
- 3. *'Oku hiva 'a Siale.*

4. *Kuo ha'u 'a Tēvita.*
5. *Na'e lele 'a Kepu.*
6. *Na'e 'uha 'anepō.*
7. *'Oku lā'ā he 'aho ni.*

Exercise 2: Rewrite each sentence using the noun subject given in parentheses.

Remove the pronoun and change the tense marker if needed

1. *Na'á ne 'alu. (Sione)*
2. *'Okú ne mohe. (Pita)*
3. *Té ne hiva. (Mele)*
4. *Kuó ne ha'u. (Seini)*
5. *Na'á ne lea. (Tēvita)*
6. *'Okú ne lele. (Kepu)*

Exercise 3: Translate into Tongan

1. Mele is singing.
2. Pita went to town.
3. Tēvita has arrived.
4. It rained yesterday.
5. It is sunny today.
6. Kepu slept at home.

Exercise 4: Translate the questions and answers into English

1. *'Oku 'alu ki fē 'a Sione? / 'Oku 'alu 'a Sione ki kolo.*
2. *Na'e mohe 'i fē 'a Mele? / Na'e mohe 'a Mele 'i 'api.*
3. *'Oku puke 'a Pita? / 'Io, 'oku puke 'aupito.*
4. *Na'e fiefia 'a Kepu? / 'Io, na'e fiefia 'aupito.*
5. *'Oku 'i fē 'a Sēmisi? / 'Oku 'i kolo.*

Exercise 5: Translate into Tongan using noun subjects and the negative

1. Sione is not going.
2. Pita did not sleep.
3. Mele was not happy.

4. Kepu is not sick.
5. Tēvita did not come.

Exercise 6: Translate into Tongan

1. It rained last night.
 2. It is sunny today.
 3. It will be very hot tomorrow.
 4. Siale is tired.
 5. Seini was angry.
-

Answers**Exercise 1**

1. Mele will go.
2. Pita slept at home.
3. Siale is singing.
4. Tēvita has arrived.
5. Kepu ran.
6. It rained last night.
7. It is sunny today.

Exercise 2

1. *Na'e 'alu 'a Sione.*
2. *'Oku mohe 'a Pita.*
3. *'E hiva 'a Mele.*
4. *Kuo ha'u 'a Seini.*
5. *Na'e lea 'a Tēvita.*
6. *'Oku lele 'a Kepu.*

Exercise 3

1. *'Oku hiva 'a Mele.*
2. *Na'e 'alu 'a Pita ki kolo.*

3. *Kuo ha'u 'a Tēvita.*
4. *Na'e 'uha 'aneafī.*
5. *'Oku lā'ā he 'aho ni.*
6. *Na'e mohe 'a Kepu 'i 'api.*

Exercise 4

1. Where is Sione going? / Sione is going to town.
2. Where did Mele sleep? / Mele slept at home.
3. Is Pita sick? / Yes, he is very sick.
4. Was Kepu happy? / Yes, he was very happy.
5. Where is Sēmisi? / He is in town.

Exercise 5

1. *'Oku 'ikai ke 'alu 'a Sione.*
2. *Na'e 'ikai ke mohe 'a Pita.*
3. *Na'e 'ikai ke fiefia 'a Mele.*
4. *'Oku 'ikai ke puke 'a Kepu.*
5. *Na'e 'ikai ke ha'u 'a Tēvita.*

Exercise 6

1. *Na'e 'uha 'anepō.*
2. *'Oku lā'ā he 'aho ni.*
3. *'E vela 'aupito 'apongipongi.*
4. *'Oku hela'ia 'a Siale.*
5. *Na'e 'ita 'a Seini.*

Chapter 16: Equational Sentences

Building on the *ko* identification pattern, this chapter adds deeper structures: using *'a* with noun subjects in equational sentences, postposed pronouns as subjects, subject-first emphasis, and diminutives for expressing smallness.

Noun subjects in equational sentences: the focus marker *'a*

In the previous chapter, *'a* appeared as the marker before noun subjects in verb-first sentences: *'E 'alu 'a Sione* (Sione will go). The same marker works in equational sentences. When the subject is a proper noun, *'a* introduces it at the end of the equational sentence:

Ko e tangata ngāue 'a Mafi?

Is Mafi a worker? (Lit. “Identity-marker a worker focus Mafi”)

Ko e ta'ahine mālohi 'a Seini.

Seini is a strong girl. The word *mālohi* (*strong*) describes the noun.

Compare the parallel between verbal and equational constructions:

Verbal sentence	Equational sentence
<i>'Oku fiefia 'a Lātū.</i>	<i>Ko e tamasi'i fiefia 'a Lātū.</i>
Lātū is happy.	Lātū is a happy boy.
<i>'Oku mālohi 'a 'Ofa.</i>	<i>Ko e ta'ahine mālohi 'a 'Ofa.</i>
'Ofa is strong.	'Ofa is a strong girl.

The left column uses *'oku* + adjective + *'a* + name. The right column uses *ko e* + noun phrase + *'a* + name. In both cases, *'a* marks the subject. The difference is the sentence type: one is verbal (using a tense marker), the other is equational (using *ko*).

The pattern:

Ko e + predicate noun (+ adjective) + 'a + proper noun subject

This also works with *ko fē* (where, which):

Ko fē 'a Sione?

Where is Sione?

Pronoun subjects in equational sentences

When the subject is a pronoun rather than a proper noun, the focus marker *'a* drops away. The postposed pronoun appears directly after the predicate:

Ko e tangata ngāue au.

I am a worker. (Lit. “Identity-marker a worker I”)

Ko e tōketā koe?

Are you a doctor?

The focus marker *'a* is always dropped before postposed pronouns in equational sentences. Compare:

With noun subject	With pronoun subject
<i>Ko e tangata ngāue 'a Mafi.</i>	<i>Ko e tangata ngāue au.</i>
Mafi is a worker.	I am a worker.
<i>Ko e ta'ahine mālohi 'a Seini.</i>	<i>Ko e ta'ahine mālohi ia.</i>
Seini is a strong girl.	She is a strong girl.

The postposed pronouns are the same forms you learned earlier: *au* (I), *koe* (you), *ia* (he/she). The pronoun *ia* appears here as a subject in equational sentences. In verbal sentences, third-person subjects use the preposed pronoun *ne* (*'okú ne kai*, he eats). In equational sentences, third-person subjects use the postposed form *ia*.

The pattern:

Ko e + predicate noun (+ adjective) + postposed pronoun

Subject-first word order for emphasis

The normal equational order places the predicate first and the subject second:

Ko e faiako 'a Lisiate.

Lisiate is the teacher.

A reversed order emphasises the subject. Placing the subject first, followed by *ko e* + predicate, stresses *who* the person is rather than *what* they are:

Ko Lisiate ko e faiako.

Lisiate is the teacher. (emphasis: Lisiate, and no one else)

Compare the two:

Normal order (predicate emphasis)	Subject-first order (subject emphasis)
<i>Ko e tangata mālohi 'a Peau.</i>	<i>Ko Peau ko e tangata mālohi.</i>

Normal order (predicate emphasis)	Subject-first order (subject emphasis)
Peau is a strong man.	Peau is a strong man.
<i>Ko e fale motu’a ’a e falé ni.</i>	<i>Ko e falé ni ko e fale motu’a.</i>
This house is an old house.	This house is an old house.

The English translations look the same, but the Tongan sentences carry different emphasis. In speech, the difference is clear from context and stress: the subject-first order spotlights the subject.

The pattern:

Ko + subject + ko e + predicate noun (+ adjective)

Note:
The subject-first pattern uses *ko* twice. The first *ko* introduces the subject, the second *ko e* introduces the predicate. Both are the identifying *ko* you already know.

Demonstratives with *ko*: review

You have already seen *ko* combined with demonstratives:

Ko’eni.

Here it is. (this, near me)

Ko ē.

There it is. (that, over there)

In practice, *ē* often serves for all three distances, whether the thing is near the speaker, near the listener, or far from both. *Ko’eni* points to something close at hand, while *ko ē* points to something the speaker is directing attention toward.

These forms appear naturally in equational exchanges:

Ko e hā ē?

What is that?

Ko e ki'i kato.

It is a small basket.

Negating equational sentences: review

To negate an equational sentence, use *'oku 'ikai ko e*:

'Oku 'ikai ko e tangata ngāue au.

I am not a worker.

'Oku 'ikai ko e tōketā 'a Mele.

Mele is not a doctor.

For past negation, the pattern uses *na'e 'ikai ko e*:

Na'e 'ikai ko e faiako 'a Fehoko.

Fehoko was not a teacher.

This is the same negation pattern introduced with *ko* earlier. The tense marker *'oku* (or *na'e* for the past) opens the sentence, followed by *'ikai*, followed by the equational construction.

Diminutives: *ki'i* and *si'isi'i*

Tongan has two common words for expressing smallness, each working in a different position. *Ki'i* goes before the noun (preposed). *Si'isi'i* goes after the noun (postposed). Both can appear with the same noun to intensify the meaning: *ha ki'i me'a si'i*, a little tiny thing.

Compare the contrast in equational sentences:

Tongan	English
<i>Ko e vaka.</i>	It is a boat.

Tongan	English
<i>Ko e ki'i vaka.</i>	It is a small boat.
<i>Ko e vaka si'isi'i.</i>	It is a small boat.
<i>Ko e ki'i vaka si'isi'i.</i>	It is a very small boat.

Ki'i and *si'isi'i* mean roughly the same thing on their own. The difference is position: *ki'i* before the noun, *si'isi'i* after it. When both appear together, the effect is “very small” or “tiny.”

Ko e ki'i tohi.

It is a small book.

Ko e ki'i tohi motu'a pē.

It is just a small old book. (*motu'a* = old)

Note:

The word *si'isi'i* is the reduplicated form of *si'i* (small). Reduplication often intensifies meaning in Tongan. The full system of reduplication is covered in Chapter 50: Reduplication.

The conjunction *pea*

Preview: The word *pea* means “and” or “and then.” It connects two independent clauses. It is formally covered in Chapter 24: Conjunctions. Treat it as “and.”

Some equational sentences use *pea* to connect two statements:

Ko e tangata ngāue 'a Vaia?

Is Vaia a worker?

'Io, pea ko e tangata mālohi.

Yes, and he is a strong man.

Pea appears naturally in equational exchanges like this one.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>pea</i>	conjunction (preview)	and, and then

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>tōketā</i>	noun	doctor
<i>si'isi'i</i>	adjective	small (after the noun)
<i>si'i</i>	adjective	small
<i>poto</i>	adjective	clever, skilled
<i>tamasi'i</i>	noun	boy, child
<i>fāma</i>	noun	farm
<i>motu'a</i>	adjective	old

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English

- 1. *Ko e faiako 'a Mele.*
- 2. *Ko e tangata ngāue 'a Sēmisi.* (*ngāue* = work)
- 3. *Ko e tamasi'i poto au.*
- 4. *Ko fē 'a Sione?*
- 5. *Ko e hā ē?*

6. *Ko e ki'i tohi si'isi'i.*
7. *'Oku 'ikai ko e faiako 'a Tēvita.*
8. *Ko Taniela ko e faiako.*

Exercise 2: Translate English to Tongan

1. I am a farmer.
2. Is Siale a teacher?
3. Lātū is a happy boy.
4. It is a small basket.
5. Where is Mele?
6. Sione is not a doctor.
7. This is a small mat.
8. Sione is the teacher. (subject emphasis)

Exercise 3: Transform the sentence from normal word order to subject-first emphasis

1. *Ko e faiako 'a Mele.*
2. *Ko e tangata mālohi 'a Peau.*
3. *Ko e ta'ahine fiefia 'a Siale.*
4. *Ko e fale motu'a 'a e fale ni.*

Exercise 4: Fill in the blank with 'a, a postposed pronoun, or ki'i/si'isi'i

1. *Ko e faiako ____ Mele.* (Mele is a teacher.)
2. *Ko e tangata faama ____.* (I am a farmer.)
3. *Ko e ____ vaka.* (It is a small boat.) (*vaka* = boat)
4. *Ko e kato ____.* (It is a small basket.)
5. *'Oku 'ikai ko e faiako ____.* (You are not a teacher.)
6. *Ko e tamasi'i poto ____ Siaosi.* (Siaosi is a smart boy.)

Answers**Exercise 1**

1. Mele is a teacher.
2. Sēmisi is a worker.
3. I am a smart boy.
4. Where is Sione?
5. What is that?
6. It is a very small book.
7. Tēvita is not a teacher.
8. Taniela is the teacher. (subject emphasis)

Exercise 2

1. *Ko e tangata fāma au.*
2. *Ko e faiako 'a Siale?*
3. *Ko e tamasi'i fiefia 'a Lātū.*
4. *Ko e ki'i kato.*
5. *Ko fē 'a Mele?*
6. *'Oku 'ikai ko e tōketā 'a Sione.*
7. *Ko e ki'i fala 'eni.*
8. *Ko Sione ko e faiako.*

Exercise 3

1. *Ko Mele ko e faiako.*
2. *Ko Peau ko e tangata mālohi.*
3. *Ko Siale ko e ta'ahine fiefia.*
4. *Ko e falé ni ko e fale motu'a.*

Exercise 4

1. 'a
2. au
3. ki'i
4. si'isi'i

5. *koe*

6. *'a*

Chapter 17: Possessives

This chapter introduces the possessive system: how to say “my,” “your,” “his,” and so on.

A possessive (sometimes called a “possessive pronoun”) is a word that shows who something belongs to or is connected to. English uses words like “my,” “your,” “his,” “our.” Tongan has two complete sets of possessive pronouns, each used in different situations.

Two classes of possession

Tongan possessives come in two classes: the **'e-class** and the **ho-class**. Which one you use depends on your relationship to the thing, not on the thing itself.

'E-class is for things you act upon, control, create, or consume. Your money, your food, your work, your animals, your tools.

Ho-class is for things that act upon you, shelter you, or define you. Your house, your body parts, your relatives, your clothes, your country.

A useful image to anchor the difference: 'e-class is for things upon which you impress yourself; ho-class is for things which impress themselves upon you.

A practical guide:

Ho-class (characterizes you)	'E-class (you control it)
Relations: <i>hoku tokoua</i> (my sibling)	Emotions: <i>'eku 'ita</i> (my anger)
Houses and boats: <i>hoku fale</i> (my house)	Animals: <i>'eku moa</i> (my chicken)
Clothes: <i>hoku tatā</i> (my hat)	Work and activities: <i>'eku ngāue</i> (my work)
Countries and lands: <i>hoku fonua</i> (my country)	Language and speech: <i>'ene lea</i> (his speech)
Body parts: <i>hoku nima</i> (my hand)	Food: <i>'eku talo</i> (my taro)
	Tools and vehicles: <i>'eku hele</i> (my knife)

Some words shift class depending on context. The word *fala* (mat) illustrates this shift: *'eku fala* is the mat I make ('e-class, because I act upon it), while *hoku fala* is the mat I sit on (ho-class, because it supports me).

Note:
Not every noun follows the general rules above.

Working out which nouns take which class is, frankly, a never-ending headache for English speakers, so do not expect it to click all at once. Some exceptions are common: *'eku tamai* (my father) and *ho'o fa'e* (your mother) take 'e-class even though they are relatives. The best strategy is to learn each noun's class as you encounter it.

'E-class possessive pronouns

The 'e-class pronouns go before the noun they modify:

Pronoun	Meaning	Example
<i>'eku</i>	my	<i>'eku hele</i> (my knife)
<i>ho'o</i>	your (sg.)	<i>ho'o tohi</i> (your book)
<i>'ene</i>	his, her, its	<i>'ene kato</i> (his/her basket)
<i>'etau</i>	our (incl.)	<i>'etau ngāue</i> (our work)
<i>'emau</i>	our (excl.)	<i>'emau vaka</i> (our boat)
<i>ho'omou</i>	your (pl.)	<i>ho'omou fala</i> (your mat)
<i>'enau</i>	their	<i>'enau me'akai</i> (their food)

Inclusive *'etau* includes the listener (“our, yours and mine”). Exclusive *'emau* excludes the listener (“our, but not yours”). This mirrors the distinction in the personal pronouns taught earlier.

Ho-class possessive pronouns

Pronoun	Meaning	Example
<i>hoku</i>	my	<i>hoku fale</i> (my house)
<i>ho</i>	your (sg.)	<i>ho hingoa</i> (your name)
<i>hono</i>	his, her, its	<i>hono kofu</i> (his/her clothes)
<i>hotau</i>	our (incl.)	<i>hotau fonua</i> (our country)
<i>homau</i>	our (excl.)	<i>homau loki</i> (our room)
<i>homou</i>	your (pl.)	<i>homou fale</i> (your house)
<i>honau</i>	their	<i>honau 'api</i> (their home)

Notice the pattern: every 'e-class pronoun contains a glottal stop in the possessive element (*'eku*, *'ene*, *'etau*), while no ho-class pronoun does (*hoku*, *hono*, *hotau*). The reliable test is the glottal stop, not the first letter: the 'e-class second-person forms *ho'o*, *ho'omo*, and *ho'omou* also begin with *h*, but each still carries a glottal stop. This distinction holds across the entire system.

When the prepositions *ki* or *'i* appear before a ho-class possessive pronoun, the article *he* does not intervene. The preposition goes directly before the possessive: *Na'a ke sio ki hoku tokoua?*

Did you see my brother? (*tokoua* = sibling)

'Oku 'i hoku fale 'a Sione.

Sione is at my house.

Compare this with ordinary nouns, where *ki* and *ʻi* combine with the article *he*: *ki he fale* (to the house). With ho-class possessives, the *he* disappears: *ki hoku fale* (to my house), not *ki he hoku fale*.

Cross-reference: Ko hai ho hingoa?

Chapter 14: Greetings and Social Formulas introduced the greeting *Ko hai ho hingoa?* (What is your name?). The word *ho* is now explained: it is the ho-class possessive pronoun for “your.” A name characterizes you, so it takes ho-class.

Dual possessive pronouns

Tongan also has dual forms for “our (two)” and “their (two)”:

ʻE-class	Ho-class	Meaning
ʻeta	hota	our (yours and mine, two)
ʻema	homa	our (his/hers and mine, two)
hoʻomo	homo	your (his/hers and yours, two)
ʻena	hona	their (two)

Ko fē hona kote?

Where are their coats (the two of them)?

Kuo ngalo homa kote.

We (he and I) have forgotten our coats.

The possessive prepositions 'a and 'o

To show possession with a noun (not a pronoun), Tongan uses two prepositions: 'a for 'e-class and 'o for ho-class. Both translate as “of” in English, but the class rules apply.

Ko e pa'anga 'a Sione.

Sione's money. (Lit. “The money of Sione.” 'E-class: money is something Sione controls.)

Ko e fale 'o Sione.

Sione's house. (Lit. “The house of Sione.” Ho-class: a house shelters Sione.)

Ko e vaka 'o Tēvita.

Tēvita's boat. (Ho-class: a boat shelters and carries you.)

The distinction is clearest with abstract nouns: *ko e tokoni 'a e faiako* means the help given by the teacher, but *ko e tokoni 'o e fonua* means the help given to the country. The teacher produces the help ('e-class), while the country receives it (ho-class).

Possessives with *ko*: describing current actions

A verbal noun is a verb being used as a noun. The word *'alu* (to go) is normally a verb, but when paired with a possessive pronoun, it becomes a noun meaning “going,” as in “your going.” Tongan uses this construction with *ko* to describe what someone is doing right now.

The pattern: **ko + possessive pronoun + verb (as verbal noun)**

Ko ho'o huo?

Are you hoeing? (Lit. “It is your hoeing?”)

Ko ho'o ako?

Are you studying? (Lit. “It is your studying?”)

Ko 'eku 'alu ki Nukunuku.

I am going to Nukunuku. (Lit. “It is my going to Nukunuku.”)

Ko 'eku 'alu ki Nuku'alofa.

I am going to Nuku'alofa. (Lit. “It is my going to Nuku'alofa.”)

Ko e hā ho'o me'a 'oku fai?

What are you doing? (Lit. “What is your thing that is doing?”)

Ko e hā 'ene me'a 'oku fai?

What is he/she doing? (Lit. “What is his/her thing that is doing?”)

Ko e fai 'eku tō manioke.

I am planting cassava. (Lit. “It is the doing of my planting cassava.”)

Ko e fai 'eku tō kumala.

I am planting sweet potato. (Lit. “It is the doing of my planting sweet potato.”)

This pattern is a common and polite greeting. When you see someone working, you observe what they are doing and ask about it:

Ko ho'o lālanga?

Are you weaving?

Ko ho'o haka?

Are you dancing?

Ko ho'o ngāue?

Are you working?

One important difference:

Construction	Meaning
<i>Ko e fai 'eku huo.</i>	I am hoeing. (right now)
<i>'Oku fai 'eku huo.</i>	I am hoeing. (generally, not at this exact moment)

With *ko*, the action is happening at this very moment. With *'oku*, the statement is about a general or habitual activity.

Note:
The subjective/objective distinction with verbal nouns is covered in Chapter 29: The Possessive System in Full, and the full verbal noun construction system is covered in Chapter 45: Verbal Nouns.

Summary of patterns

Pattern	Example	Translation
'E-class pronoun + noun	<i>'eku hele</i>	my knife
Ho-class pronoun + noun	<i>hoku fale</i>	my house
<i>ko e</i> + noun + <i>'a</i> + name	<i>Ko e hele 'a Sione.</i>	Sione's knife.
<i>ko e</i> + noun + <i>'o</i> + name	<i>Ko e fale 'o Sione.</i>	Sione's house.
<i>ko</i> + poss. pronoun + verb	<i>Ko ho'o 'alu ki fē?</i>	Where are you going?

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>'eku</i>	'e-class possessive	my
<i>ho'o</i>	'e-class possessive	your
<i>'ene</i>	'e-class possessive	his/her/its
<i>'emau</i>	'e-class possessive	our (exclusive)
<i>ho'omou</i>	'e-class possessive	your (plural)
<i>'enau</i>	'e-class possessive	their
<i>hoku</i>	ho-class possessive	my
<i>hono</i>	ho-class possessive	his/her/its
<i>hotau</i>	ho-class possessive	our (inclusive)
<i>homau</i>	ho-class possessive	our (exclusive)
<i>homou</i>	ho-class possessive	your (plural)
<i>honau</i>	ho-class possessive	their
<i>'eta</i>	'e-class dual possessive	our (inclusive, two)
<i>hota</i>	ho-class dual possessive	our (inclusive, two)
<i>'ema</i>	'e-class dual possessive	our (exclusive, two)
<i>homa</i>	ho-class dual possessive	our (exclusive, two)
<i>ho'omo</i>	'e-class dual possessive	your (two)
<i>homo</i>	ho-class dual possessive	your (two)
<i>'ena</i>	'e-class dual possessive	their (two) (also “that” (Ch 12))
<i>hona</i>	ho-class dual possessive	their (two)
<i>'o</i>	possessive preposition (ho-class)	of

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>tokoua</i>	noun	sibling
<i>tatā</i>	noun	hat
<i>fonua</i>	noun	country, land
<i>nima</i>	noun	hand
<i>kofu</i>	noun	clothes, garment
<i>me’akai</i>	noun	food
<i>pa’anga</i>	noun	dollar, money
<i>loki</i>	noun	room
<i>tamai</i>	noun	father
<i>fa’ē</i>	noun	mother
<i>huo</i>	verb	hoe
<i>fai</i>	verb	do, make
<i>tō</i>	verb	plant, sow
<i>manioke</i>	noun	cassava
<i>lālānga</i>	noun	weaving
<i>haka</i>	verb	dance
<i>kote</i>	noun	coat

Exercises

Exercise 1: Choose the correct possessive class

For each noun, write the correct possessive pronoun for “my” (’e-class *’eku* or ho-class *hoku*).

1. ___ pa'anga (money)
2. ___ tatā (hat)
3. ___ moa (chicken)
4. ___ nima (hand)
5. ___ ngāue (work)
6. ___ kofu (clothes)
7. ___ fonua (country)
8. ___ talo (taro)

Exercise 2: Complete with 'a or 'o

Fill in the blank with the correct possessive preposition.

1. Ko e hele ___ Mele. (Mele's knife)
2. Ko e fale ___ Sione. (Sione's house)
3. Ko e vaka ___ Tēvita. (Tēvita's boat)
4. Ko e ngāue ___ Siale. (Siale's work)
5. Ko e kofu ___ 'Ofa. ('Ofa's clothes)
6. Ko e kato ___ 'Ana. ('Ana's basket)

Exercise 3: Translate Tongan to English

1. *Ko ho'o 'alu ki fē?*
2. *Ko 'eku 'alu ki he fale kai.*
3. *Ko e hā ho'o me'a 'oku fai?*
4. *Ko fē hoku tatā?*
5. *Ko e vaka 'o Mele.*
6. *'Oku 'i fē ho'o kato?*

Exercise 4: Translate English to Tongan

1. Where is my hat?
2. Sione's money.
3. Are you hoeing?
4. Her house is big.
5. Our (inclusive) country.
6. Their food.

Exercise 5: Fill in the correct possessive pronoun

Use the 'e-class or ho-class pronoun given in parentheses.

- 1. Ko fē ___ tohi? (your, sg.: a book is a thing you use)
- 2. 'Oku mālohi ___ fale. (his: a house shelters him)
- 3. Ko e hā ___ me'a 'oku fai? (your, pl.)
- 4. Kuo 'osi ___ ngāue. (our, excl.: work is something we do)
- 5. Ko ___ 'alu ki Nuku'alofa. (my)

Exercise 6: Match the Tongan with its English translation

Tongan		English	
1.	Ko e fale 'o Pita.	a.	His knife.
2.	'Eku hele.	b.	Pita's house.
3.	Ko ho'o haka?	c.	My knife.
4.	'Ene hele.	d.	Where is your hat?
5.	Ko fē ho tatā?	e.	Are you dancing?

Answers

Exercise 1

- 1. 'eku pa'anga (money: you control it)
- 2. hoku tatā (hat: clothing, characterizes you)
- 3. 'eku moa (chicken: animal, you own it)
- 4. hoku nima (hand: body part)
- 5. 'eku ngāue (work: activity, you perform it)
- 6. hoku kofu (clothes: clothing, characterizes you)
- 7. hoku fonua (country: shelters you)
- 8. 'eku talo (taro: food, you consume it)

Exercise 2

1. 'a (knife: 'e-class, tool)
2. 'o (house: ho-class, shelter)
3. 'o (boat: ho-class, shelters/carries)
4. 'a (work: 'e-class, activity)
5. 'o (clothes: ho-class, characterizes)
6. 'a (basket: 'e-class, tool/container you use)

Exercise 3

1. Where are you going?
2. I am going to the cafeteria.
3. What are you doing?
4. Where is my hat?
5. Mele's boat.
6. Where is your basket?

Exercise 4

1. *Ko fē hoku tatā?*
2. *Ko e pa'anga 'a Sione.*
3. *Ko ho'o huo?*
4. *'Oku lahi hono fale.*
5. *Hotau fonua.*
6. *'Enau me'akai.*

Exercise 5

1. *ho'o* (your, sg., 'e-class: a book is a thing you use)
2. *hono* (his, ho-class: a house shelters him)
3. *ho'omou* (your, pl., 'e-class: *me'a* in this construction)
4. *'emau* (our, excl., 'e-class: work is something we do)
5. *'eku* (my, 'e-class: verbal noun construction with *ko*)

Exercise 6

- 1: b, 2: c, 3: e, 4: a, 5: d

Chapter 18: Definiteness and the Definitive Accent

This chapter returns to articles and introduces a feature of Tongan that has no equivalent in English: the definitive accent.

Three levels of definiteness

Chapter 8: Articles introduced the articles *ha*, *e*, and *he*. English has two levels of specificity: “a” (indefinite) and “the” (definite). Tongan has three. “Definite” means specific in the speaker’s mind. “Indefinite” means not specific.

Consider a basket (*kato*). Three sentences place that noun at three levels of specificity:

Ha’u mo ha kato.

Bring a basket. (Any basket.)

Ha’u mo e kato.

Bring a basket. (I have a particular one in mind, but you may not know which.)

Ha’u mo e kató.

Bring the basket. (The one you know about.)

The first sentence uses *ha*, the indefinite article. The speaker does not have a particular basket in mind.

The second uses *e*, the definite article, but with no change in pronunciation. The speaker means one particular basket, but has not singled it out for the listener. Churchward calls this level semi-definite.

The third also uses *e*, but the stress on *kato* has shifted: *kató* instead of *káto*. Both speaker and listener know exactly which one. This is full definiteness.

The difference between the second and third sentences is entirely in the pronunciation. Tongan marks “the” not just with an article (*e* or *he*) but with a shift in stress. This stress shift is called the definitive accent.

The same contrast appears with *ika* (fish):

’Oku ou fiema’u ha ika.

I want some fish. (Any fish. Indefinite.)

’Oku ou fiema’u ’a e ika.

I want fish. (A particular fish, but not identified to the listener. Semi-definite.)

’Oku ou fiema’u ’a e iká.

I want the fish. (The specific fish we both know about. Definite.)

The verb *fiema’u* (*to want, to need*) takes a direct object. The first two sentences look different because they use different articles (*ha* vs. *e*). The second and third look the same in writing but sound different: in the third, stress falls on the final *a*, producing *iká*.

Level	Tongan	English
Indefinite	<i>ha ika</i>	some fish (any fish)
Semi-definite	<i>e ika</i>	a fish (a particular one)
Definite	<i>e iká</i>	the fish

How the definitive accent works

The Introduction covered the basic stress rule: stress normally falls on the second-to-last vowel. The definitive accent overrides this. When a noun phrase is fully definite, stress moves to the very last vowel of the entire phrase.

fále. house (normal stress, second-to-last vowel)

’i he falé. in the house (stress on the last vowel)

The rule is straightforward: when a common noun is definite and preceded by the article *he* or *e*, stress shifts from the second-to-last syllable to the last syllable. Think of the article and noun as a single pronunciation unit where the stress adjusts to cover the whole group.

The same accent shift applies to other nouns. The word *koloa* (*wealth, goods*) becomes *koloá* when definite:

Na’á ku sio ki he koloá.

I looked at the goods.

The word *talavou* (*young man*) becomes *talavoú* when definite:

Na’e ha’u ’a e talavoú.

The young man came.

’Oku fiefia ’a e talavoú.

The young man is happy.

When a definite noun phrase gets longer, the definitive accent moves to the end of the whole noun group:

Tongan	English
<i>’i he falé</i>	in the house
<i>’i he fale akó</i>	in the school building
<i>’i he fale ako fo’óú</i>	in the new school building
<i>e koloá</i>	the wealth

Tongan	English
<i>e koloa lahi</i>	the great wealth

The word *akó* (*school, to learn*) is a modifier. The word *fo’ou* (*new*) adds another modifier. No matter how many adjectives or qualifying words follow the noun, the stress lands on the last vowel of the full noun group.

Long vowels and the definitive accent

When the definitive accent falls on a vowel that is already long, the long vowel expands into a double vowel, with stress on the second part.

pō (night) → *poó ni* (this night)

Consider the word *mā* (*bread*). The *ā* is already a long vowel. When the definitive accent falls on it, the long vowel expands: the pronunciation shifts toward something like *maá*. In writing, this doubling is sometimes shown explicitly and sometimes left to the reader’s knowledge.

Na’á ku kai ’a e maá.

I ate the bread.

Note:
You do not need to master every detail of long-vowel doubling at this stage. The essential point is that the definitive accent always pushes stress to the final vowel of the noun phrase, whether that vowel is short or long. The full definitive accent system is covered in Chapter 44: The Definitive Accent System.

The generic use of the definite article

Unlike English, Tongan requires a definite article before nouns that refer to a kind or class of thing in general. Where English says “fish is good” with no article, Tongan treats the entire category as a definite concept:

’Oku lelei ’a e iká.

Fish is good. (Lit. “Is good the fish,” referring to fish as a category.)

Another example: *'Oku lelei 'a e kavá* (Kava is good). The word *kavá* takes the definite article and the definitive accent, even though the sentence is about kava in general, not a specific batch.

This pattern extends to everyday nouns. When Tongan makes a general statement about water, food, or any category, the definite article appears:

'Oku mālohi 'a e vaí.

Water is powerful.

Definite common noun subjects with *e*

When a common noun is the subject of a sentence and is definite, it takes *e* (or *he* after prepositions) with the definitive accent. This follows the word order taught in Chapter 15: Noun Subjects: tense marker + verb + subject.

Na'e lele 'a e tamasi'í.

The boy ran.

Na'e ha'u 'a e faiakó.

The teacher came.

Té ke tokoni ki he tangatá?

Will you help the man?

Na'á ku sio ki he tamasi'í.

I looked at the boy.

In each sentence, the definite article (*e* or *he*) combines with the definitive accent on the final vowel to mark the noun as fully definite. Remember: *he* appears right after the prepositions *'i*, *ki*, and *mei*. It also appears after *'e*, a particle that marks who performs an action in certain sentence types. That construction is covered in Chapter 19: Transitive Word Order. Use *e* everywhere else.

Summary of the article system

Article	Type	Example	Translation
<i>ha</i>	Indefinite	<i>ha kato</i>	a basket (any basket)
<i>e / he</i>	Semi-definite	<i>e kato</i>	a basket (a particular one)
<i>e / he</i> + definitive accent	Fully definite	<i>e kató</i>	the basket

Words to Learn

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>fo'ou</i>	adjective	new
<i>fale ako</i>	noun	school building
<i>fefine</i>	noun	woman
<i>'osi</i>	verb	finished, past
<i>koloa</i>	noun	wealth, goods
<i>talavou</i>	noun	young man

Exercises

Exercise 1: Identify the definiteness level

For each sentence, state whether the noun phrase in bold is indefinite, semi-definite, or definite.

1. 'Oku ou fiema'u **ha** ika.
2. Na'á ku 'alu ki **he** falé.
3. 'Oku 'i heni **e** tohi.
4. 'Oku ou fiema'u **e** iká.
5. 'Oku 'ikai **ha** vai 'i heni.

Exercise 2: Add the definitive accent

Rewrite each noun phrase to make it fully definite. Mark the stressed final vowel with an acute accent.

1. e fale →
2. he tamasi'i →
3. e fale ako →
4. he tangata →
5. e kato lahi →

Exercise 3: Translate Tongan to English

1. 'Oku ou fiema'u ha vai.
2. 'Oku ou fiema'u 'a e vaí.
3. Na'e ha'u 'a e faiakó.
4. Na'á ku sio ki he tamasi'í.
5. Té ke tokoni ki he tangatá?

Exercise 4: Translate English to Tongan

1. I want some fish.
2. I want the fish.
3. The boy came.
4. Did you look at the teacher?
5. The house is big.

Exercise 5: Choose the correct article

Fill in the blank with *ha*, *e*, or *he* (with the definitive accent where needed). The context in parentheses tells you the level of definiteness.

1. 'Oku ou fiema'u ___ ika. (any fish)

2. *Na'á ku 'alu ki __ fale.* (the house, fully definite)
 3. *'Oku 'i heni __ tohi.* (a particular book, semi-definite)
 4. *Té ke tokoni ki __ tamasi'i?* (the boy, fully definite)
 5. *Na'e ha'u __ fefine.* (the woman, fully definite)
-

Answers

Exercise 1

1. Indefinite (*ha ika*, some fish, any fish)
2. Definite (*he falé*, the house, stress on final vowel)
3. Semi-definite (*e tohi*, a particular book, no accent shift)
4. Definite (*e iká*, the fish, stress on final vowel)
5. Indefinite (*ha vai*, any water)

Exercise 2

1. *e falé*
2. *he tamasi'í*
3. *e fale akó*
4. *he tangatá*
5. *e kato lahí*

Exercise 3

1. I want some water.
2. I want the water.
3. The teacher came.
4. I looked at the boy.
5. Will you help the man?

Exercise 4

1. *'Oku ou fiema'u ha ika.*
2. *'Oku ou fiema'u 'a e iká.*
3. *Na'e ha'u 'a e tamasi'í.*

4. *Na'á ke sio ki he faiakó?*
5. *'Oku lahi 'a e falé.*

Exercise 5

1. *ha* (indefinite)
2. *he falé* (definite, after *ki*)
3. *e* (semi-definite)
4. *he tamasi'í* (definite, after *ki*)
5. *'a e fefiné* (definite, with focus marker *'a* + article *e* as subject)

Chapter 19: Transitive Word Order

Every sentence so far has had either no object at all (*Na'e 'alu 'a Sione*. Sione went) or an indefinite object fused to the verb (*Na'á ku kai ma*. I ate bread). This chapter introduces a new sentence pattern for saying who does what to whom, using two markers: 'e for the doer and 'a for the thing acted upon.

Transitive and intransitive: the core distinction

Tongan splits sentences into two shapes based on one question: does the verb have an object? Compare:

Na'e lea 'a Sione.

Sione spoke. (No object. Intransitive.)

Na'e lau 'e Sione 'a e tohí.

Sione read the book. (Has an object: *e tohí*. Transitive.)

Lea (speak) has no object: there is nothing being spoken at. *Lau* (read) has an object: *e tohí*, the book. The first kind is called intransitive (no object); the second is transitive (has an object).

The distinction matters because the marker on the subject changes. In the intransitive sentence, the subject takes *'a*: *'a Sione*. In the transitive sentence, the subject takes *'e*: *'e Sione*. This choice of marker is fixed: a transitive subject is always *'e*, never *'a*. The form *Na'e 'alu 'e Sione* is incorrect, because *'alu* (go) has no object; the correct form is *Na'e 'alu 'a Sione*. (Whether *'a* itself is voiced before some common nouns is a separate, looser question, taken up later in this chapter.)

	Subject marker	Example
Intransitive (no object)	<i>'a</i>	<i>Na'e lea 'a Sione.</i>
Transitive (has an object)	<i>'e</i>	<i>Na'e lau 'e Sione 'a e tohí.</i>

The agent marker *'e*

Na'e 'ave 'e Pita 'a Mele.

Pita took Mele.

'E kumi 'e Tēvita 'a e tamasi'í.

Tēvita will search for the boy.

'E Pita marks Pita as the doer: the one carrying out the action. The word *'e* before a noun in a transitive sentence does exactly this: it marks the doer. Because grammar books often call the doer of a transitive verb the *agent*, *'e* is called the agent marker. It introduces the subject of any transitive verb.

The agent marker *'e* is a completely different word from the future tense marker *'e* and the vocative *'e* used for addressing someone (*'E Sione*). They look the same in writing but do different jobs in different positions.

Before a proper noun, the agent marker stands alone: *'e Pita*, *'e Sione*. Before a common noun, it combines with the definite article *he*: *'e he*.

Common noun subjects: *'e he*

When the doer is a common noun rather than a name, the agent marker combines with the article: *'e he* + noun.

Kuo fai 'e he faiakó 'a e lesení?

Has the teacher given the lesson?

Na'e tohi 'e he tamasi'i 'a e tohi.

The boy wrote the book.

Notice that *'e he* follows the same pattern as the prepositions *ki he*, *'i he*, and *mei he*: the article *he* appears after *'e*.

The focus marker *'a* on objects

You already know *'a* from intransitive sentences, where it marks the subject: *Na'e lea 'a Tolu*. Tolu spoke. In transitive sentences, *'a* shifts to mark the object instead.

Think of *'a* as spotlighting whichever noun is most directly involved in the action. In a sentence with no object, the subject is the only noun connected to the verb, so *'a* marks the subject. In a sentence with an object, the object is what the action lands on, so *'a* shifts to the object.

Té u 'ave 'a Sēmisi.

I will take Sēmisi.

Na'e 'ave 'e Pita 'a Kepu.

Pita took Kepu.

Before proper nouns, 'a always appears: 'a *Kepu*, 'a *Mele*. Before common nouns with the definite article *e*, 'a also appears: *Te nau fai 'a e ngāuē* (They will do the work). Before indefinite nouns (*ha* + noun), 'a never appears.

Written and spoken Tongan. Whether 'a appears before the article *e* is not fully fixed. In writing it shows up consistently before a definite common noun, but in everyday speech it is often dropped; you will hear both, sometimes within the same conversation. The choice is largely one of rhythm and personal style rather than a hard grammatical rule. This book writes 'a *e* as the standard form. Learning it this way gives you the complete structure; once you are comfortable with it, your ear will guide you in conversation.

The basic transitive pattern

The standard word order for a transitive sentence with noun subjects is:

TM + V + 'a + object + 'e + subject

Na'e kai 'e Sione 'a e mā.

Sione ate the bread.

Read it from left to right: *Na'e* (past) + *kai* (eat) + 'e *Sione* (by Sione) + *e mā* (the bread). In this example the subject ('e *Sione*) appears directly after the verb, and the definite object (*e mā*) follows at the end. Both orderings are correct (see below on flexible order).

When the subject is a pronoun, it goes before the verb as usual, and the object follows the verb:

Na'á ku lau 'a e tohí.

I read the book. (Lit. "Past I read [focus] the book")

Té ke 'ave 'a Mele?

Are you taking Mele?

When the object is general vs. specific

One of the most important contrasts in Tongan is between a verb with a general object (any one of a kind, with no article) and the same verb with a specific, definite object (with the article *e*). The general object fuses with the verb, and the whole combination is treated as intransitive:

Intransitive compound	Transitive
<i>Na'e kai ma 'a Sione.</i>	<i>Na'e kai 'e Sione 'a e mā.</i>
Sione ate bread.	Sione ate the bread.

In the first sentence, *kai ma* (eat bread) acts as a single intransitive verb. The subject marker is *'a*. In the second sentence, *e mā* (the bread) is a separate, definite object. The subject marker switches to *'e*.

The same contrast applies to any verb-object pair:

Na'á ku inu vai.

I drank water. (Intransitive compound.)

Na'á ku inu 'a e vaí.

I drank the water. (Transitive: definite object.)

Saying who did it, or leaving it out

Active: *Na'e langa 'e Sione 'a e falé.* Sione built the house. Passive: *Na'e langa 'a e falé.* The house was built.

Active: *Kuo kai 'e he kulī 'a e moá.* The dog has eaten the chicken. Passive: *Kuo kai 'a e moá.* The chicken has been eaten.

To leave the doer out, you simply drop the *'e* phrase from a transitive sentence. The verb does not change. Tongan does not have a separate passive verb form. These “passive” sentences are simply transitive sentences without a named doer. The object remains, marked by the definite article with the definitive accent. The only difference is that no one is named as the doer.

Note:

Tongan also has intransitive verbs that translate as passive in English even though they are not structurally passive: *ngalo* (to be forgotten), *motu* (to be severed), *melemo* (to be drowned). These are simply intransitive verbs that describe a state the subject is in.

Pronoun *ne* in transitive constructions

In intransitive sentences, the third-person singular pronoun *ne* is often dropped. The tense marker stands alone, and the pronoun is understood: *Na'e 'alu 'a Sione*. (He) went, Sione.

In transitive constructions, when the doer is the third-person singular pronoun (and not a separately named 'e agent), *ne* is required:

Na'e fai 'e Pita 'a e ngāu'é?

Did Pita do the work?

'Io, na'á ne fai 'a e ngāu'é.

Yes, he did the work.

The pronoun cannot be dropped here. *Na'e fai 'a e ngāue* without *ne* would mean “the work was done” (passive), not “he did the work.”

Postposed pronouns as transitive objects

The postposed pronouns (*au*, *koe*, *ia*, *kitautolu*, *kimautolu*, *kimoutolu*, *kinautolu*, and the duals) can serve as the object of a transitive verb. When they do, the focus marker 'a is dropped before the singular pronouns and is usually dropped before the dual and plural pronouns.

Na'e ui 'e Pita 'a Mele.

Pita called Mele. (Object is a proper noun: 'a present.)

Na'e ui ia 'e Pita.

Pita called her. (Object is a pronoun: 'a dropped.)

Té u 'ave kinautolu.

I will take them.

'Okú ne manatu'i lelei koe.

He remembers you well.

The pronoun object usually follows the verb phrase and comes before the 'e noun phrase.

Quick Practice: Passives, the required *ne*, and postposed pronoun objects

Rewrite each sentence as instructed.

1. Make passive (drop the 'e phrase): *Na'e kuki 'e Tēvita 'a e mā.* → __
2. Make passive: *Kuo faka'osi 'e Sēmisi 'a e lesoní.* → __
3. Fill in the required pronoun: *Kuo lau 'e Lupe 'a e tohí? 'Io, kuó __ lau 'a e tohí.*
4. Replace the noun object with the postposed pronoun *ia* (drop 'a): *Té u kumi 'a Sione.* → __
5. Replace the noun object with the postposed pronoun *kinautolu*: *Kuo ui 'e Mele 'a e fānau.* → __

Answers: 1. *Na'e kuki 'a e mā.* 2. *Kuo faka'osi 'a e lesoní.* 3. *ne.* 4. *Té u kumi ia.* 5. *Kuo ui kinautolu 'e Mele.*

Flexible word order for emphasis

When both the subject and the object are nouns, either one can come first:

Na'e tāmāte'i 'e Tēvita 'a Kōlaiate.

Tēvita killed Kōlaiate. (Subject first after the verb.)

Na'e tāmāte'i 'a Kōlaiate 'e Tēvita.

Kōlaiate was killed by Tēvita. (Object first after the verb.)

The meaning is the same. The markers 'e and 'a make the roles clear regardless of position. In English, “Tēvita killed Kōlaiate” means something very different from “Kōlaiate killed Tēvita.” In Tongan, 'e *Tēvita* always means “by Tēvita” and 'a *Kōlaiate* always means “Kōlaiate (the one acted upon),” no matter where they sit in the sentence.

The difference is purely one of emphasis, similar to the difference in English between “Tēvita killed Kōlaiate” and “Kōlaiate was killed by Tēvita.”

Adding “myself” / “yourself” in transitive sentences

In intransitive sentences, adding the postposed pronoun creates emphasis: *Té u nofo au*. I will stay (emphatic). In transitive sentences, the same emphasis uses 'e + the postposed pronoun, because the agent marker 'e is always present in transitive constructions:

Té u fai ia 'e au.

I will do it myself.

Na'á ku faka'osi 'e au 'a e ngāué.

I finished the work myself.

Té ke fai ia 'e koe.

You will do it yourself.

The 'e here is the same agent marker that introduces any transitive subject. When the agent and the subject pronoun are the same person, the construction adds emphasis: “I did it **myself**,” “you **yourself** will do it.”

Negation in transitive constructions

The negative pattern works the same way in transitive sentences as in intransitive ones. With a pronoun subject, use 'ikai te:

Na'e 'ikai té u fai 'a e ngāué.

I did not do the work.

With a noun subject, use *'ikai ke*:

Na'e 'ikai ke 'alu 'a Sione.

Sione did not go. (Intransitive.)

Na'e 'ikai ke fai 'e Sione 'a e ngāué.

Sione did not do the work. (Transitive.)

Notice that the only difference between the intransitive and transitive negatives is the subject marker: *'a Sione* in the first, *'e Sione* in the second.

Words to Learn

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>'ave</i>	verb	take, carry
<i>kumi</i>	verb	search for
<i>ui</i>	verb	call
<i>kuki</i>	verb	cook
<i>tāmate'i</i>	verb	kill
<i>faka'osi</i>	verb	finish
<i>manatu'i</i>	verb	remember
<i>kulī</i>	noun	dog
<i>lesoni</i>	noun	lesson
<i>motu</i>	verb (intransitive)	be severed
<i>melemo</i>	verb (intransitive)	be drowned

Exercises

Exercise 1: Identify intransitive or transitive

For each sentence, state whether it is intransitive or transitive. Identify the subject and the object (if any).

1. *Na'e lea 'a Mele.*
2. *Na'e lau 'e Mele 'a e tohí.*
3. *Na'á ku inu vai.*
4. *Na'e inu 'e Tēvita 'a e vaí.*
5. *Na'e 'alu 'a e tamasi'í.*
6. *Kuó ne fai 'a e ngāué.*

Exercise 2: Choose 'a or 'e

Fill in the blank with 'a or 'e.

1. *Na'e hiva ___ Siale.* (Siale sang.)
2. *Na'e tohi ___ Siale 'a e tohí.* (Siale wrote the book.)
3. *Na'e 'ave ___ Pita ___ Mele.* (Pita took Mele.)
4. *Na'e lele ___ e tamasi'í.* (The boy ran.)
5. *Na'e kai ___ he fefiné 'a e iká.* (The woman ate the fish.)

Exercise 3: Translate Tongan to English

1. *Na'e 'ave 'e Taniela 'a Seini.*
2. *Kuo kai 'a e moá.*
3. *Té u fai ia 'e au.*
4. *Na'e 'ikai ke lau 'e Mele 'a e tohí.*
5. *'Okú ne manatu'i au.*

Exercise 4: Translate English to Tongan

1. Sione ate the bread.
2. The fish was cooked.
3. I will take them.
4. Did Pita read the book?
5. The teacher did the work.

Exercise 5: Convert intransitive to transitive

Rewrite each intransitive sentence as a transitive sentence with a definite object. Change the subject marker as needed.

1. *Na'e kai ika 'a Sione.* (Sione ate fish.) → Sione ate the fish.
2. *Na'e inu vai 'a Mele.* (Mele drank water.) → Mele drank the water.
3. *Na'á ku tohi tohi.* (I wrote a letter.) → I wrote the letter.

Exercise 6: Make it passive

Remove the agent to create a passive-equivalent sentence. Translate the result.

1. *Na'e lau 'e Sēmisi 'a e tohí.*
2. *Kuo langa 'e Mele 'a e falé.*
3. *Na'e kuki 'e he fefiné 'a e iká.*

Exercise 7: Emphatic reflexive

Rewrite each sentence to add emphasis on who did it, using 'e + the postposed pronoun.

1. *Na'á ku fai 'a e ngāué.* (I did the work.) → I did the work myself.
2. *Na'á ke tohi 'a e tohí.* (You wrote the book.) → You wrote the book yourself.
3. *Na'á ne kuki 'a e iká.* (He cooked the fish.) → He cooked the fish himself.

Answers**Exercise 1**

1. Intransitive. Subject: *Mele*. No object.
2. Transitive. Subject: *Mele*. Object: *e tohí* (the book).
3. Intransitive (compound *inu vai*). Subject: *ku* (I). No separate object.
4. Transitive. Subject: *Tēvita*. Object: *e vaí* (the water).
5. Intransitive. Subject: *e tamasi'í* (the boy). No object.
6. Transitive. Subject: *ne* (he/she). Object: *e ngāué* (the work).

Exercise 2

1. 'a (intransitive, no object)

2. 'e (transitive, has object *e tohí*)
3. 'e Pita 'a Mele (agent 'e, object 'a)
4. 'a (intransitive, no object)
5. 'e (transitive, has object *e iká*)

Exercise 3

1. Taniela took Seini.
2. The chicken has been eaten.
3. I will do it myself.
4. Mele did not read the book.
5. He/she remembers me.

Exercise 4

1. *Na'e kai 'e Sione 'a e mā.*
2. *Kuo kuki 'a e iká.*
3. *Té u 'ave kinautolu.*
4. *Na'e lau 'e Pita 'a e tohí?*
5. *Na'e fai 'e he faiakó 'a e ngāuē.*

Exercise 5

1. *Na'e kai 'e Sione 'a e iká.* Sione ate the fish.
2. *Na'e inu 'e Mele 'a e vaí.* Mele drank the water.
3. *Na'á ku tohi 'a e tohí.* I wrote the letter.

Exercise 6

1. *Na'e lau 'a e tohí.* The book was read.
2. *Kuo langa 'a e falé.* The house has been built.
3. *Na'e kuki 'a e iká.* The fish was cooked.

Exercise 7

1. *Na'á ku fai 'a e ngāuē 'e au.* I did the work myself.
2. *Na'á ke tohi 'a e tohí 'e koe.* You wrote the book yourself.
3. *Na'á ne kuki 'a e iká 'e ia.* He cooked the fish himself.

Chapter 20: Numbers and Time

Word Study

This chapter teaches the Tongan number system: how to count, how to say prices, how to count people, and how to tell time.

Counting from one to ten

Tongan has ten basic cardinal numerals:

Number	Tongan
1	<i>taha</i>
2	<i>ua</i>
3	<i>tolu</i>
4	<i>fā</i>
5	<i>nima</i>

Number	Tongan
6	<i>ono</i>
7	<i>fitu</i>
8	<i>valu</i>
9	<i>hiva</i>
10	<i>hongofulu</i>

Three larger round numbers appear frequently:

Number	Tongan
100	<i>teau</i>
1,000	<i>afe</i>

Note:
The word *hiva* means both “nine” and “sing/song.” Context makes the meaning clear. When *hiva* appears after a numeral expression or answers a “how many” question, it means nine.

Compound numerals: the connector *mā*

For numbers above ten, Tongan names each part and connects the last part with *mā* (and):

hongofulu mā taha. eleven (ten and one)

hongofulu mā fā. fourteen (ten and four)

The tens follow a regular pattern, adding *-ngofulu* to the unit:

Number	Tongan
20	<i>uofulu</i>
30	<i>tolungofulu</i>
40	<i>fāngofulu</i>
50	<i>nimangofulu</i>

For compound numbers, *mā* appears before the last part only:

tolungofulu mā valu. thirty-eight

teau nimangofulu mā ono. one hundred and fifty-six

Larger numbers follow the same logic:

taha afe. one thousand

ua afe mā tolungeau. two thousand three hundred

Numbers as adjectives: the particle ‘e

When a number describes a noun (answering “how many of this thing?”), the particle ‘e appears before the number:

ha kato ‘e ono. six baskets

pa’anga ‘e taha. one dollar

ha tohi ‘e tolu. three books

The pattern is: noun + ‘e + number. This ‘e is a different word from the agent marker ‘e (which marks the doer in transitive sentences) and the future tense marker ‘e (which appears before noun subjects). It is a particle that attaches a number to a noun.

The particle ‘e is the standard form. When the noun has the definite article, the definitive accent falls on the last vowel of the noun as usual:

‘a e kato ‘e onó. the six baskets

Asking “how many” and “how much”: *fiha*

You have already met *fiha* as an interrogative meaning “when” or “at what time” (*Té ke ’osi he fiha?* What time will you finish?). When *fiha* appears directly after a tense marker, it asks “how much” or “what price”:

’Oku fiha ’a e sotē?

How much is the shirt?

’Oku fiha ’a e iká?

How much is the fish?

The answer uses the same *’e* + number pattern:

’Oku pa’anga ’e taha, seniti ’e ua.

One dollar and two cents.

Fiha also asks “how many” when combined with a noun:

ha kato ’e fiha? how many baskets?

Counting people: *toko*

When a number refers to people or living animals, *toko* precedes the number. The particle *’e* does not appear between *toko* and the number:

’Oku toko hiva pē.

Only nine (people).

Ko e tamaiki ’e toko tolu.

Three children.

The word *kau* (group) before a noun marks a group of people: *kau faiakó* (teachers), *kau akó* (pupils). It appears naturally with *toko* when asking about groups:

’Oku toko fiha ho’o kau akó?

How many pupils do you have?

The pattern is *toko* + number for a specific count, and *toko fiha* for the question “how many people.”

Two related words use the same *toko* base:

Tongan	Meaning
<i>tokolahi</i>	many (people)
<i>tokosi'i</i>	few (people)

'Oku nau tokosi'i pē.

There are only a few of them.

Telling time

Tongan uses the *ko* pattern for telling time.

The most common way to ask the time is:

Ko e fihá eni?

What time is it?

Two other forms are also used: *Ko e taimi fiha eni?* and *Ko e hā 'a e taimí?*. The first form is the most frequent.

To answer, state the hour with *ko e*:

Ko e tolú eni.

It is three o'clock.

Ko e valú eni.

It is eight o'clock.

For “at” a specific time, use *he* (which is *'i he* with *'i* dropped, a pattern you learned with prepositions):

Tau kamata he fitū.

We begin at seven.

He tolu.

At three.

For minutes before the hour, Tongan uses the word *toe* (*remaining, still to go*) before the time phrase. This word has other uses covered in Chapter 22: Aspect Markers, but in time-telling it simply means “remaining”:

’Oku toe ’a e miniti ’e nima ki he tolú.

Five minutes to three. (Lit. “Five minutes remain to the three.”)

For minutes after the hour, Tongan uses *’osi* (*finished, past*) to indicate that the hour has passed. Like *toe*, this word has broader uses covered in Chapter 22: Aspect Markers, but in time-telling it signals that the hour is complete:

Kuo ’osi ’a e valú, miniti ’e hongofulu.

Ten minutes past eight. (Lit. “The eight is finished, ten minutes.”)

A common shortcut in everyday speech is to state each digit:

Time	Tongan
8:15	<i>valu taha nima</i>
7:20	<i>fitu ua noa</i>
9:30	<i>hiva tolu noa</i>

For times of day, Tongan adds a word after the hour:

Tongan	Meaning
<i>pongipongi</i>	morning
<i>ho’atā</i>	midday
<i>efiafi</i>	afternoon / evening
<i>po’uli</i>	nighttime

’I he fitu pongipongi.

At 7 a.m.

'I he ono efiāfi.

At 6 p.m.

Ordinal numbers

The word for “first” is *'uluaki*. It can appear before or after the noun:

ko e 'uluaki ta'ú. the first year

For “second,” “third,” and higher, Tongan uses the ho-class possessive *hono* (which you learned with possessives) plus the number with the definitive accent:

ko hono uá. the second

ko hono tolú. the third

ko hono nimá. the fifth

This is a natural extension of the possessive system: the ordinal literally says “its second,” “its third.”

Note:

The word *tu'o* before a number means “times” in a counting sense: *tu'o taha* = once, *tu'o ua* = twice. This is covered in Chapter 22: Aspect Markers and Frequency.

Me'a e fiha (how many)

Ko e fo'i mango. Me'a e fiha?

Mangoes. How many?

The expression *me'a e fiha* (*how many*) is a conversational way to ask about quantity. It often appears on its own as a follow-up question after someone names what they want.

Ko e fo'i siaine. Me'a e fiha? Nima pē!

Bananas. How many? Just five.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>'e</i>	numeric particle	connects a number to a noun (also the future-tense marker, Ch 9)
<i>mā</i>	numeric connector	and (in compound numbers) (also “bread” (Ch 3))
<i>toko</i>	people counter	precedes number when counting people
<i>'uluaki</i>	ordinal word	first
<i>kau</i>	group marker	marks a group of people
<i>tu’o</i>	frequency marker (preview)	times (<i>tu’o taha</i> = once)

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>taha</i>	number	one
<i>ua</i>	number	two
<i>tolu</i>	number	three

Tongan	Type	English
<i>fā</i>	number	four
<i>nima</i>	number	five (also “hand” (Ch 17))
<i>ono</i>	number	six
<i>hongofulu</i>	number	ten
<i>uofulu</i>	number	twenty
<i>tolungofulu</i>	number	thirty
<i>fāngofulu</i>	number	forty
<i>nimangofulu</i>	number	fifty
<i>teau</i>	number	one hundred
<i>afe</i>	number	one thousand
<i>noa</i>	number	zero
<i>seniti</i>	noun	cent
<i>sote</i>	noun	shirt
<i>fo’i</i>	classifier	piece, individual item
<i>tokolahi</i>	adjective	many (people)
<i>tokosi’i</i>	adjective	few (people)
<i>taimi</i>	noun	time, clock
<i>miniti</i>	noun	minute
<i>pongipongi</i>	time word	morning
<i>ho’atā</i>	time word	midday
<i>po’uli</i>	time word	nighttime
<i>mango</i>	noun	mango
<i>siaine</i>	noun	banana

Tongan	Type	English
<i>tamaiki</i>	noun	children

Exercises

Exercise 1: Write the Tongan numeral

Write the Tongan word for each number.

1. 3
2. 7
3. 10
4. 15
5. 22
6. 100
7. 41

Exercise 2: Translate Tongan to English

1. *ha fala 'e valu*
2. *pa'anga 'e nima*
3. *ha tohi 'e ua*
4. *Ko e tamaiki 'e toko fā.*
5. *'Oku toko fiha e kau faiakó?*

Exercise 3: Ask and answer prices

Translate each exchange into Tongan.

1. How much is the basket? Two dollars.
2. How much is the book? Three dollars and five cents.
3. How much is the mat? One dollar.

Exercise 4: Telling time

Translate each sentence into Tongan.

1. What time is it?
2. It is six o'clock.
3. We begin at eight.
4. At 7 a.m.
5. Ten minutes to five.

Exercise 5: People counting

Translate into Tongan.

1. Five children.
2. How many teachers are there?
3. Only three (people).
4. There are many (people).

Exercise 6: Mixed translation (English to Tongan)

1. I ate the fish at seven.
2. Pita built six baskets.
3. The first book.
4. What time does the teacher arrive?

Exercise 7: Mixed translation (Tongan to English)

1. *Tau kamata he valu pongipongi.*
2. *'Oku fiha e falá?*
3. *Ko e nimá eni.*
4. *'Oku toko ono pē.*
5. *Ko hono uá.*

Exercise 8: Translate each short exchange into Tongan using me'a e fiha

1. Books. How many? Three!
2. Baskets. How many? Six!
3. Fish. How many? Five!
4. Mats. How many? Two!
5. Knives. How many? Four!

Answers**Exercise 1**

1. *tolu*
2. *fitu*
3. *hongofulu*
4. *hongofulu mā nima*
5. *uofulu mā ua*
6. *teau*
7. *fāngofulu mā taha*

Exercise 2

1. eight mats
2. five dollars
3. two books
4. There are four children.
5. How many teachers are there?

Exercise 3

1. *'Oku fiha e kató? Pa'anga 'e ua.*
2. *'Oku fiha e tohí? Pa'anga 'e tolu, seniti 'e nima.*
3. *'Oku fiha e falá? Pa'anga 'e taha.*

Exercise 4

1. *Ko e fihá eni?*
2. *Ko e onó eni.*
3. *Tau kamata he valu.*
4. *'I he fitu pongipongi.*
5. *'Oku toe 'a e miniti 'e hongofulu ki he nimá.*

Exercise 5

1. *Ko e tamaiki 'e toko nima.*
2. *'Oku toko fiha e kau faiakó?*

3. 'Oku toko tolu pē.
4. 'Oku nau tokolahi.

Exercise 6

1. Na'á ku kai e iká he fitu.
2. Na'e langa 'e Pita ha kato 'e ono.
3. Ko e 'uluaki tohí.
4. 'E tau mai 'a e faiakó 'i he fihá?

Exercise 7

1. We begin at eight in the morning.
2. How much is the mat?
3. It is five o'clock.
4. There are only six (people).
5. The second.

Exercise 8

1. Ko e tohi. Me'a e fiha? Tolu!
2. Ko e kato. Me'a e fiha? Ono!
3. Ko e ika. Me'a e fiha? Nima!
4. Ko e fala. Me'a e fiha? Ua!
5. Ko e hele. Me'a e fiha? Fā!

Chapter 21: Auxiliary Verbs

Auxiliary verbs are helper words placed before the main verb to add meaning. This chapter covers how to say you want to do something and how to say you can do something.

***fie*: want to, wish to**

To say you want to do something, place *fie* directly before the main verb. The sentence pattern stays the same as what you already know, with *fie* slotted in between the pronoun and the verb:

tense marker + pronoun + *fie* + verb

'Okú ke fie nofo 'i Ha'apai?

Do you want to live in Ha'apai?

'Okú ke fie ngāue 'i kolo?

Do you want to work in town?

'Oku ou fie 'alu lahi 'aupito ki ai.

I want very much to go there.

'Oku ou fie ha'u lahi 'aupito ki ai.

I want very much to come there.

The word order around *fie* follows the same rules you already know. Modifiers like *lahi* and *'aupito* come after the verb, in that order. Prepositional phrases like *ki ai* come at the end.

Here are more examples with different pronouns and tenses:

Tongan	English
<i>'Oku ou fie ako.</i>	I want to study.
<i>'Okú ke fie hiva?</i>	Do you want to sing?
<i>Na'á ku fie mohe 'anepō.</i>	I wanted to sleep last night.
<i>Té ke fie kai ika?</i>	Would you like to eat fish?
<i>'Oku mau fie 'alu ki kolo.</i>	We want to go to town.

fie works with any verb you have learned. The auxiliary takes the position right before the main verb, and the rest of the sentence builds outward in the usual way.

fie + adjective: an uncomplimentary meaning

When *fie* combines with certain adjectives instead of a verb, the meaning shifts. Rather than “want to be,” it implies someone imagines themselves to be something they are not: a desire to be regarded or treated as having a quality one does not truly possess.

Tongan	Literal meaning	Actual meaning
<i>fie poto</i>	want to be clever	conceited, presumptuous
<i>fie lahi</i>	want to be big	bullish, showing off

Tongan	Literal meaning	Actual meaning
<i>fie lelei</i>	want to be good	goody-goody

'Oua té ke fie poto.
Do not be conceited.

'Oua té ke fie lahi.
Do not be a show-off.

These combinations are always uncomplimentary. Telling someone *'Okú ke fie lahi* is not a neutral observation. It is a pointed remark.

Note:
Words like *fiekaia* (hungry), *fieinua* (thirsty), and *fiamohea* (sleepy), which you have seen in earlier chapters, look similar but are single compound words with their own meanings. They are not *fie* + adjective in this uncomplimentary sense. In these words, the *-a* suffix belongs to the compound as a whole, not to the base verb.

lava: to be able to

To say someone can do something, use *lava* followed by the conjunction *'o* and then the main verb:

tense marker + pronoun + *lava* + *'o* + verb

Té ke lava 'o ha'u 'anai?

Will you be able to come later?

Té ke lava 'o 'alu 'apongipongi?

Will you be able to go tomorrow?

The word *lava* literally means to arrive or achieve. The meaning progresses naturally: to arrive at a goal, to succeed in doing something, and from there, to be able. The conjunction *'o* links *lava* to the action that follows.

'Oku ou lava 'o kakau.

I can swim.

Na'e lava 'a Siale 'o hiva lelei.

Siale was able to sing well.

When a noun (rather than a pronoun) is the subject, it follows *lava* with the focus marker *'a*, and *'o* still introduces the second verb:

'E lava 'e Pita 'o fakatau 'a e me'akái?

Can Pita buy the food?

'E lava 'e Sione 'o lau 'a e tohi?

Can Sione read the book?

Notice that when the second verb is transitive, the agent marker *'e* replaces the focus marker *'a* before the noun subject, just as in normal transitive sentences. The subject particle is determined by the second verb.

'Oku 'ikai ke lava 'a Mele 'o lea lelei.

Mele cannot speak well.

'Oku 'ikai ke lava 'a 'Ana 'o hiva lelei. 'Ana cannot sing well.

In the negative, *lava* uses the same negative patterns you already know. With pronoun subjects, use *'oku 'ikai te* + pronoun + *lava*. With noun subjects, use *'oku 'ikai ke lava*.

Tongan	English
<i>'Oku 'ikai té u lava 'o 'alu.</i>	I cannot go.
<i>Na'e 'ikai té ke lava 'o ha'u?</i>	Were you not able to come?
<i>'Oku 'ikai ke lava 'a Tēvita 'o tohi.</i>	Tēvita cannot write.

Note:

Tongan has several other ways to express ability: *ala* (it is practicable), *fa'a* (one has the physical capacity), the *ma-* prefix (able as discovered by trial), and *poto 'i* (skilled at). These appear in later chapters, including Chapter 49: Prefixes. *Lava* is the general-purpose word for “can” or “be able to.”

***sai'ia*: to like**

The verb *sai'ia* (to like, to be pleased with) takes an *'i* phrase to indicate what is liked. Because *'i* before the definite article *he* drops, you will usually see *sai'ia he* rather than *sai'ia 'i he*:

'Okú ke sai'ia he me'akai?

Do you like the food?

'Okú ke sai'ia he hivá?

Do you like the song?

Sai'ia pē.

Just a little.

'Oku ou sai'ia lahi he lea faka-Tongá.

I like the Tongan language a lot.

With proper names, use *'ia* (the personal form of *'i*):

'Okú ke sai'ia 'ia Seini?

Do you like Seini?

'Okú ke sai'ia 'ia Siale?

Do you like Siale?

'To, 'oku ou sai'ia lahi ai.

Yes, I like her a lot.

'To, 'oku ou sai'ia lahi 'aupito ai.

Yes, I like her very much.

The substitute *ai* works here the same way you learned with *ki* phrases: it replaces the full *'i/'ia* phrase when the object has already been mentioned.

Tongan	English
'Oku ou sai'ia he hivá.	I like the song.
'Oku 'ikai té u sai'ia he kavá.	I do not like kava.
Na'á ke sai'ia 'ia Lātū?	Did you like Lātū?
'Io, na'á ku sai'ia lahi ai.	Yes, I liked him a lot.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
lava 'o	auxiliary construction	be able to

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
sai'ia	verb	like, be pleased with
kakau	verb	swim
fakatau	verb	buy
fakapikopiko	adjective	lazy
fiemohea	adjective	sleepy

Exercises***Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English***

1. 'Oku ou fie mohe.
2. Té ke lava 'o ha'u 'apongipongi?
3. Na'á ku fie 'alu ki Ha'apai.
4. 'Oku 'ikai té u lava 'o hiva.
5. 'Okú ke sai'ia he ika?
6. 'Oua té ke fie lahi.
7. 'E lava 'a Mele 'o 'alu?
8. 'Oku mau fie ako lea faka-Tongá.

Exercise 2: Translate English to Tongan

1. Do you want to eat?
2. I cannot swim.
3. Sione was able to come yesterday.
4. Do you like the house?
5. We want to go to the sea tomorrow.
6. Do not be conceited.
7. Can Tēvita read the book?
8. I like Tonga very much.

Exercise 3: Transform: make each sentence negative

1. 'Oku ou fie 'alu.
2. Té ke lava 'o ha'u?
3. Na'á ku sai'ia he me'akai.
4. 'Oku lava 'a Sione 'o ngāue.
5. 'Oku ou fie nofo 'i kolo.

Exercise 4: Fill in the blank with fie, lava 'o, or sai'ia

1. 'Okú ke __ he lea faka-Tongá? (Do you like the Tongan language?)
2. 'Oku ou __ 'alu ki tahi. (I want to go to the ocean.)
3. Té ke __ ha'u 'anai? (Will you be able to come later?)

4. *Na'á ku __ mohe 'anepō.* (I wanted to sleep last night.)
5. *'Oku 'ikai té u __ lahi he kavá.* (I do not like kava much.)
6. *'E __ 'a 'Ana 'o haka?* (Will 'Ana be able to dance?)

Answers

Exercise 1

1. I want to sleep.
2. Will you be able to come tomorrow?
3. I wanted to go to Ha'apai.
4. I cannot sing.
5. Do you like fish?
6. Do not be a show-off.
7. Will Mele be able to go?
8. We want to study the Tongan language.

Exercise 2

1. *'Okú ke fie kai?*
2. *'Oku 'ikai té u lava 'o kakau.*
3. *Na'e lava 'a Sione 'o ha'u 'aneafi.*
4. *'Okú ke sai'ia he falé?*
5. *'Oku mau fie 'alu ki tahi 'apongipongi.*
6. *'Oua té ke fie poto.*
7. *'E lava 'e Tēvita 'o lau 'a e tohí?*
8. *'Oku ou sai'ia lahi 'aupito 'i Tonga.*

Exercise 3

1. *'Oku 'ikai té u fie 'alu.*
2. *'E 'ikai té ke lava 'o ha'u.* (or: *'Oku 'ikai té ke lava 'o ha'u?*)
3. *Na'e 'ikai té u sai'ia he me'akai.*
4. *'Oku 'ikai ke lava 'a Sione 'o ngāue.*
5. *'Oku 'ikai té u fie nofo 'i kolo.*

Exercise 4

1. *sai'ia*
2. *fie*
3. *lava 'o*
4. *fie*
5. *sai'ia*
6. *lava*

Chapter 22: Aspect Markers and Frequency

Tense markers tell you *when* something happens. This chapter adds a second set of markers (placed between the tense marker and the verb) that tell you *what stage* the action is in: still going on, already finished, happening right now, or just starting. These are called **aspect markers**.

tense marker + pronoun + aspect marker + verb

kei: still

The word *kei* placed before the verb means “still”: something was true before, and it remains true now.

'Okú ne kei fiekaia pē.

He is still hungry.

'Oku kei vaivai pē 'a Sēmisi.

Sēmisi is still weak.

'Oku ou kei feinga pē.

I am still trying.

The limiter *pē* appears frequently with *kei*. Together they give the sense of “still just” or “continuing as before,” with no change from the expected situation.

Tongan	English
<i>'Okú ke kei nofo 'i kolo?</i>	Are you still living in town?
<i>'Oku mau kei ako.</i>	We are still studying.
<i>'Okú ne kei mohe pē.</i>	He is still sleeping.
<i>Na'á ku kei hela'ia 'aneafi.</i>	I was still tired yesterday.

In the negative, the usual negation patterns apply. With pronoun subjects:

'Oku 'ikai té u kei fiekaia.

I am not still hungry. (I am no longer hungry.)

'osi: already, finished

The word *'osi* placed before a verb means the action has already been completed.

As a main verb on its own, *'osi* means “to be finished” or “to be over.”

Kuó ne 'osi 'alu.

He has already gone.

Kuo 'osi ha'u 'a Sione?

Has Sione already come?

The tense marker *kuo* (perfect) pairs naturally with *'osi*, since both point to completion. But *'osi* can appear with other tense markers too:

Na'á ku 'osi kai.

I had already eaten.

'Oku 'osi lahi e ngāué.

The work is already considerable. (Much has already been done.)

As a main verb, *'osi* works just like any other verb:

Kuo 'osi 'a e fakatahá.

The meeting is over.

***te'eki ai*: not yet**

The natural companion to *'osi* (already) is *te'eki ai* (not yet). It indicates that something expected has not happened so far, but the speaker anticipates it will.

Kuo 'osi foki 'a Mele?

Has Mele already returned?

Te'eki ai.

Not yet.

The short answer *Te'eki ai* is one of the most common phrases in Tongan. The *ai* is required in this standalone use.

In full sentences, *te'eki* follows the same patterns as *'ikai*. Before a pronoun, use *te'eki te* (or occasionally *te'eki ke*):

'Oku te'eki té ke 'alu tu'o taha ki Ha'apai.

You have not gone even once to Ha'apai.

Before a verb with a noun subject, *te'eki* can stand without *te* or *ke*:

'Oku te'eki kamata 'a e ngāué.

The work has not started yet.

Note:

The phrase *te'eki ai ke* can also mean “before” in the sense of something happening prior to another event: *Te'eki ai ke u lea, kuó ne lea mai.* (Before I could speak, he spoke to me.) This is an awareness item. You will encounter it in reading, but the formal treatment comes in Chapter 30: Temporal and Conditional Conjunctions.

***lolotonga*: currently, in the act of**

The word *lolotonga* marks an action as being in progress at the time of speaking (or at the time referred to). English uses “-ing” forms for this; Tongan uses *lolotonga* before the verb.

'Oku ou lolotonga lau ha tohi.

I am currently reading a book.

Na'á ku lolotonga ngāue au he taimi ko iá.

I was working at that time.

Lolotonga pē 'emau kaí, kuo ha'u 'a Sione.

Right while we were eating, Sione arrived.

As a main verb, *lolotonga* means “to be in progress” or “to be going on”:

'Oku lolotonga 'a e ngāué.

The work is in progress.

***toe*: again, more, other**

The word *toe* is placed before a verb to mean “again” or “more.” It indicates repetition or addition.

'Oku toe fiekaia 'a Sēmisi.

Sēmisi is hungry again.

'Okú ke fie toe ha'u?

Do you want to come again?

Toe can also mean “more” or “other” when used before a noun as an adjective: *ha toe me'a*. another thing, an additional thing

Before a verb with a modifier, *toe* combines with *ange* to form comparisons (you will learn this pattern formally in Chapter 27: Comparison and Degree). Observe the basic meaning of repetition:

Tongan	English
<i>Na’á ku toe ’alu ki kolo.</i>	I went to town again.
<i>’Oku ou fie toe kai.</i>	I want to eat again.
<i>’Oku ’ikai té u toe fiekaia.</i>	I am not hungry anymore. (Lit. I do not again hunger.)

***toki*: just, not until**

The word *toki* is placed before the verb. It carries two related meanings, both rooted in the idea of timing: “just now” (something happened a moment ago) and “not until” (something will not happen before a certain point).

“Just” (recent past):

Na’a mau toki ha’u ’aneafi.

We just came yesterday.

Na’á ku toki fanongo ki he me’a ko iá.

I only just heard about that.

“Not until” (delayed future):

’E toki kamata ’a e fakatahá ’apongipongi.

The meeting will not begin until tomorrow.

Té u toki ngāue.

I will work presently. (Not right now, but soon.)

The common thread is that *toki* marks the action as happening at a particular point, neither sooner nor later. When referring to the past, it emphasizes recency. When referring to the future, it emphasizes delay.

Ha’u ’o inu ká ke toki ’alu.

Come and drink, then go. (Go only after drinking.)

leva: immediately

The word *leva* is placed after the verb. Where *toki* delays, *leva* does the opposite: it indicates that the action happened (or should happen) right away, without delay.

Na’á ku foki leva.

I returned at once.

Hili iá, na’e toki ’alu leva ’a Mele.

After that, Mele left immediately.

Tongan	English
<i>’Alu leva!</i>	Go at once.
<i>Na’á ku foki leva ki fale.</i>	I returned to the house immediately.

Note: Toki is preposed (before the verb) and leva is postposed (after the verb). They can even appear in the same sentence: na’e toki ’alu leva = then went immediately.

All aspect markers together

Here is a summary of the aspect markers introduced in this chapter:

Marker	Position	Meaning
<i>kei</i>	before verb	still, continuing
<i>’osi</i>	before verb	already, finished

Marker	Position	Meaning
<i>te'eki ai</i>	sentence-initial or before verb	not yet
<i>lolotonga</i>	before verb	currently, in progress
<i>toe</i>	before verb	again, more
<i>toki</i>	before verb	just, not until
<i>leva</i>	after verb	immediately
<i>toutou</i>	before verb	repeatedly
<i>ai pē</i>	after verb/clause	as always, as usual
<i>tu'o</i> + numeral	after verb	N times
<i>taki taha</i>	before verb	each one

These markers slot into the sentence pattern you already know. Multiple markers can combine when the meaning requires it:

'Oku 'ikai té u kei fie 'alu.

I no longer want to go. (Lit. I do not still want to go.)

Kuó ne 'osi lava 'o ha'u.

He has already been able to come.

Repetition, frequency, and distribution

The markers above describe the stage of an action. A closely related set of modifiers describes how often or how regularly an action occurs. These frequency and distribution markers occupy similar positions in the sentence and combine freely with aspect markers and tense markers.

Repeatedly: *toutou*

The preposed modifier *toutou* means “repeatedly,” “continuously,” or “again and again.” It comes directly before the verb.

'Oku toutou lele 'a Sēmisi ki kolo.

Sēmisi keeps running to town.

Na'e toutou lea 'a Tēvita.

Tēvita repeatedly spoke.

'Oku totonu ke toutou ako'i kinautolu.

They need to be taught again and again.

As always: *ai pē*

The adverb *ai pē* means “still,” “as always,” “as before,” or “as usual.” It indicates that something continues unchanged.

Ko ia ai pē.

Just the same old thing. / Same as always.

'Oku kei fai ai pē e ngāuē.

The work is still being done as usual.

'Oku fakalaka ai pē 'a Tonga ki mu'a.

Tonga is continuing to go forward.

'Oku ou nofo ai pē 'i kolo.

I still live in town as always.

Quick Practice: *toutou* and *ai pē*

Fill in the blank with *toutou* (repeatedly) or *ai pē* (as always, as usual).

1. *Na'e* __ *tangi 'a e tamasi'í*. The boy kept crying.
 2. *'Oku fakalaka* __ *'a e ngāu'é*. The work is moving forward as always.
 3. *'Oku kei lotu* __ *'a e fāmīlī*. The family still prays as usual.
 4. *Na'e* __ *'alu 'a Sione ki kolo*. Sione kept going to town.
 5. *'Oku* __ *ngāue 'a e fefiné 'i he 'apí*. The woman continually works at the home.
- Answers:** 1. *toutou*. 2. *ai pē*. 3. *ai pē*. 4. *toutou*. 5. *toutou*

Counting times: *tu'o* + numeral

To say how many times something has happened or will happen, place *tu'o* before a numeral. The combination follows the verb or sits in the predicate position.

Kuó u 'alu tu'o taha pē ki Vava'u.

I have gone just once to Vava'u.

Na'e tu'o tolu 'eku tohi kia Mele.

Three times I wrote to Mele. (Lit. "Was three-times my writing to Mele")

'Oku mau lotu tu'o ua he Sāpaté.

We attend services twice on Sunday.

The numeral can be any number: *tu'o taha* (once), *tu'o ua* (twice), *tu'o tolu* (three times), *tu'o fā* (four times), and so on.

For "how many times," use *tu'o fiha*:

Na'e tu'o fiha ho'o tohi ki ai?

How many times did you write to him?

For "many times" and "a few times," use *tu'o lahi* and *tu'o si'i*:

Kuó ne ha'u heni tu'o lahi.

He has come here many times.

When *tu'o* + numeral appears in the predicate with *ko e*, it takes on an ordinal sense, "the Nth time":

Ko e tu'o tolu eni 'o 'eku ha'ú.

This is the third time I have come.

Tongan	English
<i>tu'o taha</i>	once
<i>tu'o ua</i>	twice
<i>tu'o tolu</i>	three times
<i>tu'o fā</i>	four times
<i>tu'o lahi</i>	many times
<i>tu'o si'i</i>	a few times
<i>tu'o fiha</i>	how many times?

Each one: *taki taha*

The word *taki* before a numeral means “each.” The most common combination is *taki taha* (each one, individually, one by one). It appears either before or after the verb.

As a preposed adverb (the common position):

'Oku nau taki taha fa'iteliha.

Each of them does as he pleases.

Mou taki taha fai hono loto.

Each of you do what you want.

'Oku totonu ke mou taki taha fakamālō ki he faiakó.

You should each thank the teacher.

The expression *taki taha ma'ana* means “each for himself” or “each in his own way”:

'Oku tau taki taha ma'ana.

We are each man for himself.

With higher numerals, *taki* distributes the count: *taki ua* (two each), *taki tolu* (three each). These are placed before the noun they refer to:

Na’a nau ’omi taki tolu ’a e kato.

They brought three baskets each.

Note:
The related words *tāutaha* (one by one), *tahataha* (one by one), and *tautau toko* + numeral (in groups of) are less common. Recognise them if you encounter them, but *taki taha* is the form to learn actively.

Words to Learn

New **grammar words** (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>kei</i>	aspect marker	still, continuing
<i>te’eki ai</i>	aspect marker	not yet
<i>toki</i>	aspect marker	just, not until
<i>leva</i>	aspect marker (postposed)	immediately
<i>toutou</i>	preposed modifier	repeatedly, continuously
<i>ai pē</i>	adverb	as always, as usual
<i>taki taha</i>	adverb	each one, individually

New **vocabulary** (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>tu'o</i>	frequency word	times (<i>tu'o ua</i> = twice)
<i>tāutaha</i>	adverb	one by one
<i>fa'iteliha</i>	adverb	as one pleases, at will
<i>tahataha</i>	adverb	one by one (variant)
<i>ako'i</i>	verb	teach

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English

1. 'Okú ke kei nofo 'i Ha'apai?
2. Kuo 'osi 'alu 'a Mele.
3. Te'eki ai.
4. 'Oku ou lolotonga tohi ha tohi.
5. Na'á ku toe sio kia Sione 'aneafi.
6. Na'a mau toki ha'u.
7. Foki leva!
8. 'Oku te'eki té ke kai?

Exercise 2: Translate English to Tongan

1. She is still sick.
2. Have the children already come?
3. I am currently working.
4. Tēvita went to town again.
5. The meeting will not begin until tomorrow.
6. They went at once.
7. I am not hungry yet.
8. Siale is still sleeping.

Exercise 3: Transform: add the aspect marker in parentheses

1. 'Oku ou ngāue. (kei: still)
2. Kuó ne ha'u. ('osi: already)
3. Na'á ku 'alu ki kolo. (toe: again)
4. 'Okú ke lau 'a e tohí. (lolotonga: currently)
5. Na'a mau foki mai. (toki: just)
6. Na'a nau 'alu. (leva: immediately)

Exercise 4: Respond to each question with te'eki ai or kuo 'osi

1. Kuo 'osi kai 'a Pita? (not yet)
2. Kuo 'osi 'alu 'a Sione? (already)
3. Kuo 'osi 'a e fakatahá? (already)
4. Kuó ke 'osi ako? (not yet)
5. Kuo 'osi ha'u 'a 'Ana? (not yet)

Exercise 5: Translate Tongan to English (frequency and distribution)

1. 'Oku toutou tangi 'a e pēpē.
2. Kuó u 'alu tu'o ua ki Vava'u.
3. Mou taki taha nofo 'i homou falé.
4. 'Oku kei fai ai pē 'a e akó.
5. Ko e tu'o tolu eni 'o 'eku ha'ú.
6. Na'a nau 'omi taki tolu 'a e kato.

Exercise 6: Transform using tu'o

Rewrite each sentence to include the number of times given in parentheses.

Example: Kuó u 'alu ki Vava'u. (3) → Kuó u 'alu tu'o tolu ki Vava'u.

1. Na'á ku tohi kia Sione. (twice)
2. Kuó ne ha'u ki Tonga. (many times)
3. 'Oku mau lotu he Sāpaté. (twice)
4. Na'á ku lau 'a e tohí. (three times)

Answers**Exercise 1**

1. Are you still living in Ha'apai?
2. Mele has already gone.
3. Not yet.
4. I am currently writing a letter.
5. I saw Sione again yesterday.
6. We just came.
7. Go back at once.
8. Have you not eaten yet?

Exercise 2

1. 'Okú ne kei puke.
2. Kuo 'osi ha'u 'a e fānau? (or: Kuo 'osi ha'u 'a e tamaiki?)
3. 'Oku ou lolotonga ngāue.
4. Na'e toe 'alu 'a Tēvita ki kolo.
5. 'E toki kamata 'a e fakatahá 'apongipongi.
6. Na'a nau 'alu leva.
7. 'Oku te'eki té u fiekaia.
8. 'Okú ne kei mohe 'a Siale.

Exercise 3

1. 'Oku ou kei ngāue.
2. Kuó ne 'osi ha'u.
3. Na'á ku toe 'alu ki kolo.
4. 'Okú ke lolotonga lau 'a e tohí.
5. Na'a mau toki foki mai.
6. Na'a nau 'alu leva.

Exercise 4

1. Te'eki ai.
2. 'Io, kuo 'osi 'alu.

3. *'Io, kuo 'osi.*
4. *Te'eki ai.*
5. *Te'eki ai.*

Exercise 5

1. The baby keeps crying.
2. I have gone twice to Vava'u.
3. Each of you stay in your house.
4. School is still being held as usual.
5. This is the third time I have come.
6. They brought three baskets each.

Exercise 6

1. *Na'á ku tohi tu'o ua kia Sione.*
2. *Kuó ne ha'u tu'o lahi ki Tonga.*
3. *'Oku mau lotu tu'o ua he Sāpaté.*
4. *Na'á ku lau tu'o tolu 'a e tohí.*

Chapter 23: Obligation and Necessity

This chapter covers obligation and necessity: *'oku totonu ke* (should, ought to) and *kuo pau ke* (must, it is necessary that).

***'oku totonu ke*: should, ought to**

The word *tononu* means “straight” or “correct.” When it appears as the main predicate with *'oku*, it means “it is right” or “it is proper.” Adding *ke* creates a complete obligation expression: “it is right that...”

'Oku totonu ke mau foki ki 'api.

We should return home. (Lit. “It is right that we return home.”)

Preview: The word *ke* before the pronoun or verb in these patterns is the subordinator, a linking word meaning “that” or “to.” It connects the obligation expression to the action that should be done. *Ke* is covered formally in Chapter 26: Purpose, Reason, and Benefit. Treat each obligation pattern (*'oku totonu ke*, *kuo pau ke*) as a single unit.

The literal translation helps. *'Oku totonu* sets up the judgment (“it is right”), and the *ke* clause states what is right.

'Oku totonu ke ke feinga.

You should try.

Notice the doubled *ke ke*. The first *ke* is the subordinator (“that”). The second *ke* is the pronoun “you.” They happen to be the same word, but they play different roles. Reading the sentence slot by slot: *'oku* (present) + *totonu* (right) + *ke* (that) + *ke* (you) + *feinga* (try).

'Oku totonu ke ngāue lahi 'a Mele.

Mele should work hard.

When a noun subject appears instead of a pronoun, the *ke* is followed directly by the verb, and the subject comes at the end with *'a*, following the same word order as other noun-subject sentences.

Tongan	English
<i>'Oku totonu ke u ako.</i>	I should study.
<i>'Oku totonu ke ke lotu.</i>	You should pray.
<i>'Oku totonu ke ta foki.</i>	We (two) should go back.
<i>'Oku totonu ke tokoni 'a Sione.</i>	Sione should help.

'Oku totonu ke can also express probability, not just moral obligation. Context makes the distinction clear:

'Oku totonu ke tau mai 'a e vaká 'apongipongi.

The boat should arrive tomorrow. (It is probable.)

***kuo pau ke*: must, certainly**

The word *pau* means “definite” or “certain.” With *kuo* (perfect tense, indicating a completed change of state), *kuo pau* means “it has become definite.” The full

expression *kuo pau ke* signals that something is unavoidable or certain: “it must be” or “it is necessary that.”

Kuo pau ke u foki ki fale.

I must go home. (Lit. “It has become certain that I return home.”)

Kuo pau ke ke ngāue.

You must work.

Where *’oku totonu ke* expresses what is right or proper (a moral judgment), *kuo pau ke* expresses what is necessary or inevitable (a certainty):

’Oku totonu ke ke ako.

You should study. (It is the right thing to do.)

Kuo pau ke ke ako.

You must study. (It is necessary.)

Kuo pau ke also works with impersonal subjects (weather, events) to express certainty about what will happen:

Kuo pau ke vela he ’aho ní.

It is certain to be hot today.

Kuo pau ke hela’ia ’a Sēmisi.

Sēmisi must be tired. (It is certain that Sēmisi is tired.)

Negating obligation: *’oku ’ikai totonu ke*

To say “should not,” insert *’ikai* between the tense marker and *totonu*. This follows the standard negation pattern: *’oku* + *’ikai* + predicate.

’Oku ’ikai totonu ke u lea.

I should not speak.

’Oku ’ikai totonu ke ke nofo heni.

You should not stay here.

The past tense form uses *na’e*, as in all negatives:

Na’e ’ikai totonu ke ’i heni ’a Pita.

Pita should not have been here.

Compare the positive and negative patterns side by side:

Positive	Negative
<i>’Oku totonu ke u ha’u.</i>	<i>’Oku ’ikai totonu ke u ha’u.</i>
I should come.	I should not come.
<i>Na’e totonu ke ’i heni ’a Tēvita.</i>	<i>Na’e ’ikai totonu ke ’i heni ’a Tēvita.</i>
Tēvita should have been here.	Tēvita should not have been here.

Note:
With the past tense (*na’e totonu ke*), the expression means “should have,” an obligation that existed in the past. *Na’e totonu ke ’i heni ’a Tēvita* means Tēvita should have been here (but was not).

Emphatic “should not”: *’oku totonu ke ’oua na’a*

There is a second way to express “should not” that sounds more emphatic. Instead of negating *totonu* with *’ikai*, you embed the prohibition word *’oua na’a* inside the *ke* clause.

You first encountered *’oua* in the chapter on commands, where *’oua té ke* means “don’t” as a direct prohibition. Here, *’oua na’a* appears inside an obligation expression, giving it a different flavor: “it is right that you should refrain from...”

’Oku totonu ke ’oua na’a ke ’ita.

You shouldn’t be angry.

’Oku totonu ke ’oua na’a ke fakapikopiko.

You shouldn’t be lazy.

With a noun subject instead of a pronoun:

'Oku totonu ke 'oua na'a ha'u 'a Mele.

Mele should not come.

Both negative forms say “should not,” but the tone differs. *'Oku 'ikai totonu ke* is a plain statement of what is not proper. *'Oku totonu ke 'oua na'a* carries more weight, closer to “you really ought not to.”

The short form *'Oku totonu ke 'oua* can stand on its own as an emphatic “don’t,” meaning “it is right to refrain.”

All obligation patterns

Pattern	Meaning	Example
<i>'oku totonu ke</i>	should, ought to	<i>'Oku totonu ke ke ako.</i> You should study.
<i>kuo pau ke</i>	must, certainly	<i>Kuo pau ke ke ako.</i> You must study.
<i>'oku 'ikai totonu ke</i>	should not	<i>'Oku 'ikai totonu ke ke mohe.</i> You should not sleep.
<i>'oku totonu ke 'oua na'a</i>	should not (emphatic)	<i>'Oku totonu ke 'oua na'a ke mohe.</i> You shouldn't sleep.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>totonu</i>	stative (in obligation)	correct, should (<i>'oku totonu ke</i>)
<i>pau</i>	stative (in obligation)	certain, must (<i>kuo pau ke</i>)
<i>ke</i>	subordinator (formalized)	that, to (links obligation to action) (also “you” (Ch 1))
<i>'oua na'a</i>	emphatic prohibition	should not (emphatic)

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>feinga</i>	verb	try

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English

1. *'Oku totonu ke ke ako lahi.*
2. *Kuo pau ke u ngāue 'aho ni.*
3. *'Oku 'ikai totonu ke ke nofo heni.*
4. *'Oku totonu ke 'oua na'a ke 'ita.*
5. *Kuo pau ke ha'u 'a Sione.*
6. *Na'e totonu ke 'i heni 'a Lupe.*
7. *'Oku 'ikai totonu ke u mohe.*
8. *'Oku totonu ke 'oua na'a lea 'a Pita.*

Exercise 2: Translate English to Tongan

1. You should work.

2. I must go.
3. Mele should study hard.
4. I should not eat. (use 'ikai)
5. You shouldn't be lazy. (use 'oua na'a)
6. Sione must be tired.
7. Tēvita should have been here.
8. It is certain to be hot today.

Exercise 3: Change to negative using 'oku 'ikai totonu ke

1. 'Oku totonu ke u ha'u.
2. 'Oku totonu ke ke lea.
3. 'Oku totonu ke nofo 'a Siale.
4. 'Oku totonu ke mau kai.

Exercise 4: For each situation, write a complete Tongan sentence using 'oku totonu ke (should) or kuo pau ke (must)

1. Sēmisi should help. (It is the right thing to do.)
2. I must go at once. (It is necessary.)
3. You should pray. (It is proper.)
4. 'Ana must be sick. (It is certain.)
5. We should go back home. (It is the right thing.)

Answers

Exercise 1

1. You should study hard.
2. I must work today.
3. You should not stay here.
4. You shouldn't be angry.
5. Sione must come. / Sione is certain to come.
6. Lupe should have been here.
7. I should not sleep.

8. Pita should not speak.

Exercise 2

1. 'Oku totonu ke ke ngāue.
2. Kuo pau ke u 'alu.
3. 'Oku totonu ke ako lahi 'a Mele.
4. 'Oku 'ikai totonu ke u kai.
5. 'Oku totonu ke 'oua na'á ke fakapikopiko.
6. Kuo pau ke hela'ia 'a Sione.
7. Na'e totonu ke 'i heni 'a Tēvita.
8. Kuo pau ke vela he 'aho ní.

Exercise 3

1. 'Oku 'ikai totonu ke u ha'u.
2. 'Oku 'ikai totonu ke ke lea.
3. 'Oku 'ikai totonu ke nofo 'a Siale.
4. 'Oku 'ikai totonu ke mau kai.

Exercise 4

1. 'Oku totonu ke tokoni 'a Sēmisi.
2. Kuo pau ke u 'alu leva.
3. 'Oku totonu ke ke lotu.
4. Kuo pau ke puke 'a 'Ana.
5. 'Oku totonu ke mau foki ki 'api.

Chapter 24: Conjunctions

Conjunctions are words that link clauses into longer sentences. Where English uses one word for “and,” Tongan has three (*pea*, *mo*, *’o*), each with a different meaning. Tongan also splits “but” into two words (*ka* and *kae*), depending on what follows.

***pea*: and then**

Pea joins two actions in sequence. The first happens, then the next follows.

Mohe pea ngāue.

Sleep and then work.

Two commands joined by *pea*: first sleep, then work. Each half could stand alone as a separate imperative.

Pea also joins full clauses, each with its own tense marker and pronoun:

Na’á ku lotu peá u mohe.

I prayed and then I slept.

This sentence has two complete clauses: *Na’á ku lotu* (I prayed) + *peá u mohe* (and then I slept). Notice the accent on *peá*: when *pea* is immediately followed by a one-syllable pronoun (*u*), the stress shifts to its final vowel. This follows the same accent pattern you know from tense markers.

Tongan	English
<i>Na’á ku ako peá u foki ki ’api.</i>	I studied and then went home.
<i>Na’á ku ha’u peá u kamata ’eku ngāué.</i>	I arrived and then began my work.

’o: and (as part of one event)

Where *pea* means “and then” (two actions in sequence), *’o* connects two actions that the speaker treats as a single combined event. The second action arises from or belongs to the first.

Ha’u ’o kai.
Come and eat.

The coming and the eating are one event: you come in order to eat. Compare *Ha’u pea kai* (come, and then eat), which treats them as two separate steps.
’Alu ’o ako.

Go and study.

Té u foki mai ’o kamata ’eku ngāué.
I will go back and start my work.

In each case, *’o* signals that the second action is a natural result or continuation of the first, not a separate event.

Note:

You have already seen *’o* in the pattern *lava ’o* (be able to), as in *’Oku ou lava ’o lea* (I can speak). That *’o* is the same conjunction: it connects the ability to the action as a single unit.

'o in time expressions

'O can introduce phrases that work like time expressions in English. The most common is 'o *fuoloa*, where *fuoloa* means “long in duration.”

Té ke ako heni 'o fuoloa?

Will you study here for a long time?

Na'a nau ngāue 'i kolo 'o fuoloa.

They worked in town for a long time.

Although 'o *fuoloa* is technically a conjunction linking a second clause (“and it was long”), it functions as a single time expression meaning “for a long time.” Treat 'o *fuoloa* as a unit.

ka and kae: but

Tongan has two words for “but.” The choice depends on the word that comes immediately after.

Use *ka* before a tense marker, a pronoun, or a preposition:

'Oku ou sai'ia he hivá, ka 'oku 'ikai té u sai'ia he ngāué.

I like singing, but I don't like working.

After the comma, *ka* is followed by the tense marker 'oku, so *ka* is correct.

'Alu koe, ka ke foki mai he fā.

Go, but come back at four.

Here *ka* is followed by the pronoun *ke* (you).

Use *kae* before a verb, an adjective (stative), or an adverb:

Na'e 'alu 'a Sione kae nofo 'a Mele.

Sione went but Mele stayed.

After *kae*, the next word is the verb *nofo*.

Na’e ’alu ’a Pita kae puke ’a Tēvita.

Pita went but Tēvita was sick.

Here *kae* is followed by the stative *puke*.

Kae can also mean “while,” depending on context:

Na’e hiva ’a Sēmisi kae fanongo ’a ’Ana.

Sēmisi sang while ’Ana listened.

The rule is straightforward: look at the word immediately after “but.” If it is a tense marker, pronoun, or preposition, use *ka*. If it is a verb, adjective, or adverb, use *kae*.

Next word is...	Use	Example
tense marker	<i>ka</i>	<i>...ka ’oku ’ikai...</i>
pronoun	<i>ka</i>	<i>...ka ke foki...</i>
preposition	<i>ka</i>	<i>...ka ’i kolo...</i>
verb	<i>kae</i>	<i>...kae nofo...</i>
stative	<i>kae</i>	<i>...kae puke...</i>

pe: or, whether

Pe joins alternatives.

’Oku mālohi pe vaivai?

Is he strong or weak?

Pe also introduces indirect questions, where it means “whether” or “if.” The verb *’ilo* (*to know*) often pairs with *pe* in this pattern:

’Oku ’ikai té u ’ilo pe ’oku fiefia pe ’ita.

I don’t know whether (she) is happy or angry.

’Oku ’ikai té u ’ilo pe ’oku nau ngāue ’i fē.

I don't know where they work.

In the second example, *pe* introduces the indirect question (“where they work”) without offering two alternatives. This is a common pattern for reporting questions.

Dropping the tense marker after *pea*

When *pea* joins two clauses with pronoun subjects, the tense marker in the second clause is often dropped. The pronoun follows *pea* directly.

Full form (both tense markers present):

Té u ngāue, pea té u toe foki.

I will work, and then I will go back again.

Standard form (second tense marker dropped):

Té u ngāue peá u toe foki.

I will work and then go back again.

The meaning is the same. The tense of the second clause is understood from the first. This shortened form is standard in everyday speech.

Na’á ku ako peá u ’alu ki kolo.

I studied and then went to town.

With first-person singular, the pronoun form *u* is used after *pea* (the same form as in the future and perfect tenses), not *ku* or *ou*.

Note:

You already know *mo* as “with” or “and” when joining nouns (*’a Sione mo Mele*, Sione and Mele). *Mo* can also join adjectives or adverbs: *’Okú ne ngāue mālohi*

mo lelei (he works hard and well). The meaning stays the same: “and at the same time.”

Summary of conjunctions

Conjunction	Meaning	Used for
<i>pea</i>	and then	Sequential actions
<i>'o</i>	and (one event)	Actions treated as a single event; time expressions (<i>'o fuoloa</i>)
<i>ka</i>	but	Before tense markers, pronouns, prepositions
<i>kae</i>	but, while	Before verbs, adjectives, adverbs
<i>pe</i>	or, whether	Alternatives; indirect questions

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>ka</i>	conjunction	but (before tense markers, pronouns, prepositions)
<i>kae</i>	conjunction	but, while (before verbs, adjectives, adverbs)

Tongan	Function	English
<i>pe</i>	conjunction	or, whether

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>fuoloa</i>	adjective	long in duration ('o <i>fuoloa</i> = for a long time)
<i>'ilo</i>	verb	know

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English

1. *Ha'u 'o kai.*
2. *'Oku ou sai'ia he hivá, ka 'oku 'ikai té u sai'ia he ngāué.*
3. *Na'e 'alu 'a Sione kae nofo 'a Mele.*
4. *'Oku mālohi pe vaivai?*
5. *Té u ngāue peá u toe foki.*
6. *Na'a nau ngāue 'i kolo 'o fuoloa.*
7. *Na'á ku lotu peá u mohe.*
8. *Na'e 'alu 'a Pita kae puke 'a Tēvita.*

Exercise 2: Translate English to Tongan

1. Go and study.
2. Siale went but Lupe stayed. (use *kae*)
3. I will work and then sleep again.
4. Is she happy or angry?
5. I like working, but I don't like singing. (use *ka*)
6. They studied in town for a long time.

7. I prayed and then went home.
8. I don't know whether he is strong or weak.

Exercise 3: Fill in the blank with ka or kae

1. Na'e 'alu 'a Mele __ nofo 'a Sione.
2. 'Oku ou fiefia, __ 'oku 'ikai té u fie va'inga.
3. 'Alu koe, __ ke foki mai he nimá.
4. Na'e hiva 'a Sēmisi __ fanongo 'a 'Ana.
5. 'Oku ou fie mohe, __ kuo pau ke u ngāue.

Exercise 4: Join the two sentences using the conjunction in parentheses

1. Na'á ku ako. / Na'á ku 'alu ki 'api. (pea, drop the tense marker in the second clause)
2. Ha'u. / Hiva. ('o)
3. 'Oku ou fie mohe. / Kuo pau ke u ngāue. (ka)
4. Na'e hiva 'a Siale. / Na'e fanongo 'a Lupe. (kae)
5. 'Oku mālohi. / 'Oku vaivai. (pe, form a question)

Exercise 5: Choose the correct conjunction (pea, 'o, ka, kae, pe)

1. 'Alu __ hiva.
2. Na'á ku 'alu ki kolo __ u fakatau mai ha me'a.
3. 'Oku ou fie ako, __ 'oku 'ikai té u fie ngāue.
4. Na'e 'alu 'a Tēvita __ nofo 'a 'Ana.
5. 'Oku fiefia __ 'ita?
6. Na'a mau nofo 'i 'api __ fuoloa.

Answers

Exercise 1

1. Come and eat.
2. I like singing, but I don't like working.
3. Sione went but Mele stayed.

4. Is he/she strong or weak?
5. I will work and then go back again.
6. They worked in town for a long time.
7. I prayed and then slept.
8. Pita went but Tēvita was sick.

Exercise 2

1. *'Alu 'o ako.*
2. *Na'e 'alu 'a Siale kae nofo 'a Lupe.*
3. *Té u ngāue peá u toe mohe.*
4. *'Oku fiefia pe 'ita?*
5. *'Oku ou sai'ia he ngāué, ka 'oku 'ikai té u sai'ia he hivá.*
6. *Na'a nau ako 'i kolo 'o fuoloa.*
7. *Na'á ku lotu peá u foki ki 'api.*
8. *'Oku 'ikai té u 'ilo pe 'oku mālohi pe vaivai.*

Exercise 3

1. *kae* (before verb *nofo*)
2. *ka* (before tense marker *'oku*)
3. *ka* (before pronoun *ke*)
4. *kae* (before verb *fanongo*)
5. *ka* (before tense marker *kuo*)

Exercise 4

1. *Na'á ku ako peá u 'alu ki 'api.*
2. *Ha'u 'o hiva.*
3. *'Oku ou fie mohe, ka kuo pau ke u ngāue.*
4. *Na'e hiva 'a Siale kae fanongo 'a Lupe.*
5. *'Oku mālohi pe vaivai?*

Exercise 5

1. *'o* (going and singing as one event)
2. *pea* (sequential: went to town, then bought something)

3. *ka* (but, before tense marker *'oku*)
4. *kae* (but, before verb *nofo*)
5. *pe* (or)
6. *'o* (time expression: for a long time)

Chapter 25: Plural Markers

Until now, every noun in the book has appeared as singular. This chapter teaches how to talk about more than one person, animal, or thing.

In English, you add “-s” to make a noun plural: “house” becomes “houses.” Tongan nouns do not change their form. Instead, Tongan places a word before the noun to signal “more than one.” These words are plural markers. Tongan has four plural markers, each used with a different type of noun, plus a dual marker for exactly two.

ngaahi: the general plural

Ngaahi is the most common plural marker. It works with almost any noun.

ha ngaahi fale. some houses

e ngaahi falé. the houses

The plural marker sits between the article (or possessive) and the noun: article + *ngaahi* + noun.

Kato (basket).

'eku ngaahi kató. my baskets

Tongan	English
<i>ha ngaahi fale</i>	some houses
<i>e ngaahi valá</i>	the clothes
<i>'eku ngaahi kató</i>	my baskets
<i>hotau ngaahi valá</i>	our clothes

***kau*: plural for people**

Kau is used with nouns that refer to people.

e kau faiakó. the teachers

Where *ngaahi* works with any noun, *kau* is specifically for people. The structure is the same: article + *kau* + noun.

Faifekau (minister). *Tangata* (man). *Fefine* (woman).

Tongan	English
<i>e kau faiakó</i>	the teachers
<i>ha kau faifekau</i>	some ministers
<i>ha kau tangata</i>	some men
<i>e kau fefiné</i>	the women

***fanga*: plural for animals**

Fanga is used with nouns that refer to animals, including birds, fish, and insects.

Moa (chicken). *Pulu* (cow).

ha fanga moa. some chickens

e fanga puaká. the pigs

Fanga is also used with nouns preceded by *ki'i* (*small*), regardless of what the noun refers to:

- ha fanga ki'i kato.* some little baskets
- ha fanga ki'i me'a.* some little things

Tongan	English
<i>ha fanga moa</i>	some chickens
<i>e fanga puaká</i>	the pigs
<i>ha fanga pulu</i>	some cows
<i>ha fanga ki'i kato</i>	some little baskets

'ū: plural for things (smaller numbers)

'Ū is used with nouns that refer to things, especially when the number is relatively small.

- Hele (knife).*
- e 'ū tohí.* the books
- ha 'ū hele.* some knives

Both 'ū and *ngaahi* work with things. 'Ū is more natural for a few items; *ngaahi* suits larger numbers. In practice, the two are often interchangeable.

Choosing the right plural marker

Marker	Used with	Example
<i>ngaahi</i>	anything (the default)	<i>ngaahi fale</i> houses

Marker	Used with	Example
<i>kau</i>	people	<i>kau faiako</i> teachers
<i>fanga</i>	animals; <i>ki'i</i> + noun	<i>fanga moa</i> chickens
<i>'ū</i>	things (smaller number)	<i>'ū tohi</i> books

When in doubt, *ngaahi* works for most nouns.

***ongo*: the dual marker (exactly two)**

Tongan has a separate marker for exactly two of something. The dual marker *ongo* works with any noun: people, animals, or things.

- ha ongoing kato*. two baskets
- e ongoing tangatá*. the two men
- ha ongoing vaka*. two boats

Note:
The numeral *ua* (*two*) can be added for emphasis: *ha ongoing vaka 'e ua* (two boats). *Ongoing* alone already means two, so the numeral is optional.

***kau* vs. *ngaahi*: people vs. actions**

Many Tongan words can name either a person who does something or the activity itself. The plural marker signals which meaning you intend.

<i>kau</i> + noun (people)	<i>ngaahi</i> + noun (actions/things)
<i>kau hiva</i>	<i>ngaahi hiva</i>
singers	songs
<i>kau ako</i>	<i>ngaahi ako</i>
students	schools
<i>kau lotu</i>	<i>ngaahi lotu</i>
worshippers	religions
<i>kau ngāue</i>	<i>ngaahi ngāue</i>
workers	tasks

Kau hiva refers to people who sing. *Ngaahi hiva* refers to the songs themselves. The choice of plural marker changes the meaning entirely.

Note:
When plurality is already clear from context, the plural marker is often left out. After a numeral (*ha kato 'e nima*, five baskets) or the word *kotoa* (*all*), the marker is optional because the number already signals more than one.

Special plural forms: nouns

A few common nouns have irregular plural forms.
Tamasi'i (*child*). *'Eiki* (*chief, lord*).

Singular	Plural	English
<i>tamasi'i</i>	<i>tamaiki</i>	child / children

Singular	Plural	English
<i>fefine</i>	<i>fafine</i>	woman / women
<i>'eiki</i>	<i>hou'eiki</i>	chief / chiefs

These forms replace the singular when referring to two or more. They still take plural markers:

e kau tamaikí. the children

'a e hou'eikí. the chiefs

Note: Fafine is the standard form for the dual (*e ongo fafiné*, the two women). For three or more, the regular form *fefine* is used with *kau*: *e kau fefiné* (the women). In courteous speech, *fafine* is sometimes used for the plural as well.

Special plural forms: verbs

Some common verbs have different forms when the subject is two or more people.

Tokoto (to lie down).

Singular	Plural/Dual	English
<i>'alu</i>	<i>ō</i>	go
<i>ha'u</i>	<i>ō mai</i>	come
<i>tokoto</i>	<i>tākoto</i>	lie down
<i>nofo</i>	<i>nonofo</i>	live together

Use the plural form whenever the subject is dual or plural:

Na'e ō 'a e kau tamaikí ki kolo.

The children went to town.

The subject *kau tamaiki* is plural, so *ō* replaces *'alu*. Compare the singular: *Na'e 'alu 'a Sione ki kolo* (Sione went to town).

Mou ō ki 'api.

Go home. (to a group)

Kuo nau ō mai.

They have come.

The plural form *ō* carries a slightly softer tone than *'alu*. The form *nonofo* specifically means “live together,” not just a grammatical plural of “stay” or “sit”:

'Oku nonofo 'a Sione mo Mele 'i 'api.

Sione and Mele live together at home.

Most verbs have no special plural form. Only this small group does.

Special plural forms: adjectives

Some adjectives have different forms when describing plural nouns.

Singular	Plural	English
<i>lahi</i>	<i>lalahi</i>	big
<i>si'i</i>	<i>iiki</i>	small
<i>lōloa</i>	<i>lolola</i>	long

The word *lahi* has two meanings: “big” (describing size) and “many” (describing quantity). The plural form *lalahi* can only mean “big,” which removes the ambiguity:

ha ngaahi me'a lahi. many things (*lahi* = many)

ha ngaahi me'a lalahi. some big things (*lalahi* = big, plural)

The same pattern applies to *si'i*, which means both “small” and “few”:

ha ngaahi me'a si'i. a few things (*si'i* = few)

ha ngaahi me'a iiki. some small things (*iiki* = small, plural)

Note:

A few uncommon plural markers exist for specific nouns: *tukui* for places (*tukui fonua*, various countries), *tu’u* for houses, and *hala* for homes. These are rare in modern speech. The four main markers and the dual *ongo* cover nearly all situations.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>ngaahi</i>	plural marker	the (plural, general)
<i>fanga</i>	plural marker	the (plural, animals)
<i>’ū</i>	plural marker	the (plural, small group)
<i>ongo</i>	dual marker	the two, both
<i>kotoa</i>	quantifier	all

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>tangata</i>	noun	man
<i>fafine</i>	noun	women (plural of <i>fefine</i>)
<i>’eiki</i>	noun	chief, lord
<i>hou’eiki</i>	noun	chiefs (plural of <i>’eiki</i>)
<i>faifekau</i>	noun	minister
<i>puaka</i>	noun	pig
<i>pulu</i>	noun	cow

Tongan	Type	English
<i>tokoto</i>	verb	lie down
<i>nonofo</i>	verb	live together (plural of <i>nofo</i>)
<i>lōloa</i>	adjective	long, tall
<i>iiki</i>	adjective	small (plural of <i>si'i</i>)
<i>lalahi</i>	adjective	big (plural of <i>lahi</i>)

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English

1. *ha ngaahi fale*
2. *e kau faiakó*
3. *ha fanga pulu*
4. *e 'ū tohí*
5. *ha ongo vaka*
6. *e kau tamaikí*
7. *ha ngaahi me'a lalahi*
8. *ha fanga ki'i kato*

Exercise 2: Add the correct plural or dual marker (ngaahi, kau, fanga, 'ū, or ongo)

1. *ha __ moa* (some chickens)
2. *e __ faiakó* (the teachers)
3. *ha __ fale* (some houses)
4. *e __ tangatá* (the two men)
5. *ha __ hele* (some knives)
6. *e __ fefiné* (the women)
7. *ha __ puaka* (some pigs)
8. *'eku __ tohí* (my books)

Exercise 3: Choose the correct meaning

1. *kau hiva*. (a) songs (b) singers
2. *ngaahi hiva*. (a) songs (b) singers
3. *kau ako*. (a) schools (b) students
4. *ngaahi lotu*. (a) worshippers (b) religions
5. *kau ngāue*. (a) tasks (b) workers

Exercise 4: Rewrite using the correct plural form

1. *Na'e 'alu 'a Sione ki kolo*. → The children went to town. (Use *kau tamaiki* and the correct verb.)
2. *'Okú ne tokoto*. → They are lying down. (Use the plural pronoun and verb.)
3. *ha me'a lahi* → some big things (Use the plural adjective.)
4. *Na'e ha'u 'a Mele*. → The women came. (Use *kau fefine* and the correct verb.)
5. *ha me'a si'i* → some small things (Use the plural adjective.)

Exercise 5: Translate English to Tongan

1. some houses
 2. the ministers
 3. two baskets
 4. some little boats
 5. The children went to town.
 6. They have come.
 7. Sione and Mele live together at home.
 8. some big things
-

Answers**Exercise 1**

1. some houses
2. the teachers
3. some cows

4. the books
5. two boats
6. the children
7. some big things
8. some little baskets

Exercise 2

1. *fanga* (animals)
2. *kau* (people)
3. *ngaahi* (general)
4. *ongo* (dual)
5. *'ū* or *ngaahi* (things)
6. *kau* (people)
7. *fanga* (animals)
8. *ngaahi* or *'ū* (things)

Exercise 3

1. (b) singers
2. (a) songs
3. (b) students
4. (b) religions
5. (b) workers

Exercise 4

1. *Na'e ō 'a e kau tamaikí ki kolo.*
2. *'Oku nau tākoto.*
3. *ha ngaahi me'a lalahi*
4. *Na'e ō mai 'a e kau fefiné.*
5. *ha ngaahi me'a ūiki*

Exercise 5

1. *ha ngaahi fale*
2. *e kau faifekauí*

3. *ha ongo kato*
4. *ha fanga ki'i vaka*
5. *Na'e ō 'a e kau tamaikí ki kolo.*
6. *Kuo nau ō mai.*
7. *'Oku nonofo 'a Sione mo Mele 'i 'api.*
8. *ha ngaahi me'a lalahi*

Chapter 26: Purpose, Reason, and Benefit

This chapter covers how to express purpose (“in order to”), give a reason (“because”), and say who benefits from an action (“for someone”).

***ke*: to, in order to, so that**

Tongan uses the word *ke* to introduce a part of the sentence that depends on the main clause. This dependent part is called a subordinate clause: a group of words built around a verb that cannot stand on its own. It needs the main clause for its meaning.

Kole (ask, request). Sio (see, look at).

Té u kole kia Mele ke ne ha’u.

I will ask Mele to come. (Lit. “I will ask to Mele that she come”)

The main clause (*Té u kole kia Mele*) can stand alone. The *ke* clause (*ke ne ha’u*) cannot: it tells you the purpose of asking.

After *ke*, pronouns take the same forms as after tense markers: *ke u* (that I), *ke ke* (that you), *ke ne* (that he/she), *ke nau* (that they).

Kuo nau ō mai ke lau 'a e tohí.

They have come to read the book.

When the *ke* clause states a general fact rather than an action by a specific person, no pronoun is needed:

'Oku lelei ke fufulu leva 'a e valá.

The clothes had better be washed at once. (Lit. “It is good that wash immediately the clothes”)

Adding a pronoun assigns the action to a specific person:

'Oku lelei ke ke fufulu leva 'a e valá.

You had better wash the clothes at once.

The doubled *ke ke* is correct. The first *ke* is the subordinator; the second is the pronoun “you.”

Tongan	English
<i>Té u kole kia Mele ke ne ha'u.</i>	I will ask Mele to come.
<i>Kuo nau ō mai ke lau 'a e tohí.</i>	They have come to read the book.
<i>'Oku lelei ke fufulu leva 'a e valá.</i>	The clothes had better be washed at once.
<i>'Oku lelei ke ke fufulu leva 'a e valá.</i>	You had better wash the clothes at once.

Note:

The obligation patterns *'oku totonu ke* (should) and *kuo pau ke* (must) already use this *ke*. Those patterns are specific cases of subordination: the *ke* clause depends on the main clause for its meaning.

he: for, because

The word *he* introduces a reason or explanation for the preceding statement. It sits between two clauses, connecting them.

Tōmui (late).

'Okú ke tōmui, he kuo 'osi hoko.

You are late, for it has already happened.

The first clause states the situation (*'Okú ke tōmui*). The second clause, introduced by *he*, gives the reason (*kuo 'osi hoko*).

'Oua té ke 'alu, he 'oku 'uha.

Do not go, because it is raining.

'Oku ou 'alu ki 'api, he 'oku ou hela'ia.

I am going home, because I am tired.

koe'uhi: because, in order that

Koe'uhi is a more emphatic way to express “because” or “in order that.” It introduces both reasons and purposes. Where *he* is light and conversational, *koe'uhi* carries more weight.

Faiako (teacher).

'Oku ou 'alu koe'uhi ke u sio ki he faiakó.

I go in order to see the teacher.

Here *koe'uhi ke* means “in order to” or “so that.” The *ke* introduces the purpose clause, just as in the previous section.

Koe'uhi also appears before *ko* to introduce a noun as the reason:

Té u foki koe'uhi ko Mele.

I will return because of Mele. (for Mele's sake)

Pattern	Meaning
<i>koe’uhi ke</i>	in order to, so that
<i>koe’uhi ko</i>	because of (+ noun or name)
<i>koe’uhi ’oku</i>	because (+ present clause)

Dropping *koe’uhi*

In everyday speech, *koe’uhi* is frequently dropped before *ko* and *ke*. The meaning stays the same.

Té u foki koe’uhi ko Mele. → *Té u foki ko Mele.* I will return for Mele’s sake.
Na’á ku lea koe’uhi ke mahino kiate kinautolu. → *Na’á ku lea ke mahino kiate kinautolu.* I spoke so that they would understand.

Both the full and short forms are correct. The short form is more common in conversation.

Note: Koe’uhi can also be dropped before *na’a* when *na’a* means “lest” or “perhaps,” a meaning covered in Chapter 38: Warnings, Hopes, Permissions, and Uncertainty.

***ma’a* and *mo’o*: for (someone’s benefit)**

English uses a single word “for” when saying something benefits someone. Tongan has two words: *ma’a* and *mo’o*. The choice depends on the possessive class of the thing being given or intended.

Ma’a is used when the benefit involves an ’e-class item (something the recipient acts on or controls). *Mo’o* is used when it involves a ho-class item (something that characterizes or shelters the recipient).

Langa (build).
Ko e kato ika eni ma’a Tēvita.
This basket of fish is for Tēvita.

Fish is food (’e-class: you eat it), so *ma’a* is used.
’Oku langa e vaká mo’ou?

Is the boat being built for you?

A boat carries a person (ho-class: it acts on you), so *mo'o* is used.
The distinction follows the same rule as 'e-class and ho-class possessives:

<i>ma'a</i>	<i>mo'o</i>
('e-class)	(ho-class)
food (you eat it)	house (it shelters you)
money (you spend it)	boat (it carries you)
clothes (you wear them)	land (it characterizes you)

Na'a nau tānaki 'a e pa'angá ma'a Tēvita.

They collected money for Tēvita.

Na'a nau langa 'a e falé mo'o Mele.

They built a house for Mele.

When the class is uncertain, *ma'a* is the safer choice.

ma'a and mo'o with pronouns

When the beneficiary is a pronoun rather than a name or noun, *ma'a* and *mo'o* combine with postposed possessive pronoun forms.

'e-class	ho-class	English
<i>ma'aku</i>	<i>mo'oku</i>	for me
<i>ma'au</i>	<i>mo'ou</i>	for you (sg.)
<i>ma'ana</i>	<i>mo'ona</i>	for him/her
<i>ma'atau</i>	<i>mo'otau</i>	for us (incl.)
<i>ma'amau</i>	<i>mo'omau</i>	for us (excl.)

'e-class	ho-class	English
<i>ma'amou</i>	<i>mo'omou</i>	for you (pl.)
<i>ma'anau</i>	<i>mo'onau</i>	for them

The pattern is consistent: replace the 'a of the possessive with *ma'a*, and the 'o with *mo'o*.

Ko e kato ika eni ma'aku.

This basket of fish is for me.

Na'a nau langa 'a e fale mo'onau.

They built the house for them.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>he</i>	conjunction	for, because (also “the” (Ch 4))
<i>koe'uhi</i>	conjunction	because, in order that
<i>ma'a</i>	preposition ('e-class)	for (someone's benefit)
<i>mo'o</i>	preposition (ho-class)	for (someone's benefit)
<i>ma'aku</i>	beneficiary pronoun ('e-class)	for me
<i>ma'au</i>	beneficiary pronoun ('e-class)	for you
<i>ma'ana</i>	beneficiary pronoun ('e-class)	for him/her
<i>ma'atau</i>	beneficiary pronoun ('e-class)	for us (inclusive)
<i>ma'amau</i>	beneficiary pronoun ('e-class)	for us (exclusive)
<i>ma'amou</i>	beneficiary pronoun ('e-class)	for you (plural)

Tongan	Function	English
<i>ma'anau</i>	beneficiary pronoun ('e-class)	for them
<i>mo'oku</i>	beneficiary pronoun (ho-class)	for me
<i>mo'ou</i>	beneficiary pronoun (ho-class)	for you
<i>mo'ona</i>	beneficiary pronoun (ho-class)	for him/her
<i>mo'otau</i>	beneficiary pronoun (ho-class)	for us (inclusive)
<i>mo'onau</i>	beneficiary pronoun (ho-class)	for them

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>kole</i>	verb	ask, request
<i>hoko</i>	verb	happen, occur
<i>tōmui</i>	adjective	late
<i>tānaki</i>	verb	collect, gather

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English

- 1. *Kuo nau ō mai ke nau fufulu 'a e valá.*
- 2. *'Oku ou 'alu ki 'api, he 'oku ou hela'ia.*
- 3. *Ko e fala eni ma'a Siale.*
- 4. *'Oku langa e vaká mo'ou?*
- 5. *'Okú ne 'alu koe'uhi ke ne sio ki he faiakó.*
- 6. *Na'a nau tānaki 'a e pa'angá ma'ana.*
- 7. *'Oua té ke 'alu, he 'oku 'uha.*
- 8. *Kuo pau ke ke ako.*

Exercise 2: Fill in the blank with ke, he, or koe'uhi ke

1. 'Oku ou ha'u __ u sio ki he faiakó.
2. 'Okú ke tōmui, __ kuo 'osi hoko.
3. Kuo nau ō mai __ nau lau 'a e tohí.
4. 'Oua té ke hiva, __ 'okú ne mohe.
5. Na'á ku 'alu __ u fakatau mai ha ika.
6. 'Oku nau nofo 'i 'api, __ 'oku 'uha.

Exercise 3: Choose ma'a or mo'o

1. Ko e ika eni __ Mele. (fish)
2. 'Oku langa e falé __ Sione. (house)
3. Na'a nau tñnaki 'a e pa'angá __ e kau tamaikí. (money)
4. Ko e ki'i vaka eni __ Tēvita. (boat)
5. 'Ave e valá __ Siale. (clothes)
6. Ko e tohi eni __ Sēmisi. (book)

Exercise 4: Translate English to Tongan

1. I will ask Sione to come.
2. They collected money for Mele.
3. Is the boat being built for you?
4. Do not sing, because he is sleeping.
5. You should study.
6. This basket of fish is for them.
7. She is running, for she is late.
8. They have come to eat the fish.

Answers**Exercise 1**

1. They have come to wash the clothes.
2. I am going home, because I am tired.

3. This mat is for Siale.
4. Is the boat being built for you?
5. He/she is going in order to see the teacher.
6. They collected money for him/her.
7. Do not go, because it is raining.
8. You must study.

Exercise 2

1. *koe'uhi ke* (or *ke*)
2. *he*
3. *ke*
4. *he*
5. *ke* (or *koe'uhi ke*)
6. *he*

Exercise 3

1. *ma'a* (fish is food, 'e-class)
2. *mo'o* (house shelters, ho-class)
3. *ma'a* (money is controlled, 'e-class)
4. *mo'o* (boat carries, ho-class)
5. *ma'a* (clothes are worn/controlled, 'e-class)
6. *ma'a* (book is read/acted upon, 'e-class)

Exercise 4

1. *Té u kole kia Sione ke ne ha'u.*
2. *Na'a nau tñnaki 'a e pa'angá ma'a Mele.*
3. *'Oku langa e vaká mo'ou?*
4. *'Oua té ke hiva, he 'okú ne mohe.*
5. *'Oku totonu ke ke ako.*
6. *Ko e kato ika eni ma'anau.*
7. *'Okú ne lele, he 'okú ne tñmui.*
8. *Kuo nau ō mai ke kai 'a e iká.*

Chapter 27: Comparison and Degree

This chapter introduces comparison: how to say something is bigger, better, the same, different, or like something else.

Comparative: adjective + *ange*

In English, the adjective itself changes form: tall → taller, fast → faster. In Tongan, the adjective stays the same. You add the word *ange* after it.

Mālohi (strong). Vave (fast).

'Oku mālohi ange 'a Tēvita 'ia Sēmisi.

Tēvita is stronger than Sēmisi.

The adjective *mālohi* does not change form. The word *ange* after it creates the comparison. The preposition *'i* introduces the thing compared to, like English “than.”

'Oku vave ange 'a e lolí 'i he pasikalá.

The truck is faster than the bicycle.

The pattern: adjective + *ange* + 'a + first thing + 'i + second thing.

Tongan	English
<i>lahi ange</i>	bigger
<i>si'i ange</i>	smaller
<i>vave ange</i>	faster
<i>mālohi ange</i>	stronger
<i>lelei ange</i>	better
<i>sai ange</i>	better

Note:

Both *lelei* and *sai* translate as “good” and both form comparatives with *ange*. They are interchangeable in this pattern.

The “than” phrase with 'i

The 'i phrase tells you what the comparison is against. Before a proper noun, use 'ia. Before a common noun with an article, use 'i he (or 'i e).

'Oku talavou ange 'a Peni 'ia Tēvita.

Peni is better-looking than Tēvita.

'Oku ngāue lahi ange 'a e kau tamaikí 'i he faiakó.

The children work harder than the teacher.

Some adjectives need an adverb like *lahi* before *ange* to form the comparison. You cannot say *'oku 'ita ange*. Instead, say *'oku 'ita lahi ange* (more angry).

Superlative: adjective + *taha*

To say something is the most or the best, place *taha* after the adjective.

'Oku lelei taha e ngāué 'a Seini.

Seini's work is the best of all.

'Oku mālohi taha 'a Siaosi.

Siaosi is the strongest.

Tongan	English
<i>lelei taha</i>	best
<i>lahi taha</i>	biggest
<i>mālohi taha</i>	strongest
<i>vave taha</i>	fastest
<i>sai taha</i>	best

The superlative does not use an *'i* phrase. It stands alone: the thing described is the most within its group.

Modifying the comparison

Three words can go before the adjective to strengthen or soften the comparison. Each one is followed by *ange* after the adjective.

'Oku ki'i vave ange 'a e vaká 'i he pasikalá.

The boat is a little faster than the bicycle.

'Oku fu'u mālohi ange 'a Lōpeti 'ia Simi.

Lōpeti is much stronger than Simi.

'Oku toe lahi ange 'a e falé ni 'i he fale ko iá.

This house is still bigger than that house.

Modifier	Meaning	Example
<i>ki'i ... ange</i>	a little more	<i>ki'i lahi ange</i> = a little bigger
<i>fu'u ... ange</i>	much more	<i>fu'u lahi ange</i> = much bigger
<i>toe ... ange</i>	still more	<i>toe lahi ange</i> = still bigger

The modifier wraps around the adjective: modifier + adjective + *ange*.

tatau: same

The word *tatau* means “same” or “identical.” To say two things are the same, use *tatau* with the preposition *mo* (with).

'Oku tatau 'a e tohi ko eni mo e tohi ko ē.

This book is the same as that book.

With a dual pronoun subject:

'Okú na tatau.

They (two) are the same.

Tongan	English
<i>'Oku tatau eni mo ē.</i>	This is the same as that.
<i>'Okú na tatau.</i>	They are the same.

Quick Practice A: *ange*, *taha*, modifiers, and *tatau*

Choose the right word for each blank.

- 1. *'Oku lōloa* __ *'a Mele 'ia 'Ana*. Mele is taller than 'Ana.
- 2. *'Oku vave* __ *'a e hōsi 'a Sione*. Sione’s horse is the fastest.
- 3. *'Oku* __ *'a e ongo kató*. The two baskets are the same.

4. 'Oku __ talavou ange 'a Peni 'ia Sione. Peni is a little better-looking than Sione.
 5. 'Oku fu'u si'i __ 'a e fale ko iá 'i he falé ni. That house is much smaller than this house.

Answers: 1. ange. 2. taha. 3. tatau. 4. ki'i. 5. ange

fai kehekehe: different

The expression *fai kehekehe* means “different” or “to differ.” Like *tatau*, it takes *mo* to introduce the second item.

'Oku *fai kehekehe* 'a e ngāue faka-faiakó mo e ngāue faka-toketā.

The work of a teacher is different from the work of a doctor.

'Okú na *fai kehekehe* 'aupito.

They are very different.

Preview: The prefix *faka-* attached to a noun means “in the manner of” or “related to.” *Faka-faiakó* = “teacher-related / pertaining to a teacher,” *faka-toketā* = “doctor-related.” It also appears in phrases like *lea faka-Tongá* (“the Tongan language”) and *hiva faka-Tongá* (“Tongan-style singing”). The full *faka-* prefix system is covered formally in Chapter 32: The *Faka-* Prefix. For now, recognize *faka-X* as “of the X kind” or “X-style.”

To ask about the difference between two things:

Ko e hā hono fai kehekehe 'o e akó mo e va'ingá?

What is the difference between study and sport?

The possessive preposition 'o (of, ho-class) links *fai kehekehe* to the two things being compared.

***meimei* and *mei*: almost**

The words *meimei* and *mei* mean “almost” or “nearly.” Both come before the verb or adjective they modify. (The form *meinei* also appears and is the same word.)

Na’á ku meimei tō ’anepō.

I almost fell last night.

Na’e meimei motu ’a e maeá.

The rope almost broke.

Kuó ne mei foki mai.

He has nearly come back.

Kuo mei ’osi ’a e ngāué.

The work is almost finished.

With a negative, *meimei* means “hardly” or “very nearly not”:

Na’e ’ikai té u meimei mohe.

I hardly slept at all.

Na’e ’ikai té u meimei lava ke ha’u.

I was hardly able to come.

The two forms differ slightly: *mei* is the lighter form. *Meimei* is stronger and more common in everyday speech.

***matu’aki*: extremely**

The preposed modifier *matu’aki* means “extremely,” “exceedingly,” or “absolutely.” It goes before the verb or adjective it intensifies.

’Oku matu’aki ’ita ’a Seini.

Seini is exceedingly angry.

’Oku matu’aki totonu ke tau ngāue.

It is absolutely right that we work.

Matu'aki can combine with *fu'u* for extra emphasis, with *fu'u* first:

Na'e fu'u matu'aki lelei e akó 'a Taniela.

Taniela's schoolwork was absolutely outstanding.

Quick Practice B: *fai kehekehe, meimei/mei, matu'aki*

Fill in the blank with the correct word.

1. 'Oku ___ 'a e ngāue 'a e tamasi'í mo e ngāue 'a e ta'ahiné. The boy's work is different from the girl's work.
2. Na'á ku ___ tō 'i he ngoué. I almost fell in the garden.
3. Kuo ___ 'osi 'a e me'akaí. The food is nearly finished.
4. 'Oku ___ vela 'a e 'ahó. The day is extremely hot.
5. 'Oku ___ 'a e ongo tohí. The two books are different.

Answers: 1. *fai kehekehe*. 2. *meimei*. 3. *mei*. 4. *matu'aki*. 5. *fai kehekehe*

hangē: to be like, seem like

The word *hangē* means “to be like” or “to seem like.” When it modifies a verb, it is preceded by the conjunction 'o.

Na'e ngāue 'a Sēmisi 'o hangē ha fu'u hōsí.

Sēmisi worked like a big horse.

'Oku lea 'a e tamasi'í 'o hangē kuo 'ita.

The boy talks as though he is angry.

When *hangē* introduces a noun directly (not a clause), *ko* goes before the noun:

Na'e hiva 'a Neomai 'o hangē ko e ta'ahine.

Neomai sang like a young woman.

Pattern	Structure	Example
Like + noun	'o hangē + ko + noun	'o hangē ko e faiako = like a teacher
Like + noun (indefinite)	'o hangē + ha + noun	'o hangē ha fu'u laione = like a great lion
As though + clause	'o hangē + clause	'o hangē kuo 'ita = as though angry

Awareness items

Two more comparison words appear in formal Tongan. They are not common in everyday speech, but you may encounter them in reading.

Āsili means “all the more” or “still greater.” It intensifies a comparison beyond what *ange* alone expresses.

Laka 'i means “to surpass” or “exceed.” It expresses comparison by saying one thing goes beyond another.

Hangē with 'o: extended uses

The word *hangē* was introduced earlier as “like” or “as if” in comparisons. When followed by a clause introduced by 'o, *hangē* means “as if” or “like”:

Na'á ne lea 'o hangē ko e faiakó.

He spoke as though he were the teacher.

Na'á ne ngāue 'o hangē ha fu'u laioné.

He worked like a lion.

The 'o links *hangē* to the preceding verb, creating a comparison within the action: not just “he worked” but “he worked *in the manner of* a lion.”

Quick Practice C: *hangē*: like, as if

Translate each Tongan sentence to English.

1. *Na'e lele 'a e kuli 'o hangē ha hōsi.* ____
2. *'Okú ne lea 'o hangē kuo hela'ia.* ____
3. *Na'e fai 'e Mele 'a e ngāué 'o hangē ko e faiako.* ____
4. *Na'á ne kai 'o hangē kuo fiekaia.* ____

Answers: 1. The dog ran like a horse.; 2. He speaks as though tired.; 3. Mele did the work like a teacher.; 4. He ate as though hungry.

'Ange'ange (to be surpassed by)

'Oku 'ange'ange 'a e momoko 'i heni he momoko 'i Ha'amoá.

The cold here is surpassed by the cold in Samoa. (Samoa is colder.)

The verb *'ange'ange (to be surpassed by)* expresses that one thing exceeds another. It is followed by an *'i*-phrase or *he*-phrase naming the thing that does the surpassing.

'Oku 'ange'ange ho'o potó he'eku potó.

My skill surpasses yours. (Lit. Your skill is surpassed by my skill.)

The word order may feel inverted compared to English. The thing named first is the one being surpassed, not the one doing the surpassing. In the example above, “your skill” is surpassed by “my skill.”

'Oku 'ange'ange 'a e vela 'i heni he vela 'i 'Ameliká.

The heat here is surpassed by the heat in America. (America is hotter.)

***Huanoa* (how much more)**

Preview: *Kapau* means “if.” It opens the first (lesser) clause of the *huanoa* pattern below. *Kapau* and the full conditional system are taught formally in Chapter 30: Temporal, Conditional, and Concessive Conjunctions. For now, just read *kapau* as “if.”

Kapau 'okú ne 'ofa ki he fanga puaká, huanoa 'ene 'ofa ki he kakaí!

If he loves the pigs, how much more does he love the people.

The word *huanoa* (*how much more*) introduces a comparison that amplifies the first statement. The pattern is: *kapau* (if) + first clause, *huanoa* + second clause. The logic is: if the lesser thing is true, how much more must the greater thing be true.

Kapau na'e lava ia 'e Mele, huanoa 'a Sione.

If Mele was able to do it, how much more Sione.

Kapau 'oku momoko 'a e 'aho ní, huanoa 'a Kanata.

If today is cold, how much more so is Canada.

Huanoa does not always require *kapau*. It can appear after a standalone statement for rhetorical emphasis:

Na'a mo eni 'oku faka'ofa'ofa. Kae huanoa 'i he taimi ko iá!

Even now it is beautiful. But how much more at that time.

***lahi pē*: mostly**

The expression *lahi pē* means “mostly” or “mainly.” The literal force is “much, only,” indicating that one activity or place dominates.

'Oku 'i heni hono 'apí, ka 'oku lahi pē 'ene nofó ki Vava'u.

His home is here, but he lives mostly in Vava'u.

I he taimi na'á ku 'i Vava'u ai, na'á ku lahi ngāue pē.

When I was in Vava'u, I was mostly working.

Note:

Do not confuse *lahi pē* (mostly) with *lahi* as a postposed intensifier. *Na’á ku puke lahi* means “I was very sick.” *Na’á ku lahi puke pē* means “I was sick most of the time.”

***tautefito ki*: especially**

The expression *tautefito ki* means “especially,” “particularly,” or “mainly.” It narrows a general statement to one specific case. It typically appears after a broad claim, introduced by *kae* (but):

’Oku lahi ’aupito ’a e fiekaia’i ’i māmani, kae tautefito ki ’Eulopé.

There is great hunger in the world, particularly in Europe.

’Oku totonu ke tau tokoni ki he kakai vaivai, kae tautefito kiate kinautolu ’oku nau puké.

We should help people who are weak, especially those who are sick.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>ange</i>	comparative marker	more (after adjective)
<i>taha</i>	superlative marker	most, -est (after adjective) (also “one” (Ch 20))
<i>tatau</i>	stative	same, identical
<i>hangē</i>	comparative verb	be like, as if

Tongan	Function	English
<i>huanoa</i>	discourse word	how much more

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>vave</i>	adjective	fast
<i>talavou</i>	adjective	handsome, good-looking (also “young man” (Ch 18))
<i>maea</i>	noun	rope
<i>kehekehe</i>	adjective	different
<i>mātu’a</i>	noun	parents
<i>meimei</i>	adverb	almost, nearly
<i>mei</i>	adverb	almost (lighter form of <i>meimei</i>) (also “from” (Ch 7))
<i>matu’aki</i>	adverb	extremely, absolutely
<i>lahi pē</i>	adverb phrase	mostly, mainly
<i>tautefito ki</i>	adverb phrase	especially, particularly
<i>’āsili</i>	adverb	more so, increasingly
<i>laka ’i</i>	verb phrase	surpass, exceed
<i>māmani</i>	noun	world
<i>kakai</i>	noun	people

Exercises**Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English**

1. 'Oku lahi ange 'a e vaká 'i he kató.
2. 'Oku mālohi taha 'a Tēvita.
3. 'Okú na tatau.
4. Na'e lele 'a Siaosi 'o hangē ha fu'u hōsí.
5. 'Oku ki'i sai ange 'a e me'akaí 'a Mele 'i he me'akaí 'a 'Ana.
6. 'Oku fai kehekehe 'a e lea faka-Tongá mo e lea faka-Pālangi.
7. 'Oku meinei tatau 'a e ongo falé.
8. 'Oku fu'u vave ange 'a e vakapuná 'i he vaká.

Exercise 2: Translate English to Tongan

1. Sione is taller than Tēvita.
2. This house is the biggest.
3. They are very different.
4. The children are almost the same.
5. She works like a teacher.
6. The truck is a little faster than the bicycle.
7. Mele's food is still better than 'Ana's food.
8. Lōpeti is the strongest.

Exercise 3: Fill in the blank

Choose *ange*, *taha*, *tatau*, *fai kehekehe*, or *hangē* to complete each sentence.

1. 'Oku sai ____ 'a Tonga 'i Fisi.
2. 'Oku lelei ____ 'a e ngāu'é 'a Fifita.
3. 'Okú na ____ 'aupito.
4. 'Oku ____ 'a e ongo valá.
5. Na'e lea 'a Peni 'o ____ ko e faiako.
6. 'Oku fu'u lahi ____ 'a e falé ni.

Exercise 4: Transform sentences

Change each sentence from comparative to superlative, or from superlative to comparative (adding an *'i* phrase where needed).

1. *'Oku mālohi taha 'a Sēmisi.* → (comparative, comparing with Peni)
2. *'Oku vave ange 'a e lolí 'i he vaká.* → (superlative)
3. *'Oku lelei taha 'a e me'akaí 'a Seini.* → (comparative, comparing with Mele)
4. *'Oku lahi ange 'a e falé ni 'i he fale ko iá.* → (superlative)

Exercise 5: Translate Tongan to English

1. *Ko e hā hono fai kehekehe 'o e ngāué 'a Sione mo e ngāué 'a Mele?*
2. *'Oku meinei tatau 'a e ongo me'akaí.*
3. *Na'e hiva 'a e fefiné 'o hangē ko e ta'ahine.*
4. *'Oku toe mālohi ange 'a Tēvita 'ia Siaosi.*
5. *'Oku sai taha 'a e akó 'a Fifita.*

Exercise 6: Translate Tongan to English

1. *'Oku 'ange'ange 'a e momoko 'i Tongá he momoko 'i Nūsílá.*
2. *Kapau na'e lava ia 'e 'Ana, huanoa 'a Sione.*
3. *'Oku 'ange'ange ho'o ngāué he'eku ngāué.*
4. *Kapau 'oku mālohi 'a Simi, huanoa 'a Lōpeti.*
5. *Na'á ne ngāue 'o hangē ha fu'u hōsí.*

Exercise 7: Fill in the blank with 'ange'ange, huanoa, or hangē

1. *'Oku ___ 'a e vela 'i Fisi he vela 'i Ha'amoá.* The heat in Fiji is surpassed by the heat in Samoa.
2. *Kapau na'e lava ia 'e Mele, ___ 'a Tēvita.* If Mele could do it, how much more Tēvita.
3. *Na'á ne lea 'o ___ ko e faiakó.* He spoke as though he were the teacher.
4. *Kapau 'oku fiefia 'a e tamaikí, ___ 'a e mātu'á.* If the children are happy, how much more the parents.
5. *'Oku ___ 'a e ngāué 'a Sione he ngāué 'a Mele.* Sione's work is surpassed by Mele's work.

Exercise 8: Translate Tongan to English

1. *Na'á ku meimei tō 'i he halá.*
 2. *'Oku matu'aki mālohi 'a e matangí.*
 3. *'Okú ne lahi mohe pē he 'ahó ni.*
 4. *'Oku nau sai'ia he hiva, kae tautefito ki he hiva faka-Tongá.*
 5. *Kuo mei 'osi 'a e ngāué.*
-

Answers**Exercise 1**

1. The boat is bigger than the basket.
2. Tēvita is the strongest.
3. They are the same.
4. Siaosi ran like a great horse.
5. Mele's food is a little better than 'Ana's food.
6. The Tongan language is different from the English language.
7. The two houses are almost the same.
8. The airplane is much faster than the boat.

Exercise 2

1. *'Oku lōloa ange 'a Sione 'ia Tēvita.*
2. *'Oku lahi taha 'a e falé ni.*
3. *'Okú na fai kehekehe 'aupito.*
4. *'Oku meinei tatau 'a e kau tamaikí.*
5. *'Okú ne ngāue 'o hangē ko e faiako.*
6. *'Oku ki'i vave ange 'a e lolí 'i he pasikalá.*
7. *'Oku toe sai ange 'a e me'akaí 'a Mele 'i he me'akaí 'a 'Ana.*
8. *'Oku mālohi taha 'a Lōpeti.*

Exercise 3

1. *ange*

2. *taha*
3. *fai kehekehe*
4. *tatau*
5. *hangē*
6. *ange*

Exercise 4

1. 'Oku mālohi ange 'a Sēmisi 'ia Peni.
2. 'Oku vave taha 'a e lolí.
3. 'Oku lelei ange 'a e me'akaí 'a Seini 'i he me'akaí 'a Mele.
4. 'Oku lahi taha 'a e falé ni.

Exercise 5

1. What is the difference between Sione's work and Mele's work?
2. The two foods are almost the same.
3. The woman sang like a young woman.
4. Tēvita is still stronger than Siaosi.
5. Fifita's schoolwork is the best of all.

Exercise 6

1. The cold in Tonga is surpassed by the cold in New Zealand. (New Zealand is colder.)
2. If 'Ana could do it, how much more Sione.
3. My work surpasses yours. (Lit. Your work is surpassed by my work.)
4. If Simi is strong, how much more Lōpeti.
5. He worked like a big horse.

Exercise 7

1. 'ange'ange
2. *huanoa*
3. *hangē*
4. *huanoa*
5. 'ange'ange

Exercise 8

1. I almost fell on the road.
2. The wind is extremely strong.
3. He is mostly sleeping today.
4. They enjoy songs, especially Tongan songs.
5. The work is almost finished.

Chapter 28: Directional Particles

This chapter introduces directional particles, a set of words that attach to verbs to show which way an action moves. These particles appear constantly in Tongan and carry meaning that English handles through separate phrases like “come here” or “go away.”

What directional particles do

A directional particle is a word that comes after a verb and tells you which direction the action moves. English uses prepositions or separate verbs to express direction: “come here,” “go up,” “send it over.” Tongan adds a single word after the verb.

There are six directional particles. They fall into two groups: three based on person (who the action moves toward) and three based on physical direction (up, down, around).

***mai*: toward the speaker**

The particle *mai* marks movement toward the speaker. When you say *foki mai*, you are telling someone to come back to where you are.

Foki mai!

Come back! (toward me)

'Oku 'alu mai 'a Siale.

Siale is coming (toward us).

Many verbs that have no inherent direction gain it from *mai*.

'Okú ne 'omai 'a e tohí.

He is bringing the book (to me/us). (Lit. “He brings-hither the book”)

Note:

The verb *ha'u* (come) is not used with the directional particles *mai*, *atu*, *hake*, or *hifo*: you will not hear *ha'u mai*, *ha'u atu*, or *ha'u hifo*. To say “come up” or “come down,” Tongan uses *'alu hake* (go up) and *'alu hifo* (go down), even when the movement is toward the speaker. To say plain “come here,” use *ha'u* on its own or *ha'u ki heni*.

***atu*: away from the speaker, toward the listener**

The particle *atu* marks movement away from the speaker, often toward the person being addressed.

'Alu atu!

Go away! (away from me)

'Okú ne lele atu ki he falé.

He is running (away) toward the house.

Té u tala atu.

I will tell you. (sending the telling toward you)

Where *mai* pulls action toward the speaker, *atu* pushes it away. The two form a natural pair.

Tongan	English
<i>'omai</i>	bring here (toward me)
<i>'alu atu</i>	go away (from me)
<i>foki mai</i>	come back (to me)
<i>lele atu</i>	run off (away from me)

ange: toward a third person

The particle *ange* marks movement toward someone who is neither the speaker nor the listener: a third person, or a place that is neither here nor there.

Tala ange ke ha'u!

Tell him/her to come! (sending the message toward a third person)

'Okú ne 'ave ange 'a e kató ki he faiakó.

She is taking the basket to the teacher. (toward a third person)

The three person-based particles work as a set:

Particle	Direction	Example
<i>mai</i>	toward me (1st person)	<i>'Omi mai e tohí.</i> Bring me the book.
<i>atu</i>	toward you (2nd person)	<i>Té u 'oatu e tohí.</i> I will give you the book.
<i>ange</i>	toward him/her/them (3rd person)	<i>Tuku ange e tohí.</i> Leave the book for him/her.

Note:

The word *ange* also serves as the comparative marker meaning “more” (as in *lelei ange*, better). Context makes the meaning clear: after an adjective, *ange* means “more”; after an action verb, it marks direction.

***hake*: upward**

The particle *hake* marks upward movement.

Sio hake ki hē!

Look up over there!

Na’e folau hake ’a e vaká ki Niuatoputapu.

The boat sailed up to Niuatoputapu.

Na’a mau ’ā hake he pongipongi.

We woke up in the morning. (Lit. “We waked up”)

The word *hake* sometimes extends beyond literal upward movement to mean “to completion”: *’ai hake* (finish it off, lit. “place it up”).

***hifo*: downward**

The particle *hifo* marks downward movement.

Na’e tō hifo ’a e kató mei he lolí.

The basket fell down from the truck.

Na’a nau ō hifo ki tahí ’aneafi.

They went down to the ocean yesterday.

Tangutu hifo!

Sit down!

The word *hifo* can also mean “to quietness” or “to oneself.” The expression *nofo hifo* can mean “sit down” or “stay behind,” depending on context.

Preview: In emphatic commands, a definitive accent sometimes falls on the directional particle: *’Alu hifó!* (Go down!), *Nofo hifó!* (Sit down!). This accent pattern belongs to a larger system covered in Chapter 44: The Definitive Accent System. You may hear it in forceful commands.

***holo*: around, about**

The particle *holo* marks movement in various directions, without a fixed destination: wandering, going here and there, searching around.

Na’a mau ō holo ’o mamata.

We went around and looked.

Na’e kumi holo koe ’e he faiakó.

The teacher looked all around for you.

Na’á na lele holo fakataha pē.

They (two) ran around together.

Kuó ne hela he lue holó.

He is tired from walking around.

Particle	Meaning	Example
<i>hake</i>	up	<i>sio hake</i> = look up
<i>hifo</i>	down	<i>tō hifo</i> = fall down
<i>holo</i>	around	<i>’alu holo</i> = go around

Combining directional particles with other grammar

Directional particles fit into sentence patterns already taught. They come immediately after the verb, before any objects or prepositional phrases.

Pattern: TM + (pronoun) + verb + directional particle + (object) + (prepositional phrase)

Na'a ku 'omai 'a e valá mei he falé.

I brought the clothes from the house. (Lit. "I brought-hither the clothes from the house")

Té ne tala ange 'a e ongoongó ki he fāmilí.

He will tell the news to the family. (toward a third party)

Na'a mau lele hifo ki tahí.

We ran down to the sea.

'Okú na 'alu holo 'i he koló.

They (two) are going around in the village.

With the conjunction 'o linking two actions:

Na'a nau ō hake 'o ngāue.

They went up and worked.

Polite commands with *hanga*

The verb *hanga* (to turn) is used idiomatically to soften commands and requests. It appears before 'o and a transitive verb, with the object marked by 'a and any named agent by 'e:

Hanga 'o tāpuni 'a e matapaá.

Close the door. (Lit. "Turn and close the door")

Compare this with the blunt imperative *Tāpuni 'a e matapaá.* (Close the door.) The *hanga* version is noticeably more courteous.

To make the request even more polite, add particles after *hanga*. The directional *ange* (expressing deference) and *mu’a* (please) both soften further, and can be stacked:

Expression	Politeness level
<i>Hanga ’o tāpuni ’a e matapaá.</i>	Polite
<i>Hanga ange ’o tāpuni ’a e matapaá.</i>	More polite
<i>Hanga mu’a ’o tāpuni ’a e matapaá.</i>	More polite
<i>Hanga ange mu’a ’o tāpuni ’a e matapaá.</i>	Very polite

The more particles you stack, the more courteous the request.
When a specific person is named as the one being asked, that person takes *’e*:
Hanga ange mu’a ’e Sēmisi ’o fufulu ’a e ipú.
Sēmisi, would you please wash the cup.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>atu</i>	directional particle	away from speaker, toward listener
<i>hifo</i>	directional particle	downward
<i>holo</i>	directional particle	around, about

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>tala</i>	verb	tell, say

Tongan	Type	English
<i>hanga</i>	verb	turn (polite commands)
<i>tāpuni</i>	verb	close, shut
<i>fakaava</i>	verb	open
<i>fufulu</i>	verb	wash
<i>matapā</i>	noun	door
<i>fāmili</i>	noun	family
<i>ipu</i>	noun	cup
<i>ongoongo</i>	noun	news, announcement
<i>’ai</i>	verb	place, put, set
<i>’ā</i>	verb	wake up
<i>tō</i>	verb	fall (also “plant” (Ch 17))
<i>puna</i>	verb	fly, jump
<i>hū</i>	verb	enter
<i>heka</i>	verb	ride, mount
<i>fā’ele</i>	verb	be born
<i>fua</i>	verb	carry, bear
<i>li</i>	verb	throw
<i>to’o</i>	verb	take, remove
<i>tuku</i>	verb	put down, leave
<i>ofo</i>	verb	be surprised
<i>kata</i>	verb	laugh
<i>lue</i>	verb	walk
<i>mamahi</i>	verb	be in pain

Tongan	Type	English
<i>hela</i>	verb	be tired
<i>manatu</i>	verb	think of, remember
<i>falekoloa</i>	noun	shop, store

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English

1. *Ha'u ki heni!*
2. *Na'e 'alu atu 'a Sēmisi ki he falekoloá.*
3. *Tala ange ke foki mai!*
4. *Na'a mau ō holo 'o mamata.*
5. *Na'e tō hifo 'a e siainé mei he fu'u 'akau.*
6. *Sio hake ki he laní!*
7. *Na'á na lele holo 'i he koló.*
8. *'Okú ne 'ave ange 'a e me'akaí ki he kau tamaikí.*
9. *Hanga 'o tāpuni 'a e matapaá.*
10. *Hanga mu'a 'o fakaava 'a e matapaá.*
11. *Hanga ange mu'a 'e Sēmisi 'o fufulu 'a e ipú.*

Exercise 2: Translate English to Tongan

1. Come back! (to me)
2. The children ran down to the ocean.
3. She is bringing the basket (toward me).
4. Tell her to come! (toward a third person)
5. We went up and worked.
6. He looked all around for the book.
7. The mat fell down from the truck.
8. They (two) are walking around in the village.

Exercise 3: Fill in the blank

Choose *atu*, *ange*, *hake*, *hifo*, or *holo* to complete each sentence.

1. 'Alu ____! (Go away!)
2. Tala ____ ke ha'u! (Tell him to come!)
3. Na'e tō ____ 'a e kató. (The basket fell down.)
4. Na'a mau ō ____ 'o mamata. (We went around and looked.)
5. Sio ____ ki he laní! (Look up at the sky!)

Exercise 4: Transform sentences

Change the direction of each sentence by replacing the directional particle with the one given in parentheses. Translate the new sentence.

1. 'Okú ne lele mai. → (atu)
2. Na'e 'alu hifo 'a Mele. → (hake)
3. Na'a mau ō holo. → (atu)
4. Tala ange ke ha'u! → (mai: change *ange* to *mai*)

Exercise 5: Translate Tongan to English

1. Na'e folau hake 'a e vaká ki Vava'u.
2. Kuó ne hela he lele holó.
3. Na'á ku 'omai 'a e tohí mei he falé.
4. 'Oku 'alu hifo 'a e kau tamaikí ki tahi.
5. Té ne tala atu 'a e ongoongó.
6. Na'a mau 'ā hake he pongipongi.

Answers**Exercise 1**

1. Come here!
2. Sēmisi went away to the store.
3. Tell him/her to come back!
4. We went around and looked.

5. The banana fell down from the tree.
6. Look up at the sky!
7. They (two) ran around in the village.
8. She is taking the food to the children. (toward a third party)
9. Close the door. (polite)
10. Please open the door.
11. Sēmisi, would you please wash the cup.

Exercise 2

1. *Foki mai!*
2. *Na'e lele hifo 'a e kau tamaikí ki tahí.*
3. *'Okú ne 'omai 'a e kató.*
4. *Tala ange ke ha'u!*
5. *Na'a mau ō hake 'o ngāue.*
6. *Na'á ne kumi holo 'a e tohí.*
7. *Na'e tō hifo 'a e falá mei he lolí.*
8. *'Okú na lue holo 'i he koló.*

Exercise 3

1. *atu*
2. *ange*
3. *hifo*
4. *holo*
5. *hake*

Exercise 4

1. *'Okú ne lele atu.* He/she is running away.
2. *Na'e 'alu hake 'a Mele.* Mele went up.
3. *Na'a mau ō atu.* We went away.
4. *Tala mai ke ha'u!* Tell me to come! (sending the message toward the speaker)

Exercise 5

1. The boat sailed up to Vava'u.

2. He is tired from running around.
3. I brought the book from the house. (toward me)
4. The children are going down to the ocean.
5. He will tell you the news. (toward the listener)
6. We woke up in the morning.

Chapter 29: The Possessive System in Full

Building on the basic 'e-class / ho-class possessive division, this chapter explains the deeper principle behind the two classes, adds indefinite possessive forms, and shows how possessives behave with prepositions.

The deeper principle: doer and receiver

The two possessive classes follow a single principle. The 'e-class marks the possessor as the doer, the one who acts. The ho-class marks the possessor as the receiver, the one who is acted upon.

The clearest demonstration is with verbal nouns. A verbal noun is a verb used as a noun by placing a possessive pronoun before it (as in *Ko ho'o 'alu ki fē?*, Where are you going?). The possessive class tells you whether the person does the action or receives it.

Take the verb *tokoni* (to help):

'Eku tokoni. my helping (I do the helping)

Hoku tokoni. my being helped (the helping is done to me)

Both phrases contain the word “my.” *’Eku* (’e-class) puts me in the doer role. *Hoku* (ho-class) puts me in the receiver role.

Another pair, using *fili* (to choose):

’Ene fili. his choosing (he does the choosing)

Hono fili. his being chosen (the choosing is done to him)

Or think of it this way:

’eku tokoni = the helping done **by** me *hoku tokoni* = the helping done **to** me

’ene fili = the choosing done **by** him *hono fili* = the choosing done **to** him

’E-class (doer)	Ho-class (receiver)
<i>’eku tokoni</i>	<i>hoku tokoni</i>
my helping	my being helped
<i>’ene fili</i>	<i>hono fili</i>
his choosing	his being chosen
<i>’ene tohi</i>	<i>hono tohi</i>
his writing	his being written about

When the verb has no object (an intransitive verb like *ngāue*, to work, or *fiefia*, to be happy), the person is always the doer. Only the ’e-class applies:

’Ene ngāue. his working

’Enau fiefia. their being happy

The principle with everyday nouns

The doer/receiver principle extends to all possessive choices, not only verbal nouns. An earlier chapter introduced the two possessive classes and listed which nouns fall into each. That division follows the same principle: you are the doer with your knife (*’eku hele*), but the receiver with your clothes (*hoku kofu*).

Some nouns change class depending on your relationship to them:

’Eku vala. the clothes I make (I act upon them)

Hoku vala. the clothes I wear (they cover me)

'Ene hiva. the song he sings (he produces it)

Hono hiva. the song sung about him (it is about him)

Note:

Most relatives take the ho-class: *hoku tokoua* (my sibling), *hoku kāinga* (my relative). Parents and children are exceptions and take the 'e-class: *'eku tamai* (my father), *'eku fa'e* (my mother), *'eku fānau* (my children).

Possessives with plants

Plants follow the doer/receiver principle with a specific pattern. Crops and fruit take the 'e-class, because you tend and harvest them. Trees take the ho-class, because they stand over you and provide for you.

'Eku 'ufi. my yam plants (crops, 'e-class)

'Eku kumala. my sweet potatoes (crops, 'e-class)

Hoku niu. my coconut palms (trees, ho-class)

The same plant word can switch class depending on whether you mean the fruit or the tree:

'Eku niu. my coconuts (the fruit I harvest)

Hoku niu. my coconut palms (the trees)

Indefinite possessives

The possessive forms taught so far (*'eku*, *ho'o*, *'ene...*) are definite: they refer to specific things. Tongan also has indefinite possessive forms, used when the thing is not specific. These appear most often in questions and negatives.

'E-class indefinite forms

Definite	Indefinite	
<i>'eku</i>	<i>ha'aku</i>	my
<i>ho'o</i>	<i>ha'o</i>	your (sg)
<i>'ene</i>	<i>ha'ane</i>	his/her
<i>'etau</i>	<i>ha'atau</i>	our (incl.)
<i>'emau</i>	<i>ha'amau</i>	our (excl.)
<i>ho'omou</i>	<i>ha'amou</i>	your (pl)
<i>'enau</i>	<i>ha'anau</i>	their

Preview: The construction *'oku 'i ai* (“there is / there exists”) appears below minimally for the “to have” pattern. You met *'i ai* in Chapter 7 as a back-reference particle with a pronoun subject (*'Oku ou 'i ai*. “I am there”). The subjectless existential form used here is covered formally in Chapter 31: Existential Expressions. For now, treat *'Oku 'i ai ha'o X?* as the set question-frame meaning “Do you have X?”

Tongan has no verb meaning “to have.” Instead, it combines *'oku 'i ai* (there is, there exists) with a possessive pronoun:

'Oku 'i ai ha'o kato?

Do you have a basket? (Lit. “Is there a-your basket?”)

'Oku 'ikai ke 'i ai ha'aku hele.

I don't have a knife. (Lit. “There is not a knife of mine.”)

'Oku 'i ai 'eku hele 'e ua.

I have two knives. (Definite form in the answer.)

Since the pattern is built on *'oku 'i ai* (“there is”), the negative is its existential negative *'oku 'ikai ke 'i ai* (“there is not”), so “I do not have a knife” is *'Oku 'ikai ke 'i ai ha'aku hele*. Chapter 31 covers this negative form in full.

The indefinite form appears in the question (the speaker does not know if you have one) and in the negative (you have none at all). The definite form returns in affirmative answers, because the thing is now specific.

Ho-class indefinite forms

Definite	Indefinite	
<i>hoku</i>	<i>haku</i>	my
<i>ho</i>	<i>hao</i>	your (sg)
<i>hono</i>	<i>hano</i>	his/her
<i>hotau</i>	<i>hatau</i>	our (incl.)
<i>homau</i>	<i>hamau</i>	our (excl.)
<i>homou</i>	<i>hamou</i>	your (pl)
<i>honau</i>	<i>hanau</i>	their

'Oku 'i ai hao fale?

Do you have a house?

'Oku 'ikai ke 'i ai haku fale.

I don't have a house.

'Oku 'i ai hoku fale pē taha.

I have just one house. (Definite form in the answer.)

The same class rules apply to indefinite possessives. Use the 'e-class indefinite (*ha'o*) for things you control, and the ho-class indefinite (*hao*) for things that shelter or define you.

Preview: Indefinite possessives can also appear before verbal nouns, as in *ha'aku toe lea* (my speaking again). This pattern is covered formally in Chapter 45: Verbal Nouns.

Possessives after prepositions

An earlier chapter showed that ho-class possessives connect directly to *ki* and *'i*, with no article *he*: *ki hoku falé* (to my house), *'i hono lokí* (in his room). The same pattern holds after *mei* (from): *mei homau 'apí* (from our home).

'E-class possessives behave differently. When *ki*, *'i*, *mei*, or *'e* is followed by an 'e-class possessive, the article *he* appears between the preposition and the possessive (the second-person forms *ho'o*, *ho'omo*, and *ho'omou* are exceptions: they connect directly, with no *he*, as in *ki ho'o tohi*, *mei ho'omou ngāue*):

mei he'eku tamaí. from my father
ki he 'ene faiakó. to his teacher
'e he 'enau mātu'á. by their parents

Note:
Dual possessive forms also exist: *'eta/hota* (ours, yours and mine), *'ema/homa* (ours, his/hers and mine), *ho'omo/homo* (yours, two people), *'ena/hona* (theirs, two people). They follow the same class rules as the plural forms.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>ha'aku</i>	indefinite possessive ('e-class)	a ... of mine
<i>ha'o</i>	indefinite possessive ('e-class)	a ... of yours
<i>ha'ane</i>	indefinite possessive ('e-class)	a ... of his/hers
<i>ha'atau</i>	indefinite possessive ('e-class)	a ... of ours (inclusive)

Tongan	Function	English
<i>ha'amau</i>	indefinite possessive (<i>'e</i> -class)	a ... of ours (exclusive)
<i>ha'amou</i>	indefinite possessive (<i>'e</i> -class)	a ... of yours (plural)
<i>ha'anau</i>	indefinite possessive (<i>'e</i> -class)	a ... of theirs
<i>haku</i>	indefinite possessive (<i>ho</i> -class)	a ... of mine
<i>hao</i>	indefinite possessive (<i>ho</i> -class)	a ... of yours
<i>hano</i>	indefinite possessive (<i>ho</i> -class)	a ... of his/hers
<i>hatau</i>	indefinite possessive (<i>ho</i> -class)	a ... of ours (inclusive)
<i>hamau</i>	indefinite possessive (<i>ho</i> -class)	a ... of ours (exclusive)
<i>hamou</i>	indefinite possessive (<i>ho</i> -class)	a ... of yours (plural)
<i>hanau</i>	indefinite possessive (<i>ho</i> -class)	a ... of theirs
<i>'a hai</i>	possessive question (<i>'e</i> -class)	whose?
<i>'o hai</i>	possessive question (<i>ho</i> -class)	whose?

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>'ufi</i>	noun	yam
<i>niu</i>	noun	coconut
<i>kāinga</i>	noun	relative, kin
<i>fili</i>	verb	choose

Exercises

Exercise 1: Identify the role

For each verbal noun phrase, state whether the possessor is the doer or the receiver, and translate into English.

- 1. *'eku tokoni*
- 2. *hono fili*
- 3. *'ene hiva*
- 4. *hoku fili*
- 5. *'enau ngāue*
- 6. *hono tohi*

Exercise 2: Choose the correct possessive class

Fill in the blank with *'eku* or *hoku* to complete each phrase.

- 1. ____ *hele* (my knife, I use it)
- 2. ____ *fale* (my house, it shelters me)
- 3. ____ *me'akai* (my food, I eat it)
- 4. ____ *kofu* (my clothes, they cover me)
- 5. ____ *kumala* (my sweet potato plants, crops)
- 6. ____ *niu* (my coconut palms, trees)
- 7. ____ *tamai* (my father)
- 8. ____ *tokoua* (my sibling)

Exercise 3: Indefinite possessives

Translate into Tongan using the correct indefinite possessive form.

1. Do you have a knife? ('e-class)
2. I don't have a basket.
3. Does he have a book?
4. Do you have a house? (ho-class)
5. I don't have any relatives.
6. She has a lot of money. (affirmative, use definite form)

Exercise 4: Possessives with prepositions

Fill in the blank with the correct preposition and possessive combination. The class is given in parentheses.

1. ____ *falé*. to my house (*ki* + ho-class)
2. ____ *tamaí*. from my father (*mei* + 'e-class)
3. ____ *lokí*. in his room ('i + ho-class)
4. ____ *faiakó*. by their teacher ('e + 'e-class)
5. ____ *'apí*. from our (excl.) home (*mei* + ho-class)

Exercise 5: Translate English to Tongan

1. His writing (he does the writing)
2. His being chosen
3. Do you have a mat? ('e-class)
4. I don't have any food.
5. I like his sibling. (use *sai'ia* with 'i)
6. Their choosing of Siale was correct.

Answers**Exercise 1**

1. *'eku tokoni*. doer: my helping (I do the helping)
2. *hono fili*. receiver: his being chosen

3. *'ene hiva*. doer: his singing (he does the singing)
4. *hoku fili*. receiver: my being chosen
5. *'enau ngāue*. doer: their working
6. *hono tohi*. receiver: his being written about

Exercise 2

1. *'eku hele* ('e-class, tool)
2. *hoku fale* (ho-class, shelter)
3. *'eku me'akai* ('e-class, food)
4. *hoku kofu* (ho-class, clothing)
5. *'eku kumala* ('e-class, crop)
6. *hoku niu* (ho-class, tree)
7. *'eku tamai* ('e-class, parent exception)
8. *hoku tokoua* (ho-class, relative)

Exercise 3

1. *'Oku 'i ai ha'o hele?*
2. *'Oku 'ikai ke 'i ai ha'aku kato.*
3. *'Oku 'i ai ha'ane tohi?*
4. *'Oku 'i ai hao fale?*
5. *'Oku 'ikai ke 'i ai haku kāinga.*
6. *'Oku 'i ai 'ene pa'anga lahi.*

Exercise 4

1. *ki hoku falé*
2. *mei he'eku tamaí*
3. *'i hono lokí*
4. *'e he 'enau faiakó*
5. *mei homau 'apí*

Exercise 5

1. *'Ene tohi*
2. *Hono fili*

3. *'Oku 'i ai ha'o fala?*
4. *'Oku 'ikai ke 'i ai ha'aku me'akai.*
5. *'Oku ou sai'ia 'i hono tokoua.*
6. *Na'e tonu 'enau fili 'a Siale.*

Chapter 30: Temporal, Conditional, and Concessive Conjunctions

This chapter introduces conjunctions that express conditions and timing: “if,” “while,” “until,” “when,” and “although.” It also covers several expressions that round out your ability to handle concession, universal conditions, and gradual progression. These add to the basic conjunctions (*pea*, *ka/kae*, *’o*, *he*), connecting whole clauses to express how two events relate to each other.

If: *kapau*

The word *kapau* means “if.” It introduces a condition: something that may or may not happen.

Kapau té ke foki, té u kuki.

If you return, I’ll cook.

The *kapau* clause states the condition. The second clause states the result. Each clause keeps its own tense marker. The condition can use any tense marker, depending on when the condition applies:

Kapau té ke tokoni mai, 'e sai 'aupito 'a e ngāué.

If you help, the work will be very good.

Kapau is always followed by a tense marker (*'oku*, *te*, *na'a*, *kuo*, *'e*) or by *ko*. It never stands alone without one of these.

When the *kapau* clause comes first, the result clause may optionally begin with *pea* (then). Both forms are correct, with or without *pea*.

When the “if” clause comes second: 'o kapau

When the result comes first and the condition follows, *'o* is placed before *kapau*:

Té u kuki 'o kapau té ke foki.

I'll cook if you return.

This means the same thing as *Kapau té ke foki, té u kuki*. The only difference is clause order. When the “if” clause comes first, use *kapau* alone. When it comes second, use *'o kapau*.

Preview: Tongan has another conditional word, *ka*, which can mean “if and when” or “whenever.” It describes conditions that are expected or probable, while *kapau* is for conditions that are uncertain. *Ka ha'u 'a Sione, peá ke tala ki ai 'oku ou 'i heni* (When Sione comes, tell him I am here). This use of *ka* is covered formally in Chapter 47: Conditionals and Counterfactuals. If you encounter *ka* at the beginning of a sentence before a verb or noun subject (rather than before a tense marker or pronoun, where it means “but”), it likely means “when” or “whenever.”

While: lolotonga as a conjunction

You met *lolotonga* in Chapter 22: Aspect Markers, where it meant “currently” or “in the act of,” placed before a verb within a single clause. *Lolotonga* also works as a conjunction meaning “while.” In this use, it sits between two full clauses, saying that one event happens during another.

Na'á ku mohe lolotonga na'á ne lau tohi.

I slept while she was reading.

'Okú ne hiva lolotonga 'oku ou ngāue.

She sings while I work.

Each clause has its own tense marker. The tense markers do not need to match: one clause can be past while the other is present, depending on the meaning.

Until: *kae'oua ke*

The phrase *kae'oua ke* means “until.” It introduces the event that brings the first action to an end.

Té u ngāue heni kae'oua ke nau foki mai.

I will work here until they come back.

After *kae'oua*, use *ke* when the “until” event has not yet happened. When the “until” event marks a completed state (the perfect sense), replace *ke* with *kuo*:

'E nofo ai kae'oua kuo mālohi.

She will stay there until she is strong. (Lit. “Will stay there until has-become strong.”)

Preview: In *'E nofo ai*, the particle *ai* attaches directly to a verb as a back-reference meaning “there” (referring to a place mentioned earlier). This extends the Chapter 7 use of *ai* (which combines with *'i*, *ki*, and *mei*); the bare post-verbal form, plus the subjectless existential *'oku 'i ai*, is covered formally in Chapter 31: Existential Expressions.

The difference: *kae'oua ke* looks forward to a future event. *Kae'oua kuo* looks forward to a point of completion.

When something happens: *'i he* + verbal noun

Tongan expresses “when” by using *'i he* followed by a verbal noun: a possessive pronoun plus a verb, as covered in the previous chapter. The second clause usually begins with *pea*.

'I he 'osi 'enau hivá, pea nau mohe.

When they finished singing, they slept. (Lit. “In the finishing of their singing, then they slept.”)

The *'osi* here is the same *'osi* (finished, completed) you know as an aspect marker. Combined with *'i he* and a possessive verbal noun, it creates a temporal clause: “at the point when their [action] was finished.”

Another pattern for “when” uses *ko e* with *pē* (just, only) to express “as soon as”:

Ko e ha'u pē 'e Mele, peá u 'ave leva 'ene kato.

As soon as Mele came, I carried her basket right away.

Both patterns use *pea* to begin the main clause. The *'i he* pattern emphasizes a moment in time. The *ko e ... pē* pattern emphasizes immediacy.

Preview: The word *hilí* means “after” and works as a time marker between events, the opposite of *lolotonga* (while/during). *Hilí 'a e ngāué, na'a mau kai* (After the work, we ate). This is covered formally in Chapter 42: Time Expressions and Personal Questions. Recognize *hilí* as meaning “after” when you encounter it.

Although: *neongo*

The word *neongo* means “although,” “even though,” or “in spite of.” When the *neongo* clause comes first, the second clause often begins with *ka* (but):

Neongo 'eku hela'ia, ka té u ngāue pē.

Although I am tired, I will work anyway.

Neongo 'eku vaivai, ka té u feinga atu pē.

Even though I am weak, I will keep trying.

The *ka* is optional but common. Without it, the sentence still works:

Té ke lava 'o tokoni lahi, neongo ho'o masiva.

You can help a lot, even though you are poor.

When *neongo* follows the main clause (as in the sentence above), it states the concession after the main point, similar to how *'o kapau* states the condition after the result.

Note:

After *neongo*, the possessive pronoun + verb pattern is common: *neongo 'eku hela'ia* (although my being-tired, i.e., although I am tired). This is the same verbal noun construction used with *'i he* above and throughout the possessive system.

Whoever, whatever: *'ilonga*

The word *'ilonga* (*whoever, whatever, whichever*) introduces a clause that refers to any and all members of a kind, without specifying which one:

'Ilonga ia 'oku fie tokoni pea ha'u ke tau ngāue.

Whoever wants to help should come so we can work.

The structure is *'ilonga* + clause describing the kind of person or thing, followed by the main clause. The word *ia* often appears after *'ilonga* as a grammatical filler, though it is not always present.

'Ilonga ha kolo 'oku mau 'i ai, 'oku 'i ai foki mo e 'Otuá.

Whatever town we are in, God is also there.

Here *'ilonga* applies to a place (*kolo*, town) rather than a person. The construction works the same way: *'ilonga* + indefinite noun + relative clause, then the main clause.

'Ilonga 'a kinautolu 'oku nau nofo 'i Vava'ú, 'e fetukutuku kinautolu ki Tongatapu.

All those who live in Vava'u, whoever they are, will be removed to Tongatapu.

When the subject is a specific group, *'ilonga* adds the meaning “whoever they may be,” emphasising that no exceptions apply.

Different, nevertheless, provided that: *kehe*

The adjective *kehe* (*different*) has three idiomatic uses that go beyond its basic meaning.

kae kehe (*nevertheless, however*)

Na'e faingata'a 'a e ngāué, kae kehe, na'a nau lava ia.

The work was difficult, nevertheless, they accomplished it.

Kae kehe appears at the start of a clause, followed by a slight pause (a comma in writing). It signals a contrast or concession, much like “nevertheless” or “however” in English. This is a close relative of *neongo*: both express concession, but *neongo* introduces the conceded fact (“although X”) while *kae kehe* introduces the contrasting result (“nevertheless, Y”).

kehe ke (*provided that, so long as*)

Fa'iteliha koe ki he totongi té ke ma'ú, kae kehe ke ke ha'u 'o fai 'a e ngāué.

Decide for yourself about the payment you will receive, provided that you come and do the work.

Kehe ke. (or *kae kehe ke*) introduces a condition that must be met. The clause after *ke* states what is required. The meaning is: everything else is flexible, but this one condition matters. Compare this with *kapau* (if): *kapau* introduces a condition that may or may not be true, while *kehe ke* introduces the one condition the speaker insists on.

Kehe pē ke tau ngāue mālohi.

The one thing that matters is that we work hard.

Here *kehe pē ke* (with the limiter *pē*) narrows the condition further: just this one thing, nothing else.

kehe as an adjective (different)

In its basic use, *kehe* simply means “different”:
’Oku kehe ’a e lea faka-Tongá mei he lea faka-Pilitāniá.
The Tongan language is different from the English language.

By and by: *faifai*

The intransitive verb *faifai* (*by and by, as time went on*) is typically framed between two occurrences of *pea* (and/then):
Pea faifai pea hoko ’a e me’á.
And by and by the thing happened.

The pattern *pea faifai pea* + verb creates a narrative sense of gradual progression: “and as time passed, eventually...” This pairs naturally with the temporal conjunctions above: *lolotonga* marks simultaneous events, *kae’oua ke* marks the endpoint, and *faifai* marks a gradual unfolding.
Faifai can also be turned into a verbal noun with *’i he*:
’I he faifai na’a nau ’ilo ’a e mo’oní.
In the course of time they came to know the truth.

Summary of new conjunctions and expressions

Expression	Meaning	Pattern
<i>kapau</i>	if (condition first)	<i>kapau</i> + condition, result
<i>’o kapau</i>	if (condition second)	result, <i>’o kapau</i> + condition

Expression	Meaning	Pattern
<i>lolotonga</i>	while, during	clause + <i>lolotonga</i> + clause
<i>kae’oua ke</i>	until	clause + <i>kae’oua ke</i> + event
<i>kae’oua kuo</i>	until (completed)	clause + <i>kae’oua kuo</i> + completion
<i>’i he</i> + verbal noun	when	<i>’i he</i> + poss. + verb, <i>pea</i> + clause
<i>neongo</i>	although	<i>neongo</i> + concession, (<i>ka</i>) + result
<i>’ilonga</i>	whoever, whatever	<i>’ilonga</i> (+ <i>ia</i>) + clause, main clause
<i>kae kehe</i>	nevertheless	clause, <i>kae kehe</i> , contrasting clause
<i>kehe ke</i>	provided that	clause, <i>kehe ke</i> + required condition
<i>faifai</i>	by and by	<i>pea faifai pea</i> + verb

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>kapau</i>	conjunction	if
<i>’o kapau</i>	conjunction phrase	if (when condition comes second)

Tongan	Function	English
<i>kae’oua ke</i>	conjunction phrase	until
<i>neongo</i>	conjunction	although, even though
<i>hili’</i>	conjunction	after

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>’ilonga</i>	pronoun	whoever, whatever, whichever
<i>kehe</i>	adjective/conjunction	different; nevertheless (<i>kae kehe</i>); provided that (<i>kehe ke</i>)
<i>faifai</i>	verb	by and by, as time went on
<i>mo’oni</i>	noun/adjective	truth; true

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate into English

1. *Kapau ’okú ne fiekaia, té u kuki.*
2. *Na’á ne lele lolotonga na’á ku mohe.*
3. *Té u nofo heni kae’oua ke nau foki mai.*
4. *’I he ’osi ’ene ngāue, peá ne kai.*
5. *Neongo ’eku fiekaia, ka té u ngāue pē.*
6. *’E sai ’a e me’á ’o kapau té ke tokoni mai.*

Exercise 2: Translate into Tongan

1. If you come, I will sing.

2. I was reading while she was sleeping.
3. I will work until they come back.
4. When he finished eating, he slept.
5. Although she is weak, she will try anyway.
6. He will stay there until he is well.

Exercise 3: Combine the two sentences into one, using the conjunction in parentheses

1. *Té ke ha'u. / Té u fiefia. (kapau)*
2. *Na'á ku tohi. / Na'á ne hiva. (lolotonga)*
3. *Té u nofo. / Nau foki mai. (kae'oua ke)*
4. *'Eku hela'ia. / Té u 'alu pē. (neongo ... ka)*
5. *'Osi 'emau ako. / Mau kai. ('i he ... pea)*

Exercise 4: Fill in the blank with the correct conjunction

1. ____ té ke ako, 'e sai ho'o ngāue.
2. Té u nofo heni ____ ke nau foki mai.
3. Na'á ku lau tohi ____ na'á ne mohe.
4. ____ 'eku hela'ia, ka té u tokoni atu pē.
5. ____ 'osi 'ene hiva, peá ne kai.

Exercise 5: Rewrite each sentence, moving the “if” clause to the opposite position. Remember: use 'o kapau when the condition follows the result, and kapau alone when it comes first

1. *Kapau té ke ha'u, té u kuki.*
2. *Té u fiefia 'o kapau té ke hiva.*
3. *Kapau 'okú ne puke, 'oua té ke 'alu ki ai.*
4. *'E sai 'a e ngāué 'o kapau té ke tokoni mai.*

Exercise 6: Complete the sentence with 'ilonga, kae kehe, kehe ke, or faifai

1. ____ ia 'oku fie ako pea ha'u ki he akó. (Whoever wants to study should come to school.)

2. Na'e mamafa 'a e ngāu'é, ____, na'a nau 'osi ia. (The work was heavy, nevertheless, they finished it.)
3. ____ pē ke ke fanongo ki ho'o fa'ē. (The one thing that matters is that you listen to your mother.)
4. Pea ____ pea 'osi 'a e matangí. (And by and by the wind stopped.)
5. Na'e 'ikai 'ene pa'anga, ____ ke ne feinga. (He had no money, provided that he try.)

Exercise 7: Translate into English

1. 'Ilonga ia 'oku fie ha'u pea ha'u ki heni.
 2. Na'e faingata'a 'a e halá, kae kehe, na'a nau a'u ki he kolo.
 3. Pea faifai pea 'osi 'a e matangí ko iá.
 4. Kehe pē ke ke 'alu ki he akó.
 5. 'Ilonga ha kolo 'oku mau 'i ai, 'oku 'i ai foki mo e 'Otuá.
 6. 'I he faifai na'a nau 'ilo 'a e mo'oní.
-

Answers

Exercise 1

1. If she is hungry, I will cook.
2. She ran while I was sleeping.
3. I will stay here until they come.
4. When he finished working, he ate.
5. Although I am hungry, I will work anyway.
6. Things will be good if you help.

Exercise 2

1. Kapau té ke ha'u, té u hiva.
2. Na'á ku lau tohi lolotonga na'á ne mohe.
3. Té u ngāue kae'oua ke nau foki mai.
4. 'I he 'osi 'ene kai, peá ne mohe.
5. Neongo 'ene vaivai, ka té ne feinga atu pē.

6. 'E nofo ai kae'oua kuo mo'ui.

Exercise 3

1. Kapau té ke ha'u, té u fiefia.
2. Na'á ku tohi lolotonga na'á ne hiva.
3. Té u nofo kae'oua ke nau foki mai.
4. Neongo 'eku hela'ia, ka té u 'alu pē.
5. 'I he 'osi 'emau ako, pea mau kai.

Exercise 4

1. Kapau
2. kae'oua
3. lolotonga
4. Neongo
5. 'I he

Exercise 5

1. Té u kuki 'o kapau té ke ha'u.
2. Kapau té ke hiva, té u fiefia.
3. 'Oua té ke 'alu ki ai 'o kapau 'okú ne puke.
4. Kapau té ke tokoni mai, 'e sai 'a e ngāué.

Exercise 6

1. 'Ilonga
2. kae kehe
3. Kehe
4. faifai
5. kehe ke

Exercise 7

1. Whoever wants to come, come here.
2. The road was difficult, nevertheless, they reached the town.
3. And by and by that wind stopped.

4. The one thing that matters is that you go to school.
5. Whatever town we are in, God is also there.
6. In the course of time they came to know the truth.

Chapter 31: Existential Expressions

Building on the back-reference word *ai*, this chapter introduces the existential expression *'oku 'i ai* (there is, there are). You previewed this pattern in Chapter 29, where it combined with indefinite possessives to form the Tongan equivalent of “to have” (*'Oku 'i ai ha'o kato?* Do you have a basket?). This chapter gives it its full treatment as a standalone existential.

There is, there are: *'oku 'i ai*

The combination *'i ai* can also sit in the verb position of a sentence, where it means “there is” or “there are.” This is how Tongan expresses existence. Literally, *'i ai* means “is in-it” or “is there,” and in the verb slot it becomes an existential statement.

'Oku 'i ai ha fo'i moli 'i fale?

Is there an orange in the house?

'Io, 'oku 'i ai.

Yes, there is.

The pattern: *'oku + 'i ai + ha + noun (+ location)*.

'Oku 'i ai ha tangata 'i heni?

Is there a man here?

The indefinite article *ha* is typical in existential sentences because the speaker is asking whether something exists, not pointing to a specific one.

With other tense markers, the construction works the same way:

Na'e 'i ai ha vaka 'i tahi.

There was a boat at sea.

'E 'i ai ha kātōanga 'apongipongi.

There will be a celebration tomorrow.

There is not: *'oku 'ikai ke 'i ai*

The negative existential follows the standard negation pattern. Place *'ikai ke* before *'i ai*:

'Oku 'ikai ke 'i ai ha taha.

There is no one.

'Oku 'ikai ke 'i ai ha me'akai 'i fale.

There is no food in the house.

In everyday speech, the *ke 'i ai* is often dropped, leaving just *'oku 'ikai*: you may hear *'Oku 'ikai ha me'akai 'i fale* for “there is no food in the house.” That shorter form is also correct. This book always teaches and drills the full *'oku 'ikai ke 'i ai*, which keeps the existential core *'i ai* visible.

In past and future tenses:

Na'e 'ikai ke 'i ai ha vaka.

There was no boat.

'E 'ikai ke 'i ai ha tangata 'i heni.

There will be no one here.

The classifier *fo'i* in existential contexts

You met *fo'i* in Chapter 20 as the classifier that singles out one individual unit: *ha fo'i niu* (one coconut), *ha fo'i mā* (one loaf of bread). Its original sense relates to fruit (one fruit from a tree), and it extends naturally to any complete, self-contained item, especially round objects. This section extends that usage into the existential and generic patterns this chapter introduces.

Tongan	English
<i>ha fo'i niu</i>	a (single) coconut
<i>ha fo'i moli</i>	an orange
<i>ha fo'i moa</i>	an egg
<i>ha fo'i mā</i>	a loaf (of bread)

Without *fo'i*, the noun is more general. *Ha niu* could mean a coconut, some coconuts, or even a coconut tree, depending on context. *Ha fo'i niu* means specifically one coconut.

Fo'i also works with non-round nouns when the point is to single out one item from a larger category:

ha fo'i lea. a single word (compared to *ha lea*, which could mean a word, a statement, or a language)

ha fo'i me'a. one (single) thing

'Oku 'i ai ha fo'i siaine 'i he kato?

Is there a banana in the basket?

Preview: The word *'aki* is another back-reference word, similar to *ai*. Where *ai* replaces *'i* and *ki* phrases, *'aki* replaces phrases meaning “with” or “by means of”: *Na’á ne tohi 'aki* (He wrote with it). This is covered formally in Chapter 33: Instrumental *'aki* and the Suffix *-’i*. Recognize *'aki* as meaning “with it” or “with them” when you encounter it.

Preview: When Tongan expresses “whenever there is,” it uses *ka 'i ai* instead of *kapau 'oku 'i ai*: *Ka 'i ai ha kātōanga lahi, peá ke tala mai* (Whenever there is a big celebration, tell me). The conditional *ka* (if and when, whenever) is covered formally in Chapter 47: Conditionals and Counterfactuals. Recognize *ka 'i ai* as meaning “whenever there is.”

Summary of new patterns

Pattern	Meaning	Example
<i>'oku 'i ai + ha + noun</i>	there is/are	<i>'Oku 'i ai ha tangata.</i> There is a man.
<i>'oku 'ikai ke 'i ai + ha + noun</i>	there is not	<i>'Oku 'ikai ke 'i ai ha taha.</i> There is no one.
<i>fo'i + noun</i>	a single, individual	<i>ha fo'i niu</i> a (single) coconut

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>'i ai</i>	existential marker	there is, there are (with tense marker)
<i>lahi</i>	quantifier (in existentials)	many, much
<i>si'i</i>	quantifier (in existentials)	few, little (also “small” (Ch 16))
<i>'oku 'iai</i>	existential phrase	there is/are
<i>na'e 'iai</i>	existential phrase (past)	there was/were

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>moli</i>	noun	orange
<i>feitu'u</i>	noun	place, area
<i>mahaki</i>	noun	sickness
<i>palopalema</i>	noun	problem
<i>kātoanga</i>	noun	celebration, festival

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate into English

- 1. *'Oku 'i ai ha fo'i mā 'i fale?*
- 2. *'Oku 'ikai ke 'i ai ha vaka 'i tahi.*
- 3. *'E 'i ai ha kātoanga 'apongipongi.*
- 4. *'Oku 'i ai ha fo'i mango 'i he kato?*

Exercise 2: Translate into Tongan

- 1. Is there a teacher here?

2. There is no food in the house.
3. There was a boat at sea.
4. Is there an egg in the basket?

Exercise 3: Rewrite each sentence as a negative existential

1. 'Oku 'i ai ha faiako 'i heni.
 2. 'Oku 'i ai ha fo'i niu 'i fale.
 3. Na'e 'i ai ha vaka.
 4. 'Oku 'i ai ha me'akai.
 5. 'Oku 'i ai ha taha 'i he kolo.
-

Answers

Exercise 1

1. Is there a loaf of bread in the house?
2. There is no boat at sea.
3. There will be a celebration tomorrow.
4. Is there a mango in the basket?

Exercise 2

1. 'Oku 'i ai ha faiako 'i heni?
2. 'Oku 'ikai ke 'i ai ha me'akai 'i fale.
3. Na'e 'i ai ha vaka 'i tahi.
4. 'Oku 'i ai ha fo'i moa 'i he kato?

Exercise 3

1. 'Oku 'ikai ke 'i ai ha faiako 'i heni.
2. 'Oku 'ikai ke 'i ai ha fo'i niu 'i fale.
3. Na'e 'ikai ke 'i ai ha vaka.
4. 'Oku 'ikai ke 'i ai ha me'akai.
5. 'Oku 'ikai ke 'i ai ha taha 'i he kolo.

Chapter 32: The *Faka-* Prefix

Word Study

This chapter introduces *faka-*, one of the most productive word-building tools in Tongan. A prefix is an element placed at the beginning of a word to change its meaning.

Manner and likeness: *faka-* with nouns

When *faka-* is attached to a noun, it creates an adjective or adverb meaning “in the manner of” or “pertaining to” that noun.

Tonga → *faka-Tonga* (Tongan, in the Tongan way)

'Okú ke poto he hiva faka-Tonga?

Are you good at Tongan singing?

Here *faka-Tonga* describes the style of *hiva* (*singing*) as Tongan.

When *faka-* is attached to a proper place name, it is written with a hyphen: *faka-Tonga*, *faka-Pālangi*. With common nouns, it is written as one word: *fakatangata*, *fakaako*.

Noun	<i>faka-</i> form	Meaning
<i>tangata</i> (man)	<i>fakatangata</i>	human, in a human manner
<i>ako</i> (school, learning)	<i>fakaako</i>	pertaining to school, educational
<i>Tonga</i>	<i>faka-Tonga</i>	Tongan, in the Tongan way
<i>Pālangi</i> (European)	<i>faka-Pālangi</i>	in the European way

'Okú ne haka fakatangata.

He dances in a human (not stylized) manner.

Causative verbs: making things happen

The second function of *faka-* is causative. When attached to an adjective or an intransitive verb, it creates a verb meaning “to make” or “to cause.” A causative verb expresses making something happen rather than doing it yourself.

mohe (to sleep) → *fakamohe* (to put to sleep)

Na’á ne fakamohe ’ene tamasi’í.

She put her child to sleep.

The word *mohe* means “to sleep,” something you do yourself. Adding *faka-* makes it causative: *fakamohe* means “to cause to sleep,” to put someone to sleep.

totonu (straight, correct) → *fakatotonu* (to straighten)

Na’á ku fakatotonu ’a e falá.

I straightened the mat.

lelei (good) → *fakalelei* (to mend, to make good)

Kuó ne fakalelei 'a e vaká.
He has mended the boat.

Base word	Meaning	<i>faka-</i> form	Meaning
<i>mohe</i>	sleep	<i>fakamohe</i>	put to sleep
<i>lelei</i>	good	<i>fakalelei</i>	mend, repair
<i>totonu</i>	straight	<i>fakatotonu</i>	straighten
<i>fo'ou</i> (new)	new	<i>fakafo'ou</i>	restore, make new
<i>foki</i> (return)	return	<i>fakafoki</i>	send back, return (something)

The pattern is consistent: *faka-* + adjective = “to make [adjective],” and *faka-* + intransitive verb = “to cause [verb] to happen.”

Reflexive causatives: causing oneself

Some *faka-* verbs are intransitive: the subject causes the action upon themselves, or a group does it collectively.

taha (one) → *fakataha* (to assemble, to gather together)
Kuo nau fakataha 'i he fale lotú.
They have assembled in the church.

The idea behind *fakataha* is “to cause oneself to become one,” to come together as a group. No separate object is needed.

mama'o (*far, distant*) → *fakamama'o* (to depart, to move oneself away)
Na'á ne fakamama'o mei he kolō.
He departed from the village.

Whether a *faka-* causative comes out transitive or reflexive is a property of the individual word and is best learned verb by verb. *Fakamohe* and *fakalelei* are transitive: the subject causes the action on someone or something else. *Fakataha* and *fakamama’o* are reflexive: the subject causes the action on themselves, or a group does it collectively.

Temporal adverbs: *faka-* with time nouns

When *faka-* is attached to a noun naming a period of time, it creates an adverb meaning “every [time period].”

Time noun	<i>faka-</i> form	Meaning
<i>’aho</i> (day)	<i>faka’aho</i>	daily
<i>uike</i> (week)	<i>fakauike</i>	weekly
<i>ta’u</i> (year)	<i>fakata’u</i>	yearly

’Oku ou lotu faka’aho.

I pray daily.

Na’e ’alu fakauike.

He went weekly.

These temporal adverbs sit after the verb, in the same position as other adverbs like *lelei* (well) or *mālohi* (hard).

Narrowing the sense: *faka-e-*

The compound prefix *faka-e-* is a more specific version of *faka-*. Where *faka-* means “pertaining to [noun] in general,” *faka-e-* narrows the meaning to “pertaining to one particular [noun].”

ha me’a fakakolo. a village matter (relating to villages in general)

ha me’a fakaekolo. a matter pertaining to one particular village

Fakakolo describes something that relates to villages as a category. *Fakaekolo* singles out one specific village, distinguishing it from others.

Preview: When *faka-* is combined with a reduplicated (repeated) form of a word, the meaning shifts. For example, *poto* (clever) becomes *fakapotopoto* (sensible, prudent, wise), not simply “to make clever.” The combination of *faka-* with reduplication is covered formally in Chapter 50: Reduplication. Recognize words like *fakapotopoto* as having a nuanced meaning built from the base word.

Summary of *faka-* patterns

Pattern	Function	Example
<i>faka-</i> + noun	manner/likeness	<i>faka-Tonga</i> Tongan, in the Tongan way
<i>faka-</i> + adjective/verb	causative (transitive)	<i>fakamohe</i> to put to sleep
<i>faka-</i> + adjective/verb	causative reflexive (intransitive)	<i>fakataha</i> to assemble
<i>faka-</i> + time noun	temporal adverb	<i>faka’aho</i> daily

Pattern	Function	Example
<i>faka-e-</i> + noun	pertaining to one particular	<i>fakaekolo</i> pertaining to this village

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>faka-</i>	prefix (manner)	in the manner of, -like, -wise
<i>faka-</i>	prefix (causative)	to cause, to make

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>faka-Tonga</i>	adverb	in Tongan style
<i>faka-Pālangi</i>	adverb	in European style
<i>fakalelei</i>	verb	to fix, to make good
<i>fakatotonu</i>	verb	to straighten, to correct
<i>fakafo’ou</i>	verb	to renew
<i>fakamamā</i>	verb	to lighten, to relieve
<i>fakamālohi</i>	verb	to strengthen
<i>fakamamafa</i>	verb	to make heavy, to emphasize
<i>fakamama’o</i>	verb	to distance
<i>faka’aho</i>	adverb	daily
<i>fakauike</i>	adverb	weekly

Tongan	Type	English
<i>fakamāhina</i>	adverb	monthly
<i>fakamaheni</i>	adjective	familiar, accustomed
<i>faka'atā</i>	verb	to make free, to open
<i>uike</i>	noun	week
<i>mama'o</i>	adjective	far, distant
<i>mamafa</i>	adjective	heavy
<i>mamā</i>	adjective	light (weight)
<i>'atā</i>	adjective	free, clear

Exercises

Exercise 1: Form the *faka-* word from each base word, and give its English meaning

1. *Tonga*
2. *mohe*
3. *'aho*
4. *tangata*
5. *lelei*
6. *uike*
7. *taha*
8. *totonu*

Exercise 2: Translate into English

1. *'Okú ne lea faka-Tonga.*
2. *Na'á ne fakamohe 'ene tamasi'í.*
3. *Kuo nau fakataha 'i he fale akó.*
4. *'Oku ou ngāue faka'aho.*

- 5. *Kuó ne fakalelei 'a e falá.*
- 6. *Na'e 'alu fakauike.*

Exercise 3: Translate into Tongan

- 1. I put my child to sleep.
- 2. I pray daily.
- 3. They have assembled in the school.
- 4. Are you good at Tongan dance?
- 5. He has straightened the mat.
- 6. He came yearly.

Exercise 4: Fill in the blank with the correct faka- form

- 1. *'Oku ou hiva __.* (in the Tongan way)
- 2. *Na'á ne __ 'ene tamasi'í.* (put to sleep)
- 3. *'Oku ou lotu __.* (daily)
- 4. *Na'á ku __ 'a e falá.* (straightened)
- 5. *Kuo nau __ 'i heni.* (assembled)

Exercise 5: Match each faka- word to its meaning

1. <i>fakalelei</i>	a. daily
2. <i>faka-Tonga</i>	b. to straighten
3. <i>faka'aho</i>	c. human, in a human manner
4. <i>fakatotonu</i>	d. to mend, repair
5. <i>fakatangata</i>	e. Tongan, in the Tongan way

Answers

Exercise 1

- 1. *faka-Tonga.* Tongan, in the Tongan way

2. *fakamohe*. to put to sleep
3. *faka'aho*. daily
4. *fakatangata*. human, in a human manner
5. *fakalelei*. to mend, to make good
6. *fakauike*. weekly
7. *fakataha*. to assemble, to gather together
8. *fakatotonu*. to straighten

Exercise 2

1. He/she speaks Tongan. (Lit. "He/she talks in the Tongan way")
2. She put her child to sleep.
3. They have assembled in the school.
4. I work daily.
5. He/she has mended the mat.
6. He went weekly.

Exercise 3

1. *Na'á ku fakamohe 'eku tamasi'í.*
2. *'Oku ou lotu faka'aho.*
3. *Kuo nau fakataha 'i he fale akó.*
4. *'Okú ke poto he haka faka-Tonga?*
5. *Kuó ne fakatotonu 'a e falá.*
6. *Na'e ha'u fakata'u.*

Exercise 4

1. *faka-Tonga*
2. *fakamohe*
3. *faka'aho*
4. *fakatotonu*
5. *fakataha*

Exercise 5

1. d

2. e
3. a
4. b
5. c

Chapter 33: Instrumental *'aki* and the Suffix *-i*

This chapter introduces two tools for building more precise sentences: the word *'aki*, which expresses the instrument or means used to do something, and the suffix *-i*, which changes how a verb relates to its object. A suffix is a letter or group of letters added to the end of a word to change its meaning or grammatical function.

Expressing “with” and “by means of”: *'aki*

Tongan uses *mo* for accompaniment, as in *Na'á ku 'alu mo Sione* (I went with Sione). For expressing the instrument or means used to do something, Tongan uses a different word: *'aki*. The word *'aki* functions like a preposition, showing the relationship between a verb and the tool or material involved.

Fufulu 'aki ho falá e vai māfaná.

Wash your mat with warm water.

Here *'aki* tells you the means: warm water is the instrument used for washing. The verb *fufulu* means “to wash (something).”

After verbs of making, 'aki means “of” or “out of,” indicating the material something is made from.

'Oku ngaohi eni 'aki 'a e niu.

This is made of coconut. (Lit. “Is made this with the coconut”)

The verb *ngaohi* (to make) combines with 'aki to state the material.

Meaning of 'aki	Example
with, by means of	<i>fufulu 'aki e vai</i> (wash with water)
of, out of (material)	<i>ngaohi 'aki 'a e niu</i> (made of coconut)
by, to the extent of	<i>lahi ange 'aki e ta'u 'e taha</i> (older by one year)

Word order

The word 'aki can appear in two positions. It can sit right after the verb, before the object:

Fufulu 'aki ho falá e vai māfaná.

Wash your mat with warm water. (Lit. “Wash with your-mat the warm-water”)

Or it can come after the object, in its logical position:

Fufulu ho falá 'aki e vai māfaná.

Wash your mat with warm water.

Both orders are correct and mean the same thing. The first pattern, with 'aki immediately after the verb, is the more common word order in natural Tongan speech.

Referring back: 'aki as “with it”

When the instrument has already been mentioned and you want to refer back to it without repeating the noun, 'aki on its own means “with it” or “with them.” In this use, 'aki functions as a pronominal adverb: a single word that replaces a preposition-plus-pronoun combination. You have already seen this with *ai* (there, in it) in earlier chapters. The word 'aki works the same way, but for instruments.

Na'á ne puke 'a e helé 'o ne tā 'aki 'a e iká.

He grabbed the knife and cut the fish with it.

The word *puke* here means “grabbed” and *tā* means “struck” or “cut.” The word 'aki means “with it,” referring back to the knife (*hele*).

In a relative construction, 'aki connects back to a noun mentioned earlier, meaning “with which.”

Ko e hele eni na'á ne tā 'aki 'a e iká.

This is the knife with which he cut the fish.

Making verbs transitive: the suffix -'i

Many Tongan verbs are intransitive: they describe an action without taking a direct object. The suffix -'i turns such a verb into a transitive verb, one that takes a direct object marked with 'a. Recall that in transitive sentences, 'a marks the object and 'e marks the agent, while in intransitive sentences 'a marks the subject.

tokoni (to help, to give assistance) is intransitive. The person helped is introduced by the preposition *ki*:

Na'á ku tokoni ki Seini.

I helped Seini. (Lit. “I helped to Seini”)

tokoni'i is transitive. The person helped becomes a direct object:

Na'á ku tokoni'i 'a Seini.

I helped Seini.

Both sentences translate the same way in English, but the Tongan grammar differs. Without -'i, *tokoni* takes the preposition *ki*. With -'i, *tokoni'i* takes a direct object marked by 'a.

pule (to be in charge, to govern) is intransitive with *ki*:

'Okú ne *pule ki he ngāué*.

He is in charge of the work.

pule'i is transitive:

'Okú ne *pule'i 'a e ngāué*.

He manages the work.

Base verb	Meaning	With -'i	Meaning
<i>tokoni</i>	help (+ <i>ki</i>)	<i>tokoni'i</i>	help (someone directly)
<i>pule</i>	be in charge (+ <i>ki</i>)	<i>pule'i</i>	govern, manage
<i>kole</i> (to request)	request (+ <i>ki</i>)	<i>kole'i</i>	ask for (something specific)
<i>tā</i>	hit, strike	<i>tā'i</i>	hit (something/someone)
<i>maumau</i> (to be broken)	be broken, wasted	<i>maumau'i</i>	break or waste (something)

Connotative differences with and without -'i

Sometimes both forms work with the same noun, but the -'i form carries a subtle shift in meaning toward directness or specificity.

manatu (to remember) without -'i suggests emotional remembering, with longing or nostalgia. It takes *kia* before a person's name:

'Oku ou *manatu* *kia* Lupe.

I remember Lupe. (with feeling, reminiscing)

manatu'i with -'i suggests factual recall. It takes a direct object:

'Oku ou *manatu'i* 'a Lupe.

I remember Lupe. (I can recall her)

teuteu (to prepare) without -'i:

Kuo *teuteu* 'a e vaká.

The boat has been prepared.

teuteu'i with -'i carries a stronger sense of completion or elaboration:

Kuo *teuteu'i* 'a e vaká.

The boat has been decorated. (prepared elaborately, fitted out)

Executive -'i: emphasis on completion

When -'i is added to a verb that is already transitive, the effect is not to create transitivity but to emphasize that the action is carried through to completion.

tāpuni (to close, to shut):

Na'á ku *tāpuni* e katō.

I closed the basket.

tāpuni'i:

Na'á ku *tāpuni'i* e katō.

I closed the basket completely.

With *tāpuni*, you state the action. With *tāpuni'i*, you emphasize that the action was carried through: the basket is not just pushed shut, it is firmly closed.

vahe (to divide):

Na'á ne *vahe* 'a e iká.

She divided the fish.

vahe'i:

Na'á ne vahe'i 'a e iká.

She divided up the fish. (into portions, completely)

The suffix -'aki: "to use as"

When the suffix -'aki is attached to a noun or intransitive verb, it creates a transitive verb meaning "to treat as" or "to use as."

ngāue (work) → *ngāue'aki* (to use)

'Oku mau ngāue'aki 'ene 'u falá.

We are using his mats.

The connection: *ngāue* means "to work," and *ngāue'aki* extends this to "to work with," which naturally becomes "to use." Because *ngāue'aki* is a transitive verb, its postposed subject takes the agent marker 'e:

'Oku ngāue'aki 'e he kau akó 'a e ngaahi tohí.

The students are using the books.

Base word	-'aki verb	Meaning
<i>ngāue</i> (work)	<i>ngāue'aki</i>	to use
<i>sipinga</i> (pattern)	<i>sipinga'aki</i>	to use as a pattern
<i>fai</i> (do)	<i>fai'aki</i>	to manage with, to let suffice

Note:

The suffix -'aki and the prepositional word 'aki covered earlier in this chapter are related but distinct. The suffix is part of the verb (*ngāue'aki* is one word), while the prepositional 'aki is a separate word (*fufulu 'aki*).

Preview: Some verbs form their transitive counterparts with a suffix ending in -a rather than -'i. For example, *lotu* (to pray) becomes *lotua* (to pray for), and *folau* (to voyage) becomes *folaua* (to voyage toward). These -a type suffixes, which often carry a sense of duration or process, are covered formally in Chapter 48: Suffixes.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
'aki	instrumental preposition	with, by means of
-'i	transitive suffix	makes verb transitive
-'aki	suffix	to use as, to treat as
fai'aki	verb (from -'aki)	to manage with, to decide upon

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
tā	verb	hit, strike, chop
ngaohi	verb	make, create
pule	verb	be in charge, govern
maumau	verb	be broken, wasted

Tongan	Type	English
<i>puke</i>	verb	grab, hold, seize (also “sick” (Ch 9))
<i>teuteu</i>	verb	prepare
<i>māfana</i>	adjective	warm
<i>sipinga</i>	noun	pattern, model
<i>fakatātā</i>	noun	example, illustration
<i>matā</i>	verb	watch, observe
<i>lotu'i</i>	verb	pray for (transitive)
<i>tokoni'i</i>	verb	help (transitive, specific person)
<i>langa'i</i>	verb	build (transitive)
<i>fufulu'i</i>	verb	wash (transitive)
<i>fakamā'opo'opo</i>	verb	tidy up

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate into English

1. *Fufulu 'aki e katō e vai māfaná.*
2. *Na'á ku tokoni'i 'a 'Ana.*
3. *'Okú ne pule'i 'a e fale akó.*
4. *'Oku mau ngāue'aki 'ene 'u helé.*
5. *Na'á ku tāpuni'i e katō.*
6. *Kuo teuteu'i e fale lotú.*

Exercise 2: Translate into Tongan

1. I helped Tēvita. (use *tokoni'i*)
2. She divided the fish completely. (use *vahe'i*)
3. We are using his mats. (use *ngāue'aki*)

4. Wash your mat with warm water. (use 'aki after the verb)
5. He manages the work. (use pule'i)
6. They closed the basket. (use tāpuni)

Exercise 3: Rewrite each sentence using the -'i transitive form. Change the ki phrase to a direct object with 'a

1. Na'á ku tokoni ki Lupe.
2. 'Okú ne pule ki he kolō.
3. Na'a mau tokoni ki Tēvita.

Exercise 4: Fill in the blank with 'aki (separate word), -'i (suffix), or -'aki (suffix)

1. Fufulu __ ho falá e vai māfaná. (with, instrument)
2. Na'á ku tokoni__ 'a Mele. (helped, transitive)
3. 'Oku mau ngāue__ 'ene tohí. (using)
4. Na'á ne puke 'a e helé 'o ne tā __ e iká. (with it)
5. Na'á ku tāpuni__ e katō. (closed completely)

Exercise 5: Translate into English. Pay attention to the difference in meaning between each pair

1. 'Oku ou manatu kia Sēmisi.
2. 'Oku ou manatu'i 'a Sēmisi.
3. Kuo teuteu 'a e falé.
4. Kuo teuteu'i 'a e falé.
5. Na'á ku tāpuni 'a e falé.
6. Na'á ku tāpuni'i 'a e falé.

Answers

Exercise 1

1. Wash the basket with warm water.
2. I helped 'Ana.

3. He/she manages the school.
4. We are using his/her knives.
5. I closed the basket (completely, securely).
6. The church has been decorated.

Exercise 2

1. *Na'á ku tokoni'i 'a Tēvita.*
2. *Na'á ne vahe'i 'a e iká.*
3. *'Oku mau ngāue'aki 'ene 'u falá.*
4. *Fufulu 'aki ho falá e vai māfaná.*
5. *'Okú ne pule'i 'a e ngāué.*
6. *Na'a nau tāpuni e katō.*

Exercise 3

1. *Na'á ku tokoni'i 'a Lupe.*
2. *'Okú ne pule'i 'a e kolō.*
3. *Na'a mau tokoni'i 'a Tēvita.*

Exercise 4

1. *'aki* (separate word)
2. *'i* (→ *tokoni'i*)
3. *'aki* (→ *ngāue'aki*)
4. *'aki* (pronominal adverb)
5. *'i* (→ *tāpuni'i*)

Exercise 5

1. I remember Sēmisi (with feeling, nostalgically).
2. I remember Sēmisi (I can recall him, factually).
3. The house has been prepared.
4. The house has been decorated.
5. I closed the house.
6. I closed the house (completely, securely).

Chapter 34: Reported Speech

This chapter introduces ways to report what someone said, thought, or heard: strung clauses without a connective, the verb *pehē* (to say, to think), and the reportative word *tokua* (they say, it is said).

Reporting what you hear, know, or believe

In English, reported speech often uses “that”: “I hear *that* Fiji is beautiful.” Tongan does the same thing more simply: it strings two clauses together with no connecting word at all. The first clause states the act of hearing, knowing, or believing. The second clause states the content.

’Oku ou fanongo ko e kolō lelei ’a Nuku’alofa.

I hear that Nuku’alofa is a good town. (Lit. “Is I hear is a town good Nuku’alofa”)

There is no word for “that” between *fanongo* (*to hear, to listen*) and the second clause. The two clauses sit side by side. The verb *fanongo* signals that what follows is something the speaker heard, not something directly witnessed.

Na’á ku ’ilo ’e tōmui ’a Seini.

I knew that Seini would be late.

Here *'ilo* (*to know*) introduces the reported content. The future tense marker *'e* in the second clause shows that the lateness had not yet happened at the time of knowing.

'Oku ou tui té u fiefia pē.

I believe I will be happy.

The verb *tui* (*to believe*) works the same way. The second clause (*té u fiefia pē*) states what the speaker believes.

This pattern works with any verb of perception or thinking:

Verb	Meaning	Example
<i>fanongo</i>	hear, listen	<i>'Oku ou fanongo ko e tangata mālohi.</i> I hear that Tēvita is a strong man.
<i>'ilo</i>	know	<i>Na'á ku 'ilo 'e foki 'a Mele.</i> I knew Mele would return.
<i>tui</i>	believe	<i>'Oku ou tui 'e lele 'a Sēmisi.</i> I believe Sēmisi will run.

Note:
The second clause keeps its own tense marker. The tense of the reported content does not change to match the first clause. If someone thought something would happen in the future, the future marker *'e* stays, even if the first clause is past tense.

***Pehē*: to say, to think**

The verb *pehē* means “to say” or “to think.” It is one of the most common ways to introduce reported speech.

Na'e pehē 'e Tēvita 'e foki 'a Mele.

Tēvita thought Mele would return.

The structure is: tense marker + *pehē* + 'e phrase (naming the speaker) + reported content. The 'e phrase works the same way as in transitive sentences, marking the person who says or thinks.

'Oku pehē 'e he faiakō té ke nofo heni.

The teacher thinks you will stay here.

When a common noun is the speaker, 'e he introduces it, just as in any transitive sentence.

'Okú ke pehē té ke hela'ia 'i Fisi?

Do you think you will be tired in Fiji?

When the subject is a pronoun, *pehē* takes the regular pronoun position after the tense marker. The accent on 'okú appears because *ke* (a one-syllable pronoun) follows the tense marker.

Speaker type	Pattern	Example
Pronoun	TM + pronoun + <i>pehē</i> + content	<i>'Oku ou pehē 'e 'alu 'a Sione.</i> I think Sione will go.
Name	TM + <i>pehē</i> + 'e + name + content	<i>Na'e pehē 'e Siale 'e ngāue 'a Mele.</i> Siale said Mele would work.
Common noun	TM + <i>pehē</i> + 'e he + noun + content	<i>'Oku pehē 'e he faiakō té ke nofo.</i> The teacher thinks you will stay.

***Pehē* as an adverb: thus, like this, like that**

The word *pehē* has a second, distinct use: as an adverb meaning “thus,” “like this,” or “like that.” In this use it describes the manner of an action, not an act of saying or thinking.

Na'e pehē pē mei he kamata'angá.

It was that way from the beginning.

'Oku pehē pē mo au.

Same here. (Lit. “Is thus only with me”)

Kapau 'oku pehē, té u 'alu au.

If that is the way it is, I will go.

When *pehē* follows a verb, it means “in this way” or “in that way”:

'Oua té ke lea pehē.

Do not talk like that.

***Pehe'i*: to do or treat in this way**

By adding the transitive suffix *-i* (from the previous chapter), *pehē* becomes *pehe'i*. This transitive form means “to do in this way” or “to treat in this way.” It takes an object.

Tohi pehe'i!

Write it like this.

'Oua té ke pehe'i 'a e fefiné!

Do not treat the woman that way.

'Oku pehe'i hono fufulu.

The washing is done this way. (Lit. “Is thus-done its washing”)

Ko e hā 'okú ke pehe'i ai 'a Lupe?

Why do you treat Lupe that way? (Lit. “Is what you treat-thus for-it Lupe?”)

Pehe'i often appears in commands, telling someone to do a task in a particular way:

Tō pehe'i!

Plant it this way.

Tuku pehe'i pē ia!

Leave it the way it is.

***Tokua*: they say, it is said**

The word *tokua* signals that the speaker is reporting something without committing to its truth. It is similar to “they say” or “it is said” in English. It usually appears at the beginning of a sentence.

Tokua kuo foki 'a Sione ki Fisi.

It is said that Sione has returned to Fiji.

'Oku nofo tokua 'i Ha'apai.

She lives, so they say, in Ha'apai.

When *tokua* appears at the start, it colours the whole sentence as secondhand information. When it appears after the verb, it colours only that clause. In both positions, *tokua* tells the listener: this is what others report, not what I personally witnessed.

Na'á ne pehē tokua ko hono 'apí pē.

He said that it was just his own home.

Here *tokua* and *pehē* work together: *pehē* introduces what “he” said, and *tokua* marks the whole report as something the current speaker did not verify.

***Ko ia*: That is it / Therefore**

The phrase *ko ia* has two uses. As a predicative expression, it means “that is it” or “that is all.”

Kó ia.

That is it.

Ko ia pē.

That is all.

As an inferential expression at the beginning of a sentence (followed by a pause), *ko ia* means “therefore” or “that being so.”

Ko ia, na’e ’ikai té u ’alu ki he fakatahá.

Therefore, I did not go to the meeting.

Ko ia, ’oku totonu ke ke nofo ’i ’api.

Therefore, you should stay at home.

***Tā*: the interjection of discovery**

The interjection *tā* appears at the start of a sentence and signals the discovery of something previously unknown, or the emergence of a new fact. It is similar to “So...” or “I see that...” in English, though often it has no exact English equivalent.

Tā né ’ikai té ke ’alu.

So you did not go after all.

Tā ’oku mo’oni.

So it is true. (I see now that it is true.)

Tā carries a sense of surprise or realization. The speaker has just learned or understood something new.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>pehē</i>	verb/adverb	say, think; thus

Tongan	Function	English
<i>pehe'i</i>	transitive form of <i>pehē</i>	say to, do thus to
<i>tokua</i>	reportative word	they say, it is said
<i>ko ia</i>	inferential phrase	therefore, that is why
<i>tā</i>	interjection	so! (discovery) (also “hit” (Ch 33))
<i>'oku pehē</i>	reported speech marker	it is said that, one says

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>mahalo</i>	verb	think, suppose
<i>'amanaki</i>	verb	hope, expect
<i>fakapapau</i>	verb	confirm, make certain
<i>fakahā</i>	verb	reveal, make known
<i>talanoa</i>	verb	chat, converse

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate into English

1. *'Oku ou fanongo ko e tangata ngāue mālohi 'a Sēmisi.*
2. *Na'e pehē 'e 'Ana 'e ha'u 'a Mele.*
3. *Tokua kuo 'alu 'a Siale ki Vava'u.*
4. *'Oua té ke pehe'i e tamasi'i!*
5. *Tā 'oku fiefia 'a Lupe.*
6. *Ko ia, na'á ku nofo pē 'i 'api.*
7. *'Oku pehē 'e he faiaikō 'e lele 'a e fānau.*
8. *Na'e pehē pē mei he kamata'angá.*

Exercise 2: Translate into Tongan

1. I hear that Tēvita is a good teacher.
2. Sione thought Mele would work.
3. It is said that Lupe has gone to Fiji.
4. Do not talk like that.
5. Therefore, you should study.
6. So he is strong after all.
7. Do you think you will be tired?
8. Write it like this.

Exercise 3: Choose pehē (say/think), pehē (thus/like this), or pehe'i (do/treat in this way)

Decide which form fits each blank and write the complete sentence.

1. Na'e ____ 'e Sione 'e ha'u 'a Mele. (Sione thought Mele would come.)
2. 'Oua té ke ____ e fefiné! (Do not treat the woman that way.)
3. 'Oku ____ pē mo au. (Same here.)
4. 'Oku ou ____ 'e 'alu 'a Tēvita. (I think Tēvita will go.)
5. Fufulu ____! (Wash it like this.)
6. Kapau 'oku ____, té u foki au. (If that is the way it is, I will return.)

Exercise 4: Add tokua or tā to the beginning of each sentence and translate

1. Kuo 'alu 'a Sēmisi ki Ha'amoā. (reportative)
2. 'Oku mo'oni. (discovery)
3. Na'e 'ikai té ke foki. (discovery)
4. Kuo ngāue 'a Mele 'i he falekoloa. (reportative)

Answers**Exercise 1**

1. I hear that Sēmisi is a hardworking man.
2. 'Ana said Mele would come.

3. It is said that Siale has gone to Vava'u.
4. Do not treat the boy that way.
5. So Lupe is happy (after all).
6. Therefore, I just stayed at home.
7. The teacher thinks the children will run.
8. It was that way from the beginning.

Exercise 2

1. 'Oku ou fanongo ko e faiako lelei 'a Tēvita.
2. Na'e pehē 'e Sione 'e ngāue 'a Mele.
3. Tokua kuo 'alu 'a Lupe ki Fisi.
4. 'Oua té ke lea pehē.
5. Ko ia, 'oku totonu ké ke ako.
6. Tā 'okú ne mālohi.
7. 'Okú ke pehē té ke hela'ia?
8. Tohi pehe'i!

Exercise 3

1. Na'e **pehē** 'e Sione 'e ha'u 'a Mele. (say/think: introduces reported speech with 'e phrase)
2. 'Oua té ke **pehe'i** e fefiné! (treat in this way: transitive, takes object *e fefiné*)
3. 'Oku **pehē** pē mo au. (thus: adverbial, means "same here")
4. 'Oku ou **pehē** 'e 'alu 'a Tēvita. (think: introduces reported speech with pronoun subject)
5. Fufulu **pehe'i**! (do in this way: transitive command)
6. Kapau 'oku **pehē**, té u foki au. (thus: adverbial, means "like this/that")

Exercise 4

1. Tokua kuo 'alu 'a Sēmisi ki Ha'amoā. It is said that Sēmisi has gone to Samoa.
2. Tā 'oku mo'oni. So it is true.
3. Tā na'e 'ikai té ke foki. So you did not return after all.
4. Tokua kuo ngāue 'a Mele 'i he falekoloa. It is said that Mele has been working at the store.

Chapter 35: Adjectives and Compound Adjectives

This chapter covers how adjectives attach to nouns to describe them directly: their position after the noun, special adjectives that precede the noun, how to combine two adjectives for emphasis, the intensifier *fu'u*, and color words. It then covers how Tongan builds compound adjectives by joining two words, including the *loto* compounds used for emotional states.

Attributive adjectives after the noun

An adjective is a word that describes a noun: what kind, what size, what quality. In earlier chapters, adjectives appeared in the verb slot (*'okú ne mālohi*, he is strong). When an adjective sits next to a noun and describes it directly, it is called an attributive adjective.

In Tongan, the standard position for an attributive adjective is after the noun.

ha me'a lahi. a big thing

ha tangata mālohi. a strong man

ha fale fo’ou. a new house

The noun comes first, the adjective follows. This is the opposite of English word order (“a big thing” vs. *ha me’a lahi*, literally “a thing big”).

’Oku ou fiema’u ha kato lahi.

I want a big basket.

Na’á ku fakatau mai ha vaka fo’ou.

I bought a new boat.

More examples of postposed adjectives:

Tongan	English
<i>ha me’a si’i</i>	a small thing
<i>ha tohi fo’ou</i>	a new book
<i>ha fale kovi</i>	a bad house
<i>ha tangata masiva</i>	a poor man

Adjectives before the noun

A few adjectives go before the noun instead of after it. These words take the preposed position (for *’uluaki* this is the usual construction, though it can also follow the noun, as in *ko e kalasi ’uluaki* = the first class):

fu’u (big, large) *ki’i* (small, little) *’uluaki* (first) *mu’aki* (first in time, former, early)
toe (other, additional)

ha fu’u fale. a big house

ha ki’i tamasi’i. a small boy

ha ’uluaki me’a. the first thing

ha mu’aki tu’i. a former king

ha toe me’a. another thing (an additional thing)

Note:

The word *toe* means “additional” or “more of the same kind.” The word *kehe* (different) is postposed: *ha me’a kehe* = a different thing. To say “another thing of a different kind,” combine them: *ha toe me’a kehe*.

Double adjectives: preposed and postposed together

When you want extra emphasis on size, you can use a preposed adjective and a postposed adjective together on the same noun. The preposed word goes before the noun, the postposed word goes after it. The two adjectives reinforce each other.

ha fu’u me’a lahi. a great big thing

ha ki’i me’a si’i. a little tiny thing

ha fu’u fale lahi. a very big house

Na’á ku sio ki ha fu’u vaka lahi.

I saw a very big boat.

The pattern is: article + preposed adjective + noun + postposed adjective. This combination intensifies the description beyond what either adjective alone would convey.

***Fu’u* as intensifier and tree classifier**

The word *fu’u* has two uses beyond its role as a preposed adjective meaning “big.”

Size intensifier: Before an adjective or adverb, *fu’u* intensifies the meaning, similar to “really” or “very much.”

fu’u lahi. really big, very much

fu’u lelei. really good

Na’e fu’u lele lahi ’a e tangata mālohí.

The strong man really ran too fast.

'Oku fu'u hela'ia 'a Mele.

Mele is really tired.

Tree classifier: Before a plant name, *fu'u* means “the whole tree or plant” (as opposed to a single fruit). Compare this with *fo'i*, which you learned as a classifier for single round objects.

fu'u

(tree/plant)

fo'i

(single fruit)

fu'u mango

a mango tree

fo'i mango

a mango (fruit)

fu'u niu

a coconut palm

fo'i niu

a coconut

fu'u mei

a breadfruit tree

fo'i mei

a breadfruit

Na'e tō 'a e fu'u niu he matangí.

The coconut palm fell in the wind.

'Oku ou fiema'u ha fo'i mango, kae 'ikai ko e fu'u mango.

I want a mango (fruit), not a mango tree.

Colors

Tongan color words function as both nouns and postposed adjectives. As adjectives, they follow the same pattern as any postposed adjective: noun + color.

Common colors:

Tongan	English
<i>hinehina</i>	white
<i>'uli'uli</i>	black
<i>kulokula</i>	red
<i>lanumata</i>	green
<i>engeenga</i>	yellow

'Oku ou fiema'u e vala hinehiná.

I want the white clothing.

Ko fē e kato 'uli'ulí?

Where is the black basket?

Na'á ku fakatau mai ha sote kulokula.

I bought a red shirt.

When a color adjective is the last word in a definite noun phrase, the definitive accent falls on its final vowel, just as with any other postposed adjective:

e sote hinehiná. the white shirt

e tupenu 'uli'ulí. the black lava-lava

e kato kulokulá. the red basket

Note:

Color words can also stand alone as nouns. *Ko e hinehina* = It is white (referring to the color itself). *'Oku ou sai'ia 'i he kulokulá* = I like the red (color).

The adjective patterns above all involve single words placed before or after the noun. Tongan also builds compound adjectives by joining two words into a single describing expression.

Compound adjectives

Tongan builds compound adjectives by joining two words. Three patterns are common.

Noun + adjective: The first word is a noun (naming a body part, a quality, or a domain), the second is a simple adjective. Together they describe a characteristic.

Compound	Literal meaning	English
<i>sino-mālohi</i>	body-strong	strong-bodied
<i>sino-vaivai</i>	body-weak	weak-bodied
<i>anga-lelei</i>	behaviour-good	well-behaved, good-natured
<i>anga-kovi</i>	behaviour-bad	ill-behaved

Ko e tangata sino-mālohi 'a Tēvita.

Tēvita is a strong-bodied man.

'Oku anga-lelei 'a e fānau.

The children are well-behaved.

Verb + noun: The first word is a verb, the second is its object noun. Together they describe someone by what they habitually do.

Preview: Verbs used as adjectives appear here as part of compound adjectives. This pattern is covered formally in Chapter 41: Word Class Flexibility. Observe how a verb and its object combine into a single describing word: *ha tangata tau* = a fighting man (a soldier), where *tau* (to fight) acts as an adjective after the noun.

ha tangata ngāue. a working man

Verb + adverb: The first word is a verb, the second is an adverb or adverbial element. These are written as one word.

Compound	Literal meaning	English
<i>faingofua</i>	do-easily	easy
<i>faingata’a</i>	do-difficultly	difficult
<i>tu’umālie</i>	stand-well	prosperous, well-off
<i>tu’utāmaki</i>	stand-badly	unfortunate, in adversity

’Oku *faingofua* ’a e ngāué.

The work is easy.

’Oku *faingata’a* ’a e akó.

The studying is difficult.

Preview: Nouns used as adjectives also occur in Tongan: *ha sipi tangata* = a male sheep (a ram), where *tangata* (man) describes the sheep. This pattern is covered formally in Chapter 41: Word Class Flexibility. Notice that nouns can describe other nouns when placed after them.

Loto compounds: emotional states

The noun *loto* (mind, heart, spirit) combines with adjectives to form compound words describing emotional or character states. These compounds function as adjectives (and, like all Tongan adjectives, can appear in the verb slot with a tense marker).

Compound	Literal meaning	English
<i>loto lelei</i>	mind-good	agreeable, willing
<i>loto mamahi</i>	mind-painful	sad, upset
<i>loto to’a</i>	mind-brave	courageous
<i>loto lahi</i>	mind-big	brave, bold, eager

Compound	Literal meaning	English
<i>loto 'ofa</i>	mind-loving	affectionate, kind
<i>loto kovi</i>	mind-bad	malicious, ill-disposed
<i>loto fo'i</i>	mind-defeated	cowardly

'Oku ou loto mamahi 'i he me'a ko iá.

I am upset about that.

'Ai ké ke loto lelei!

Work on being agreeable. (Lit. "Make that you heart-good")

'Oua té ke loto fo'i!

Do not be a coward.

Ko e tamasi'i loto to'a 'a Sēmisi.

Sēmisi is a courageous boy.

'Oku loto lahi 'a Mele ké ne 'alu.

Mele is eager to go.

These compounds follow all the standard patterns: they can appear after a noun (*ha tangata loto lahi* = a brave man), in the verb slot (*'oku ou loto mamahi* = I am upset), and with the full range of tense markers.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>fu'u</i>	preposed intensifier / tree classifier	very big; a ... tree

Tongan	Function	English
<i>mu'aki</i>	preposed adjective	first, former, early
<i>angé</i>	postposed comparative	more (comparative)
<i>tahá</i>	postposed superlative	most (superlative)

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>kovi</i>	adjective	bad
<i>hinehina</i>	adjective (color)	white
<i>'uli'uli</i>	adjective (color)	black
<i>kulokula</i>	adjective (color)	red
<i>lanumata</i>	adjective (color)	green
<i>engeenga</i>	adjective (color)	yellow
<i>sino-mālohi</i>	compound adjective	strong-bodied
<i>sino-vaivai</i>	compound adjective	weak-bodied
<i>anga-lelei</i>	compound adjective	well-behaved, good-natured
<i>anga-kovi</i>	compound adjective	ill-behaved
<i>faingofua</i>	compound adjective	easy
<i>faingata'a</i>	compound adjective	difficult
<i>tu'umālie</i>	compound adjective	prosperous
<i>tu'utāmaki</i>	compound adjective	unfortunate
<i>loto mamahi</i>	compound (loto)	sad, upset
<i>loto to'a</i>	compound (loto)	courageous
<i>loto lahi</i>	compound (loto)	brave, eager

Tongan	Type	English
<i>loto 'ofa</i>	compound (loto)	affectionate, kind
<i>loto kovi</i>	compound (loto)	malicious
<i>loto fo'i</i>	compound (loto)	cowardly
<i>tupenu</i>	noun	waist-cloth, lava-lava
<i>'akau</i>	noun	tree, plant
<i>mei</i>	noun	breadfruit (also “from” (Ch 7))
<i>maka</i>	noun	stone, rock

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate into English

1. *'Oku ou fiema'u ha fale fo'ou.*
2. *Ko fē e tohi 'uli'ulí?*
3. *Na'e fu'u lahi 'a e fu'u niu.*
4. *Ha ki'i me'a si'i pē.*
5. *Na'á ku fakatau mai ha sote hinehina.*

Exercise 2: Translate into Tongan

1. I want the red basket.
2. Where is the black book?
3. Mele is really tired.
4. A great big boat.

Exercise 3: Choose the correct adjective position

Place the adjective in the correct position (before or after the noun) and write the complete phrase.

1. ____ me'a ____ (lahi: big)

2. ____ fale ____ (fu'u: big)
3. ____ tamasi'i ____ (ki'i: small)
4. ____ me'a ____ (kehe: different)
5. ____ tohi ____ ('uluaki: first)
6. ____ me'a ____ (toe: additional)

Exercise 4: Fu'u: intensifier or tree?

Translate each phrase and state whether *fu'u* is used as a size intensifier or a tree classifier.

1. *fu'u mango*
2. *fu'u lahi*
3. *fu'u niu*
4. *fu'u lelei*
5. *fu'u mei*
6. *fu'u hela'ia*

Exercise 5: Translate into English

1. *Ko e tangata sino-mālohi 'a Pita.*
2. *'Oku loto mamahi 'a Seini.*
3. *'Oku faingofua 'a e akó.*

Exercise 6: Translate into Tongan

1. Sione is a well-behaved man.
2. The work is difficult.
3. Do not be a coward.
4. Tēvita is eager to go.

Exercise 7: Build loto compounds

Complete each sentence with the correct *loto* compound and translate.

1. *'Oku ou ____ 'i he me'a na'e hoko.* (sad/upset about what happened)
2. *Ko e tangata ____ 'a Sione.* (courageous man)
3. *'Ai ké ke ____!* (be agreeable)
4. *'Oua té ke ____!* (do not be cowardly)

5. 'Oku ____ 'a Lupe ké ne ako. (eager to study)

Answers

Exercise 1

1. I want a new house.
2. Where is the black book?
3. The coconut palm was really big.
4. Just a little tiny thing.
5. I bought a white shirt.

Exercise 2

1. 'Oku ou fiema'u e kato kulokulá.
2. Ko fē e tohi 'uli'ulí?
3. 'Oku fu'u hela'ia 'a Mele.
4. Ha fu'u vaka lahi.

Exercise 3

1. *ha me'a lahi* (postposed: standard adjective)
2. *ha fu'u fale* (preposed: *fu'u* always goes before the noun)
3. *ha ki'i tamasi'i* (preposed: *ki'i* always goes before the noun)
4. *ha me'a kehe* (postposed: *kehe* is a standard adjective)
5. *ha 'uluaki tohi* (preposed: the usual construction for *'uluaki*, though it can also follow the noun, as in *ko e kalasi 'uluaki*)
6. *ha toe me'a* (preposed: *toe* always goes before the noun)

Exercise 4

1. *fu'u mango*. a mango tree (tree classifier)
2. *fu'u lahi*. really big (size intensifier)
3. *fu'u niu*. a coconut palm (tree classifier)
4. *fu'u lelei*. really good (size intensifier)
5. *fu'u mei*. a breadfruit tree (tree classifier)

6. *fu'u hela'ia*. really tired (size intensifier)

Exercise 5

1. Pita is a strong-bodied man.
2. Seini is upset.
3. The studying is easy.

Exercise 6

1. *Ko e tangata anga-lelei 'a Sione*.
2. *'Oku faingata'a 'a e ngāué*.
3. *'Oua té ke loto fo'i!*
4. *'Oku loto lahi 'a Tēvita ké ne 'alu*.

Exercise 7

1. *'Oku ou loto mamahi 'i he me'a na'e hoko*. I am upset about what happened.
2. *Ko e tangata loto to'a 'a Sione*. Sione is a courageous man.
3. *'Ai ké ke loto lelei!* Work on being agreeable.
4. *'Oua té ke loto fo'i!* Do not be a coward.
5. *'Oku loto lahi 'a Lupe ké ne ako*. Lupe is eager to study.

Chapter 36: Cleft Sentences and Emphatic Word Order

Every verbal sentence pattern covered so far places the verb first: *na'e kai 'e Sione e fo'i molí* (Sione ate the orange). This chapter shows how to move the subject to the front for emphasis, producing a structure similar to “It was Sione who ate the orange.”

Moving the subject to the front: transitive verbs

In a verbal sentence, standard Tongan word order puts the verb first. The subject follows, marked by 'e:

Na'e kai 'e Tēvita e fo'i niú.

Tēvita ate the coconut.

The focus falls naturally on the action. To shift the focus to who performed it, move the subject to the front with *ko*. A pronoun then appears after the tense marker to represent the displaced subject:

Ko Tēvita na’á ne kai e fo’i niú.

It was Tēvita who ate the coconut.

Both sentences describe the same event. The first stresses the action. The second stresses the person: Tēvita, and no one else. This construction is called a cleft sentence.

The full pattern:

ko + subject + tense marker + pronoun + verb + object

Ko Mele na’á ne fufulu ’a e valá.

It was Mele who washed the clothes.

Preview: The pronoun *ne* in this pattern refers back to *Mele*. This is a relative use of the cardinal pronoun, where *ne* functions like “who” within the cleft sentence. The broader use of cardinal pronouns in relative clauses is covered in Chapter 51: Special Pronoun Uses. The cleft construction is the pattern to learn.

The pronoun must match the subject:

Ko au na’á ku ’ave ’a e kató.

It was I who carried the basket.

Ko kinautolu na’a nau tohi ’a e tohí.

It was they who wrote the letter.

Standard word order	Cleft (emphatic) word order
<i>Na’e kai ’e Sēmisi e mā.</i>	<i>Ko Sēmisi na’á ne kai ’a e mā.</i>
Sēmisi ate the bread.	It was Sēmisi who ate the bread.
<i>Na’e ’ave ’e ’Ana ’a e falá.</i>	<i>Ko ’Ana na’á ne ’ave ’a e falá.</i>
’Ana carried the mat.	It was ’Ana who carried the mat.

Note:

The tense marker accent follows the usual convention. Before the one-syllable pronoun *ne*, accent the tense marker: *na’á ne*. Before *ku*: *na’á ku*. Before the two-syllable pronoun *nau*, no accent: *na’a nau*.

Moving the subject to the front: intransitive verbs

With intransitive verbs and adjectives used as verbs, no pronoun is needed to repeat the subject. The tense marker connects directly to the verb:

Ko Pita ’oku ngāue heni.
It is Pita who works here.

Ko e fānau na’e hiva.
It was the children who sang.

Standard word order	Cleft (emphatic) word order
<i>’Oku ngāue ’a Pita heni.</i>	<i>Ko Pita ’oku ngāue heni.</i>
Pita works here.	Pita (and no one else) works here.
<i>Na’e tangi ’a e ki’i tamasi’i.</i>	<i>Ko e ki’i tamasi’i na’e tangi.</i>
The little boy cried.	It was the little boy who cried.

Adding emphasis with *ia* and *foki*

The pronoun *ia* placed after the subject in a cleft sentence reinforces the identity of the person being highlighted:

Ko e fefine ia na’e ’ita.
She was the woman who was angry.

Ko e ki’i tamasi’i ia na’e tangi.

He was the little boy who cried.

The word *foki* (also) placed after the subject contributes a similar emphatic effect:

Ko e tangata foki na'e lea.

He was also the man who spoke.

Note:

The word *ia* also has a separate adverbial use where it suggests that what happened differed from what was expected. *Na'e ha'u 'a Mele ia* can mean “Mele came” with the implication that her coming was surprising or contrary to expectations. This contrastive shade of *ia* is distinct from the emphatic *ia* in cleft sentences.

“That’s why” with *ko e me’a ia ... ai*

The phrase *ko e me’a ia* (literally “that is the thing”) combined with *ai* after the verb expresses “that’s why” or “that’s the reason”:

Ko e me’a ia 'oku ou loto mamahi ai.

That’s why I am upset.

Ko e me’a ia na’á ku ha'u ai.

That’s the reason I came.

Ko e me’a ia 'okú ne ngāue ai.

That’s why he works.

The word *ai* refers back to *ko e me’a ia*, occupying the same slot after the verb where *ai* appears in other patterns you have learned.

When *ko e me’a ia* points to a specific thing rather than expressing “that’s why,” the clause often contains *ki ai*:

Ko e me’a ia 'oku 'ikai té u loto ki ai.

That’s the thing I don’t agree to.

Emphatic equational sentences

You learned equational sentences with *ko* in Chapter 16: Equational Sentences. The standard order places the predicate first and the subject after *’a*: *Ko e tangata mālohi ’a Pita* (Pita is a strong man). To emphasize the subject instead, reverse the order and introduce the predicate with a second *ko*:

Predicate first (standard)	Subject first (emphatic)
<i>Ko e tangata mālohi ’a Pita.</i>	<i>Ko Pita ko e tangata mālohi.</i>
Pita is a strong man.	Pita (and no one else) is a strong man.
<i>Ko e faiako au.</i>	<i>Ko au ko e faiako.</i>
I am a teacher.	I (specifically) am a teacher.

Ko Lātū ko e pule lahi.
Lātū is the high authority.

The standard order stresses what the person is. The reversed order stresses who the person is.

Leaving out “whom,” “which,” and “that”

Ko e fefine eni na’á ku ’iló.
This is the woman whom I found. (Lit. “Is the woman this I found”)

The English sentence uses *whom* to tie the description back to *the woman*. Tongan has no equivalent: the slot where the object would normally go simply stays empty. *’Ilo* (to know, to find) usually takes an object, but here the object IS the noun being described (*fefine*), so it is not repeated. The definitive accent on *’iló* marks where the description ends.

Ko e tohi eni na’a nau laú.

This is the book that they read.

Ko e kato eni na’á ne ’avé.

This is the basket that he carried.

Ko e ika eni na’á ku kaí.

This is the fish that I ate.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>ko e me’a ia ... ai</i>	cleft phrase	that is the reason ... (lit. that is the thing ... therefore)

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>faka’amu</i>	verb	desire, wish for
<i>loto</i>	verb	want, be willing
<i>foki</i>	particle	also, too (emphatic, placed after the subject; distinct from the verb <i>foki</i> “return”)

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate into English

- 1. *Ko Sione na’á ne ’ave ’a e iká.*

2. *Ko e fefine ia na'e hiva.*
3. *Ko e me'a ia 'oku ou 'ita ai.*
4. *Ko Seini ko e faiako.*
5. *Ko e tangata eni na'á ku 'iló.*
6. *Ko kinautolu na'a nau fufulu 'a e valá.*
7. *Ko e me'a ia na'á ne ha'u ai.*
8. *Ko Lupe 'oku ako heni.*

Exercise 2: Rewrite in emphatic (cleft) word order

Rewrite each sentence to emphasize the subject.

1. *Na'e tohi 'e Tēvita 'a e tohí.*
2. *'Oku ngāue 'a Mele heni.*
3. *Na'e lea 'a e faiako.*
4. *Na'e kai 'e Pita e mā.*
5. *'Oku hiva 'a e fānau.*
6. *Na'e 'ave 'e Sēmisi 'a e falá.*

Exercise 3: Translate into Tongan

1. It was 'Ana who drank the tea.
2. That's why he came.
3. This is the book that I read.
4. Mele (and no one else) is a teacher.
5. It was the children who sang.
6. That's the reason I am here.

Exercise 4: Complete with ko e me'a ia ... ai

Fill in the blanks to express “that's why” or “that's the reason.”

1. ____ 'oku ou hela'ia ____.
2. ____ na'á ne 'alu ____.
3. ____ 'oku nau ngāue mālohi ____.
4. ____ na'á ku fanongo ____.

Exercise 5: Fill in the blank

Choose the correct word to complete each sentence.

1. Ko Sione ____ ne kai 'a e mā. (*na'á / na'e / 'e*)
2. Ko e tangata ____ na'e 'ita. (*ia / ai / eni*)
3. Ko e me'a ia 'oku ou loto mamahi _____. (*ia / ai / eni*)
4. Ko e me'a ____ 'oku ou hela'ia ai. (*ia / eni / foki*)
5. Ko Mele ____ e faiako. (*'a / ko e / 'e*)
6. Ko e ika eni na'á ku _____. (*kaí / kai / 'ita*)

Answers**Exercise 1**

1. It was Sione who carried the fish.
2. She was the woman who sang.
3. That's why I am angry.
4. Seini (and no one else) is a teacher.
5. This is the man whom I found.
6. It was they who washed the clothes.
7. That's the reason he came.
8. It is Lupe who studies here.

Exercise 2

1. *Ko Tēvita na'á ne tohi 'a e tohí.*
2. *Ko Mele 'oku ngāue heni.*
3. *Ko e faiako na'e lea.*
4. *Ko Pita na'á ne kai 'a e mā.*
5. *Ko e fānau 'oku hiva.*
6. *Ko Sēmisi na'á ne 'ave 'a e falá.*

Exercise 3

1. *Ko 'Ana na'á ne inu e tī.*

2. *Ko e me'a ia na'á ne ha'u ai.*
3. *Ko e tohi eni na'á ku laú.*
4. *Ko Mele ko e faiako.*
5. *Ko e fānau na'e hiva.*
6. *Ko e me'a ia 'oku ou 'i heni ai.*

Exercise 4

1. *Ko e me'a ia 'oku ou hela'ia ai.*
2. *Ko e me'a ia na'á ne 'alu ai.*
3. *Ko e me'a ia 'oku nau ngāue mālohi ai.*
4. *Ko e me'a ia na'á ku fanongo ai.*

Exercise 5

1. *na'á.* the tense marker *na'a* takes an acute accent before the one-syllable pronoun *ne*
2. *ia.* the emphatic pronoun reinforcing the subject's identity
3. *ai.* refers back to *ko e me'a ia*
4. *ia.* completing the set phrase *ko e me'a ia ... ai*
5. *ko e.* the second *ko* introduces the predicate in an emphatic equational sentence
6. *kaí.* a transitive verb with the definitive accent marking the end of the relative clause; *'ita* (angry) is intransitive and would not take an unexpressed object

Chapter 37: Postposed Possessives

Possessives so far have been preposed: *'eku tohi* (my book), *'ene tohi* (his book). This chapter introduces possessive pronouns that go after the noun, used to emphasize ownership: “That book is MINE.”

Postposed possessives: 'e-class

The 'e-class preposed possessives (*'eku*, *ho'o*, *'ene...*) express who acts upon or controls something. The postposed 'e-class forms carry the same meaning, but they follow the noun and add emphasis to the possessor.

Ko e kato ia 'a'aku.

That basket is mine.

The word *'a'aku* means “mine” in the 'e-class. It is built from two parts: the possessive preposition *'a* (marking 'e-class), reduplicated, plus the pronoun. Think of *'a'aku* as “of-of-me,” stressing that the thing belongs to the speaker.

The singular forms:

Postposed form	Meaning	Built from
<i>'a'aku</i>	mine	<i>'a + 'a + ku</i>
<i>'a'au</i>	yours (sg.)	<i>'a + 'a + u</i>
<i>'a'ana</i>	his/hers/its	<i>'a + 'a + na</i>

Ko e hele ia 'a'au.

That knife is yours.

Ko e me'a ia 'a'ana.

That thing is his.

The dual and plural forms follow a regular pattern without redoubling:

Postposed form	Meaning
<i>'ataua</i>	ours (dual inclusive)
<i>'amaua</i>	ours (dual exclusive)
<i>'amoua</i>	yours (dual)
<i>'anaua</i>	theirs (dual)
<i>'atautolu</i>	ours (plural inclusive)
<i>'amautolu</i>	ours (plural exclusive)
<i>'amoutolu</i>	yours (plural)
<i>'anautolu</i>	theirs (plural)

Ko e fala ia 'amautolu.

That mat is ours (exclusive).

Ko e me'a ia 'amoutolu.

That thing is yours (plural).

Postposed possessives: ho-class

The ho-class covers things that shelter, characterize, or define you (*hoku fale*, my house). The postposed ho-class forms use the possessive preposition 'o instead of 'a.

The singular forms:

Postposed form	Meaning	Built from
'o'oku	mine	'o + 'o + ku
'o'ou	yours (sg.)	'o + 'o + u
'o'ona	his/hers/its	'o + 'o + na

Ko e fale ia 'o'oku.

That house is mine.

Ko e vala ia 'o'ou.

Those clothes are yours.

Ko e kofu ia 'o'ona.

That dress is hers.

The dual and plural forms:

Postposed form	Meaning
'otaua	ours (dual inclusive)
'omaua	ours (dual exclusive)
'omoua	yours (dual)
'onaua	theirs (dual)
'otautolu	ours (plural inclusive)
'omautolu	ours (plural exclusive)

Postposed form	Meaning
<i>'omoutolu</i>	yours (plural)
<i>'onautolu</i>	theirs (plural)

Ko e fatongia ia 'omautolu.

That responsibility is ours (exclusive).

Note:

The choice between 'e-class and ho-class follows the same rules taught in earlier chapters. Use 'e-class (*'a'aku*, *'a'au...*) for things you control or act upon (food, money, tools, animals). Use ho-class (*'o'oku*, *'o'ou...*) for things that shelter or define you (house, clothes, body parts, relatives).

Asking “whose?”: *'a hai* and *'o hai*

To ask “whose?” with an 'e-class noun, use *'a hai*:

Ko e hele eni 'a hai?

Whose knife is this?

Ko e kato eni 'a hai?

Whose basket is this?

To ask “whose?” with a ho-class noun, use *'o hai*:

Ko e fale eni 'o hai?

Whose house is this?

Ko e vaka eni 'o hai?

Whose boat is this?

Ko e fatongia 'o hai ke fakama'a e 'api?

Whose responsibility is it to clean the yard?

The *hai* is the interrogative word “who.” Combined with the possessive preposition (*’a* or *’o*), it asks who the possessor is.

Question	Class	Example
<i>’a hai?</i>	<i>’e</i> -class	<i>Ko e pa’anga eni ’a hai?</i> (Whose money is this?)
<i>’o hai?</i>	<i>ho</i> -class	<i>Ko e kofu eni ’o hai?</i> (Whose dress is this?)

Adding emphasis to a possessor

Hono soté.

His shirt.

Hono soté ’ona.

HIS shirt (not anyone else’s).

A noun can carry both a preposed and a postposed possessive at the same time. In the first sentence, *hono* alone tells you the shirt is his. In the second, the postposed *’ona* (the short form of *’o’ona*) repeats that ownership and pushes the stress onto the owner. Use this when the question on the table is *whose*, not *what*. The postposed half (*’ona*, *’aku*, *’au*, and so on) is called a *pronominal adjective*, because it sits after the noun the way an adjective does.

Note:
The shorter forms (*’aku*, *’au*, *’ana*, *’oku*, *’ou*, *’ona*) drop the reduplicated syllable. They are interchangeable with the longer forms in most contexts; when a possessive is already in front of the noun and you are tacking another on for emphasis, the shorter form is more common.

’Eku pa’angá ’aku.

MY money (emphasizing that it is mine).

Ho'o tohi 'au.

YOUR book (emphasizing that it is yours).

The definitive accent in *hono soté* falls on the last vowel before the postposed form, as it does for any definite noun.

Standing in as the verb: “This is his”

'Oku 'a'ana eni.

This is his. (lit. “Is his this”)

'Oku 'o'ona eni.

This is his. (ho-class)

In these sentences, the postposed possessive takes a tense marker and acts as the verb of the sentence. This is the same trick adjectives use in Tongan, where *masiva* (poor) and *fiefia* (happy) take tense markers directly without needing an English-style “is.” It is called the *predicative* use of the postposed possessive (*predicative* = standing in the position of the verb).

Both sentences above mean “This is his,” but the class differs. Use *'a'ana* when talking about something the person controls ('e-class), and *'o'ona* for something that characterizes them (ho-class).

'Oku 'a'aku 'a e kató.

The basket is mine.

'Oku 'o'oku 'a e falé.

The house is mine.

The shorter forms work the same way:

'Oku 'ana eni.

This is his.

'Oku 'ona eni.

This is his. (ho-class)

Predicative ('e-class)	Predicative (ho-class)	Meaning
'Oku 'a'aku eni.	'Oku 'o'oku eni.	This is mine.
'Oku 'a'au eni.	'Oku 'o'ou eni.	This is yours.
'Oku 'a'ana eni.	'Oku 'o'ona eni.	This is his/hers.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
'a'aku	postposed possessive ('e-class)	mine
'a'au	postposed possessive ('e-class)	yours
'a'ana	postposed possessive ('e-class)	his/hers
'atautolu	postposed possessive ('e-class)	ours (inclusive)
'amautolu	postposed possessive ('e-class)	ours (exclusive)
'amoutolu	postposed possessive ('e-class)	yours (plural)
'anautolu	postposed possessive ('e-class)	theirs
'o'oku	postposed possessive (ho-class)	mine
'o'ou	postposed possessive (ho-class)	yours
'o'ona	postposed possessive (ho-class)	his/hers
'otautolu	postposed possessive (ho-class)	ours (inclusive)
'omautolu	postposed possessive (ho-class)	ours (exclusive)
'omoutolu	postposed possessive (ho-class)	yours (plural)
'onautolu	postposed possessive (ho-class)	theirs

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>fatongia</i>	noun	responsibility, duty
<i>fakama'a</i>	verb	clean, make clean

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English

1. *Ko e hele eni 'a'aku.*
2. *Ko e fale ia 'o'ona.*
3. *Ko e kato eni 'a hai?*
4. *'Oku 'a'au 'a e tohi.*
5. *Ko e vala ia 'o'ou.*
6. *Hono valá 'ona.*
7. *Ko e me'a ia 'amautolu.*
8. *Ko e fatongia 'o hai ke kuki e me'akai?*

Exercise 2: Translate English to Tongan

1. That mat is mine. ('e-class)
2. Whose house is this?
3. This is hers. ('e-class, predicative)
4. HIS book. (pronominal adjective, emphasizing possessor)
5. The money is yours. (predicative)
6. That basket is theirs (plural). ('e-class)
7. Whose clothes are these?
8. The boat is ours (exclusive). (ho-class)

Exercise 3: Choose the correct class

Fill in the blank with the correct postposed possessive ('e-class or ho-class).

1. *Ko e pa'anga ia ____.* (mine)
2. *Ko e fale ia ____.* (yours, sg.)

3. Ko e fanga sipi ia _____. (his)
4. Ko e kofu ia _____. (hers)
5. Ko e tohi ia _____. (ours, excl. plural)
6. Ko e vaka ia _____. (theirs, plural)

Exercise 4: Rewrite with pronominal adjective for emphasis

Add the pronominal adjective to emphasize the possessor.

1. 'Eku kato → _____ (MY basket)
2. Ho vaka → _____ (YOUR boat)
3. Hono fale → _____ (HIS house)
4. 'Ene hele → _____ (HER knife)

Exercise 5: Answer the question

Answer each question using a postposed possessive, as shown in the example.

Example: *Ko e tohi eni 'a hai?* → *Ko e tohi ia 'a'aku.*

1. *Ko e kato eni 'a hai?* (mine)
2. *Ko e fale eni 'o hai?* (hers)
3. *Ko e vala eni 'o hai?* (yours, sg.)
4. *Ko e hele eni 'a hai?* (theirs, plural)
5. *Ko e pa'anga eni 'a hai?* (ours, excl. plural)

Answers

Exercise 1

1. This knife is mine.
2. That house is his/hers.
3. Whose basket is this?
4. The book is yours.
5. Those clothes are yours.
6. HIS clothes (emphatic).
7. That thing is ours (exclusive).
8. Whose responsibility is it to cook the food?

Exercise 2

1. *Ko e fala ia 'a'aku.*
2. *Ko e fale eni 'o hai?*
3. *'Oku 'a'ana eni.*
4. *'Ene tohi 'ana.*
5. *'Oku 'a'au e pa'angá.*
6. *Ko e kato ia 'anautolu.*
7. *Ko e vala eni 'o hai?*
8. *Ko e vaka ia 'omautolu.*

Exercise 3

1. *'a'aku* (money is 'e-class: you control it)
2. *'o'ou* (house is ho-class: it shelters you)
3. *'a'ana* (animals are 'e-class: you act upon them)
4. *'o'ona* (clothing is ho-class: it characterizes you)
5. *'amautolu* (books are 'e-class: you act upon them)
6. *'onautolu* (boats are ho-class: a vessel carries and shelters you, like a house)

Exercise 4

1. *'Eku kató 'aku*
2. *Ho vaká 'ou*
3. *Hono falé 'ona*
4. *'Ene helé 'ana*

Exercise 5

1. *Ko e kato ia 'a'aku.*
2. *Ko e fale ia 'o'ona.*
3. *Ko e vala ia 'o'ou.*
4. *Ko e hele ia 'anautolu.*
5. *Ko e pa'anga ia 'amautolu.*

Chapter 38: Warnings, Hopes, Permissions, and Uncertainty

This chapter introduces a set of expressions built around the subordinator *ke* (taught in Chapter 26: Purpose, Reason, and Benefit) that let you grant permission, express hopes, and issue warnings. These are social expressions that come up frequently in daily conversation.

Granting permission: *tuku ke*

The verb *tuku* has several ordinary meanings: to put down, to leave, to stop. When followed by *ke*, it takes on the special meaning of “let” in the sense of “allow” or “permit.”

Tuku ke 'alu 'a e fefiné.

Let the woman go.

The structure is *tuku ke* + verb + subject (or pronoun). The *ke* signals that what follows is the thing being allowed.

Tuku ké u fakamahino atu.

Let me explain it to you.

Tuku ke 'alu ia.

Let him go.

When a pronoun follows *ke*, the verb comes after the pronoun:

Tuku ke nau ō kinautolu.

Let them go.

Tuku ké ke nofo heni.

Let yourself stay here.

This *tuku ke* is “let” only in the sense of “allow.” It does not work for “let” as a suggestion or command (for that, Tongan uses other structures covered in Chapter 5: Commands and Emphasis, such as *tau hiva*, “let us sing”).

Note: *Tuku ke* can also appear in negative commands. The prohibitive *'oua* combines with *tuku ke* to forbid allowing something: *'Oua te mou tuku ke lele noa'ia e fanga puaká* (Do not let the pigs run around loose).

Expressing hopes: *'ofa ke* and *'ofa pē ke*

The verb *'ofa* ordinarily means “to love.” In a special construction with *ke*, it expresses a wish or hope, equivalent to English “may” or “I hope that.”

'Ofa ke mo'ui lelei 'a e fonuá ni.

May this country prosper. (Lit. “Love that be-well the country”)

Adding *pē* between *'ofa* and *ke* gives the expression a warmer, more earnest tone, often translated as “I hope that” or “let us hope that.”

'Ofa pē ke tau a'usia e ta'u fo'ou.

May we all live until the new year.

'Ofa pē ke mou fiefia 'i homau ki'i motú.

May you all be happy on our little island.

'Ofa pē can also be followed by a tense marker instead of *ke*, to express hope about something that may already be true or may have happened:

'Ofa pē 'oku 'ikai puke.

I hope he is not sick.

'Ofa pē kuo nau a'u ki ai.

I hope they have arrived there.

'Ofa pē té ne foki lelei mai.

I hope he will come back safe and sound.

Note:

The formal variant *tauange ke* carries a similar meaning but is more hortative (urging or exhorting). *Tauange ké ke mo'ui 'o 'aonga ki he fonuá.* (May you live to be of service to the country.) You may encounter this in speeches and written Tongan.

Warnings: suggestive *na'a*

The word *na'a* has appeared before as a past tense marker (*na'á ku kai*, I ate). In this chapter, *na'a* serves a completely different function: it introduces a warning or caution, meaning “lest” or “or else.”

Lele mai na'á ke tōmui.

Run here or you will be late. (Lit. “Run hither lest you be late”)

The warning pattern is: command or statement + *na'a* + the thing to be avoided. The speaker is saying “do this, because otherwise that bad thing might happen.”

Fakalelei'i 'a e valá na'a maumau he halá.

Fix the clothes lest they get ruined on the road.

Mou tokanga lelei na'a hoko ha fakatu'utāmaki.

You all be very careful lest some disaster occur.

Hola na’á ke lavea.

Run away lest you get hurt.

When a pronoun immediately follows *na’a*, only context tells you whether this is the tense marker or the warning word. In a warning, *na’a* follows a command or advice and introduces a consequence to avoid.

Uncertainty: *na’a* as “perhaps”

The same word *na’a* can also express uncertainty, meaning “perhaps” or “maybe.” In this use, *na’a* stands at the beginning of its clause and is followed by a tense marker or *ko*.

Na’a kuó ke hela.

Perhaps you are tired.

Na’a ko hono falé ení.

Perhaps this is his house.

Na’a kuo ’osi ho’o pa’angá.

Perhaps you have no more money.

Na’a ’oku mo’oní ia.

Perhaps he is right.

The difference between the two uses is position and function. The warning *na’a* follows a command and introduces a feared outcome. The “perhaps” *na’a* begins a clause and introduces an uncertain possibility.

Use	Position	Meaning	Example
Warning	After a command	lest, or else	<i>Ako mālohi na’á ke tō he sivi.</i>

Use	Position	Meaning	Example
Uncertainty	Beginning of clause, before TM or ko	perhaps, maybe	<i>Na’a kuó ne puke.</i>

Stronger warning: **telia na’a**

For a more emphatic warning, *telia na’a* replaces the simple *na’a*. The meaning is identical (“lest”), but the phrasing is stronger and more deliberate.

Mou ako mālohi, teliá na’a mou tō he sivi.

Study hard, lest you fail the exam.

Fakalelei’i ’a e kaá telia na’a maumau he halá.

Fix the car well lest it break down on the road.

’Oua té ke mohe, teliá na’a li’aki koe.

Do not sleep, lest you be left behind.

Tokanga ki ho’o tohi teliá na’a mole.

Take care of your book lest it be lost.

Note: Telia na’a and the simple warning na’a are interchangeable in meaning. Telia na’a adds weight and formality.

Respect and deference: **telia** alone

The word *telia* without *na’a* takes a different meaning entirely: “for the sake of” or “out of respect for.”

’Ai homou ta’ovala telia ’a Nuku.

Put on your ta’ovalas out of respect for Nuku.

Kuo fai eni 'e he tu'í telia 'a e fonuá.

The king has done this for the sake of the country.

This *telia* expresses deference or consideration. The speaker is explaining why something should be done (or was done), and the reason is respect or concern for someone or something.

***Fai mo ke* (hurry up and)**

Fai mo ke 'alu!

Hurry up and go.

The imperative expression *fai mo ke* (*hurry up and, get a move on and*) urges someone to act quickly. The structure is *fai mo ke* + verb. It always addresses the second person.

Fai mo ke faka'osi 'o ka tau ō!

Hurry and finish so we can go.

Fai mo ke ngāue na'a po'ulí!

Get a move on and work before it gets dark.

When addressing multiple people, or when including the speaker, *ke* changes to match the audience. *Fai mo tau ō!* (Come on, let us go) uses the inclusive first person plural *tau* instead of *ke*.

Adverbs of uncertainty: *nai*, *'apē*, and *koā*

The expressions in this chapter (warnings, hopes, permissions) share a common thread: the speaker is not simply stating facts but hedging, hoping, or urging caution. Three postposed adverbs operate in the same space, marking uncertainty or requesting a clearer response. Unlike the preposed modifiers taught in earlier chapters, these come after the verb or at the end of the clause.

Nai: *I wonder*

Nai adds a tone of wondering or gentle uncertainty. In questions, it softens the directness.

'Oku 'i fē nai 'a Siale?

I wonder where Siale is.

Té ke fie 'alu nai?

I wonder whether you would like to go.

'Oku toko fiha nai ho'o fānau?

How many children do you have? (polite, softened)

'Apē: *perhaps, I guess*

'Apē introduces conjecture or a gentle suggestion. It is normally avoided directly after the interrogatives *hai* and *fē*, though *hā*-initial questions such as *Ko e hā 'apē...?* (“what could the reason be?”) do occur.

'E ha'u 'apē 'a e vakapuná 'apongipongi?

Is the airplane coming tomorrow? (I guess it might)

'Oku kei ngāue 'apē 'a 'Ana pe 'ikai?

Does 'Ana still work or not?

Ko e hā 'apē 'a e me'a 'oku 'ita ai 'a e pulé?

Why is the boss angry? (what could the reason be)

Koā: *please tell me*

Koā requests a definite answer or expresses suspense. It carries a sense of “tell me” or “really.”

Té ke ha'u koā pe 'ikai?

Are you coming or not? (I need a clear answer)

'Oku nofo koā heni 'a Sione?

Does Sione live here? (please tell me)

Ko e hā koā e me’a te tau fai?
What on earth are we going to do?

The idiom *’ikai koā* introduces a fact, like “as a matter of fact” or “to tell you the truth”:
’ikai koā na’á ku ’osi tala ange ke ’oua te nau ō mai.
Why, I told them not to come.

Adverb	Meaning	Position	Tone
<i>nai</i>	I wonder, perhaps	postposed	gentle uncertainty
<i>’apē</i>	perhaps, I guess	postposed	conjecture, suggestion
<i>koā</i>	please tell me	postposed	requests definite answer

Note:
The adverb *tokaange* (undoubtedly, it will come to pass) is used in positive predictions: *Tokaange pē ha ’aho te tau fe’iloaki ai* (There is certain to be a day when we meet). Recognise it when you encounter it, but it is not as frequent as the adverbs above.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>tuku ke</i>	permission phrase	let, allow
<i>’ofa ke</i>	optative phrase	may, I hope that
<i>na’a</i>	warning word	lest, or else; perhaps (also “marks an action as past” (Ch 1))

Tongan	Function	English
<i>telia na’a</i>	emphatic warning	lest (stronger)
<i>telia</i>	preposition	for the sake of, out of respect for
<i>fai mo ke</i>	imperative phrase	hurry up and
<i>nai</i>	postposed adverb	I wonder, perhaps
<i>’apē</i>	postposed adverb	perhaps, I guess
<i>koā</i>	postposed adverb	please tell me, is it really

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>siví</i>	noun	exam, test
<i>kā</i>	noun	car
<i>ta’ovala</i>	noun	waist mat (formal wear)
<i>fakakaukau</i>	verb	think, consider
<i>a’u</i>	verb	arrive, reach
<i>tauange</i>	verb	may (formal)
<i>tokaange</i>	adverb	undoubtedly

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English

- Tuku ke ’alu e tamasi’i.*
- ’Ofa pē ke mou mo’ui lelei.*

3. *Ngāue mālohi na'á ke masiva.*
4. *Na'a kuó ne puke.*
5. *Mou fanongo lelei, teliá na'a mou hala.*
6. *'Ofa pē kuo nau a'u ki ai.*
7. *Tuku ké ke nofo heni.*
8. *'Ai ho valá telia 'a e kakaí.*

Exercise 2: Translate English to Tongan

1. Let the children play.
2. May you be happy.
3. Hurry lest you be late.
4. Perhaps she is tired.
5. Study hard, lest you fail the exam.
6. I hope they are well.
7. Let me help.
8. The king did this for the sake of the people.

Exercise 3: Choose the correct expression

Fill in the blank with *tuku ke*, *'ofa pē ke*, *na'a*, or *telia na'a*.

1. ____ 'alu 'a e fefiné. (Let the woman go.)
2. Lele mai ____ ke tōmui. (Run here or you'll be late.)
3. ____ mou fiefia. (May you all be happy.)
4. ____ kuó ne hela. (Perhaps he is tired.)
5. Ako mālohi, ____ mou tō he sivi. (Study hard, lest you fail.)
6. ____ nau ō kinautolu. (Let them go.)

Exercise 4: Warning or uncertainty?

For each sentence, state whether *na'a* means “lest/or else” (warning) or “perhaps/maybe” (uncertainty).

1. *Ako mālohi na'á ke tō he sivi.*
2. *Na'a kuo 'osi e me'akaí.*
3. *Ha'u vave na'a 'osi 'a e kavaí.*
4. *Na'a ko 'Ana ia.*

5. *Mohe mu'a na'a ke hela 'apongipongi.*

Exercise 5: Transform sentences

Rewrite each command by adding a warning clause with *telia na'a*.

Example: *Ako mālohi.* → *Ako mālohi, telia na'a ke tō he sivi.*

1. *Tokanga ki ho'o pa'angá.* (lest it be lost)
2. *Fakalelei'i 'a e vaká.* (lest it break on the sea)
3. *Ha'u vave.* (lest the food be gone)
4. *Ngāue mālohi.* (lest the boss be angry)

Exercise 6: Translate into Tongan using fai mo ke

1. Hurry up and eat!
2. Hurry up and study!
3. Hurry up and come!
4. Come on, let us sing!
5. Hurry up and run!

Exercise 7: Fill in the blank: nai, 'apē, or koā

Choose the adverb that matches the tone described in brackets.

1. *Té ke ha'u ___ pe 'ikai?* [requesting a definite answer]
2. *'E ha'u ___ 'a e vakapuná 'apongipongi?* [gentle conjecture]
3. *'Oku 'i fē ___ 'a Mele?* [wondering]
4. *Ko e hā ___ 'a e me'a 'oku 'ita ai 'a e pulé?* [what could the reason be]
5. *'Oku toko fiha ___ ho'o fānau?* [polite, softened]
6. *'Oku nofo ___ heni 'a Sione pe 'ikai?* [I need a clear answer]

Exercise 8: Mixed Adverb Review

Each sentence below contains a blank. Choose the correct adverb from the box.
Each adverb is used once.

Word bank: *loko, teitei, toutou, ai pē, meimei, matu'aki, lahi pē, nai, 'apē, koā*

1. *'Oku ___ tangi 'a e pēpē.* (the baby cries repeatedly)
2. *Na'a ku ___ tō 'i he halá.* (I almost fell on the road)
3. *Ko e ha'u 'eni 'o 'Isileli ___ ki heni.* (Isileli comes here as always)

4. 'Oku 'ikai ke ____ sai e ngāué. (the work is not quite good)
5. 'Oku 'i fē ____ 'a ho'o tohí? (I wonder where your book is)
6. 'E 'ikai té u ____ 'alu ki ai. (I will not go there at all)
7. 'Oku ____ mālohi 'a e falé ni. (this house is extremely strong)
8. 'Oku ____ nofo 'a Siosaia 'i Nuku'alofa. (Siosaia lives mostly in Nuku'alofa)
9. Té ke ō ____ pe 'ikai? (are you going or not: I need an answer)
10. 'E lava ____ 'o fai 'a e ngāué 'apongipongi? (can the work perhaps be done tomorrow)

Answers

Exercise 1

1. Let the boy go.
2. May you all be well.
3. Work hard or you will be poor.
4. Perhaps he is sick.
5. Listen carefully, lest you go wrong.
6. I hope they have arrived there.
7. Let yourself stay here.
8. Put on your clothes out of respect for the people.

Exercise 2

1. Tuku ke va'inga e fānau.
2. 'Ofa pē ké ke fiefia.
3. Vave mai na'á ke tōmui.
4. Na'a kuó ne hela.
5. Mou ako mālohi, telia na'a mou tō he sivi.
6. 'Ofa pē 'oku nau mo'ui lelei.
7. Tuku ké u tokoni.
8. Kuo fai eni 'e he tu'í telia 'a e kakaí.

Exercise 3

1. *Tuku ke 'alu 'a e fefiné.*
2. *Lele mai na'á ke tōmui.*
3. *'Ofa pē ke mou fiefia.*
4. *Na'a kuó ne hela.*
5. *Ako mālohi, telia na'a mou tō he sivi.*
6. *Tuku ke nau ō kinautolu.*

Exercise 4

1. Warning (follows a command, introduces feared consequence)
2. Uncertainty (begins clause, before tense marker *kuo*)
3. Warning (follows a command, introduces feared consequence)
4. Uncertainty (before *ko*, introduces uncertain identification)
5. Warning (follows advice, introduces feared consequence)

Exercise 5

1. *Tokanga ki ho'o pa'angá, teliá na'a mole.*
2. *Fakalelei'i 'a e vaká, teliá na'a maumau he tahi.*
3. *Ha'u vave, teliá na'a 'osi e me'akaí.*
4. *Ngāue mālohi, teliá na'a 'ita 'a e pulé.*

Exercise 6

1. *Fai mo ke kai!*
2. *Fai mo ke ako!*
3. *Fai mo ke ha'u!*
4. *Fai mo tau hiva!*
5. *Fai mo ke lele!*

Exercise 7

1. *koā*
2. *'apē*
3. *nai*
4. *'apē*

5. *nai*

6. *koā*

Exercise 8

1. *toutou*

2. *meimei*

3. *ai pē*

4. *loko*

5. *nai*

6. *teitei*

7. *matu'aki*

8. *lahi pē*

9. *koā*

10. *'apē*

Chapter 39: Relative Clauses with *Ai* and Demonstratives

This chapter expands two grammar areas that appeared in basic form earlier: the back-reference word *ai* and the demonstrative system. Two useful expressions, *na'a mo* (even) and *kae'uma'a* (and also), round out the chapter.

***Ai* in relative clauses**

The word *ai* appeared earlier as a back-reference meaning “there” or “in it,” and in the existential expression *'oku 'i ai* (there is). *Ai* also serves a connecting function: it links a descriptive clause back to a noun in the main clause, much as English uses “where,” “in which,” or “that...in.”

Ko e falé eni 'okú ne ngāue ai.

This is the house he works in. (Lit. “Is the house this he works in-it”)

The *ai* at the end refers back to *fale*. Without it, the clause would leave the listener asking “works where?” *Ai* completes the connection: he works in THIS house.

Ko e koló ia na’á ku nofo ai.
That is the village I lived in.

Ko e tamasi’í ia na’á ku lea ki ai.
That is the boy I spoke to.

In the third example, *ki ai* keeps the preposition *ki* visible while *ai* stands in for the noun. The same applies with *mei*:

Ko e motú ia na’á ku ha’u mei ai.
That is the island I came from.

The pattern: a *ko* clause introduces a noun, and the descriptive clause that follows uses *ai* (or *ki ai*, *mei ai*) to refer back to it.

Without back-reference	With <i>ai</i>
<i>’Oku nau nofo ’i he koló.</i> (They live in the village.)	<i>Ko e koló eni ’oku nau nofo ai.</i> (This is the village they live in.)
<i>’Okú ne ngāue ’i he falé.</i> (He works in the house.)	<i>Ko e falé eni ’okú ne ngāue ai.</i> (This is the house he works in.)
<i>Na’á ku lea ki he tamasi’í.</i> (I spoke to the boy.)	<i>Ko e tamasi’í ia na’á ku lea ki ai.</i> (That is the boy I spoke to.)

Note:
Bare *ai* replaces phrases with *’i*. When the original phrase uses *ki* or *mei*, the preposition remains: *ki ai*, *mei ai*.

All the pointing words in one place

Earlier chapters introduced demonstratives for place (*heni, hena, hē*) and for identifying nouns (*ni, na, eni, ē*). The table below gathers all of them in one place, grouped by who they refer to (me, you, both, or something already mentioned) and by how they fit into a sentence.

	Near me (1st)	Near you (2nd)	Pointing	Mentioned (3rd)
After noun (enclitic)	<i>ni</i>	<i>na</i>	–	–
Pronoun	<i>eni</i>	<i>ena</i>	<i>ē</i>	<i>ia</i>
After <i>’i/ki/mei</i>	<i>heni</i>	<i>hena</i>	<i>hē</i>	–
“Like this/that”	<i>peheni</i>	<i>pehena</i>	<i>pehē</i>	–

Near me: *ni, eni, heni, peheni*

These forms refer to what is near the speaker or in the speaker’s current focus. *Ni* is an enclitic (a small word that leans on the word before it and shifts its stress forward): *fále* becomes *falé ni*.

’I he falé ni ’oku mau lotu ai.
In this house we pray.

Nofo heni.
Stay here.

Near you: *na, ena, hena, pehena*

These forms refer to what is near the listener. *Na* is also an enclitic: *fále* becomes *falé na*.
Ho valá na ’oku lelei ’aupito.

Those clothes of yours are very nice.

Ko ho’o kató ena ’i he loki.
There (near you) is your basket in the room.

Pointing: ē, hē, pehē

The speaker uses these to point at something, whether physically or in imagination. They are not tied to a particular person.

Ko e hā ē?

What is that? (pointing)

Tuku hē.

Put it there. (where I am pointing)

Mentioned: ia

The pronoun *ia* refers to something already mentioned or being discussed, detached from both speaker and listener.

Ko ia pē.

That is all.

When *ko ia* begins a sentence followed by a pause, it means “therefore” or “that being so” (covered in Chapter 24: Conjunctions):

Ko ia, na’e ’ikai té u ’alu ki he fakatahá.

That being so, I did not go to the meeting.

Ko’eni with days of the week

The form *ko’eni* specifies the current instance of something. With days of the week, it means “this” day of the current week.

Té u ’alu ki he māketi he Falaite ko’eni.

I will go to the market this Friday.

Tongan	English
<i>Mōnite</i>	Monday

Tongan	English
<i>Tūsīte</i>	Tuesday
<i>Pulelulu</i>	Wednesday
<i>Tu’apulelulu</i>	Thursday
<i>Falaite</i>	Friday
<i>Tokonaki</i>	Saturday
<i>Sāpate</i>	Sunday

Eni as “now”

Beyond its pronoun use, *eni* works as an adverb meaning “now,” especially when a situation has changed or is being contrasted with an earlier state.

’Oku ou nofo eni ’i Pangai.

Now I live at Pangai.

The related enclitic *ni* also carries a “now” sense, but is lighter and less emphatic:

Ko ’eku toki a’u mai ni.

I have just arrived.

Ko ’eku toki a’u mai eni.

I have only just now arrived. (More emphatic)

Pehē as “thus” or “like this”

The manner demonstrative *pehē* also functions as an adjective meaning “of this kind” or “such,” and as an adverb meaning “in this way” or “thus.” Its compan-

ions *peheni* and *pehena* work the same way, oriented toward speaker and listener respectively.

Ha me'a pehē.

A thing like that. / Such a thing.

Fai pehē.

Do it like that.

'Oua té ke fai peheni.

Do not do it like this.

Note:

This demonstrative *pehē* must not be confused with the verb *pehē* (to say, to think) covered in Chapter 34: Reported Speech. The verb takes an agent phrase: *Na'á ne pehē...* (He said...). The demonstrative describes manner or type.

Two additional expressions

Na'a mo (e): even

The expression *na'a mo* before a pronoun or name (or *na'a mo e* before a common noun with an article) means “even” or “even with.”

Na'a mo ia, he 'ikai té ne lava.

Even he cannot.

Na'a mo Mele, na'e 'ikai fie ha'u.

Even Mele did not want to come.

Na'a mo e 'ahó ni 'oku kei puke pē 'a Tēvitá.

Even today Tēvita is still just sick.

Kae’uma’a: and also, not to mention

Kae’uma’a adds emphasis to an additional item, meaning “and also,” “not to mention,” or “as well.”

’Oku ou tokoni kia Tēvita kae’uma’a hono fāmilí.
I help Tēvita and also his family.

Mou tokanga ki he ngāué kae’uma’a ’a e akó.
Pay attention to work and also to school.

Kae’uma’a ha’ane ’ita ’iate ia.
Not to mention his anger at her.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>ai</i> (in relative clauses)	relative connector	where, in which, that ... in
<i>peheni</i>	manner demonstrative	like this
<i>pehena</i>	manner demonstrative	like that (near you)
<i>na’a mo</i>	emphatic phrase	even
<i>kae’uma’a</i>	conjunction	not to mention, let alone

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>māketi</i>	noun	market
<i>tokanga</i>	verb	pay attention
<i>kau mātu'a</i>	noun phrase	elders

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English

1. *Ko e falé eni 'oku ou nofo ai.*
2. *'Oku ou ngāue eni 'i Nuku'alofa.*
3. *Na'a mo Sēmisi, na'e 'ikai fie tokoni mai.*
4. *Ko ia, na'a ku nofo pē 'i 'api.*
5. *Ko e tamasi'i ia na'a ku lea ki ai.*
6. *Mou fai peheni.*
7. *'Oku ou sai'ia 'i he fonuá ni kae'uma'a hono kakaí.*
8. *Te mau 'alu ki he lotú he Sāpate ko'eni.*

Exercise 2: Translate English to Tongan

1. This is the village they live in.
2. Now I live at Neiafu.
3. Even he cannot.
4. That is the island I came from.
5. Pay attention to the children and also to the elders.
6. Do it like that.
7. That being so, she stayed at home.
8. I will go to the market this Wednesday.

Exercise 3: Combine into one sentence using *ai*

Rewrite each pair as a single sentence with *ai* (or *ki ai*, *mei ai*).

Example: *Ko e falé eni. 'Oku ou nofo 'i he fale.* → *Ko e falé eni 'oku ou nofo ai.*

1. *Ko e falé ia. Na'á ku ngāue 'i he fale.*
2. *Ko e tangatá eni. 'Okú ne tokoni ki he tangata.*
3. *Ko e koló ia. Na'á ku ha'u mei he kolo.*
4. *Ko e fale lotú eni. 'Oku mau lotu 'i he fale lotu.*
5. *Ko e me'á ia. Na'á ku fakakaukau ki he me'a.*

Exercise 4: Fill in the correct demonstrative

Choose from: *ní, na, eni, ena, ē, ia, heni, pehē*

1. *'I he 'ahó ____ 'oku ou ngāue.* (this day = today)
2. *Ko ____!* (There it is, pointing)
3. *Fai ____.* (Do it like that.)
4. *Ko ____ pē.* (That is all.)
5. *Nofo ____.* (Stay here.)
6. *Ko ho'o kató ____ 'i he loki.* (There is your basket, near you, in the room.)

Exercise 5: Translate sentences with na'a mo and kae'uma'a

1. Even I did not want to go.
2. I help the children and also the elders.
3. Even the teacher did not want to help.
4. Not to mention his laziness.
5. Even today the work is not yet finished.

Answers

Exercise 1

1. This is the house I live in.
2. Now I work in Nuku'alofa.
3. Even Sēmisi did not want to help.
4. That being so, I just stayed at home.
5. That is the boy I spoke to.
6. Do it like this (you all).
7. I like this country and also its people.

8. We will go to church this Sunday.

Exercise 2

1. *Ko e koló eni 'oku nau nofo ai.*
2. *'Oku ou nofo eni 'i Neiafu.*
3. *Na'a mo ia, he 'ikai té ne lava.*
4. *Ko e motú ia na'á ku ha'u mei ai.*
5. *Mou tokanga ki he tamaikí kae'uma'a 'a e kau mātu'á.*
6. *Fai pehē.*
7. *Ko ia, na'á ne nofo pē 'i 'api.*
8. *Té u 'alu ki he māketi he Pulelulu ko'eni.*

Exercise 3

1. *Ko e falé ia na'á ku ngāue ai.*
2. *Ko e tangatá eni 'okú ne tokoni ki ai.*
3. *Ko e koló ia na'á ku ha'u mei ai.*
4. *Ko e fale lotú eni 'oku mau lotu ai.*
5. *Ko e me'á ia na'á ku fakakaūkau ki ai.*

Exercise 4

1. *ni*
2. *ē*
3. *pehē*
4. *ia*
5. *heni*
6. *ena*

Exercise 5

1. *Na'a mo au, na'e 'ikai té u fie 'alu.*
2. *'Oku ou tokoni ki he tamaikí kae'uma'a 'a e kau mātu'á.*
3. *Na'a mo e faiakó, na'e 'ikai fie tokoni.*
4. *Kae'uma'a ha'ane fakapikopiko.*
5. *Na'a mo e 'ahó ni 'oku te'eki ai 'osi 'a e ngāué.*

Chapter 40: Spatial Nouns

Word Study

This chapter teaches a set of nouns that Tongan places before other nouns to express precise spatial relationships: inside, under, on top of, in front of, and beside.

Where English uses prepositions (“inside the box,” “under the table”), Tongan uses spatial nouns placed directly before the noun they locate. The spatial noun and the following noun form a tight compound, and the whole compound fits into the sentence with a preposition like *’i* (at/in) or *ki* (to/toward).

The basic pattern:

’i he + spatial noun + noun (with definitive accent on the final noun)

’i he loto katō. inside the basket (Lit. “at the interior basket”)

The spatial noun *loto* (inside) goes before *kato* (basket). The definitive accent falls on the last vowel: *katō*. The preposition *’i he* signals location.

A shorter form is also common. The compound of spatial noun + noun can act as a single location word, taking *’i* or *he* directly:

’i loto falé. inside the house

he funga tēpilé. on top of the table

Both the full form (*'i he loto falé*) and the short form (*'i loto falé*) are correct and interchangeable.

The following household and location words appear frequently in spatial expressions:

Tongan	English
<i>puha</i>	box, chest
<i>tēpile</i>	table
<i>sea</i>	chair
<i>mohenga</i>	bed
<i>hala</i>	road, path
<i>matatahi</i>	beach

Loto: inside, interior

Loto placed before a noun means “inside” that thing.

Na’e tuku ’a e helé ’i loto falé.

The knife was put inside the house.

Na’a mau va’inga ’i loto koló.

We played in the center of the village.

Na’e tō ’a Mele he loto vai.

Mele fell right in the middle of the water.

Note:

You already know *loto* from compound adjectives like *loto mamahi* (upset) and *loto lelei* (agreeable), where it means “heart” or “spirit.” As a spatial noun before another noun, *loto* means “inside” or “interior.” Context makes the meaning clear: *loto fale* = inside the house (spatial), *loto mamahi* = upset at heart (emotional).

Lalo: under, underneath

Lalo before a noun means “under” or “below” that thing.

Na’á ku ’ilo hoku hele ’i hoku lalo mohengá.

I found my knife under my bed.

’Oku nofo ’a e iká he lalo maká.

The fish stay under the rocks.

Na’e tuku ’a e pa’angá he lalo falá.

The money was put under the mat.

’Oku nau inu kava he lalo mangō.

They are drinking kava under the mango tree.

Note:

Before nouns denoting trees, *lalo* sometimes changes to *lolo*: *’i he lalo mangó* or *’i he lolo mangó* (under the mango tree). Both forms are correct.

Tu’a: outside, behind

Tu’a before a noun means “outside of” or “behind” that thing.

Na’á ku tu’u pē he tu’a falé.

I stood just outside the house.

’Oku tatali ’a Sēmisi mei tu’a koló.

Sēmisi is waiting from outside of town.

’Oku nofo he tu’a koló.

He lives on the outskirts of town.

The preposition *mei* (from) combines naturally with *tu'a*: *mei tu'a koló* = from outside of town.

Mui: end, space behind

Mui before a noun means “at the end of” or “at the far side of.”

'I he mui tēpilé. At the end of the table

'Oku 'alu 'a Tēvita ki mui fonuá.

Tēvita has gone to the cape. (Lit. “to the end of the land”)

Quick Practice A: *loto, lalo, tu'a, mui*

Choose the right spatial noun for each blank.

1. *'Oku 'i __ falé 'a e tamasi'í.* The boy is inside the house.
2. *'Oku 'i __ tēpilé 'a e helé.* The knife is under the table.
3. *Na'á ku tu'u he __ falé.* I stood outside the house.
4. *Na'a mau 'alu ki __ koló.* We went to the far end of the village.
5. *Na'e va'inga 'a e tamaikí 'i __ koló.* The children played in the center of the village.

Answers: 1. *loto*. 2. *lalo*. 3. *tu'a*. 4. *mui*. 5. *loto*

Mata: front

Mata before a noun means “in front of.” It is used most naturally with buildings, villages, and groups of trees.

'Oku nofo mai 'a e fefiné mei he mata falé.

The woman is sitting in front of the house. (Lit. “sits hither from the front of the house”)

Na'a mau tali pē he mata koló.

We waited on the outskirts of the village.

Note:

In other contexts, *mata* means “face” or “eye” and takes *’o*: *mata ’o e tangatá* (the man’s face). As a spatial noun before buildings and places, no *’o* is needed.

***Funga*: top, surface**

Funga before a noun means “on top of” or “on the surface of.”

’Oku tuku ’a e tohí he funga tēpilé.

The book is placed on top of the table.

Na’a mau nofo pē he funga vaká.

We stayed on deck. (Lit. “on top of the boat”)

Tuku he funga katō!

Put it on top of the basket.

***Tafa’aki*: side**

Tafa’aki before a noun means “at the side of” or “beside.”

’Oku tu’u ’a e fu’u ’akau he tafa’aki falé.

The tree stands by the side of the house.

Hū mai he tafa’aki ko eé!

Enter from that side over there.

Nofo hifo he tafa’aki ’o Tēvita!

Sit down by the side of Tēvita.

Ve'e: beside, at ground level

Ve'e before a noun means "right beside" that thing, at ground or floor level.

Tali mai he ve'e halá!

Wait for me by the roadside.

'Oku tuku ia he ve'e falé.

It is by the side of the house.

'Oku nau nofo he ve'e matatahí.

They live right by the beach.

Na'á ma fetaulaki he ve'e fale koloá.

We (two) met by the side of the store.

Note: Ve'e is a variant of va'e (leg, foot). As a spatial noun, ve'e means "beside." For the physical leg of furniture, use va'e with 'o: *va'e 'o e tēpilé* (the leg of the table).

Quick Practice B: mata, funga, tafa'aki, and ve'e

Choose the right spatial noun for each blank.

1. *'Oku tuku 'a e tohí he __ tēpilé.* The book is on top of the table.
2. *'Oku nofo 'a Mele he __ falé.* Mele is sitting beside the house.
3. *Na'a mau tatali he __ falé.* We waited in front of the house.
4. *Na'á ku tu'u he __ matatahí.* I stood right by the beach.
5. *'Oku tuku 'a e me'akaí he __ falá.* The food is placed on top of the mat.

Answers: 1. *funga.* 2. *tafa'aki.* 3. *mata.* 4. *ve'e.* 5. *funga*

Summary of spatial nouns

Spatial noun	Meaning	Example
<i>loto</i>	inside	<i>ʻi loto falé</i>
<i>lalo</i>	under	<i>he lalo tēpilé</i>
<i>tu’a</i>	outside, behind	<i>he tu’a falé</i>
<i>mui</i>	end	<i>ʻi he mui tēpilé</i>
<i>mata</i>	front	<i>he mata falé</i>
<i>funga</i>	top, surface	<i>he funga tēpilé</i>
<i>tafa’aki</i>	side	<i>he tafa’aki falé</i>
<i>ve’e</i>	beside	<i>he ve’e halá</i>

Quick Practice C: Translate the spatial expressions

Translate each Tongan compound to English.

- 1. *ʻi loto vaká.* ____
- 2. *he funga falá.* ____
- 3. *he lalo tēpilé.* ____
- 4. *he tu’a koló.* ____
- 5. *he mui fonuá.* ____
- 6. *he ve’e matatahí.* ____

Answers: 1. inside the boat; 2. on top of the mat; 3. under the table; 4. outside the village; 5. at the end of the land; 6. right by the beach

Spatial nouns with people

When the noun after a spatial noun is a person or living animal, the spatial noun cannot go directly before the name. A preposition must appear between them. With things (spatial noun goes directly before the noun):

’i he lalo tēpilé. under the table
he tu’a falé. outside the house
With people (a preposition is inserted):
’i he tu’a ’o e fefiné. behind the woman
’i he funga ’o ’ene fa’ee. on his mother’s lap (Lit. “on the surface of his mother”)
Before proper names, the personal preposition *’ia* is used:
ki mu’a ’ia Sione. ahead of Sione
The rule: with things, the spatial noun goes directly before the noun. With people, insert *’o* (before a common noun with its article) or *’ia* (before a proper name).

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>loto</i>	spatial noun	inside, interior (also “want” (Ch 36))
<i>lalo</i>	spatial noun	under, underneath
<i>tu’a</i>	spatial noun	outside, behind
<i>mui</i>	spatial noun	end, space behind
<i>mata</i>	spatial noun	front
<i>funga</i>	spatial noun	top, surface
<i>tafa’aki</i>	spatial noun	side
<i>ve’e</i>	spatial noun	beside, at the foot of
<i>mu’a</i>	spatial noun	front, ahead of (esp. of people) (also “please” (Ch 5))

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>puha</i>	noun	box, chest
<i>tēpile</i>	noun	table
<i>sea</i>	noun	chair
<i>mohenga</i>	noun	bed
<i>matatahi</i>	noun	beach
<i>fale koloa</i>	noun	store, shop
<i>tatali</i>	verb	wait
<i>fetaulaki</i>	verb	meet
<i>va’e</i>	noun	leg, foot

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English

- 1. *Na’e tuku ’a e valá ’i loto katō.*
- 2. *’Oku tuku ’a e tohí he funga seá.*
- 3. *’Oku tu’u ’a Sēmisi he tu’a falé.*
- 4. *Na’a mau nofo he ve’e halá.*
- 5. *Na’á ku ’ilo ’a e pa’angá ’i he lalo mohengá.*
- 6. *’Oku nofo mai ’a e fefiné he mata falé.*

Exercise 2: Translate English to Tongan

- 1. The money was put under the mat.
- 2. The children are playing outside the house.
- 3. Put the book on top of the table.
- 4. We stayed by the side of the road.

5. The clothes are inside the basket.
6. They live right by the beach.

Exercise 3: Fill in the correct spatial noun

Choose from: *loto, lalo, tu'a, mui, mata, funga, tafa'aki, ve'e*

1. 'Oku tuku 'a e me'akaí he ____ *tēpilé*. (The food is on top of the table.)
2. Na'á ku nofo 'i ____ *falé*. (I stayed inside the house.)
3. 'Oku tu'u 'a e vaká he ____ *matatahí*. (The boat stands by the beach.)
4. 'Oku va'inga e fānaú he ____ *falé*. (The children are playing outside the house.)
5. Na'e tuku 'a e tohí 'i he ____ *mohengá*. (The book was put under the bed.)
6. 'Oku nofo ia he ____ *falé*. (She is sitting in front of the house.)
7. 'Oku tu'u 'a e fu'u 'akau he ____ *falé*. (The tree stands by the side of the house.)
8. 'Oku 'i ai ha fale koloa he ____ *halá*. (There is a store at the end of the road.)

Exercise 4: Rewrite with a person

Replace the object with the person given in parentheses. Adjust the structure to follow the person rule.

Example: *he tu'a falé* (outside the house) → *'i he tu'a 'o Tēvita* (behind Tēvita)

1. *he tafa'aki vaká* (by the side of the boat) → by the side of Sione
2. *'i he lalo tēpilé* (under the table) → under Mele
3. *ki mu'a fale* (in front of the house) → ahead of 'Ana

Answers

Exercise 1

1. The clothes were put inside the basket.
2. The book is on top of the chair.
3. Sēmisi is standing outside the house.
4. We stayed by the roadside.
5. I found the money under the bed.
6. The woman is sitting in front of the house.

Exercise 2

1. *Na'e tuku 'a e pa'angá he lalo falá.*
2. *'Oku va'inga e fānaú he tu'a falé.*
3. *Tuku e tohí he funga tēpilé!*
4. *Na'a mau nofo he ve'e halá.*
5. *'Oku 'i loto katō 'a e valá.*
6. *'Oku nau nofo he ve'e matatahí.*

Exercise 3

1. *funga*
2. *loto*
3. *ve'e*
4. *tu'a*
5. *lalo*
6. *mata*
7. *tafa'aki*
8. *mui*

Exercise 4

1. *he tafa'aki 'o Sione*
2. *'i lalo 'ia Mele*
3. *ki mu'a 'ia 'Ana*

Chapter 41: Word Class Flexibility

This chapter covers a broad pattern in Tongan: the same word can serve as a noun, a verb, an adjective, or an adverb depending on how it is used in a sentence.

English keeps its word classes fairly separate. The word “rain” is a noun, and “to rain” needs a different form (“it rained”). In Tongan, the word *’uha* means both “rain” (the thing) and “to rain” (the event), with no change to the word itself. The sentence structure tells you which role the word is playing.

’uha. rain (noun)

Na’e ’uha ’anepō.

It rained last night. (verb, introduced by a tense marker)

The noun *’uha* becomes a verb simply by appearing after a tense marker. No suffix, no conjugation. This flexibility runs through the entire language.

Nouns used as verbs

Weather and nature words shift naturally between noun and verb. When a tense marker introduces them, they describe an event rather than a thing.

Na’e lā’ā ’aneafi.

It was sunny yesterday. (Lit. “Was sun yesterday”)

Mahalo ’e matangi.

Perhaps it will be windy.

Words for rank and status work the same way.

’Okú ne ’eiki.

He is a chief.

The difference between *’okú ne ’eiki* (he is a chief, verb) and *ko ha ’eiki ia* (he is a chief, noun) is grammatical. In the first, *’eiki* functions as a verb: it takes a tense marker and a pronoun. In the second, *’eiki* is a noun: it takes an article. Both translate the same way in English, but the Tongan structures are different.

Noun meaning	Verb meaning	Example
<i>’uha</i> , rain	to rain	<i>Na’e ’uha.</i> It rained.
<i>lā’ā</i> , sun	to be sunny	<i>’Oku lā’ā.</i> It is sunny.
<i>matangi</i> , wind	to be windy	<i>’E matangi.</i> It will be windy.
<i>tu’i</i> , king	to be king	<i>’Okú ne tu’i.</i> He is king.

Verbs used as nouns

Most Tongan verbs double as nouns. The noun form typically refers to the action itself, the person who does it, or the thing produced by the action.

tohi. to write → *ha tohi.* a book, a letter (the thing written)

’alu. to go → *’ene ’alu.* his going (the action)

You already know this pattern from possessive constructions: *Ko ho’o ’alu ki fē?* (Where are you going?) uses *’alu* as a noun meaning “your going.”

Verb meaning	Noun meaning	Example
<i>tohi</i> , to write	book, letter	<i>Na’á ku lau ha tohi.</i> I read a book.
<i>hiva</i> , to sing	song	<i>Ha hiva lelei.</i> A good song.
<i>ngāue</i> , to work	work	<i>’Okú ne fai e ngāué.</i> He is doing the work.

Verbs used as adjectives

A verb placed directly after a noun describes a quality of that noun, forming a compound.

ha tangata tau. a fighting man, a soldier (Lit. “a man [who] fights”)

ha loki mohe. a bedroom (Lit. “a room [for] sleeping”)

ha loki tohi. a writing room, a study (Lit. “a room [for] writing”)

When a transitive verb is used this way, it can carry either an active or a passive sense:

Active: *ha me’a ta’ofi.* a brake (Lit. “a thing [that] hinders”) Passive: *’ufi ta’o.* baked yam (Lit. “yam [that has been] baked”)

Context determines which reading applies.

Compound	Meaning
<i>ha tangata tau</i>	a soldier (a man who fights)
<i>ha loki mohe</i>	a bedroom (a room for sleeping)
<i>ika tunu</i>	roasted fish
<i>mā tunu</i>	toast (toasted bread)

Nouns used as adjectives

Nouns placed after another noun can describe a quality of the first noun, typically indicating material or a defining characteristic.

ha 'ā maka. a stone fence (Lit. “a fence [of] stone”)

ha 'aho lā'ā. a sunny day (Lit. “a day [of] sun”)

ha pō māhina. a moonlight night (Lit. “a night [of] moon”)

This pattern overlaps with compound nouns from earlier chapters (*fale mohe*, *fale kai*). The structural mechanism is the same: the second word specifies the first.

Nouns used as adverbs

Some nouns appear directly after a verb to modify it, filling the role of an English adverbial phrase.

'Okú ne mohe 'aho.

He sleeps during the day. (*'aho*, day, acts as “during the day”)

'Oku nau nofo tahi.

They live by the sea. (*tahi*, sea, acts as “by the sea”)

'Oku mau nofo matatahi.

We live on the coast. (*matatahi*, coast, acts as “on the coast”)

This is similar to the travel compound pattern (*ha'u vakapuna*, come by aeroplane), where the noun tells you how or where the action happens.

Fai + verbal noun

The verb *fai* (to do) combines with a verbal noun as its object to form an idiom meaning “to carry out” or “to perform” the action.

'Okú ne fai ngāue.

He is working. (Lit. “He does work”)

Na'a mau fai lotu.

We prayed. (Lit. “We did prayer”)

The verbal noun after *fai* is a bare indefinite object. Together, *fai* + noun functions as a single intransitive verb, following the same pattern as *kai ma* (eat bread) or *inu kava* (drink kava).

'Ai: a versatile verb

The verb *'ai* means “to put,” “to do,” or “to make.” It substitutes freely for more specific transitive verbs when the context makes the action clear.

Ko 'eku 'alu 'o 'ai 'eku ki'i me'a peá u toe foki.

I am going to take care of a little business and then come back. (Lit. “It is my going and doing my little thing and I again return”)

Ko ho'o 'ai ke hā?

What are you doing that for?

Ko e 'ai ke u ngāue.

I am getting ready to work.

In everyday speech, *'ai* often replaces *fai* and many other transitive verbs when the specific action is understood from context.

Note:

Some Tongan verbs fall into finer categories than simply “transitive” and “intransitive.” Verbs like *kai* (to eat) and *inu* (to drink) can be used in three ways: intransitive (*Na'á ku kai*, I ate), transitive (*Na'á ku kai e iká*, I ate the fish), or with a bare indefinite object (*Na'á ku kai ika*, I ate fish). In this last use, the verb and its object function together as a single unit, which grammarians call a semi-transitive construction. These distinctions do not change how you build sentences, but they explain why certain verb + bare noun combinations behave as a single intransitive verb.

Note:

Some Tongan intransitive verbs translate as passives in English, but they are not passive in Tongan. *Ngalo* (to be forgotten) is intransitive: *Na'e ngalo 'iate au* means "I forgot" (Lit. "was-forgotten at me"), with no object. Similarly, *mole* (to be lost, to perish) is simply intransitive: *Na'a nau mole* means "they were lost." Tongan does not have a passive voice in the English sense. When a transitive sentence drops its agent (*Na'e langa e falé*, "the house was built"), the structure changes, but the verb form does not.

Quick Practice: *fai* + verbal noun

Translate each Tongan sentence to English.

1. *Na'á ku fai ngāue 'aneafi.*
2. *'Okú ne fai lotu pē.*
3. *Te tau fai hiva.*
4. *Kuo 'osi fai ako 'a Tēvita.*
5. *Na'a nau fai malanga 'i he Sāpaté.*

Answers: 1. I worked yesterday.; 2. She is just praying.; 3. We will sing.; 4. Tēvita has already studied.; 5. They preached on Sunday.

***Ngali* (to seem, to look like)**

'Oku ngali faingata'a 'a e ngāué.

The work looks difficult.

The word *ngali* (to seem, to look like) appears before an adjective or stative to express how something appears, rather than how it actually is. The pattern is: TM + *ngali* + adjective (+ subject).

'Oku ngali totonu 'ene ma'u 'a e 'apí.

His getting the home seems right. (Lit. is apparently right his getting the home)

'Oku ngali fe'unga 'a e me'akaí.

The food looks like enough.

The word *ngali* can also express suitability or fittingness when followed by *mo* (with):

'Oku ngali mo ia ke ne fai pehē.

It is fitting for him to do it that way.

The negative form *ta'e ngali* means “unbecoming” or “not fitting”:

'Oku ta'e ngali 'aupito ho'o leá.

Your speech is not becoming at all.

'Oku ta'e ngali 'a e fuhu 'a e lahi mo e si'i.

It is not fitting for the big one to fight the little one.

Note:

In compounds, *ngali tangata* means “manly” or “like a man,” and *ngali fefine* means “ladylike” or “like a woman.” These function as fixed expressions.

***Ngalingali* (to look as if, to seem)**

Ngalingali is the extended form of *ngali*. It carries a weaker, more tentative sense of “seeming.”

'Oku ngalingali 'e 'uha he 'ahó ni.

It looks like it will rain today.

As a verb, *ngalingali* is followed by a full clause:

'Oku ngalingali 'e 'ikai ke lava 'a e ngāuē.

It looks like the work will not get done.

'Oku ngalingali sai ange 'a e fakakaukau ko iá.

That idea seems better.

As a preposed modifier (placed directly before a verb or adjective), it works without a clause:

'Oku ngalingali 'uha he 'ahó ni.

It looks like rain today.

Na'e ngalingali faingata'a 'a e halá.

The road appeared to be difficult.

The difference between *ngali* and *ngalingali* is one of certainty. *Ngali* is a firmer assessment: things genuinely look a certain way. *Ngalingali* is more tentative: things merely seem that way, and the speaker is less sure.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>ngali</i>	particle	to seem, to look like
<i>ngalingali</i>	particle	to seem (tentative, extended form)

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>tu'i</i>	noun/verb	king; to be king
<i>taki</i>	verb	lead
<i>malanga</i>	noun/verb	sermon; to preach
<i>fakakaaukau</i>	noun/verb	thought; to think
<i>fe'unga</i>	adjective	enough; suitable
<i>tunu</i>	verb	to roast, to grill

Tongan	Type	English
<i>ta’o</i>	verb	to bake
<i>ta’ofi</i>	noun/verb	a brake; to hinder, to stop
<i>fuhu</i>	noun/verb	a fight; to box

Exercises

Exercise 1: Identify the word class

State whether the word in parentheses functions as a noun, verb, adjective, or adverb in each sentence.

- 1. *Na’e ’uha lahi ’anepō.* It rained hard last night. (*’uha*)
- 2. *Ha tohi lelei.* A good book. (*tohi*)
- 3. *’Oku nau nofo matatahi.* They live on the coast. (*matatahi*)
- 4. *Ha tangata tau.* A fighting man. (*tau*)
- 5. *Ha ’ā maka.* A stone fence. (*maka*)
- 6. *Ha pō māhina.* A moonlight night. (*māhina*)

Exercise 2: Translate Tongan to English

- 1. *’Oku lā’ā he ’ahó ni.*
- 2. *Na’á ku mohe ’aho.*
- 3. *Ha loki tohi.*
- 4. *’Oku nau fai ngāue.*
- 5. *Ko ho’o ’ai ke hā?*
- 6. *Ika tunu.*

Exercise 3: Translate English to Tongan

- 1. It rained last night.
- 2. A bedroom.
- 3. A stone fence.
- 4. We prayed. (use *fai* + *lotu*)

5. He sleeps during the day.
6. A sunny day.

Exercise 4: Choose ngali or ngalingali for each blank

1. 'Oku __ lelei 'a e me'akaí. The food looks good.
2. 'Oku __ 'e 'uha 'apongipongi. It looks like it will rain tomorrow.
3. 'Oku ta'e __ ho'o leá. Your speech is unbecoming.
4. 'Oku __ 'e 'ikai ke ha'u 'a Sione. It looks like Sione will not come.
5. 'Oku __ fe'unga 'a e pa'angá. The money looks like enough.
6. Na'e __ sai ange 'a e fakakaukau ko iá. That idea seemed better.

Exercise 5: Translate Tongan to English

1. 'Oku ngali mālohi 'a e matangí.
2. 'Oku ngalingali 'e lā'ā 'apongipongi.
3. 'Oku ta'e ngali 'aupito 'ene leá.
4. Na'e ngalingali sai ange 'a e vaká.
5. 'Oku ngalingali 'e 'ikai ke 'osi 'a e ngāuē.

Answers

Exercise 1

1. verb: 'uha (rain) takes a tense marker, so it is acting as a verb
2. noun: tohi (book) is introduced by the article ha
3. adverb: matatahi (coast) modifies the verb nofo, telling where
4. adjective: tau (fight) modifies tangata, describing the type of man
5. adjective: maka (stone) modifies 'ā, describing the type of fence
6. adjective: māhina (moon) modifies pō, describing the type of night

Exercise 2

1. It is sunny today.
2. I slept during the day.
3. A writing room (a study).

4. They are working.
5. What are you doing that for?
6. Roasted fish.

Exercise 3

1. *Na'e 'uha 'anepō.*
2. *Ha loki mohe.*
3. *Ha 'ā maka.*
4. *Na'a mau fai lotu.*
5. *'Okú ne mohe 'aho.*
6. *Ha 'aho lā'ā.*

Exercise 4

1. *ngali.* firm assessment, adjective follows directly
2. *ngalingali.* tentative, full clause with 'e follows
3. *ngali.* fixed expression *ta'e ngali*
4. *ngalingali.* tentative, full clause with 'e 'ikai ke follows
5. *ngali.* firm assessment, adjective follows directly
6. *ngalingali.* tentative assessment as preposed modifier

Exercise 5

1. The wind looks strong.
2. It looks like it will be sunny tomorrow.
3. His speech is very unbecoming.
4. The boat seemed better.
5. It looks like the work won't be finished.

Chapter 42: Time Expressions

This chapter covers practical time expressions: talking about months and expressing time relationships like “since” and “after.”

Months with *’i*

You already know that with days of the week, the preposition *’i* drops and the article *he* stands alone:

Té u ’alu he Mōnite kaha’ú.

I will go next Monday.

With months, the pattern reverses: the article *he* drops, and *’i* stands alone.

’I Sānuāli.

In January.

’I Tisema.

In December.

Tongan	English
<i>Sānuāli</i>	January
<i>Fēpueli</i>	February
<i>Ma’asi</i>	March
<i>’Epeleli</i>	April
<i>Mē</i>	May
<i>Sune</i>	June
<i>Siulai</i>	July
<i>’Aokosi</i>	August
<i>Sepitema</i>	September
<i>’Okatopa</i>	October
<i>Nōvema</i>	November
<i>Tisema</i>	December

All month names are borrowed from English. They follow the same preposition rule: *’i* + month, with no article.

Na’á ku ha’u ’i Ma’asi.

I came in March.

’E foki ’a Siale ’i Nōvema.

Siale will return in November.

Ho-class for nouns of time

Nouns of time take the ho-class possessive. This includes *ta’u* (year), *’aho* (day), *māhina* (month), *uike* (week), and *taimi* (time).

Hono ta’u nimangofulu eni.

He is fifty years old. (Lit. “His year fifty this”)

Ko e Mōnite 'o e uike kaha'ú.

Monday of next week. (The possessive preposition 'o marks the ho-class relationship between Monday and the week.)

Time nouns take ho-class because they characterise a period rather than being something a person acts upon or controls. This follows the same principle as *hoku hingoā* (my name): inherent characteristics take ho-class.

Talu (mei): since, ever since

The word *talū* (or *talū mei*) means “since” or “ever since,” referring to a point in time from which something has continued.

Talu 'eku ha'ú 'oku te'eki té u ongo'i ta'elata.

Since I came, I have never felt homesick.

Talu mei he ta'u kuo 'osí 'oku ou kei mo'ui lelei pē.

Since last year I am still quite healthy.

When a *talū* clause comes first in the sentence, it is often followed by *mo* and a verbal noun. This *mo* does not mean “with” in the usual sense. It links the *talū* clause to its result.

Talu ho'o ha'ú mo 'ene momoko.

Ever since you came, it has been cold. (Lit. “Since your coming and its being cold”)

Talu 'enau folai mo 'ene hakō.

Ever since they sailed, it has been windy.

The phrase *talū mei ai* means “ever since then,” where *ai* substitutes for the object of *mei*.

Na'e mapuni 'a e māketi he uike kuo 'osí, pea talū mei ai 'oku tokolahi 'a e kakaí 'oku si'isi'i 'enau me'akaí.

The market was closed last week, and ever since then many people have had little food.

Pattern	Example
<i>talū</i> + possessive + verbal noun	<i>Talū 'eku ha'ú...</i> Since I came...
<i>talū mei he</i> + noun	<i>Talū mei he ta'u kuo 'osí...</i> Since last year...
<i>talū ... mo</i> + verbal noun	<i>Talū ho'o 'alú mo e tangi 'a Seini.</i> Ever since you went, Seini has cried.
<i>talū mei ai</i>	Ever since then

***Hilí*: after**

The word *hilí* means “after.” It introduces a noun or event that has already happened, and the main clause follows with *pea* (and then).

Hilí 'a e fakatahá pea mau ō 'o kai.

After the meeting we went and ate.

Hilí 'eku puké peá u foki 'o ngāue.

After my sickness I returned to work.

Hilí ia, na'e toki lea leva 'a e faiakó.

After that, the teacher spoke immediately.

When *hilí* introduces a definite common noun, the focus marker *'a* appears, following the same rules as after a verb: *hilí 'a e fakatahá* (after the meeting), *hilí 'a e pekia 'a Mosesé* (after the death of Moses). With a pronoun or possessive, no *'a* is needed: *hilí 'eku puké* (after my sickness).

Kaha'u* and *kuo hilí

The word *kaha'u* means “coming” or “next” when referring to future time, and “the future” as a noun.

Ko e 'ai eni ke lelei 'a e kaha'ú 'o Tonga.

This is being done for the good of Tonga’s future.

’Oku tau ’amanaki lelei ki he kaha’ú.

We have great hope for the future.

The phrase *kuo hili* means “past” or “gone by,” referring to past time.

’Oku tau ako mei he kuo hili.

We learn from the past.

Na’e fa’a fai pehē he kuo hili.

It was often done that way in the past.

Na’e lelei ia he kuo hili, ka ’oku kovi ia he ngaahi ’ahó ni.

It was fine in the past, but it is bad nowadays.

Expression	Meaning	Example
<i>kaha’u</i>	future, next, coming	<i>e uike kaha’ú</i>
		next week
<i>kuo hili</i>	past, gone by	<i>he kuo hili</i>
		in the past

Fuofua and fua: first, initial

The preposed words *fuofua* and its shorter form *fua* mean “first” or “initial.” They appear before the noun or verb they modify.

Ko ’emau fuofua fakataha eni.

This is our first meeting.

Ko e fuofua tohi eni na’á ku lau.

This is the first book I read.

Na’á ku fua talanoa mo Tēvita, peá ma toki alea mo e pulé.

I talked with Tēvita first, and then we discussed with the boss.

Fuofua and *fua* differ from *'uluaki* (first) in that they emphasise the initial occurrence of an event, not a position in a sequence. *Ko e fuofua fakataha* means “the first-ever meeting” (emphasising that this is a new event), while *ko e 'uluaki fakataha* means “the first meeting” (in a series, with a second and third to follow).

Ordinal numerals

An earlier chapter introduced ordinal numbers: *'uluaki* for “first,” and *ko hono* + number (with a definitive accent) for “second” and beyond. This section covers further uses of ordinals.

Ordinal forms function as nouns. To specify what is being counted, add *'o e* + noun:

Ko hono tolu 'o e himí.

The third hymn.

Ko e 'aho hongofulu mā taha 'o Sānuali.

The eleventh day of January.

Ordinals also appear as postposed adjectives with names and titles:

Ko Tupou 'Uluaki.

Tupou the First.

Ko Tupou Ua.

Tupou the Second.

The interrogative ordinal *fíha* asks “which (in a sequence)”:

Ko e 'aho fíha eni 'o e māhiná?

What day of the month is this?

Ordinal	Tongan	Example
first	<i>'uluaki</i>	<i>ko e 'uluaki 'aho</i> the first day

Ordinal	Tongan	Example
second	<i>ko hono uá</i>	<i>ko hono ua 'o e ta'ú</i> the second year
third	<i>ko hono tolú</i>	<i>ko hono tolu 'o e tohi</i> the third book
which?	<i>fiha</i>	<i>ko hono fiha?</i> which one (in order)?

Note:

Tongan also has fraction words based on *vahe* (to divide): *vaheua* means “half” and *vahetolu* means “a third.” These are formed by combining *vahe* with the cardinal number. The word *liunga* before a numeral expresses multiplication: *liunga tolu* means “three times as much.” You will encounter these in reading, though this chapter does not practise them formally.

Note:

The word *taha* (one) has several extended meanings beyond the number. It can mean “someone” or “anyone” (*ha taha*, a person), “other” or “another” (*ha kolo 'e taha*, another village), or “same” (*'oku ta'u taha ia mo hoku fohá*, he is the same age as my son).

Spatial Words as Time Expressions

Several expressions built from spatial words extend into the domain of time.

Ki mu’a: before, ahead, first

The phrase *ki mu’a* means “before” (in time), “ahead,” or “first.” It appears after the verb or at the end of the clause.

Na'á ku lau 'a e tohí ki mu'a peá u toki foaki ia ma'a Sēmisi.

I read the book first and then gave it to Sēmisi.

Na'á ku ha'u au ki mu'a he onó.

I came before six o'clock.

Na'e 'alu atu ia ki mu'a 'ia Mele.

He went there before Mele.

Mou teuteu ki mu'a, na'a mou tōmui.

Get ready ahead of time, lest you be late.

Ki mui: *after, afterward*

Ki mui is the opposite of *ki mu'a*. It means “after” (in time) or “afterward.”

Na'e toki ha'u 'a Siale ki mui 'ia 'Ana.

Siale came after 'Ana.

Na'á ku toki 'ilo ki mui kuo lavea 'a e tamasi'í.

I just found out afterward that the boy was hurt.

'Amui: *later on, in the future*

'Amui means “later on” or “in the future.” It sits at the end of the clause.

'Oku 'i ai ha ngaahi me'a lahi 'e hoko 'amui.

There are many things that will happen in the future.

Tau toki 'ilo 'amui.

We will find out later on.

Tōmu'a: *first of all*

Tōmu'a is a preposed modifier meaning “first of all” or “before anything else.”

It goes directly before the verb.

Té u tōmu'a tala hono koví peá u toki tala hono leleí.

I will first tell its bad side and then tell its good side.

Tau tōmu’a tokanga’i ’a ’apí.

Before anything else, we should take care of home.

Te nau tōmu’a ō kinautolu.

They will go first.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>talu</i>	conjunction	since, ever since
<i>ki mu’a</i>	time phrase	before, ahead
<i>ki mui</i>	time phrase	after, afterward

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>Sānuali</i>	month name	January
<i>Fēpueli</i>	month name	February
<i>Ma’asi</i>	month name	March
<i>’Epeleli</i>	month name	April
<i>Mē</i>	month name	May
<i>Sune</i>	month name	June
<i>Siulai</i>	month name	July
<i>’Aokosi</i>	month name	August

Tongan	Type	English
<i>Sepitema</i>	month name	September
<i>'Okatopa</i>	month name	October
<i>Nōvema</i>	month name	November
<i>Tisema</i>	month name	December
<i>kaha'u</i>	noun/adjective	future, next, coming
<i>'amui</i>	adverb	later on, in the future
<i>tōmu'a</i>	adverb	first of all, before anything else
<i>liunga</i>	multiplier	times as much (<i>liunga ua</i> = twice as much)
<i>himi</i>	noun	hymn

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English

- 1. *Na'á ku ha'u 'i Sānuali.*
- 2. *Hilí 'a e lotú pea mau ō ki 'api.*
- 3. *Talu 'eku nofo heni 'oku ou fiefia.*
- 4. *Ko hono fā 'o e himí.*
- 5. *Ko 'emau fuofua fakataha eni.*
- 6. *'Oku tau ako mei he kuo hilí.*

Exercise 2: Translate English to Tongan

- 1. She will return in August.
- 2. After the work, we went and ate.
- 3. Ever since you came, it has rained.
- 4. The first day of March.
- 5. We have great hope for the future.
- 6. What day of the month is this?

Exercise 3: Fill in the blank

Choose the correct word or phrase to complete each sentence.

- 1. Na’á ku ha’u ____ ‘Epeleli. (‘i / ‘i he)
- 2. ____ e ngāué pea nau ō. (Hilí / Talu)
- 3. Ko e ____ tohi eni na’á ku lau. (fuofua / ‘uluaki)
- 4. Talu ____ ha’ú mo ‘ene momoko. (ho’o / ho)

Exercise 4: Match the expression

Match each Tongan expression with its English meaning.

	Tongan	English
1	<i>talú meí ai</i>	a. the past
2	<i>kuo hilí</i>	b. ever since then
3	<i>kaha’u</i>	c. the first meeting
4	<i>ko hono tolú</i>	d. the future, next
5	<i>fuofua fakataha</i>	e. the third

Exercise 5: Spatial words as time expressions

Translate into English:

- 1. *Tau toki ‘ilo ‘amui.*
- 2. *Na’á ne tōmu’a ‘alu ki he fakatahá.*

Translate into Tongan:

- 3. She came before Sione. (use *ki mu’a*)
- 4. There are many things that will happen in the future. (use *‘amui*)
- 5. I read the letter first and then gave it to ‘Ana. (use *ki mu’a*)
- 6. They will go first. (use *tōmu’a*)
- 7. Mele arrived after Sione. (use *ki mui*)
- 8. We will find out later on. (use *‘amui*)
- 9. Get ready ahead of time. (use *ki mu’a*)

Answers**Exercise 1**

1. I came in January.
2. After the prayer service we went home.
3. Since I have been living here, I am happy.
4. The fourth hymn.
5. This is our first meeting.
6. We learn from the past.

Exercise 2

1. 'E foki 'a ia 'i 'Aokosi.
2. Hilí 'a e ngāu'é pea mau ō 'o kai.
3. Talu ho'o ha'ú mo 'ene 'uhá.
4. Ko e 'uluaki 'aho 'o Ma'asi.
5. 'Oku tau 'amanaki lelei ki he kaha'ú.
6. Ko e 'aho fiha eni 'o e māhiná?

Exercise 3

1. 'i. months use 'i alone, with no article
2. Hilí. “after” an event; talu means “since”
3. fuofua. “first” in the sense of “initial,” emphasising a first occurrence
4. ho'o. possessive before the verbal noun ha'ú (your coming)

Exercise 4

1: b (*talū mei ai* = ever since then) 2: a (*kuo hilí* = the past) 3: d (*kaha'u* = the future, next) 4: e (*ko hono tolú* = the third) 5: c (*fuofua fakataha* = the first meeting)

Exercise 5

1. We will find out later on.
2. He went first to the meeting.
3. Na'á ne ha'u ki mu'a 'ia Sione.

4. *'Oku 'i ai ha ngaahi me'a lahi 'e hoko 'amui.*
5. *Na'á ku lau 'a e tohi ki mu'a peá u toki foaki ia ma'a 'Ana.*
6. *Te nau tōmu'a ō kinautolu.*
7. *Na'e toki ha'u 'a Mele ki mui 'ia Sione.*
8. *Tau toki 'ilo 'amui.*
9. *Mou teuteu ki mu'a.*

Chapter 43: The *Ta'e*- Prefix and Advanced Negation

Building on the basic negation with *'ikai*, this chapter introduces the prefix *ta'e*-, which attaches directly to words to create negative forms like English “un-” or “without,” along with several idiomatic expressions for emphatic negation.

The prefix *ta'e*-

You have already seen how a prefix changes a word's meaning, as with *faka*-. The prefix *ta'e*- works the same way: it attaches to the front of a word and creates the negative or opposite form.

Before nouns: “without”

When *ta'e*- appears before a noun, it means “without” that thing.

Na'e 'alu ta'e su 'a Maikolo.

Maikolo went without shoes.

'Oku ngāue ta'e totongi 'a Sēmisi.

Sēmisi is working without pay.

Here *su* (*shoes*) and *totongi* (*pay*) are the nouns being negated. The phrase *ta'e su* means “without shoes” and *ta'e totongi* means “without pay.” The rest of the sentence keeps its normal word order.

Before verbs and adjectives: “un-,” “not”

When *ta'e*- appears before a verb or adjective, it creates the opposite meaning, like English “un-” or “in-.”

Base word	With <i>ta'e</i> -
<i>fe'unga</i> (<i>suitable</i>)	<i>ta'e fe'unga</i> (<i>unsuitable</i>)
<i>mahino</i> (<i>clear</i>)	<i>ta'e mahino</i> (<i>unclear, unintelligible</i>)
<i>totonu</i> (<i>correct</i>)	<i>ta'e totonu</i> (<i>incorrect</i>)
<i>'ofa</i> (<i>loving, kind</i>)	<i>ta'e 'ofa</i> (<i>unkind</i>)
<i>tokanga</i> (<i>attentive</i>)	<i>ta'e tokanga</i> (<i>careless, inattentive</i>)

'Oku ta'e mahino 'enau leá.

Their speech is unintelligible. (Lit. “Is not-clear their speech”)

'Oku ta'e fe'unga 'ene ngāué.

His work is inadequate.

When *ta'e*- + adjective follows a noun, it works as a postposed modifier:

Ko e tangata ta'e 'ofa mo'oni 'a Tēvita.

Tēvita is a truly unkind man.

Here *mo'oni* (*truly*) intensifies *ta'e 'ofa*. The whole phrase *tangata ta'e 'ofa mo'oni* modifies the subject.

When *ta'e*- + word appears with a possessive pronoun, it can function as a noun meaning “the not-doing-of” or “the lack of”:

Ko e lahi 'ene ta'etokanga.

His carelessness is great. (Lit. “The greatness of his not-paying-attention”)

Before a phrase: “without doing”

When *ta’e*- introduces a phrase with *te* + pronoun + verb, it means “without someone doing something.” This mirrors the *’ikai te* + pronoun pattern, but with *ta’e* in place of *’ikai*.

Na’e ’alu ’a Tēvita ta’e té ne tala mai.

Tēvita went without telling me.

Na’á ku ngāue kia Sēmisi ta’e té u ma’u ha me’a.

I worked for Sēmisi without receiving anything.

Ta’e- compared with ’ikai

Both *ta’e*- and *’ikai* express negation, but they work differently. *’ikai* is a separate word that fits between the tense marker and the verb, using *ke* or *te* as a link. *Ta’e*- attaches directly to the word it negates. The *ta’e*- form often carries a slightly stronger or more definitive negative tone.

<i>’ikai</i> construction	<i>ta’e</i> - construction	Meaning
<i>’Oku ’ikai ke tokanga ’a Sione.</i>	<i>’Oku ta’e tokanga ’a Sione.</i>	Sione is inattentive.
<i>Na’e ’ikai ke fe’unga ’ene ngāué.</i>	<i>Na’e ta’e fe’unga ’ene ngāué.</i>	His work was inadequate.
<i>’Oku ’ikai ke ’i ai ha faiako heni.</i>	<i>’Oku ta’e ’i ai ha faiako heni.</i>	There is no teacher here.

Double negative for emphasis

When *’ikai* and *ta’e*- appear together in the same sentence, the two negatives cancel out, producing an emphatic positive. The logic: “it will not fail to happen” means “it will definitely happen.”

’E ’ikai pē ke ta’e ’osi ’a e ngāue ko iá.

That work will certainly be completed. (Lit. “Will not just not-finish the work”)

'E 'ikai té u ta'e fai e ngāué ni.

I will certainly do this work. (Lit. "Will not I not-do this work")

The particle *pē* (just) in the first sentence reinforces the certainty. The speaker is saying that the negative outcome is itself impossible.

Tala'ehai: let no one suppose

The word *tala'ehai* (let no one say) is an idiom meaning "let no one suppose" or "don't believe for a moment that." It originates from 'e *tala* 'e *hai* (who shall say?). In use, it functions as a strong form of "not," coloured by the sense of "whatever anyone might think."

Tala'ehai kuó ne ngalo'i kitautolu.

Let no one suppose he has forgotten us.

Na'á ku foki, he tala'ehai 'oku ou puke.

I returned, not because I am sick. (Lit. "I returned, for let-no-one-suppose I am sick")

Tala'ehai ko Sēmisi na'á ne kaiha'a 'a e pa'angá.

Let no one suppose Sēmisi stole the money.

The conjunction *he* (because, for) often introduces a *tala'ehai* clause, as in the second example. Despite being nearly equivalent to 'ikai, *tala'ehai* always carries its original nuance of challenging what others might assume.

Koloto: not at all

The word *koloto* means "not at all," but it carries more than simple negation. It implies surprise or disappointment that something expected did not happen, or that something which ought to exist is missing.

'Oku ou toutou tohi kiate ia, ka koloto ha'ane talí.

I keep writing to him, but he never answers at all.

Koloto ke ne tokoni'i hono fāmili.

He did not help his family at all.

Koloto ha taha.

Not one. Not a single person.

In the first example, the speaker expected a reply and is disappointed that none came. In the second, the speaker expected help that never materialised. This emotional undertone, the jolt of an expected thing being absent, distinguishes *koloto* from a plain *'ikai*.

***Ne'ine'i*: no wonder**

The word *ne'ine'i* means “no wonder” or “it is not surprising that.” It replaces the tense marker at the beginning of its clause. When the subject is a noun placed after the verb, as in all the examples below, the verb follows directly after *ne'ine'i*. When the subject is a preposed pronoun, the form becomes *ne'ine'i te* (for example *Ne'ine'i te nau fiefia*, “No wonder they were glad”).

Ne'ine'i tangi 'a Seini he na'e puké.

No wonder Seini cried, she was sick.

Ne'ine'i hola 'a Mele ia.

No wonder Mele ran away.

Ne'ine'i mole hono tohí ko e lahí 'ene ta'etokanga.

No wonder he lost his book, he was very careless. (Lit. “No wonder lost his book, the greatness of his carelessness”)

Here *hola* (*run away*) and *mole* (*lose, be lost*) are verbs that follow *ne'ine'i* directly. Because *ne'ine'i* takes the place of the tense marker, no *'oku*, *na'e*, or other marker appears before the verb.

Note:

The expression *mole ke mama'o* means “far from it” or “not at all.” It is used as a standalone emphatic denial: *Mole ke mama'o*. (Far from it.) With a possessive pronoun, it expresses distance from an action: *Mole ke mama'o ha'aku fai pehē*. (Far be it from me to do such a thing.) This expression appears in reading but is not practised formally in this chapter.

Expression	Meaning	Nuance
<i>ta’e-</i> + word	un-, not, without	Creates opposite of the following word
<i>’ikai</i> + <i>ta’e-</i>	emphatic positive (double negative)	“It will certainly...”
<i>tala’ehai</i>	let no one suppose	“Whatever anyone might think, it is not...”
<i>koloto</i>	not at all	Surprised or disappointed that something expected is absent
<i>ne’ine’i</i>	no wonder	“It is not surprising that...”

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>ta’e-</i>	negation prefix	un-, not, without
<i>tala’ehai</i>	particle	let no one suppose, whatever anyone might think
<i>koloto</i>	adverb	not at all (surprise/disappointment)

Tongan	Function	English
<i>ne’ine’i</i>	particle	no wonder (replaces tense marker)
<i>mole ke mama’o</i>	idiom	far from it, not at all

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>ta’e’aonga</i>	adjective	useless (from <i>’aonga</i> , useful)
<i>ta’efakalao</i>	adjective	illegal (from <i>fakalao</i> , legal)
<i>ta’efiemālie</i>	adjective	uncomfortable, dissatisfied
<i>ta’etotonu</i>	adjective	unjust, incorrect
<i>kaiha’a</i>	verb	steal

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English

- 1. *’Oku ta’e mahino ’ene leá.*
- 2. *Na’e ’alu ta’e su ’a Lupe.*
- 3. *’E ’ikai pē ke ta’e ’osi ’a e ngāue ko iá.*
- 4. *Koloto ke ne tokoni’i hono fāmílí.*
- 5. *Ne’ine’i hola ’a Mele ia.*
- 6. *Tala’ehai ko au na’á ku kaiha’a ’a e pa’angá.*
- 7. *’Oku ta’e fe’unga ’ene ngāué.*
- 8. *Na’á ku ngāue kia Sēmisi ta’e té u ma’u ha me’a.*

Exercise 2: Translate English to Tongan

- 1. Sione is working without pay.

- 2. His speech was unintelligible.
- 3. I will certainly do this work.
- 4. No wonder Tēvita ran away.
- 5. He did not help his family at all.
- 6. I returned, not because I am sick.

Exercise 3: Transform with *ta'e*-

Rewrite each sentence by replacing the *'ikai ke* construction with *ta'e*-.

- 1. 'Oku 'ikai ke fe'unga 'ene ngāué.
- 2. Na'e 'ikai ke totonu 'ene leá.
- 3. 'Oku 'ikai ke 'ofa 'a Sione.
- 4. Na'e 'ikai ke mahino 'a e tohí.
- 5. 'Oku 'ikai ke tokanga 'a e tangatá.

Exercise 4: Match the expression

Match each Tongan expression with its English meaning.

	Tongan	English
1	<i>ta'e totonu</i>	a. not at all
2	<i>ne'ine'i</i>	b. let no one suppose
3	<i>koloto</i>	c. no wonder
4	<i>tala'ehai</i>	d. far from it
5	<i>mole ke mama'o</i>	e. incorrect
6	<i>ta'e totongi</i>	f. without pay

Answers

Exercise 1

- 1. His speech is unintelligible.

2. Lupe went without shoes.
3. That work will certainly be completed.
4. He did not help his family at all.
5. No wonder Mele ran away.
6. Let no one suppose I stole the money.
7. His work is inadequate.
8. I worked for Sēmisi without receiving anything.

Exercise 2

1. *'Oku ngāue ta'e totongi 'a Sione.*
2. *Na'e ta'e mahino 'ene leá.*
3. *'E 'ikai té u ta'e fai e ngāué ni.*
4. *Ne'ine'i hola 'a Tēvita ia.*
5. *Koloto ke ne tokoni'i hono fāmilí.*
6. *Na'á ku foki, he tala'ehai 'oku ou puke.*

Exercise 3

1. *'Oku ta'e fe'unga 'ene ngāué.*
2. *Na'e ta'e totonu 'ene leá.*
3. *'Oku ta'e 'ofa 'a Sione.*
4. *Na'e ta'e mahino 'a e tohí.*
5. *'Oku ta'e tokanga 'a e tangatá.*

Exercise 4

1: e (*ta'e totonu* = incorrect) 2: c (*ne'ine'i* = no wonder) 3: a (*koloto* = not at all) 4: b (*tala'ehai* = let no one suppose) 5: d (*mole ke mama'o* = far from it) 6: f (*ta'e totongi* = without pay)

Chapter 44: The Definitive Accent System

Chapter 18: Definiteness and the Definitive Accent introduced the basic stress shift. This chapter shows the full system: how it works with nested phrases, dropped openings, opening phrases that carry the accent, and long vowels under stress.

Three levels of definiteness, revisited

Chapter 18: Definiteness and the Definitive Accent showed three levels of specificity. Here is the system in full.

Consider these three sentences:

Na'á ku fa'o ia ki ha puha.

I put it into a box. (Some box or other.)

Na'á ku fa'o ia ki he puha.

I put it into a box. (One particular box.)

Na'á ku fa'o ia ki he puhá.

I put it into the box.

The three levels are:

Level	Article	Accent?	Meaning
Indefinite	<i>ha</i>	No	Any one, not specific
Semi-definite	<i>e / he</i>	No	One particular thing, but not singled out for the listener
Definite	<i>e / he</i>	Yes	The specific one both speaker and listener know

The indefinite form with *ha* is vague: it refers not to one particular thing but to something or anything of the kind indicated. The semi-definite form with *e* or *he* (without accent) is not vague: the speaker has a particular thing in mind. The definite form adds the final step: it refers specifically to this or that, to the thing already mentioned or already known.

Semi-definiteness explained

The difference between indefinite and semi-definite is subtle but real. Two patterns make it visible.

Possessive pronouns show the same three levels

The three-level system extends to possessive pronouns. Compare:

'Oku 'ikai ke 'i ai ha'anau me'akai.

They have no food. (Indefinite: *ha'anau*.)

Na'a nau 'omai 'enau me'akai.

They brought their food. (Semi-definite: *'enau*, no accent.)

'Oku fu'u si'i 'enau me'akaí.

Their food is insufficient. (Definite: *'enau* with accent on the last vowel of the group.)

The indefinite form *ha'anau* signals “any provisions of theirs” or “no provisions of theirs.” The semi-definite form *'enau* (without accent) signals “their particular provisions.” The definite form *'enau ... me'akaí* (with accent) signals “those specific provisions we are talking about.”

When English shows no difference, Tongan does

English speakers often map *e/he* to “the” and *ha* to “a.” This flattens Tongan’s three levels into two. But consider:

Na'á ku misi 'anepō 'oku ou to'o hoku fo'i nifo.

I dreamt last night that I took out one of my teeth.

The speaker uses *hoku* (semi-definite), not *haku* (indefinite), because the dream was about one particular tooth. English cannot easily show this distinction. Tongan marks it with the possessive form.

The indefinite form is especially common in questions, negative sentences, conditional clauses, and commands:

'Oku 'i ai hatau fatongia ke fai?

Do we have a duty to perform? (Indefinite: *hatau*.)

'Oku 'i ai hotau fatongia ke fai.

We have a duty to perform. (Semi-definite: *hotau*.)

The choice between *hatau* and *hotau* depends on how definite the speaker’s thought is. In the question, the duty is hypothetical. In the statement, the speaker has a particular duty in mind.

The definitive accent at group end

The basic rule, introduced in Chapter 18: Definiteness and the Definitive Accent, is this: when a noun group is definite, stress falls on the very last vowel of the entire group. As the group grows longer, the accent moves with it.

Tongan	English
<i>ʻi he falé</i>	in the house
<i>ʻi he fale akó</i>	in the school building
<i>ʻi he fale ako motuʻá</i>	in the old school building
<i>ʻi he fale ako foʻoú</i>	in the new school building

The same principle applies to other nouns. The word *loki* (*room*) extends the same way:

Tongan	English
<i>ʻi he lokí</i>	in the room
<i>ʻi he loki mohé</i>	in the bedroom
<i>ʻi he loki mohe foʻoú</i>	in the new bedroom

The core noun is *fale* or *loki*. Each qualifier (*ako*, *motuʻa*, *foʻou*, *mohe*) extends the group, and the accent travels to the end. Think of the whole group as a single pronunciation unit: the accent always caps it off.

Three more examples show the accent on different nouns:

Naʻá ku sio ki he meʻangāué (tool). I looked at the tool.

ʻOku lahi ʻa e kavengá (responsibility). The responsibility is great.

Naʻe ʻalu e tangata mo ʻene meʻangāue foʻoú.

The man went with his new tool.

This holds even when a relative clause extends the group:

Té u ʻalu ki he fale kuo nau fakataha aí.

I will go to the house in which they have assembled.

The accent falls on *ai* because the relative clause *kuo nau fakataha ai* is part of the noun group headed by *fale*.

Adverbs do not extend the group

Not every word that follows a noun belongs to the noun group. Adverbs qualify the verb, not the noun, so the accent does not move onto them.

Na'á ke 'alu ki he fakatahá 'aneafi?

Did you go to the meeting yesterday?

The accent stays on *fakatahá* because *'aneafi* (yesterday) modifies *'alu* (go), not *fakataha* (meeting). Compare:

Na'á ke 'alu ki he fakataha lahí?

Did you go to the big meeting?

Here *lahi* is an adjective modifying *fakataha*, so the accent moves to *lahí*. And when a relative clause replaces the adjective:

Na'á ke 'alu ki he fakataha na'e fai 'aneafi?

Did you go to the meeting that was held yesterday?

Now *na'e fai 'aneafi* is an adjectival clause qualifying *fakataha*, and the accent is carried to the end of the whole group.

Groups within groups

Ko e hā 'a e 'uhinga na'e 'ita ai 'a e faiakó kiate aú?

Why was the teacher angry with me?

Two accents appear. The smaller group inside is *e faiako* (the teacher), and its accent falls on *faiakó*. The larger group runs all the way from *e 'uhinga* to *au* (it's the whole "the reason why the teacher was angry with me"), and its accent lands on the final *aú*. Each accent marks the end of its own group.

A noun group can contain another noun group inside it. Each one is definite on its own, and each gets its own definitive accent.

When the smaller group falls at the very end of the larger one, a single accent does the job for both:

Ko e hā 'a e 'uhinga na'e 'ita ai kiate au 'a e faiakó?

(Same meaning, different word order.)

Here *au* is no longer the last word of any group, so it loses its accent. The single accent on *faiakó* covers both groups at once.

Dropped openings

Ko Mele na'á ne fai 'a e ngāué.

It was Mele who did the work.

The accent on *ngāué* does two things at once. First, it marks the end of *e ngāue* (the work), the visible noun group. But there is also a larger group hiding behind the sentence: the full thought is “The person who did the work was Mele,” and “the person who did the work” is itself a definite noun group. Its opening (“the person”) has been dropped because the listener can supply it from context. The accent on *ngāué* also marks the end of *that* group.

Tongan sometimes drops the opening of a noun group when context makes it recoverable. The accent still falls on the last spoken word, marking the end of the unspoken whole.

This pattern is most common in cleft sentences, the *ko* + subject + *na'á ne* + verb structure introduced in Chapter 36: Cleft Sentences and Emphatic Word Order.

Compare the non-cleft version:

Na'e fai 'a e ngāué 'e Mele.

Mele did the work.

Here *ngāué* takes the accent simply as the last word of its own definite noun group. Nothing is being dropped.

The same pattern appears in sentences expressing “it is ... that”:

Ko ia 'oku ou pehē ai 'e aú, 'oku totonu ke fai leva 'a e ngāué.

That is why I say the work ought to be done at once.

The accent on *aú* marks the end of the dropped opening “[the reason] for which I say.”

Phrasal and clausal definitive accents

Ko ho'o 'alú ki fē?

Where is it that you are going? (Lit. “Your going, to where?”)

Without the accent on *'alú*, *Ko ho'o 'alu ki fē?* would be a casual question. With the accent, it becomes more deliberate: “Where, specifically, is it that you are going?” The opening *ho'o 'alu* (your going) is functioning here as a definite reference: it picks out a specific thing the rest of the sentence asks about, and because that reference is definite, its last vowel takes the accent.

This pattern extends from single phrases to whole clauses. When a sentence opens by establishing a definite reference (a specific person, thing, place, time, or moment) and then says something about it, the opening element takes the definitive accent, even though it isn't the grammatical subject.

Phrasal examples

Ko 'eku 'alú ki Ma'ufanga.

My going is to Ma'ufanga. (It is to Ma'ufanga that I am going.)

Ko 'ene 'itá kiate kitautolu.

His anger is at us. (It is with us that he is angry.)

In each case, the opening phrase (*'eku 'alu*, *'ene 'ita*) presents something definite, and the accent marks it.

Clausal examples

The same principle extends to whole clauses. When an opening clause establishes a definite time, situation, or circumstance, its final vowel takes the accent.

Na'á ku 'alu atú, kuo 'osi 'a e fakatahá.

When I arrived, the meeting was over.

The first clause *Na'á ku 'alu atu* ends with the accented *atú*. This signals that the clause presents a definite moment in time: “When I arrived” is established as a definite reference point, and the rest of the sentence says what was true at that moment.

Pongipongi haké, kuo fekau mai ke mau ō.

As soon as morning came, we were told to go.

The clause *Pongipongi hake* ends with *haké*, marking the dawn as a definite moment. The perfect tense *kuo* in the second clause adds a sense of immediacy: no sooner had morning come than the order arrived.

Na'á ne lea kiate kimautilú ke mau kātaki.

What he said to us was that we should be patient.

The first clause, ending in *kimautilú*, presents a definite fact (what he said to us), and the second clause states the content.

Even conditional clauses can take this accent when placed first:

Kapau 'oku te'eki té ke 'alú, fei mo 'alu.

If you have not yet gone, go at once.

The conditional clause is treated as presenting a definite situation, and *'alú* is accented accordingly.

Definitive accent for emphasis on directional adverbs

The directional adverbs *mai* (hither), *atu* (away), *hake* (up), *hifo* (down), and others can take the definitive accent in commands and requests for special emphasis.

Normal	Emphatic
<i>'Alu hifo.</i> (Come down.)	<i>'Alu hifó.</i> (Come down, I say.)
<i>'Alu atu 'o vakai.</i> (Go and look.)	<i>'Alu atú 'o vakai.</i> (Go and look, will you.)
<i>To'o mai ho koté.</i> (Hand me your coat.)	<i>To'o maí ho koté.</i> (Hand me your coat, now.)

When a directional adverb is emphasized this way and is followed by a pronoun or a phrase ending in a pronoun, that pronoun also takes a definitive accent:

To'o maí iá.
Hand that to me. (emphatic)

This emphatic use is limited to directional adverbs. It does not occur with verbs like *ha'u* or compound verbs like *'omai* where the adverb is already built into the verb.

Double vowels under the definitive accent

Chapter 18: Definiteness and the Definitive Accent noted that when a long vowel receives the definitive accent, it expands into a double vowel. Here is how that works.

Tongan does not stress long vowels under the definitive accent. When the accent would force stress onto a long vowel, the vowel splits into two short vowels, and the stress lands on the second.

hū (to go in) → the verb stem *huufi* (to open officially, with suffix *-fi*) *fakahā* (to show) → *fakahaa'i* (to show, with suffix *-i*) *pō* (night) → *poó ni* (this night)

When stress moves further along, the double vowel contracts back to a normal long vowel:

huúfi → *hūfi* (with further accent shift) *poó ni* → *pō ní* (with the accent carried to *ní*)

Two kinds of double vowels

Note:

Not all double vowels in Tongan arise from long vowels splitting under stress. Some occur because two normal vowels from different parts of a compound word come together: *faka-* + *ava* produces *fakaava* (to open), where *aa* is simply two normal *a* vowels side by side. These “compound” double vowels do not contract into long vowels when stress shifts: *fakaavá’i* (not *fakāva’i*). The double vowels described above, which arise from long vowels splitting under stress, do contract back when stress moves away. This distinction is useful to know but rarely causes confusion in practice.

Words to Learn

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>puhá</i>	noun	box (accent example)
<i>tēpilé</i>	noun	table (accent example)
<i>falé</i>	noun	house (accent example)
<i>me’angāue</i>	noun	tool
<i>kavenga</i>	noun	burden (also: load, responsibility)
<i>nifo</i>	noun	tooth
<i>misí</i>	noun/verb	dream; to dream

Exercises

Exercise 1: Identify the level of definiteness

For each sentence, state whether the underlined noun phrase is indefinite, semi-definite, or definite.

1. *Na'á ne kumi ha tohi.*
2. *Na'á ne lau e tohi.*
3. *Na'á ne lau 'a e tohi.*
4. *'Oku 'i ai hatau ngāue ke fai.*
5. *'Oku 'i ai hotau ngāue ke fai.*
6. *'Oku fu'u faingata'a hotau ngāué.*

Exercise 2: Place the definitive accent

Rewrite each sentence, adding the definitive accent (acute mark on the final vowel) to the appropriate word. If no accent is needed, write the sentence unchanged.

1. *Kuó ne lau e tohi fo'ou.* (the new book, definite)
2. *'Oku ou fiema'u ha kato.* (a basket, indefinite)
3. *Na'á ku 'alu ki he fale ako.* (the school, definite)
4. *'Oku lahi 'a e ngaahi ika 'i he tahi.* (the sea, definite)
5. *Na'á ne 'omai e me'a lahi.* (the big thing, definite)

Exercise 3: Groups within groups

Each sentence contains two noun groups. Identify them and place the definitive accent at the end of each.

1. *Ko e ha e 'uhinga na'e lea ai 'a e faiako kiate au?* (Why did the teacher speak to me?)
2. *Ko e hā 'a e me'a na'e 'omai 'e he tangata ki he fale?* (What did the man bring to the house?)

Exercise 4: Phrasal accents

Translate each English sentence into Tongan. The opening phrase should carry a phrasal definitive accent.

1. It is to Nuku'alofa that I am going.
2. His love is for the children.
3. When I arrived, the food was finished.

Exercise 5: Emphatic directional adverbs

Rewrite each command in emphatic form by adding the definitive accent to the directional adverb.

1. *'Alu atu 'o tokoni.*
2. *To'o mai 'a e tohí.*

Exercise 6: Double vowels

For each word, write the form that appears when the definitive accent falls on the long vowel.

1. *pō* (night) → ____
2. *hū* (to enter) → ____
3. *fakahā* (to show) → ____

Answers

Exercise 1

1. Indefinite (*ha tohi*)
2. Semi-definite (*e tohi*, no accent)
3. Definite (*e tohí*, with accent)
4. Indefinite (*hatau ngāue*)
5. Semi-definite (*hotau ngāue*, no accent)
6. Definite (*hotau ngāué*, with accent)

Exercise 2

1. *Kuó ne lau e tohi fo'óú.*
2. *'Oku ou fiema'u ha kato.* (no accent, indefinite)
3. *Na'á ku 'alu ki he fale akó.*
4. *'Oku lahi 'a e ngaahi ika 'i he tahí.*

5. *Na'á ne 'omai e me'a lahi.*

Exercise 3

1. Inner group: *'a e faiakó*; outer group: *e 'uhinga na'e lea ai 'a e faiakó kiate aú*
→ *Ko e hā 'a e 'uhinga na'e lea ai 'a e faiakó kiate aú?*
2. Inner group: *'e he tangatá*; outer group: *e me'a na'e 'omai 'e he tangatá ki he falé* → *Ko e hā 'a e me'a na'e 'omai 'e he tangatá ki he falé?*

Exercise 4

1. *Ko 'eku 'alú ki Nuku'alofa.*
2. *Ko 'ene 'ofá ki he fānaú.*
3. *Na'á ku 'alu atú, kuo 'osi 'a e me'akaí.*

Exercise 5

1. *'Alu atú 'o tokoni.*
2. *To'o maí 'a e tohi.*

Exercise 6

1. *poó*
2. *huú*
3. *fakahaá*

Chapter 45: Verbal Nouns

A verbal noun is a verb used as a noun, a word for an action treated as a thing. Building on the basic construction *Ko ho'o 'alu ki fē?* (Where are you going?), this chapter covers what happens to subjects and objects when a verb becomes a verbal noun, and how verbal nouns build temporal clauses.

Pronoun subjects become possessives

Na'á ne lau 'a e tohí.

He read the book.

Na'á ku ofo 'i he'ene lau 'a e tohí.

I was surprised at his reading the book. (I was surprised when he read the book.)

In the first sentence, the pronoun *ne* (he) sits between the tense marker and the verb. In the second, it has become the possessive *'ene* (his). When a verb turns into a verbal noun, this kind of pronoun subject moves in front of it as a possessive. The possessive is 'e-class because the subject is the one doing the

action. The pattern *'i he* + possessive + verbal noun creates a clause meaning “when” or “because.”

Pronoun	Possessive	Example
<i>ku</i> (I)	<i>'eku</i>	<i>'i he'eku tohi ...</i> (when I wrote ...)
<i>ke</i> (you)	<i>ho'o</i>	<i>'i he ho'o ngāue ...</i> (when you worked ...)
<i>ne</i> (he/she)	<i>'ene</i>	<i>'i he'ene lau ...</i> (when he/she read ...)
<i>nau</i> (they)	<i>'enau</i>	<i>'i he 'enau kai ...</i> (when they ate ...)
<i>mau</i> (we excl.)	<i>'emau</i>	<i>'i he 'emau tā ...</i> (when we built ...)

Note:
After *'i he*, the possessives *'eku* and *'ene* contract into single forms: *he'eku*, *he'ene*.
The possessives *ho'o* and *'enau* do not contract and remain separate words.

Three more verbs illustrate the same conversion. The verb *tō* (*plant*) becomes a verbal noun when the pronoun changes to a possessive:

Na'á ne tō 'a e 'akau.
He planted the tree.

Na'á ku ofo 'i he'ene tō 'a e 'akaí.
I was surprised at his planting the tree.

The verb *tā* (*strike, hit, build*) works the same way:
Na'a mau tā 'a e falé.
We built the house.

'I he 'emau tā 'a e falé, na'e 'uha.

When we built the house, it rained.

The verb *fai* (*do, make*) is especially common in verbal noun constructions:

Na'á ne fai 'a e ngāué.

He did the work.

'I he'ene fai 'a e ngāué, na'á ku mālōlō.

When he did the work, I rested.

Noun subjects stay the same

Na'e fufulu 'e 'Ana 'a e valá. 'Ana washed the clothes.

'I he fufulu 'e 'Ana 'a e valá. When 'Ana washed the clothes

The subject *'e 'Ana*, placed after the verb, keeps its agent marker *'e* and slides straight through into the verbal noun construction. Intransitive verbs work the same way, with the subject marker *'a* staying in place:

Na'e 'alu 'a Sēmisi ki Fisi.

Sēmisi went to Fiji.

'I he 'alu 'a Sēmisi ki Fisi. When Sēmisi went to Fiji

In both cases, the postposed subject (*'e 'Ana*, *'a Sēmisi*) passes unchanged into the verbal noun construction.

What happens to objects

Objects behave in three ways, depending on what the subject is and where it sits. The three subsections below show each in turn.

Object unchanged (preposed possessive subject)

'i he'ene lau 'a e tohí. at his reading the book

When a possessive pronoun is doing the subject work (*'ene* here), the object *'a e tohi* sits in its original form. Nothing changes.

Object becomes an 'o phrase (postposed subject or no subject)

'E fufulu 'a e valá.

The clothes will be washed.

Té u tokoni 'i he fufulu 'o e valá.

I will help with the washing of the clothes.

When the verb has a postposed subject or no subject at all, the object can switch from *'a e + noun* to *'o e + noun*, using the possessive preposition *'o* (of). The object *'a e vala* becomes *'o e vala* (of the clothes). This tends to happen when the object comes before the subject in the verbal noun construction.

Pronoun object becomes an objective possessive

Na'e tokoni au 'e Sēmisi.

Sēmisi helped me.

Na'á ku fiefia 'i hoku tokoni 'e Sēmisi.

I was glad when I was helped by Sēmisi. (Lit. “at my being-helped by Sēmisi”)

When the object is a pronoun and the verb has a postposed subject (or no subject), the pronoun changes to a ho-class possessive. The pronoun *au* (me) becomes *hoku* (my, ho-class). The ho-class marks the person as the one being acted upon.

Impersonal verbal nouns

Impersonal verbs such as weather and time-of-day expressions have no subject. When these verbs become verbal nouns, Tongan places *he'ene* (its) before them, even though there is no real “it” doing the action.

'i he'ene 'afuá. when it became fine (Lit. “at its becoming-fine”)

'i he'ene efiāfi hifó. when evening came (Lit. “at its becoming-evening down”)

'i he'ene 'aho haké. when the next day came (Lit. “at its becoming-day up”)

This *he'ene* is a fixed part of the construction. It appears regardless of whether the original impersonal verb had any pronoun.

Temporal clauses with verbal nouns

Two constructions use verbal nouns to form temporal clauses.

'I he + verbal noun

This construction means “when” or “because”:

'I he 'osi 'enau ngāué, pea nau mālōlō.

When their work was finished, they rested.

The particle *pea* (and then) introduces the main clause. All the verbal noun constructions shown earlier in this chapter (*'i he'ene lau*, *'i he fufulu 'e 'Ana*, *'i he 'alu 'a Sēmisi*) follow this same temporal pattern.

Ko e + verbal noun (+ pea)

This construction also means “when,” often with a sense of “as soon as.” The limiter *pē* (just) after the verbal noun strengthens this sense:

Ko e 'osi pē 'a e me'akai, pea nau mālōlō.

As soon as the food was finished, they rested.

When the main clause is in the future, the future tense marker can replace *pea*:

Ko e lava pē 'eku ngāué, te mau kai.

When my work is done, we will eat.

Verbal nouns as sentence subjects

'Oku mālie e hiva 'a Seini.

Seini’s singing is superb. (Lit. “Is superb the singing of Seini”)

’Oku mālohi e ngāue ’a Tēvita.

Tēvita’s working is hard. (Lit. “Is hard the working of Tēvita”)

A verbal noun like *hiva* (singing) or *ngāue* (working) can be the subject of a sentence on its own. The doer attaches with *’a* (showing who the action belongs to), and a descriptive word like *mālie* (superb) or *mālohi* (hard) describes the action itself.

Compare these with the standard verb pattern:

Verbal noun as subject	Standard verb pattern
<i>’Oku mālie e hiva ’a Seini.</i>	<i>’Oku hiva mālie ’a Seini.</i>
(Seini’s singing is superb.)	(Seini sings superbly.)
<i>’Oku mālohi e ngāue ’a Tēvita.</i>	<i>’Oku ngāue mālohi ’a Tēvita.</i>
(Tēvita’s work is hard.)	(Tēvita works hard.)
<i>’Oku mālohi e tā ’a Sione.</i>	<i>’Oku tā mālohi ’a Sione.</i>
(Sione’s hitting is strong.)	(Sione hits hard.)
<i>’Oku lelei e fai ’a Mele.</i>	<i>’Oku fai lelei ’a Mele.</i>
(Mele’s doing is good.)	(Mele does well.)

Both express the same meaning. The verbal noun construction is considered more natural in Tongan.

Ko + possessive + verbal noun, expanded

Chapter 22: Aspect Markers introduced this pattern for actions happening right now. With the verbal noun constructions above, you can see how it fits into the broader system:

Ko ho’o lele ki fē?

Where are you running to? (Lit. “It is your running to where?”)

Ko ’eku fufulu vala.

I am washing clothes. (Lit. “It is my washing clothes.”)

The possessive pronoun (*ho’o*, *’eku*) marks the subject using the ’e-class, because the subject is the doer. The verb after it functions as a verbal noun.

Note:

Compare *’ene ngāue* (his working, an action) with *hono ngāue* (his work, the job itself). Same word, different possessive: the ’e-class (*’ene*) names an action, the ho-class (*hono*) names a thing or quality. Same with *’ene masiva* (his being poor, a state) versus *hono masiva* (his poverty, a quality). Not every verb used as a noun is a verbal noun; the possessive class signals which is which. The ’e-class points to doing or being; the ho-class points to the thing or quality itself.

Words to Learn

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>mālōlō</i>	verb	rest
<i>mālie</i>	adjective	superb, well done

Exercises

Exercise 1: Rewrite as verbal noun constructions

Convert each sentence into a verbal noun construction beginning with *’i he*. Change the preposed pronoun to a possessive pronoun.

- Na’á ne hiva ’i he fale lotu.* (He sang in the church.)
- Na’á ku tohi ’a e tohí.* (I wrote the book.)

3. *Na'a nau kai 'a e me'akaí.* (They ate the food.)
4. *Na'á ke ngāue 'i he ngoué.* (You worked in the garden.)
5. *Na'á ne 'alu ki Fisi.* (She went to Fiji.)

Exercise 2: Postposed subjects

Rewrite each sentence as a verbal noun construction beginning with *'I he*. The postposed subject stays unchanged.

1. *Na'e 'alu 'a Mele ki kolo.* (Mele went to town.)
2. *Na'e fufulu 'e 'Ana 'a e valá.* ('Ana washed the clothes.)
3. *Na'e nofo 'a Tēvita 'i fale.* (Tēvita stayed at the house.)

Exercise 3: Translate into Tongan

Use verbal noun constructions with *'i he* or *ko e ... pea*.

1. When Sione arrived, they ate.
2. When it rained, we stayed at home.
3. When the work is done, you rest.
4. I was glad when she sang.

Exercise 4: Verbal nouns as subjects

Rewrite each sentence so that the action becomes the subject and the modifier becomes the predicate.

Example: *'Oku lele vave 'a Sione.* → *'Oku vave e lele 'a Sione.*

1. *'Oku hiva mālie 'a Lupe.* (Lupe sings superbly.)
2. *'Oku ngāue mālohi 'a Sēmisi.* (Sēmisi works hard.)
3. *Na'e ako lelei 'a 'Ana.* ('Ana studied well.)

Exercise 5: 'Ene vs. hono

For each pair, state whether the possessive signals a verbal noun (an action) or a concrete/abstract noun (a thing or quality). Translate both.

1. (a) *'ene ngāue* / (b) *hono ngāue*
2. (a) *'ene masiva* / (b) *hono masiva*
3. (a) *'ene tohi* / (b) *hono tohi*

Answers**Exercise 1**

1. *'i he'ene hiva 'i he fale lotu.* when he sang in the church
2. *'i he'eku tohi 'a e tohi.* when I wrote the book
3. *'i he 'enau kai 'a e me'akaí.* when they ate the food
4. *'i he ho'o ngāue 'i he ngoué.* when you worked in the garden
5. *'i he'ene 'alu ki Fisi.* when she went to Fiji

Exercise 2

1. *'I he 'alu 'a Mele ki kolo.* When Mele went to town
2. *'I he fufulu 'e 'Ana 'a e valá.* When 'Ana washed the clothes
3. *'I he nofo 'a Tēvita 'i fale.* When Tēvita stayed at the house

Exercise 3

1. *'I he tau mai 'a Sione, na'a nau kai.* (or *Ko e tau mai pē 'a Sione, pea nau kai.*)
2. *'I he'ene 'uhá, na'a mau nofo 'i 'api.*
3. *Ko e lava pē 'a e ngāué, pea mou mālōlō.*
4. *Na'á ku fiefia 'i he'ene hiva.*

Exercise 4

1. *'Oku mālie e hiva 'a Lupe.* Lupe's singing is superb.
2. *'Oku mālohi e ngāue 'a Sēmisi.* Sēmisi's working is hard.
3. *Na'e lelei e ako 'a 'Ana.* 'Ana's studying was good.

Exercise 5

1. (a) *'ene ngāue* = his working (verbal noun: action) / (b) *hono ngāue* = his work, his job (concrete noun: thing)
2. (a) *'ene masiva* = his being poor (verbal noun: state) / (b) *hono masiva* = his poverty (abstract noun: quality)
3. (a) *'ene tohi* = his writing (verbal noun: action) / (b) *hono tohi* = his book/letter (concrete noun: thing)

Chapter 46: Noun Classes

Building on the personal-noun and local-noun distinction, this chapter covers the full noun classification system: common nouns as a third type, and the verbs that follow the same pattern.

Two types of nouns

The name *Sione* is already specific: there is no need to say “the Sione.” The place name *Vava’u* is already specific: there is no need to say “the Vava’u.” Words like these are **self-defining nouns**: they are definite on their own. They do not take an article (*e*, *he*, or *ha*) and normally do not carry the definitive accent.

Common nouns are everything else. They need an article to show definiteness. Compare:

Self-defining noun	Common noun
<i>ki Vava’u</i>	<i>ki he motú</i>
(to Vava’u)	(to the island)
<i>kia Mele</i>	<i>ki he fefiné</i>
(to Mele)	(to the woman)

The common noun *motu* (island) needs the article *he* and carries the definitive accent. The self-defining noun *Vava’u* needs neither.

Many nouns can be used both ways. The word *tahi* (sea) can be self-defining (*ki tahi*, to sea, referring to the sea in general) or common (*ki he tahi*, to the sea, referring to a specific body of water).

Personal and local nouns

Both personal nouns and local nouns are self-defining, but each type has an extension.

Group words treated like personal names

The collective noun *hou’eiki* (chiefs, nobility) is not a proper name, but Tongan treats it as one: *kia hou’eiki* (to the chiefs).

Other words treated like place names

Beyond proper place names and familiar local nouns like *’api*, *kolo*, *fale*, and *tahi*, Tongan treats several other words as local nouns when they refer to general locations:

Word	Meaning	Example
<i>’uta</i>	inland, interior	<i>ki ’uta</i> (to the interior)

Word	Meaning	Example
<i>ngoue</i>	garden	<i>ki ngoue</i> (to the garden)
<i>loto</i>	inside	<i>'i loto</i> (inside)

These words function as local nouns because they refer to places that need no further identification. When they take an article and the definitive accent, they become common nouns with a more specific meaning:

ki tahi. (to sea, generally) vs. *ki he tahí* (to the sea, a specific body of water) *'i loto.* (inside) vs. *'i he lotó* (in the mind)

The word *loto* shifts meaning entirely: as a local noun it means “inside” (a place), but as a common noun with an article it means “mind.”

Verbal nouns as a noun class

The previous chapter covered verbal noun constructions in detail. In the classification system, verbal nouns form a third group within common nouns. A verbal noun denotes doing something, having something, or being something.

'ene taki. his leading (he does the leading: 'e-class possessive)
hono taki. his being led (the leading is done to him: ho-class possessive)
The possessive class signals the difference. The 'e-class (*'ene*) marks the doer. The ho-class (*hono*) marks the one acted upon, or names the thing or quality itself.

The same distinction extends to words like *mālohi* (strong), which describe a state rather than an action:

'ene mālohi. his being strong (a state: verbal noun)
hono mālohi. his strength (a quality: abstract noun)

The verbal noun describes the fact that someone is strong. The abstract noun names the quality of strength.

Verbs with 'i and 'ia

Certain verbs take an 'i phrase as their complement, meaning “at,” “in,” or “about.” When the complement is a personal noun, 'i becomes 'ia:

'Okú ne 'ofa he ta'ahiné.

He loves the girl. (common noun: he = 'i he)

'Okú ne 'ofa 'ia Seini.

He loves Seini. (personal noun: 'ia)

'Okú ne 'ita he tamasi'í.

He is angry at the boy. (common noun)

'Okú ne 'ita 'ia Tēvita.

He is angry at Tēvita. (personal noun)

The pattern applies to other verbs that take 'i phrases:

Verb	With common noun ('i	
	he)	With personal noun ('ia)
'ofa	'ofa he fefiné	'ofa 'ia 'Ana
(love)		
'ita	'ita he tamasi'í	'ita 'ia Sione
(angry at)		
sai'ia	sai'ia he me'akaí	sai'ia 'ia Mele
(like)		
loto mamahi	loto mamahi he ngāué	loto mamahi 'ia Lupe
(sad about)		

Note:
With *sai'ia*, the *'i* before *he* drops in speech, as it does in other constructions: *'Oku ou sai'ia he me'akaí* rather than *'Oku ou sai'ia 'i he me'akaí*.

Summary of the classification system

Noun type	Article needed?	Definitive accent?	Preposition forms
Personal (names of people)	No	No	<i>'ia, kia, meia</i>
Local (names of places, quasi-place nouns)	No	No	<i>'i, ki, mei</i>
Common (everything else)	Yes	Yes	<i>'i he, ki he, mei he</i>

The classification determines the preposition form. If you know what type of noun follows a preposition, you know which form to use.

Classifier *la'i*: flat objects

Chapter 31: Existential Expressions introduced the classifier *fo'i* for single, round, or complete objects. The classifier *la'i* works the same way but for objects that are long, thin, and flat. It probably comes from *lau'i* (the leaf of).

- la'i pepa.* a sheet/piece of paper
- la'i papa.* a board
- la'i foomu.* a form (document)
- To'o hake 'a e la'i pepá.*

Pick up the piece of paper.

Na’á ke fakafonu ’a e la’i foomú?

Did you fill out the form?

Classifier	Object type	Example
<i>fo’i</i>	single, round, complete	<i>fo’i moli</i> (an orange)
<i>la’i</i>	long, thin, flat	<i>la’i pepa</i> (a sheet of paper)

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>la’i</i>	classifier	flat objects (from <i>lau’i</i> , the leaf of)

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>’uta</i>	noun (quasi-local)	inland, interior
<i>ngoue</i>	noun (quasi-local)	garden, plantation
<i>tahi</i>	noun (quasi-local)	sea (as location type)
<i>toafa</i>	noun (quasi-local)	wilderness, bush
<i>’api</i>	noun (quasi-local)	homestead (as location type) (also “home” (Ch 6))

Tongan	Type	English
<i>pepa</i>	noun	paper; a sheet of paper
<i>papa</i>	noun	board
<i>foomu</i>	noun	form (a document you fill in)

Exercises

Exercise 1: Choose the correct preposition form

Fill in the blank with the correct form of the preposition in parentheses.

1. Na'á ku 'alu __ Fisi. (ki)
2. Na'á ku lea __ Lupe. (ki)
3. Na'á ne nofo __ Sēmisi. ('i)
4. Te mau folau __ Ha'apai. (mei)
5. Na'á ne tokoni __ faiakó. (ki)
6. Te nau foki __ Siaosi. (mei)

Exercise 2: Personal, local, or common?

For each noun, state whether it is personal, local, or common, then write the correct form of *ki* before it.

1. *Mele*
2. *kolo*
3. *tamasi'i* (definite)
4. *Nuku'alofa*
5. *hou'eiki*
6. *tahi*

Exercise 3: Translate into English

1. *Na'á ne 'alu ki Vava'u.*
2. *'Okú ne 'ofa 'ia 'Ana.*

3. 'Oku mālohi hono ngāuē.
4. Na'á ku lea kia hou'eiki.
5. 'Okú ne 'ita 'ia Sēmisi.
6. 'ene ako vs. hono ako

Exercise 4: Translate into Tongan

1. I went to Nuku'alofa.
2. She spoke to Tēvita.
3. They are coming from Ha'apai.
4. He is angry at Lupe.
5. We stayed at home. (use 'api as a local noun)
6. His writing (the action) vs. his book (the thing)

Exercise 5: Self-defining or common?

For each pair of sentences, explain the difference in meaning.

1. (a) *ki tahi* / (b) *ki he tahi*
2. (a) *'i fale* / (b) *'i he falé*
3. (a) *'i loto* / (b) *'i he lotó*

Exercise 6: Translate into Tongan

1. Pick up the piece of paper.
2. Did you fill out the form?

Answers

Exercise 1

1. *Na'á ku 'alu ki Fisi.* I went to Fiji. (local noun: standard *ki*)
2. *Na'á ku lea kia Lupe.* I spoke to Lupe. (personal noun: *kia*)
3. *Na'á ne nofo 'ia Sēmisi.* He stayed with Sēmisi. (personal noun: *'ia*)
4. *Te mau folau mei Ha'apai.* We will sail from Ha'apai. (local noun: standard *mei*)
5. *Na'á ne tokoni ki he faiakó.* He helped the teacher. (common noun: *ki he*)

6. *Te nau foki meia Siaosi*. They will return from Siaosi. (personal noun: *meia*)

Exercise 2

1. *Mele*. personal: *kia Mele*
2. *kolo*. local: *ki kolo*
3. *tamasi'i* (definite). Common: *ki he tamasi'i*
4. *Nuku'alofa*. local: *ki Nuku'alofa*
5. *hou'eiki*. personal (quasi-personal): *kia hou'eiki*
6. *tahi*. local (quasi-local): *ki tahi*

Exercise 3

1. He went to Vava'u.
2. He loves 'Ana.
3. His work is hard. (abstract noun with ho-class possessive: the quality of his work)
4. I spoke to the chiefs.
5. He is angry at Sēmisi.
6. *'ene ako* = his studying (verbal noun: the action) vs. *hono ako* = his education/studies (abstract noun: the thing itself)

Exercise 4

1. *Na'á ku 'alu ki Nuku'alofa*.
2. *Na'á ne lea kia Tēvita*.
3. *'Oku nau ha'u mei Ha'apai*. (or *Te nau ha'u mei Ha'apai*.)
4. *'Okú ne 'ita 'ia Lupe*.
5. *Na'a mau nofo 'i 'api*.
6. *'ene tohi* (his writing, the action) vs. *hono tohi* (his book, the thing)

Exercise 5

1. (a) *ki tahi* = to sea (self-defining local noun: the sea in general, as a direction or destination) / (b) *ki he tahí* = to the sea (common noun: a specific body of water, identified by the article and definitive accent)

2. (a) *'i fale* = at the house / at home (self-defining local noun: the familiar location) / (b) *'i he falé* = in the house (common noun: a specific building)
3. (a) *'i loto* = inside (self-defining local noun: the interior of something) / (b) *'i he lotó* = in the mind (common noun: a different meaning entirely)

Exercise 6

1. *To'o hake 'a e la'i pepá.*
2. *Na'á ke fakafonu 'a e la'i foomú?*

Chapter 47: Conditionals and Counterfactuals

This chapter introduces *ka*, a marker for conditional and hypothetical situations: “if and when,” “whenever,” “had you done this,” and “if it weren’t for.”

Conditional future *ka*

Ka ha’u ’a Siale, peá ke tala ki ai.

When Siale comes, tell him.

The word *ka* at the start of a clause marks a condition the speaker expects to happen. Siale is likely coming; the question is when. The main clause follows with *pea* (and then) or stands on its own with a future tense marker.

When the subject of the *ka* clause is a noun, *ka* appears once, directly before the verb:

Ka puke ’a Mele, peá ke tala mai.

If Mele gets sick, tell me.

The pattern is: *ka* + verb + *’a* + noun subject.

Pronoun subjects: the double ka

When the subject is a pronoun, the pronoun sits between the conjunction *ka* and a second *ka* that serves as the future tense marker (replacing *te* or *'e* inside conditional clauses):

Ka ke ka faka'osi ho'o ngāue, té ke fiefia lahi.

Whenever you finish your work, you will be very happy.

The first *ka* is the conjunction (“if/when”). The pronoun *ke* (you) comes next. The second *ka* is the future tense marker.

Ka nau ka lea mai, té u tala kiate kinautolu.

If they speak to me, I will tell them.

Subject type	Pattern	Example
Noun	<i>ka</i> + verb + <i>'a</i> + noun	<i>Ka ha'u 'a Siale ...</i>
Pronoun	<i>ka</i> + pronoun + <i>ka</i> + verb	<i>Ka ke ka faka'osi ...</i>

ka* versus *kapau

Chapter 30: Temporal and Conditional Conjunctions introduced *kapau* (if). Both words express conditions, but they differ in how likely the speaker considers the outcome.

Kapau 'e ha'u 'a Sēmisi, té u loto mamahi.

If Sēmisi comes, I will be upset. (He probably will not come.)

Ka ha'u 'a Sēmisi, té u loto mamahi.

When(ever) Sēmisi comes, I will be upset. (He is probably coming.)

kapau leaves the outcome open. *ka* leans toward it happening. In many contexts, *ka* translates as “whenever” rather than “if.”

***ka 'i ai*: whenever there is**

The existential *'i ai* (there is/are) combines with *ka* to express “whenever there is” or “if there is.” This is the conditional future form of *'oku 'i ai*:

Ka 'i ai ha ngāue, peá ke tala mai.

Whenever there is work, tell me.

Ka 'i ai ha me'a ke fai, peá ke ha'u.

If there is something to do, come.

Past conditional *ka ne*: what might have been

Ka ne ke ha'u 'anepō, na'e 'ikai ke hoko e kovi ní.

Had you come last night, this bad thing would not have happened.

The combination *ka ne* marks a counterfactual condition about the past: something that did not happen, and what would have resulted if it had. *Ka ne* is a shortened form of *kapau na'e* (if + past tense marker).

The main clause uses a past tense marker to express the imagined result:

Ka ne u feinga, na'á ku lava.

Had I tried, I would have succeeded.

Ka ne lava mai 'a e faiakó, na'a tau fiefia lahi.

If the teacher had been able to come, we would have been very happy.

Subject type	Pattern
Pronoun	<i>ka ne</i> + pronoun + verb
Noun	<i>ka ne</i> + verb + ('a) + noun

Note:
The first-person singular pronoun after *ka ne* is *u* (not *ku* or *ou*): *Ka ne u ha'u ...*
(Had I come ...).

Tongan uses its past tense forms for imaginary situations, just as English does. “If Sione *were* here” uses a past-like verb form even though it refers to the present. Tongan follows the same logic with *ka ne*.

Present counterfactuals with *ka ne*

Ka ne also expresses present situations that are not true:
Ka ne 'i heni 'a Tēvita, 'e hiva.

If Tēvita were here, he would sing.

Ka ne 'i heni 'a Lupe, kuo 'osi e ngāué.
Were Lupe here, the work would be finished.

Tēvita is not here right now, but the speaker imagines the result if he were. The main clause uses different tense markers depending on the imagined result:

Main clause marker	Meaning	Example
<i>'e</i>	would (single action)	<i>'e hiva</i> (he would sing)
<i>'oku</i>	would be (ongoing)	<i>'oku hiva</i> (he would be singing)
<i>kuo</i>	would have already	<i>kuo 'osi e ngāué</i> (the work would be finished)

***ka ne 'ikai*: if it were not for**

Ka ne 'ikai 'a Sione, 'oku kei vaivai pē 'emau ngāue.

If it were not for Sione, our work would still be weak.

The phrase *ka ne 'ikai* means “if it were not for” or “if it had not been for.” It names a person or thing whose presence or action prevents a worse outcome:

Ka ne 'ikai 'a Mele, 'oku 'ikai lava e ngāué.

If it were not for Mele, the work could not be done.

The main clause takes whatever tense marker fits the imagined result.

***ta'e'oua*: an alternative**

Ta'e'oua carries the same meaning as *ka ne 'ikai*. It always appears after *ka ne* or *kapau na'e*:

Ka ne ta'e'oua ia, kuó u tō.

If it had not been for him, I would have fallen.

Ka ne ta'e'oua 'ene tokoni lelei, 'oku mau kei vaivai pē.

If it were not for her good help, we would still be weak.

Ta'e'oua is a compound of *ta'e* (not) and *'oua* (refrain), forming a double negative that means “were it not.”

Moderative *mei*: nearly, would, should, might

The adverb *mei* (nearly), placed before the verb, softens the statement:

Kuo mei 'osi.

It is nearly finished.

Kuo nau mei 'alu atu.

They have nearly gone.

In conditional sentences, *mei* appears in the main clause to express what “would” or “might” have happened:

Ka ne 'ikai ke pehē, na'á ku mei 'ita.

If it were not so, I would be angry.

Na'e 'ikai mei lava 'eku ha'ú ka ne ta'e'oua 'a e vaká.

I would not have been able to come if it had not been for the boat.

The connection between “nearly” and “would” is natural: something that would have happened in an imagined scenario is something that nearly happened in reality. *Mei* covers both senses.

***Hei'ilo*: who knows, perhaps**

The expression *hei'ilo* stands alone or introduces a clause to signal that the speaker does not know what will happen. It translates as “who knows” or “perhaps.”

Hei'ilo pē 'e 'alu 'a Sione 'apongipongi.

Who knows whether Sione will go tomorrow.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>ka</i>	conjunction (conditional)	when, if and when, whenever (future) (also “but” (Ch 24))
<i>ka ne</i>	past conditional form	if ... had (counterfactual)
<i>hei'ilo</i>	expression	who knows, perhaps

Exercises**Exercise 1: Fill in the blank**

Choose *ka*, *kapau*, or *ka ne* to complete each sentence.

1. ___ ha'u 'a 'Ana, peá ke tala ki ai. (She is expected.)
2. ___ 'e ha'u 'a 'Ana, peá ke tala ki ai. (You are not sure she will come.)
3. ___ ke ha'u 'anepō, na'e 'ikai ke hoko 'a e me'a ní.
4. ___ 'i ai ha ngāue, peá ke tala mai.
5. ___ u feinga, na'á ku lava.
6. ___ ke ka 'alu ki kolo, peá ke fakatau mai ha mā.

Exercise 2: Translate into English

1. *Ka ne 'i heni 'a Sēmisi, 'e tokoni.*
2. *Ka 'i ai ha ika, te mau kai.*
3. *Kapau 'e 'uhá, te mau nofo 'i fale.*
4. *Ka ne 'ikai 'a Lupe, 'oku kei vaivai pē 'emau ngāue.*
5. *Kuo mei 'osi e ngāué.*
6. *Ka ne u ako, na'á ku poto.*

Exercise 3: Translate into Tongan

1. Had I come, I would have helped.
2. If Tēvita were here, he would sing.
3. Whenever there is fish, tell me.
4. If it were not for Siale, the work would not be finished.
5. It is nearly finished.
6. Whenever you go to town, buy bread.

Exercise 4: Match

Match each *ka ne* clause (1-5) with the correct main clause (a-e).

	<i>ka ne</i> clause		Main clause
1.	<i>Ka ne 'i heni 'a Mele ...</i>	a.	<i>na'á ku tokoni.</i>
2.	<i>Ka ne u 'ilo ...</i>	b.	<i>'oku 'ikai lava e ngāué.</i>
3.	<i>Ka ne 'ikai 'a Sēmisi ...</i>	c.	<i>kuo 'osi e ngāué.</i>
4.	<i>Ka ne ke tala mai ...</i>	d.	<i>na'á ku ha'u.</i>
5.	<i>Ka ne ta'e'oua 'ene tokoni ...</i>	e.	<i>'oku mau kei vaivai pē.</i>

Answers

Exercise 1

1. *Ka ha'u 'a 'Ana, peá ke tala ki ai.* When 'Ana comes, tell her. (ka*: she is expected)*
2. *Kapau 'e ha'u 'a 'Ana, peá ke tala ki ai.* If 'Ana comes, tell her. (kapau*: uncertain)*
3. *Ka ne ke ha'u 'anepō, na'e 'ikai ke hoko 'a e me'a ní.* Had you come last night, this thing would not have happened. (ka ne*: past counterfactual)*
4. *Ka 'i ai ha ngāue, peá ke tala mai.* Whenever there is work, tell me. (ka*: expected or recurring)*
5. *Ka ne u feinga, na'á ku lava.* Had I tried, I would have succeeded. (ka ne*: past counterfactual)*
6. *Ka ke ka 'alu ki kolo, peá ke fakatau mai ha mā.* Whenever you go to town, buy bread. (ka ... ka*: pronoun subject, conditional future)*

Exercise 2

1. If Sēmisi were here, he would help.
2. Whenever there is fish, we will eat.
3. If it rains, we will stay in the house.
4. If it were not for Lupe, our work would still be weak.
5. The work is nearly finished.
6. Had I studied, I would have been smart.

Exercise 3

1. *Ka ne u ha'u, na'á ku tokoni.*
2. *Ka ne 'i heni 'a Tēvita, 'e hiva.*
3. *Ka 'i ai ha ika, peá ke tala mai.*
4. *Ka ne 'ikai 'a Siale, 'oku 'ikai ke 'osi e ngāué.*
5. *Kuo mei 'osi.*
6. *Ka ke ka 'alu ki kolo, peá ke fakatau mai ha mā.*

Exercise 4

1-c, 2-a, 3-e, 4-d, 5-b

Were Mele here, the work would be finished. Had I known, I would have helped. If it were not for Sēmisi, we would still be weak. Had you told me, I would have come. If it were not for her help, the work could not be done.

Chapter 48: Suffixes

Word Study

Tongan has a set of productive suffixes that create new nouns, adjectives, and verbs from existing words. Where the prefix *faka-* attaches to the front of a word, suffixes attach to the end.

A suffix is a short element added after a word to change its meaning or function. English does this too: “teach” becomes “teacher” with the suffix *-er*. Tongan suffixes work the same way, and once you learn them, you can decode unfamiliar words on sight and create new ones yourself.

***-’anga*: place, source, or means**

nofo’anga. dwelling-place (from *nofo*, to stay/live)

The suffix *-’anga* turns a verb (or occasionally a stative) into a noun that names the place, source, or means of the action. The pattern is simple: verb + *-’anga* = the place where, or thing through which, the action happens.

ako’anga. school, seat of learning (from *ako*, to study)

ngāue’anga. workplace (from *ngāue*, to work)

kai’anga. eating-place (from *kai*, to eat)

fiefia’anga. source of happiness (from *fiefia*, happy)

These nouns can also be used as adjectives by placing them after another noun: *fale nofo’anga* (dwelling-house), *loki ngāue’anga* (work-room). The *-’anga* noun narrows down what kind of building or room it is.

A noun formed with *-’anga* can be followed by the object of the original verb: *kili’anga papa*. place for sawing boards, sawmill (from *kili*, to saw, and *papa*, board)

tuku’anga tohi. place for keeping books, bookcase (from *tuku*, to put, and *tohi*, book)

Verb/stative	+ <i>-’anga</i>	Meaning
<i>nofo</i> (stay)	<i>nofo’anga</i>	dwelling-place
<i>ako</i> (study)	<i>ako’anga</i>	school
<i>ngāue</i> (work)	<i>ngāue’anga</i>	workplace
<i>kai</i> (eat)	<i>kai’anga</i>	eating-place
<i>mohe</i> (sleep)	<i>mohe’anga</i>	sleeping-place
<i>fiefia</i> (happy)	<i>fiefia’anga</i>	source of happiness
<i>tuku</i> (put)	<i>tuku’anga</i>	storage place

-nga: thing (not place)

The suffix *-nga* looks similar to *-’anga* but the difference matters. Where *-’anga* points to a place, *-nga* points to a thing.

mohe’anga. sleeping-place (where you sleep)

mohenga. bed (the thing you sleep on)

tu’u’anga. standing-place, site

tu’unga. stand, ladder, or (figuratively) rank, status

In some cases the difference is small: *mālohi’anga* (source of strength) versus *mālohinga* (that which strengthens). But the general distinction holds: *-’anga* answers “where?” and *-nga* answers “what?”

Other examples with *-nga*:

Verb	+ <i>-nga</i>	Meaning
<i>vahe</i> (divide)	<i>vāhenga</i>	portion, division
<i>toe</i> (remain)	<i>toenga</i>	remainder
<i>fou</i> (go by a route)	<i>founga</i>	route, method
<i>ako</i> (learn)	<i>ākonga</i>	disciple, student

Note:
Some words formed with *-nga* involve a vowel change in the base word. *Ako* becomes *ākonga* (disciple) with a lengthened first vowel. *Fotu* (to appear) becomes

fōtunga (appearance) with a long *ō*. These are irregular and must be learned individually.

Transitive suffixes: the *-a* type (durational)

An earlier chapter introduced the distinction between transitive verbs (which take an object) and intransitive verbs (which do not). Tongan has two types of transitive suffixes. The first type (endings like *-ʻi*, *-hi*, *-si*) was covered in an earlier chapter. This section covers the second type: suffixes ending in *-a*.

A verb with a first-type suffix (*-ʻi*) tends to emphasize carrying the action through to completion. A verb with a second-type suffix (*-a*) has a different character. It may express the action as a process or ongoing state rather than a completed event. It often appears without a named agent, making it equivalent to the English passive. And it can sound less abrupt, more courteous or emotional.

folau. to voyage (intransitive)

folaua. to voyage toward (transitive, durational, the journey viewed as a process)

ʻilo. to know (transitive)

ʻiloa. to be well known (durational, often used without an agent)

ʻOku ʻiloa ʻa Sēmisi.

Sēmisi is well known. (Lit. “Is known Sēmisi”)

The durational character is fundamental. When a verb takes the *-a* suffix, the action is presented as something with duration, not a single sharp event. This naturally leads to impersonal use (no agent stated), because a state or process often matters more than who caused it.

Adjective and intransitive suffixes: *-a*, *-fia*, *-hia*, *-ia*, *-ina*

These suffixes turn nouns into adjectives or intransitive verbs describing a state. They answer the question: “What condition is it in?”

The suffix -a (from nouns)

Add -a to a concrete noun to get an adjective meaning “covered with” or “abounding in” that thing:

Noun	+ -a	Meaning
<i>efu</i> (dust)	<i>efua</i>	dusty
<i>niu</i> (coconut)	<i>niua</i>	abounding in coconut trees
<i>lango</i> (fly)	<i>langoa</i>	infested with flies
<i>namu</i> (mosquito)	<i>namua</i>	full of mosquitoes

’Oku fu’u efua ’aupito ’a e halá.

The road is very dusty.

This suffix also appears in familiar compound words you already know: *fie-mo-hea* (sleepy), *fie-inua* (thirsty), *fie-kaia* (hungry). Each is built from *fie-* (wanting) plus a verb plus -a.

Other state suffixes

The suffixes -*fia*, -*hia*, -*ia*, and -*ina* work similarly, forming intransitive verbs that describe states:

Base	Suffix	Result	Meaning
<i>tonu</i> (right, just)	- <i>hia</i>	<i>tonuhia</i>	innocent, not guilty

Base	Suffix	Result	Meaning
<i>hala</i> (to err)	<i>-ia</i>	<i>halaia</i>	guilty
<i>'uha</i> (rain)	<i>-ina</i>	<i>'uheina</i>	caught in the rain
<i>ili</i> (apprehensive)	<i>-fia</i>	<i>ilifia</i>	frightened

Na’á ku ’uheina.

I was caught in the rain.

These verbs are intransitive even though their English translations often sound passive (“was caught,” “was paralyzed”). They describe the subject’s state, not an action done to the subject by someone.

Two ways to say “passive”

Tongan has no passive verb form. When you want to express something equivalent to the English passive, you have two options. The first is the impersonal transitive: use a transitive verb without naming the agent. *Na’e foa’i ’a e ipú.* (The cup was broken, by someone.) The second is a state-describing intransitive verb. *Na’e mafoa ’a e ipú.* (The cup broke, it is in a broken state.) Both translate as “the cup was broken” in English, but the first implies someone broke it; the second simply describes the result.

-’ia: possessing, regarding as, emphasizing

The suffix *-’ia* has three distinct uses, all productive and common.

1. Possessing or abounding in

Attached to a noun, *-’ia* means “having,” “characterized by,” or “abounding in”:

koloa'ia. wealthy (from *koloa*, wealth)

kakai'ia. densely populated (from *kakai*, people)

Ko e fonua kakai'ia 'a 'Amelika.

America is a densely populated land.

'Oku kumā'ia e ngouē.

The garden is infested with rats. (Lit. “Is rat-abounding the garden”)

Noun	+ -'ia	Meaning
<i>koloa</i>	<i>koloa'ia</i>	wealthy
(wealth)		
<i>kakai</i>	<i>kakai'ia</i>	populated
(people)		
<i>kumā</i>	<i>kumā'ia</i>	infested with rats
(rat)		
<i>mamahi</i>	<i>mamahi'ia</i>	in pain
(pain)		
<i>pupuha</i>	<i>pupuha'ia</i>	covered in sweat
(sweat)		

2. *Regarding as*

Attached to adjectives, *-'ia* forms intransitive verbs meaning “to regard as” or “to consider or find to be” what the adjective means. The verb is followed by *'i* (with a noun) or the adverb *ai* (referring back to something already mentioned):

'Oku ou lelei'ia ai.

I regard it as good. I am pleased with it.

Na'á ku faka'ofa'ia 'ia Siale.

I felt sorry for Siale.

Na'á ke mālie'ia he hivá?

Did you enjoy the song?

The connection between uses 1 and 2 is logical. *Faingata'a'ia* can mean “having difficulty” (use 1: possessing difficulty) or, with *ai*, “finding it difficult” (use 2: regarding as difficult). The suffix works the same way; the context determines which reading applies.

3. *Emphasizing*

Attached to *'ikai* (before *ko*), to *noa* (worthless), or to question words like *fē* (which), *-ia* intensifies the meaning:

'Oku 'ikai'ia ko ia pē.

It is not only that. (Emphasizing: truly not just that.)

Ha va'inga noa'ia pē.

An utterly worthless game.

***Fai'aki*: a special *-'aki* verb**

The suffix *-'aki*, covered in an earlier chapter, creates transitive verbs meaning “to use as.” One *-'aki* verb deserves special attention here. *Fai'aki* (from *fai*, to do) means “to manage with,” “to decide upon,” or “to let something suffice”:

Tau fai'aki pē ho'o fakakaūkau.

We will go along with your opinion.

Possessive suffix *-i*: compound nouns

The suffix *-i* works differently from the others in this chapter. It does not create a verb or an adjective. Instead, it bonds two nouns together into a tight compound, replacing the preposition *'o* (of).

Compare the loose form and the compound form:

Ko e mata 'o e helé.

The blade of the knife. (Two separate noun phrases joined by 'o.)

Ko e mata'i hele.

The knife-blade. (One compound noun.)

The compound form is tighter and more specific. The first noun names a part (*mata*, blade/edge/face) and the second names the whole (*hele*, knife). The *-i* suffix fuses them.

Loose form	Compound	Meaning
<i>mata 'o e hele</i>	<i>mata'i hele</i>	knife-blade
<i>'ulu 'o e ika</i>	<i>'ulu'i ika</i>	fish-head
<i>tefito 'o e me'a</i>	<i>tefito'i me'a</i>	principal thing, root of the matter

Na'e lavea 'a e tamasi'i he mata'i taó.

The boy was injured on the point of the spear.

Some *-i* compounds have idiomatic meanings. *Mo'oni'i me'a* (lit. “truth-of thing”) means “fact.” *Mingimingi'i me'a* (lit. “shrivellings-of things”) means “details, fine points.” These are fixed expressions worth learning as vocabulary.

-ngata'a (hard to) and -ngofua (easy to)

These two suffixes attach to verbs to express difficulty or ease:

Verb	+ -ngata’a	+ -ngofua
<i>ma’u</i>	<i>ma’ungata’a</i>	<i>ma’ungofua</i>
(get)	(hard to get)	(easy to get)
<i>fai</i>	<i>faingata’a</i>	<i>faingofua</i>
(do)	(difficult)	(easy)
<i>’alu</i>	<i>’alungata’a</i>	–
(go)	(hard going, rough)	
<i>mahae</i>	–	<i>mahaengofua</i>
(tear)		(tears easily)
<i>’ita</i>	–	<i>’itangofua</i>
(be angry)		(quick to anger)

’Oku ma’ungata’a ’aupito ’a e me’akái ’i he taimi ení.
Food is very hard to get right now.

’Oku faingofua ke ako e lea faka-Tongá.
It is easy to learn the Tongan language.

You already know *faingata’a* (difficult) from earlier chapters. Now you can see that it is built from *fai* (do) + *-ngata’a* (hard to). The word was always a suffix construction.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
-’anga	suffix	place, source, or means of
-nga	suffix	result or product (not place)
-a	suffix (transitive)	process, duration
-a	suffix (adjectival)	covered with, abounding in
-fia	suffix (stative)	state or condition
-hia	suffix (stative)	state or condition
-ia	suffix (stative)	state or condition
-ina	suffix (stative)	state or condition
-’ia	suffix	possessing; regarding as; emphasizing
-’i	suffix (compound nouns)	of, pertaining to (replaces ’o) (also “makes verb transitive” (Ch 33))
-ngata’a	suffix	hard to, difficult to
-ngofua	suffix	easy to

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>nofo’anga</i>	noun	dwelling place
<i>ako’anga</i>	noun	school, place of learning
<i>ngāue’anga</i>	noun	workplace

Tongan	Type	English
<i>vāhenga</i>	noun	salary, share
<i>founga</i>	noun	method, way
<i>ākonga</i>	noun	student, pupil
<i>toenga</i>	noun	remainder
<i>tu'unga</i>	noun	stand, ladder; rank, status
<i>koloa'ia</i>	adjective	wealthy
<i>mamahi'ia</i>	adjective	in pain, aggrieved
<i>ilifia</i>	adjective	afraid
<i>tonuhia</i>	adjective	justified, righteous
<i>halaia</i>	adjective	guilty
<i>mata'i hele</i>	noun	blade of a knife
<i>'ulu'i ika</i>	noun	head of a fish
<i>tefito'i me'a</i>	noun	main thing

Exercises

Exercise 1: Form the word

Add the suffix shown to the base word and give the meaning.

1. *nofo* + *-'anga* = ____ (meaning: ____)
2. *mohe* + *-nga* = ____ (meaning: ____)
3. *koloa* + *-'ia* = ____ (meaning: ____)
4. *fai* + *-'aki* = ____ (meaning: ____)
5. *mata* + *-'i* + *hele* = ____ (meaning: ____)
6. *fai* + *-ngata'a* = ____ (meaning: ____)
7. *ma'u* + *-ngofua* = ____ (meaning: ____)

8. *efu* + *-a* = ____ (meaning: ____)

Exercise 2: Translate into English

1. 'Oku koloa'ia 'a e kakaí 'o e koló.
2. Ko e mohenga ení 'oku mālohi.
3. 'Oku ma'ungata'a 'aupito 'a e iká.
4. 'Oku mau ngāue'aki 'a e tohí.
5. Ko e mata'i helé 'oku mālohi.

Exercise 3: Translate into Tongan

1. The road is very dusty.
2. America is a populated land.
3. I am pleased with it. (Use *lelei'ia ai*.)
4. She used the basket.
5. The knife-blade is sharp.

Exercise 4: -'anga or -nga?

Choose the correct suffix for each sentence and translate.

1. Ko e mohe__ 'o Siale 'oku fo'ou. (Siale's __ is new.)
2. Ko e nofo__ ko ení 'oku lahi. (This dwelling-__ is big.)
3. Ko e tu'u__ 'o e faiakó 'oku mālohi. (The teacher's __ is strong.)
4. Ko e mohe__ 'o e fānau 'oku 'i lalo. (The children's sleeping-__ is downstairs.)

Exercise 5: Fill in the blank

Choose from: -'ia, -'aki, -a, -ngata'a, -ngofua

1. 'Oku kumā__ 'a e falé. The house is infested with rats.
2. 'Oku mau sipinga__ 'ene ngāué. We use his work as an example. (*sipinga* = pattern, from Chapter 33)
3. 'Oku langu__ 'a e me'akái. The food is infested with flies. (from *lango*)
4. 'Oku ma'u__ 'a e iká 'i he tahí. Fish is easy to get in the sea.
5. 'Oku fai__ ke ako e lea faka-Tongá. It is difficult to learn the Tongan language.

Answers**Exercise 1**

1. *nofo'anga* (dwelling-place)
2. *mohenga* (bed)
3. *koloa'ia* (wealthy)
4. *fai'aki* (to manage with, to let suffice)
5. *mata'i hele* (knife-blade)
6. *faingata'a* (difficult, hard to do)
7. *ma'ungofua* (easy to get)
8. *efua* (dusty)

Exercise 2

1. The people of the village are wealthy.
2. This bed is strong/sturdy.
3. Fish is very hard to get.
4. We are using the book.
5. The knife-blade is strong/sharp.

Exercise 3

1. 'Oku fu'u efua 'aupito 'a e halá.
2. Ko e fonua kakai'ia 'a 'Amelika.
3. 'Oku ou lelei'ia ai.
4. Na'e ngāue'aki 'e ia 'a e kató.
5. 'Oku mālohi 'a e mata'i helé.

Exercise 4

1. *mohenga* (bed): Siale's bed is new.
2. *nofo'anga* (dwelling-place): This dwelling-place is big.
3. *tu'unga* (rank, standing): The teacher's standing is strong.
4. *mohe'anga* (sleeping-place): The children's sleeping-place is downstairs.

Exercise 5

1. *kumā'ia*. The house is infested with rats.
2. *sipinga'aki*. We use his work as an example.
3. *langoa*. The food is infested with flies.
4. *ma'ungofua*. Fish is easy to get in the sea.
5. *faingata'a*. It is difficult to learn the Tongan language.

Chapter 49: Prefixes

Word Study

This chapter covers four prefixes that attach to the front of a word. Each one changes the meaning of the verb or noun it modifies in a specific, predictable way.

A prefix is a short element added before a word to change its meaning. English does this with *un-* (undo), *re-* (redo), and *co-* (coworker). Tongan prefixes work the same way, and you already know one: *faka-*. The four prefixes here are *fe-*, *ma-* (with its variants *mo-* and *mā-*), *mo'u-*, and *kaungā-*.

***fe-* with *-'aki*: reciprocal and reciprocative verbs**

'Oku nau fe'ofa'aki.

They love one another.

The prefix *fe-* combined with the suffix *-'aki* creates verbs expressing reciprocal action (doing something to each other) or reciprocative movement (going back

and forth). These two meanings shade into each other, and context tells you which one applies.

To build a *fe-...-’aki* verb, wrap the base verb: *fe-* goes in front, *-’aki* goes at the end.

Base verb	<i>fe-...-’aki</i> form	Meaning
<i>’ofa</i> (love)	<i>fe’ofa’aki</i>	to love one another
<i>tokoni</i> (help)	<i>fetokoni’aki</i>	to help each other
<i>lea</i> (speak)	<i>felea’aki</i>	to speak to each other
<i>tohi</i> (write)	<i>fetohi’aki</i>	to write to each other
<i>talanoa</i> (talk)	<i>fetalanoa’aki</i>	to talk to one another
<i>tali</i> (wait)	<i>fetali’aki</i>	to wait for each other
<i>’ita</i> (be angry)	<i>fe’ita’aki</i>	to be angry with each other

The reciprocative sense (back and forth) appears with movement verbs:

Base verb	<i>fe-...-’aki</i> form	Meaning
<i>’alu</i> (go)	<i>fe’alu’aki</i>	to go back and forth

Base verb	<i>fe</i> -...-'aki form	Meaning
'ave	<i>fe'āveaki</i>	to carry back and forth (carry)
<i>folau</i>	<i>fefolau'aki</i>	to travel back and forth (voyage)

Because these verbs describe mutual action, their subjects are always dual or plural. You cannot use *fe'ofa'aki* with a single person.

'Okú na fetokoni'aki.

They two help each other.

Na'a nau fetalanoa'aki 'i he efiāfi.

They talked to one another in the evening.

'Oku totonu ke ta fe'ofa'aki.

We should love one another.

***fe*- with other suffixes: communal and reciprocal verbs**

The prefix *fe*- also combines with suffixes other than -'aki. With suffixes like -i, -fi, -hi, and -ni, *fe*- forms communal verbs (doing something together or simultaneously) and reciprocal verbs.

Communal verbs describe a group acting at the same time. Their subjects are always dual or plural:

Base verb	<i>fe</i> - form	Meaning
<i>lele</i>	<i>felelei</i>	to run together (plural) (run)

Base verb	<i>fe-</i> form	Meaning
<i>kata</i> (laugh)	<i>fekata'i</i>	to laugh together
<i>tangi</i> (weep)	<i>fetāngihi</i>	to weep together
<i>hū</i> (enter)	<i>fehuufi</i>	to enter together

Reciprocal verbs with these suffixes describe mutual states:

Base	<i>fe-</i> form	Meaning
<i>'ofo'ofa</i> (friendly)	<i>fe'ofo'ofani</i>	to be friendly with one another
<i>'ite'ita</i> (ill-will)	<i>fe'ite'itani</i>	to harbour mutual ill-will
<i>loto</i> (mind, will)	<i>felotoi</i>	to agree with each other

Some *fe-* verbs have no suffix at all. These are common enough to learn as vocabulary:

Base	<i>fe-</i> form	Meaning
<i>tongi/totongi</i> (pay)	<i>fetongi</i>	to replace, take the place of
<i>kumi</i> (seek)	<i>fekumi</i>	to search together

Base	<i>fe-</i> form	Meaning
<i>tuku</i>	<i>fetuku</i>	to carry from one place to another (put)

One *fe-* verb worth special attention is *fetu’utaki*, meaning “to communicate” or “to be in contact.” It appears frequently in modern Tongan:

’Okú na fetu’utaki ma’u pē.

They two communicate constantly.

Note:

Several *fe-* verbs have meanings that cannot be predicted from the base word alone. *Fetongi* (to replace) is related to *totongi* (to pay), but the connection is not obvious. *Fepaki* (to collide) probably comes from *pā* (to touch). These are best learned as vocabulary items.

***ma-*: potential (ability discovered by trial)**

mahiki. able to lift (from *hiki*, to lift)

The prefix *ma-* attached to a transitive verb means “to be able to do” what the verb describes. The ability is discovered by trying: you attempt the action, and *ma-* tells the listener whether you succeed or fail. Many transitive verbs can take *ma-* in this sense.

Na’á ke mahiki e puha ko iá?

Were you able to lift that box?

’Oku ’ikai ke mafai ’e ia e ngāué.

He cannot manage the work.

The distinction from *lava* (to be able to), which you learned in Chapter 21: Auxiliary Verbs, is important. *Lava* describes general ability or capacity. *Ma-* describes ability proven in the moment, by actual trial.

ma-, mo-, mā-: resultative state

mahae. to be torn (from *hae*, to tear)

The same prefix *ma-* (along with its variants *mo-* and *mā-*) has a second, different use. Attached to certain verbs, it forms intransitive verbs describing a state that results from an action. The action may have happened accidentally, spontaneously, or by an unknown agent.

Na’e mahae ’a e kofu ’o Sialé.

Siale’s garment was torn. (Something tore it, or it tore on its own.)

Compare this with the active transitive: *Na’e hae ’e ia ’a e kofú.* (He tore the garment.) The *ma-* form describes the result without naming who or what caused it.

Base verb	<i>ma-/mo-/mā-</i> form	Meaning
<i>hae</i> (tear)	<i>mahae</i>	to be torn
<i>kohi</i> (scratch)	<i>makohi</i>	to be scratched
<i>to’o</i> (take off)	<i>mato’o</i>	to come off
<i>hiki</i> (lift)	<i>mahiki</i>	to be slightly raised
<i>fusi</i> (pull)	<i>mafusi</i>	to be pulled slightly out of position
<i>vete</i> (take apart)	<i>movete</i>	to come to pieces

Base verb	<i>ma-/mo-/mā-</i> form	Meaning
<i>vae</i>	<i>māvae</i>	to be separated, parted
(divide)		

Some *ma-* forms carry a sense of “slightly” or “a little,” suggesting a small or accidental result rather than a complete one:

mafusi. to be pulled slightly out of position (from *fusi*, to pull)

mateke. to be pushed slightly out of position (from *teke*, to push)

Na’e movete ’a e vaká.

The boat came to pieces.

Kuó na māvae.

They two have parted.

Note:
The same verb can have both the potential meaning and the resultative meaning. *Mahiki* can mean “able to lift” (potential) or “slightly raised” (resultative). Context and sentence structure make the intended sense clear.

An idiomatic use of *ma-* appears after *ke* in paired expressions emphasizing thoroughness:

Ako ke maako.

To learn thoroughly. (Lit. “Study so-as-to ma-study”)

Tu’u ke matu’u.

To stand firm.

Puke ke mapuke.

To hold tightly.

The pattern is verb + *ke* + *ma-* + verb, and it means carrying the action to its proper result or full extent.

mo’u-: continuation or overdoing

mo’umohea. to oversleep (from *mohe*, to sleep)

The prefix *mo’u-* indicates that an action or state continues for an unusually long time, often longer than intended. It is related to *ma’u* (firm, continuous). The suffix *-a* is added to the end of the verb along with *mo’u-* at the front.

When building *mo’u-* verbs, the final vowel of the base word changes: a short final *-a* becomes long *-ā* under the suffix. But if the word already ends in long *-ā*, it stays as it is.

Base verb	<i>mo’u-...-a</i> form	Meaning
<i>mohe</i> (sleep)	<i>mo’umohea</i>	to oversleep
<i>tu’u</i> (stand)	<i>mo’utu’ua</i>	to remain standing too long
<i>’ā</i> (be awake)	<i>mo’u’ā</i>	to stay awake too long
<i>nofo</i> (stay)	<i>mo’unofoa</i>	to overstay
<i>sio</i> (look, watch)	<i>mo’usioa</i>	to stay too long watching
<i>tali</i> (wait)	<i>mo’utalia</i>	to wait too long

Kātaki’i ’eku tōmui, na’á ku mo’umohea.

Forgive my lateness, I overslept.

Kuo mo’unofoa ’a e vaká ’i he motú.

The boat has stayed too long at the island.

Kuó ne mo’utu’ua ’i he māketí.

He has been standing too long at the market.

***kaungā*:- fellow, together**

kaungāngāue. fellow-worker (from *ngāue*, to work)

The prefix *kaungā*- adds the meaning “together” or “fellow” to verbs and some nouns. It describes shared experience, joint action, or the relationship of doing something alongside others.

With verbs:

Base verb	<i>kaungā</i> - form	Meaning
<i>ngāue</i> (work)	<i>kaungāngāue</i>	to work together, fellow-worker(s)
<i>lotu</i> (worship)	<i>kaungālotu</i>	to worship together, fellow-worshipper(s)
<i>ako</i> (study)	<i>kaungā ako</i>	fellow student(s)
<i>mamahi</i> (suffer)	<i>kaungā mamahi</i>	fellow sufferer(s)

With nouns:

Base noun	<i>kaungā</i> - form	Meaning
<i>’api</i> (home, allotment)	<i>kaungā ’api</i>	neighbour(s) (whose allotment adjoins yours)
<i>me’a</i> (thing)	<i>kaungāme’a</i>	associate(s)

kaungā- verbs can also function as nouns (as you would expect from the word-class flexibility covered in Chapter 41: Word Class Flexibility):

hoku kaungāngāue. my fellow-worker(s)
hotau kaungālotu. our fellow-worshipper(s) (inclusive)
’Ofa ki ho kaungā ’apí.
Love your neighbour.

Na’a mau kaungā ako fakataha.
We were fellow students together.

Mou omi ke tau kaungā ngāue hení.
Come so we can be fellow workers here.

Note:
Nouns formed with *kaungā*- can take the plural marker *ngaahi*, but they often carry a collective sense without it. *Hoku kaungāngāue* can mean “my fellow-worker” or “my fellow-workers” depending on context.

ve’e as a variant of va’e

The word *ve’e* appears before nouns meaning “by the side of” or “the side of.” It is likely a variant of *va’e* (foot, leg), which you know from the spatial nouns covered in Chapter 40: Spatial Nouns. You may encounter *ve’e* in phrases like *ve’e hala* (roadside) or *ve’e fale* (the side of the house).

’Okú ne tu’u he ve’e halá.

He is standing by the roadside.

This is a lexical variant, not a new grammar pattern.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>fe-...-’aki</i>	reciprocal prefix + suffix	each other, one another
<i>fe-</i>	prefix (reciprocal)	mutual action
<i>ma-</i>	prefix (potential)	able to be (discovered by trial)
<i>ma-/mo-/mā-</i>	prefix (resultative)	in a state resulting from
<i>mo’u-</i>	prefix	continuing or overdoing
<i>kaungā-</i>	prefix	fellow, together

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>fe’ofa’aki</i>	verb	love one another
<i>fetokoni’aki</i>	verb	help one another
<i>fetalanoa’aki</i>	verb	converse with one another
<i>fe’alu’aki</i>	verb	go back and forth
<i>fetongi</i>	verb	exchange, take turns
<i>fekumi</i>	verb	search together
<i>fetu’utaki</i>	verb	communicate

Tongan	Type	English
<i>mahiki</i>	verb	be able to lift
<i>mafai</i>	verb	be able to be done
<i>mahae</i>	adjective	torn
<i>māvae</i>	adjective	separated
<i>movete</i>	adjective	fallen apart
<i>mo'umohea</i>	verb	oversleep, sleep too long
<i>kaungāngāue</i>	noun	fellow worker
<i>kaungālotu</i>	noun	fellow worshipper
<i>kaungāme'a</i>	noun	companion, friend

Exercises

Exercise 1: Build the *fe-...-’aki* form

Give the *fe-...-’aki* form and its meaning.

1. *’ofa* (love) → ____ (meaning: ____)
2. *tokoni* (help) → ____ (meaning: ____)
3. *lea* (speak) → ____ (meaning: ____)
4. *talanoa* (talk) → ____ (meaning: ____)
5. *’alu* (go) → ____ (meaning: ____)
6. *tohi* (write) → ____ (meaning: ____)

Exercise 2: Translate into English

1. *’Oku nau fe’ofa’aki.*
2. *Na’á ma fetokoni’aki ’i he ngāué.*
3. *’Oku totonu ke ta felea’aki.*
4. *Na’e mahae ’a e falá.*
5. *Kuó ne mo’umohea.*

6. *Ko hoku kaungāngāue 'a Tēvita.*

Exercise 3: Translate into Tongan

1. They two talk to one another every day.
2. The clothes were torn.
3. She overslept.
4. We were fellow students together.
5. The boat came to pieces.
6. Love your neighbour.

Exercise 4: ma- potential or ma- resultative?

For each sentence, state whether *ma-* expresses potential (ability) or resultative (resulting state), then translate.

1. *Na'á ke mahiki e puha ko iá?*
2. *Na'e mahae 'a e kofú.*
3. *Na'e movete 'a e katō.*
4. *'Oku 'ikai ke mafai 'e ia e ngāué.*

Exercise 5: Fill in the prefix

Choose from: *fe-...-'aki*, *ma-*, *mo'u-*, *kaungā-*

1. Na'e ___ 'a e falá. (The mat was torn.) [prefix: ___]
2. Na'a nau ___'aki 'i he efiáfí. (They talked to one another in the evening.)
[prefix + suffix: ___]
3. Kuo ___ 'a Mele. (Mele has overslept.) [prefix: ___]
4. Ko hoku ___ 'a Sēmisi. (Sēmisi is my fellow-worker.) [prefix: ___]
5. 'Okú na ___ ma'u pē. (They two communicate constantly.) [verb with prefix: ___]

Answers

Exercise 1

1. *fe'ofa'aki* (to love one another)

2. *fetokoni'aki* (to help each other)
3. *felea'aki* (to speak to each other)
4. *fetalanoa'aki* (to talk to one another)
5. *fe'alu'aki* (to go back and forth)
6. *fetohi'aki* (to write to each other)

Exercise 2

1. They love one another.
2. We two helped each other with the work.
3. We (two) should speak to each other.
4. The mat was torn.
5. He/she has overslept.
6. Tēvita is my fellow-worker.

Exercise 3

1. 'Okú na *fetalanoa'aki* 'i he 'aho kotoa.
2. Na'e mahae 'a e ngaahi valá.
3. Na'á ne mo'umohea.
4. Na'a mau kaungā ako fakataha.
5. Na'e movete 'a e vaká.
6. 'Ofa ki ho kaungā 'apí.

Exercise 4

1. Potential: Were you able to lift that box?
2. Resultative: The garment was torn.
3. Resultative: The basket came to pieces.
4. Potential: He cannot manage the work.

Exercise 5

1. *mahae*. *ma-* (resultative prefix)
2. *fetalanoa'aki*. *fe-...-'aki* (reciprocal)
3. *mo'umohea*. *mo'u-* (continuation)
4. *kaungāngāue*. *kaungā-* (fellow)

5. *fetu'utaki*. *fe-* (communal, no *-'aki* suffix)

Chapter 50: Reduplication and Expressive Sound Devices

Word Study

This chapter covers reduplication, where part or all of a word is repeated to create a new meaning. It also introduces expressive sound devices that stretch vowels to shift meaning.

kata means “to laugh.” *katakata* means “to smile” (to laugh slightly). The base word is repeated in full, and the meaning softens. This is one of several effects reduplication can have in Tongan, and the pattern is highly productive.

Types of reduplication

Tongan has three main types of reduplication, depending on which part of the word gets repeated.

Complete reduplication

The entire word is repeated:

Base word	Reduplicated form	Meaning
<i>kata</i> (laugh)	<i>katakata</i>	to smile (laugh slightly)
<i>kehe</i> (different)	<i>kehekehe</i>	various
<i>kofu</i> (garment)	<i>kofukofu</i>	bundle, parcel

In some cases the repeated portion shows a vowel change:

Base word	Reduplicated form	Meaning
<i>mu'a</i> (front, n.)	<i>mu'omu'a</i>	to go in front
<i>mafi</i> (powerful)	<i>māfīmafi</i>	almighty

Fully reduplicated words carry two stresses, one on each half: *kátakáta*, *kéhekéhe*. The main stress falls on the second half, as you would expect from the general rule that the last stress in a word is the principal one.

Partial reduplication: early part repeated

The beginning of the word is repeated:

Base word	Reduplicated form	Meaning
<i>mata</i> (face, eye)	<i>mamata</i>	to look, to see

Base word	Reduplicated form	Meaning
<i>fo'ou</i> (new)	<i>fo'ofō'ou</i>	somewhat new, unfamiliar
<i>po'uli</i> (dark)	<i>pōpō'uli</i>	somewhat dark, overcast

Notice that *pōpō'uli* shows a vowel change: the repeated *po* becomes *pō*.

Partial reduplication: later or middle part repeated

Less common, but worth recognising:

Base word	Reduplicated form	Meaning
<i>havili</i> (strong wind)	<i>hivilivili</i>	gentle wind, breeze
<i>talinga</i> (ear)	<i>talingelinga</i>	fungus

In the middle type, the middle syllables of a longer word are repeated:
fesiofaki (to eye one another) → *fesiosiofaki* (to keep eyeing one another)

Effects of reduplication

The type of reduplication (complete or partial) does not by itself determine the meaning. The same process can produce different effects depending on the base word. The main effects are:

Plurality, repetition, or continuance

Reduplication can signal “more than one,” “again and again,” or “for a sustained period.” These three senses shade into each other:

kupu (a single segment or section) → *kupukupu* (segments, sections: three or more)

tosi (to peck once) → *tositosi* (to peck repeatedly)

vakai (to look) → *vakavakai* (to keep on looking)

pakipaki and *pakipaki'i* mean “to break into many pieces,” from *paki'i* (to break). Compare *paki ua* (to break into two): the reduplication signals plurality.

Intensification

Reduplication can strengthen or amplify the meaning:

Base word	Reduplicated form	Meaning
<i>'uli</i> (dirty)	<i>'uli'uli</i>	black
<i>kātoa</i> (all, whole)	<i>katokatoa</i>	absolutely all
<i>fiefia</i> (to rejoice)	<i>fiefia</i> → built from <i>fia</i> + <i>fia</i>	to rejoice (the word itself is a historical reduplication)

'Oku 'uli'uli 'a e langi hé.
The sky over there is black.

Na'e katokatoa 'a e kau akó.
Absolutely all the students were there.

Moderation

Reduplication can soften or moderate the meaning, expressing “somewhat” or “a little.” This is the opposite of intensification, and context or the addition of *pē* (just, only) often signals the moderative sense:

Base word	Reduplicated form	Meaning
<i>māfana</i> (warm)	<i>māmāfana</i>	lukewarm
<i>momoko</i> (cold)	<i>mokomoko</i>	cool
<i>kata</i> (laugh)	<i>katakata</i>	smile (laugh slightly)
<i>havili</i> (strong wind)	<i>hivilivili</i>	breeze (gentle wind)
<i>fakasio</i> (to watch, stare)	<i>fakasiosio</i>	to peep

’Oku māmāfana ’a e vaí.
The water is lukewarm.

Na’e mokomoko ’a e efiafi.
The evening was cool.

Note:
Some reduplicated forms can carry either an intensifying or a moderating meaning depending on context. *Lahilahi*, from *lahi* (big), can mean “quite big” or “moderately big.” The moderative sense is often signalled by adding *pē*: *’oku lahilahi pē* (it is just moderately big).

Meaning modification without changing part of speech

Some reduplicated forms modify the meaning in ways that go beyond simple intensification or moderation, while the word remains the same part of speech:

Base word	Reduplicated form	Meaning
<i>tapu</i> (forbidden, sacred)	<i>toputapu</i>	sacred (higher register)
<i>taki</i> (lead by the hand)	<i>tataki</i>	guide
<i>moho</i> (cooked)	<i>momoho</i>	ripe
<i>fili</i> (choose)	<i>fi fili</i>	ponder, wonder
<i>langa</i> (build)	<i>lalanga</i>	weave
<i>vale</i> (foolish)	<i>valevale</i>	baby (not yet able to think)
<i>fanongo</i> (listen)	<i>fanongōnongo</i>	to announce, publish

These are best learned as vocabulary. The connection between the base word and the reduplicated form is usually visible, but the specific meaning shift is not always predictable.

Changing part of speech

Reduplication can turn a word from one part of speech into another. You already know from Chapter 41: Word Class Flexibility that Tongan words move between classes freely. Reduplication is one of the regular mechanisms for this.

Noun → adjective:

Base noun	Reduplicated adjective	Meaning
<i>luo</i> (hole)	<i>luoluo</i>	full of holes
<i>va'a</i> (branch)	<i>va'ava'a</i>	branched, branching
<i>toto</i> (blood)	<i>totototo</i>	blood-coloured, red
<i>vai</i> (water)	<i>vaivai</i>	weak (watery)

'Oku *luoluo* 'a e *halá*.

The road is full of holes.

'Oku *totototo* 'a e *langi* 'i he *efiafi*.

The sky is red in the evening.

Noun → verb:

Base noun	Reduplicated verb	Meaning
<i>pou</i> (post, pillar)	<i>poupou</i>	to support
<i>filo</i> (thread)	<i>filofilo</i>	to spin (make thread)
<i>mata</i> (face)	<i>mamata</i>	to look, to see

Adverb → noun:

Base adverb	Reduplicated noun	Meaning
<i>hake</i> (up)	<i>hahake</i>	the east
<i>hifo</i> (down)	<i>hihifo</i>	the west

You have seen *hahake* and *hihifo* before as directional terms. They are, in origin, reduplicated forms of the directional particles *hake* and *hifo*.

faka- combined with reduplication

The prefix *faka-*, which you learned in Chapter 32: The *Faka-* Prefix, combines with reduplication to moderate or otherwise modify a word’s meaning. The base word is reduplicated and *faka-* is added at the front:

Base word	<i>faka-</i> + reduplication	Meaning
<i>poto</i> (clever)	<i>fakapotopoto</i>	sensible, wise
<i>ala</i> (to touch)	<i>fakaalaala</i>	to be careful, cautious
<i>hanga</i> (to face)	<i>fakahangahanga</i>	to intend
<i>fua</i> (to measure)	<i>fakafuofua</i>	to estimate
<i>ma’u</i> (to get, be firm)	<i>fakama’uma’u</i>	to restrain oneself

Base word	<i>faka-</i> + reduplication	Meaning
<i>'ai</i> (to place, cause)	<i>faka'ai'ai</i>	to incite, encourage

The effect is often one of moderation or abstraction. *Poto* means “clever” in a direct, concrete sense. *Fakapotopoto* means “wise” or “sensible,” a more considered quality. *Fua* means “to measure” precisely. *Fakafuofua* means “to estimate,” a less exact action.

'Oku fakapotopoto 'a e faiakó.

The teacher is wise.

Na'á ne fakafuofua 'a e mamafá.

He estimated the weight.

Note:
Not every *faka-* + reduplicated form follows this pattern. *Fakamu'omu'a* (to put in front, to give preference to) is simply the causative of *mu'omu'a* (to go in front), not a moderated form. The word-building process is the same, but the meaning comes from the regular causative function of *faka-*.

Expressive sound devices

Reduplication repeats syllables to modify meaning. Tongan also manipulates vowel length itself as an expressive tool. These devices stretch the sounds of the language to signal intensity, duration, or ceremony.

Vowel protraction for superlativeness

la—hi. very very big, enormous

Tongan can express extreme degree by drawing out a vowel far beyond normal length. This is not the same as a long vowel marked with a macron. A protracted vowel is held for several times the length of an ordinary long vowel, stretching the word as the speaker stretches the meaning.

The vowel that gets protracted is usually the one that carries the main stress. In *lahi* (big), the stress falls on the *a*, so protracting it produces *la—hi*, meaning something far beyond merely big.

si—’i. very very small, absolutely tiny

mani—fi. very very thin

The dashes in the spelling represent the drawn-out vowel. In speech, the speaker simply holds the vowel for as long as the emotion demands. There is no fixed duration. A speaker describing something merely very big might hold the vowel for a second. A speaker describing something astonishingly big might hold it for three or four.

This is different from using *’aupito* (very) or *lahi* (much) as modifiers. Those words intensify within normal speech rhythm. Vowel protraction breaks the rhythm deliberately, signalling that ordinary intensifiers are not enough.

Vowel protraction for duration

The same technique expresses extended duration with certain verbs:

tu—’u. to stand for a very long time

fuolo—a. for a very very long time

Here the protracted vowel does not mean “very much standing” but “standing for an extremely long time.” The speaker holds the vowel to mirror the length of time being described.

Note:

Whether protraction signals superlativeness or duration depends on the word. With adjectives/statives like *lahi* (big) or *si’i* (small), it means extreme degree. With verbs like *nofo* (sit/stay) or *tu’u* (stand), it means prolonged duration.

Ceremonial protraction of the definite article

In formal or respectful speech, the definite article *e* can itself be protracted:
Fakafeta'i e— toka kava!
(Ceremonial) Thank you for the kava.

The word *fakafeta'i* is the respectful form of “thank you,” used instead of *mālō* in formal settings. The protracted article *e—* adds weight and ceremony to the expression. The casual equivalent would be *Mālō e ma'u kava!* (Thank you for the kava), with no protraction.

This kind of protraction is heard in ceremonial occasions: the arrival of a distinguished visitor, formal gift-giving, or speeches at traditional gatherings. It signals that the speaker is observing protocol, not just making conversation.

Customary shouts

Tongan has fixed exclamatory shouts in which a vowel is always protracted:

Shout	Emotion	Comparable to
<i>Tue—!</i>	Joy, exultation	“Hooray!”
<i>'Iohoe—!</i>	Grief, pain, distress	A cry of anguish
<i>Iu—huhū!</i>	Alarm	A warning cry

Tue—! often appears in a repeated form: *Tuētutuētutue—!* The *tuē* may be repeated any number of times, building excitement with each repetition.

'Iohoe—! is the opposite: a cry of sudden or overwhelming grief. Its protracted final vowel carries the weight of the speaker’s distress.

Iu—huhū! begins on a very high note and serves as an alarm call.

These are fixed expressions. They are not built from productive grammar rules. You learn them as complete units, the way English speakers learn “Hooray!” or “Help!”

Vowel lengthening for emphasis in repeated verbs

A related but distinct device appears when a verb is repeated immediately (with no word between the two occurrences) to express long continuance. The stressed vowel of the verb is lengthened, but not protracted to the extreme degree described above:

Na’a nau tūli tūli ’o a’u ki he vao.

They chased and chased all the way to the bush.

The original verb *tuli* (to chase) has its penultimate vowel *u* lengthened to *ū* when repeated: *tūli tūli*. This lengthening signals that the chasing went on for a long time, not just that it happened twice.

Na’á ne tohi tohi pea ’osi ’a e tohí.

He wrote and wrote until the book was finished.

Here *tohi* does not show visible lengthening in spelling because its stressed vowel *o* is already short and the lengthening is subtle. The key structural signal is the immediate repetition of the verb.

The pattern is: repeat the verb with no intervening word, optionally lengthen the stressed vowel, and the meaning shifts from simple repetition to prolonged or exhaustive action.

Words to Learn

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>katakata</i>	verb	smile, laugh slightly
<i>mu’omu’a</i>	adjective	early, in good time
<i>mamata</i>	verb	look at, watch
<i>pakipaki</i>	verb	break into many pieces

Tongan	Type	English
<i>vakavakai</i>	verb	investigate
<i>toputapu</i>	adjective	sacred, holy
<i>tataki</i>	verb	lead, guide
<i>momoho</i>	adjective	ripe
<i>fifili</i>	verb	hesitate, be uncertain
<i>fanongōnongo</i>	verb	announce, publish
<i>valevale</i>	adjective	confused, foolish
<i>fakapotopoto</i>	verb	be careful, be wise
<i>fakaalaala</i>	verb	be alert, be cautious
<i>fakama'uma'u</i>	verb	be moderate, be restrained
<i>faka'ai'ai</i>	verb	encourage
<i>vao</i>	noun	bush, outback
<i>langi</i>	noun	sky

Exercises

Exercise 1: Identify the type

For each pair, state whether the reduplication is complete, partial (early), or partial (later/middle).

1. *kata* → *katakata*
2. *mata* → *mamata*
3. *havili* → *havilivili*
4. *kehe* → *kehekehe*
5. *fo'ou* → *fo'ofu'ou*
6. *fesiofaki* → *fesiosiofaki*

Exercise 2: Identify the effect

For each reduplicated word, state whether the effect is intensification, moderation, plurality/repetition, or part-of-speech change.

1. 'uli'uli (black, from 'uli dirty)
2. māmāfana (lukewarm, from māfana warm)
3. kupukupu (segments, from kupu segment)
4. luoluo (full of holes, from luo hole)
5. katakata (smile, from kata laugh)
6. katokatoa (absolutely all, from kātoa all)

Exercise 3: Translate into English

1. 'Oku māmāfana 'a e tī ko iá.
2. Na'e 'uli'uli 'a e langi 'anepō.
3. 'Oku fakapotopoto 'a e tangata ko iá.
4. Na'e mokomoko 'a e vaí.
5. 'Oku luoluo 'a e hala ki he 'utá.
6. Na'á ne fakafuofua 'a e taimí.

Exercise 4: Translate into Tongan

1. The water is lukewarm.
2. That woman is wise.
3. The evening was cool.
4. The road is full of holes.
5. He estimated the weight.
6. The sky is black.

Exercise 5: Build the faka- + reduplication form

Give the faka- + reduplicated form and its meaning.

1. poto (clever) → ____ (meaning: ____)
2. fua (measure) → ____ (meaning: ____)
3. ma'u (get, be firm) → ____ (meaning: ____)
4. hanga (face) → ____ (meaning: ____)

5. *ala* (touch) → ____ (meaning: ____)

Exercise 6: Complete reduplication or faka- + reduplication?

Fill in the correct form of the word in brackets.

1. 'Oku ____ 'a e vaí. (The water is lukewarm.) [*māfana*]
2. 'Oku ____ 'a Sēmisi. (Sēmisi is wise.) [*poto*]
3. Na'e ____ 'a e halá. (The road was full of holes.) [*luo*]
4. Na'á ne ____ 'a e me'á. (He estimated the thing.) [*fua*]
5. 'Oku ____ 'a e langi hé. (The sky over there is black.) [*'ulī*]

Exercise 7: Identify the expressive device

For each item, state whether the device is (a) vowel protraction for superlativeness, (b) vowel protraction for duration, (c) ceremonial protraction, (d) a customary shout, (e) vowel lengthening in a repeated verb, or (f) none of these.

1. *la—hi*
2. *Tue—!*
3. *Na'á ne tūli tūli 'a e puaká.*
4. *Fakafeta'i e— toka kava!*
5. *no—fo*
6. *si—'i*
7. *'Tohoe—!*

Exercise 8: Transform using vowel protraction or repetition

Rewrite each sentence to express the meaning in parentheses.

1. 'Oku lahi 'a e falé. → (The house is absolutely enormous.)
2. Na'á ne nofo 'i he kolo ko iá. → (He stayed in that town for a very long time.)
3. Na'a nau kumi 'a e tamasi'í. → (They searched and searched for the child.)
4. 'Oku si'i 'a e me'á. → (The thing is absolutely tiny.)
5. Na'á ne tu'u 'i he hala ko iá. → (He stood on that road for a very long time.)

Answers**Exercise 1**

1. *kata* → *katakata*: complete
2. *mata* → *mamata*: partial (early)
3. *havili* → *hivilivili*: partial (later)
4. *kehe* → *kehekehe*: complete
5. *fo'ou* → *fo'ofu'ou*: partial (early)
6. *fesiofaki* → *fesiosiofaki*: partial (middle)

Exercise 2

1. *'uli'uli*: intensification
2. *māmāfana*: moderation
3. *kupukupu*: plurality
4. *luoluo*: part-of-speech change (noun → adjective)
5. *katakata*: moderation
6. *katokatoa*: intensification

Exercise 3

1. That tea is lukewarm.
2. The sky was black last night.
3. That man is wise.
4. The water was cool.
5. The road to the interior is full of holes.
6. He estimated the time.

Exercise 4

1. *'Oku māmāfana 'a e vai.*
2. *'Oku fakapotopoto 'a e fefine ko iá.*
3. *Na'e mokomoko 'a e efiafi.*
4. *'Oku luoluo 'a e halá.*
5. *Na'á ne fakafuofua 'a e mamafá.*
6. *'Oku 'uli'uli 'a e langí.*

Exercise 5

1. *fakapotopoto* (sensible, wise)
2. *fakafuofua* (to estimate)
3. *fakama'uma'u* (to restrain oneself)
4. *fakahangahanga* (to intend)
5. *fakaalaala* (to be careful, cautious)

Exercise 6

1. *māmāfana*
2. *fakapotopoto*
3. *luoluo*
4. *fakafuofua*
5. *'uli'uli*

Exercise 7

1. (a) Vowel protraction for superlativeness.
2. (d) A customary shout (joy/exultation).
3. (e) Vowel lengthening in a repeated verb (prolonged chasing).
4. (c) Ceremonial protraction of the definite article.
5. (b) Vowel protraction for duration (sitting/staying for a very long time).
6. (a) Vowel protraction for superlativeness (extremely small).
7. (d) A customary shout (grief/distress).

Exercise 8

1. *'Oku la—hi 'a e falé.*
2. *Na'á ne no—fo 'i he kolo ko iá.*
3. *Na'a nau kūmi kūmi 'a e tamasi'í.*
4. *'Oku si—'i 'a e me'á.*
5. *Na'á ne tū—'u 'i he hala ko iá.*

Chapter 51: Special Pronoun Uses

This chapter introduces several special pronoun uses that expand the Tongan pronoun system.

English has the word “one” used as an indefinite pronoun: “One should not speak too quickly.” Tongan has the same concept, using the first-person inclusive singular pronoun *te* (preposed) and *kita* (postposed) in a way that goes beyond their literal meaning of “I and you.”

The impersonal pronoun: *te* and *kita*

You already know *te* as the first-person inclusive singular preposed pronoun (I-and-you). In its impersonal use, *te* and *kita* mean “one” in the indefinite sense: anyone in general, including the speaker and the listener.

'Oku 'ikai totonu ke te tokanga pē kiate kita.

One should not attend only to oneself.

The structure is identical to any other pronoun sentence: tense marker + subordinator *ke* + pronoun *te* + verb. But here *te* does not mean “I and you (two).” It means “a person in general.” And *kita* (the postposed form) means “oneself.”

This impersonal meaning is the primary function of *te/kita*. A second, related use is as a polite or humble way to say “I” or “me.” Instead of using *ou* (I) directly, a speaker may choose *te* to sound less self-centred:

’Okú te mā kita.

One is ashamed. (Or: I am ashamed, said humbly.)

The effect is similar to saying “one finds oneself embarrassed” in English instead of “I’m embarrassed.” The speaker is technically including everyone, but the meaning is clearly personal.

’Okú te fie ’alu ka ’oku ’ikai te lava.

One wants to go but one cannot.

Here the speaker is talking about a personal wish but frames it through the impersonal *te* out of modesty.

Note:
The compound *siokita* means “selfish” (literally “look after oneself”). Its opposite is *ta’esiokita*, “unselfish,” using the negative prefix *ta’e*- you learned previously.

Impersonal possessive forms

Just as the regular pronouns have possessive forms, the impersonal pronoun has its own set. These follow the same two-class system (’e-class and ho-class) you already know:

Form	Class	Meaning
<i>’ete</i>	’e-class preposed definite	one’s (things one controls)

Form	Class	Meaning
<i>hoto</i>	ho-class preposed definite	one’s (things that characterise one)
<i>ha’ate</i>	’e-class preposed indefinite	one’s (indefinite, ’e-class)
<i>hato</i>	ho-class preposed indefinite	one’s (indefinite, ho-class)

The class distinction works the same way as with all other possessive pronouns. Use *’ete* for things you act upon or control (’e-class), and *hoto* for things that belong to you by nature or shelter you (ho-class):

’Oku totonu ke tauhi ’e te ’ete ngāué.
One should take care of one’s work.

’Oku totonu ke tokanga ki hoto fāmilí.
One should care for one’s family.

The postposed forms are *’a’ata* (’e-class) and *’o’ota* (ho-class), meaning “of one’s” or “of mine” (humbly). The benefactive forms are *ma’ata* (’e-class) and *mo’ota* (ho-class), meaning “for one” or “for me” (humbly).

Rhetorical dual for plural

Tongan speakers sometimes use the dual (two-person) pronoun where you might expect the plural (three-or-more), to create a sense of personal intimacy. A preacher addressing a congregation might say *ke ta* (that we two, you and I) instead of *ke tau* (that we all), making the appeal feel direct and personal rather than addressed to a crowd.

This applies to all types of pronouns: cardinal pronouns, possessive pronouns, pronominal adjectives, and pronominal adverbs. The effect is to make a general statement feel like a conversation between two people.

Ke ta feinga ke fai 'a e ngāuē.

That we strive to do the work. (Said to a group, but using the dual to create closeness.)

Where the plural *tau* would be factually accurate, the dual *ta* draws the listener in as though the speaker is talking to each person individually.

Dual for singular idiom

A related but distinct pattern: when a situation involves two or more people, Tongan often prefers a pronoun that includes everyone involved, even if the English equivalent would single out just one person.

Na'á ma nofo mo ia.

I stayed with him.

The pronoun *ma* means “we two (excluding you).” But the English meaning is “I stayed with him,” not “We two stayed.” Tongan uses *ma* because both the speaker and the other person were involved in the staying. The togetherness is built into the pronoun itself rather than expressed separately.

This pattern extends across persons:

Té mo nofo mo ia?

Will you stay with him?

Here *mo* means “you two.” English says “Will you stay with him?” but Tongan sees the situation as involving both people and chooses the dual pronoun accordingly.

Na'a nau talanoa mo ia.

They talked with him.

Even if only two people were talking with him, *nau* (they, three or more) is used because, including him, there were three people involved. The pronoun counts everyone in the situation, not just the grammatical subject.

Note:

This is not an error or a special exception. It reflects a fundamental difference in how Tongan conceptualises group actions. Where English focuses on who is doing the action (“I stayed”), Tongan focuses on who is in the situation (“we-two were staying together”).

***kau*: first person singular at the start of a sentence**

When the first-person singular pronoun appears as the very first word in a sentence (with no tense marker before it), Tongan uses the form *kau*:

Kau 'alu mu'a?

May I go, please?

Kau fufulu mu'a 'eku ipu.

Let me wash my cup.

This *kau* is simply another form of “I,” used only in sentence-initial position. Do not confuse it with *ka u* (but I) or *ka u* (if/when I), where *ka* is a conjunction and *u* is the pronoun. In *kau 'alu mu'a*, there is no conjunction: *kau* is the pronoun by itself.

Cardinal pronouns in a relative sense

Pronouns you already know as personal (“I,” “you,” “he”) can also function like English “who” or “which” when they appear in a clause that describes a noun:

Ko au 'oku ou lolotonga lea kiate koé, ko au ia.

I who am speaking to you am he.

The second *ou* does not introduce a new person. It refers back to *au* (I) in a relative sense: “I, who am speaking.” English would use “who” here. Tongan simply repeats the pronoun.

Ko kimoutolu kuo mou toki a'u mai, kuo pau ke mou ō leva ki he koló.

You who have just arrived must go to town at once.

The first *mou* functions as “who” (you who have just arrived). The second *mou* is the regular pronoun in the obligation clause.

This works with all persons. The pronoun in the relative clause matches the person it refers back to:

'Oku 'aonga kiate kitautolu kotoa pē 'oku tau fie 'alu 'i he hala totonú.

It is of value to all of us who want to walk the right path.

Here *tau* (we, inclusive) is used in a relative sense: “all of us who want to walk.”

***te* and *'e* without their future meaning**

In certain types of clauses, *te* and *'e* do not indicate the future tense. Instead, they simply mark where the verb of the description begins. The actual tense comes from the main clause.

This happens specifically in adjectival clauses (clauses that describe a noun), most commonly when the noun being described is indefinite:

'Oku 'ikai ha tamasi'i ako heni té ne ta'e 'ofa ki homou fonuá.

There is not a school child here who does not love your country.

The main clause uses *'oku* (present tense). The relative clause uses *té ne*, but this does not mean “who will not love” (future). It means “who does not love” (present), matching the main clause.

Na'e 'ikai ha'ane lea 'e fai.

He did not say a word. (Lit. There was not a word of his to say.)

Here the main clause is past (*na'e*), and *'e* in the relative clause also carries past meaning despite looking like the future marker.

This usage appears to be confined to adjectival clauses whose antecedent (the noun being described) is indefinite, typically after expressions like *'oku 'ikai ha* (there is not a...) or *na'e 'i ai ha* (there was a...).

ne vs. na’a/na’e: a note on nuance

You have used *na’a* and *na’e* as past tense markers throughout this book. There is a third form, *ne*, which also marks the past tense but carries an additional shade of meaning: it implies that what happened was “as expected” or “as intended.”
Na’e ’alu ’a Sione.

Sione went. (Simple past, neutral.)

Ne ’alu ’a Sione.

Sione went. (As planned, as expected.)

Ne ’ikai ke ’alu ’a Sione.

Sione did not go (as we expected him to).

This is a subtle distinction. In everyday use, *na’a/na’e* and *ne* are often interchangeable. But when you encounter *ne* in texts, you may notice this implication of expectation behind it.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>te</i>	impersonal pronoun	one (indefinite); also humble “I”
<i>kita</i>	impersonal postposed pronoun	oneself
<i>’ete</i>	impersonal possessive (’e-class)	one’s

Tongan	Function	English
<i>hoto</i>	impersonal possessive (ho-class)	one's
<i>ha'ate</i>	impersonal indefinite possessive ('e-class)	a ... of one's
<i>hato</i>	impersonal indefinite possessive (ho-class)	a ... of one's
<i>'a'ata</i>	impersonal postposed possessive ('e-class)	of one's
<i>'o'ota</i>	impersonal postposed possessive (ho-class)	of one's
<i>ma'ata</i>	impersonal benefactive ('e-class)	for one
<i>mo'ota</i>	impersonal benefactive (ho-class)	for one
<i>kau</i>	first-person pronoun (sentence-initial)	I (at start of sentence); a separate word <i>kau</i> marks groups of people (Ch 20)

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>siokita</i>	verb	be selfish
<i>ta'esiokita</i>	verb	be unselfish
<i>loi</i>	verb	lie, tell a lie

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English

1. 'Oku 'ikai totonu ke te loi kiate kita.
2. 'Okú te fie tokoni ka 'oku 'ikai te lava.
3. Kau nofo mu'a 'i hení?
4. Na'á ma lea mo ia.
5. 'Oku totonu ke tauhi 'e te hoto fāmílí.
6. Té mo 'alu mo ia ki he tokonakí?
7. 'Oku 'ikai ha taha 'e ta'e fie 'alu ki ai.

Exercise 2: Translate English to Tongan

1. One should not eat too much.
2. May I sit here, please?
3. I stayed with her. (Use the dual-for-singular idiom.)
4. One's work is important.
5. They talked with him. (Three or more people involved.)
6. One wants to study but one cannot.

Exercise 3: Choose the correct form

Select the most appropriate pronoun form for each blank.

1. 'Oku 'ikai totonu ke ___ siokita. (*te / ou / tau*)
2. ___ 'alu mu'a 'o sio? (*Kau / Ku / Ka u*)
3. Na'á ___ nofo mo ia. (I stayed with him.) (*ku / ma / ta*)
4. Té ___ haka mo ia? (Will you dance with her?) (*ke / mo / mou*)
5. 'Oku totonu ke tauhi 'e te ___ ngāué. (*'ete / 'eku / hoto*)

Exercise 4: Transform these sentences

Rewrite each sentence using the impersonal pronoun *te/kita* instead of the given personal pronoun.

1. 'Oku ou fie 'alu ka 'oku 'ikai té u lava. →
2. 'Oku 'ikai totonu ke u tokanga pē kiate au. →
3. 'Oku ou mā 'aupito. →

Exercise 5: Identify the dual-for-singular pattern

In each sentence, identify which pronoun uses the dual-for-singular (or more-inclusive) idiom and explain who is actually meant.

1. *Na'á ma 'alu ki he māketí mo ia.*
 2. *Té mo ako mo ia?*
 3. *Na'a nau ngāue fakataha mo ia.*
-

Answers**Exercise 1**

1. One should not lie to oneself.
2. One wants to help but one cannot.
3. May I stay here, please?
4. I spoke with him. (Lit. We two spoke with him, using dual-for-singular.)
5. One should take care of one's family.
6. Will you (two) go with him to the provisions?
7. There is no one who does not want to go there.

Exercise 2

1. *'Oku 'ikai totonu ke te kai lahi 'aupito.*
2. *Kau nofo mu'a 'i hení?*
3. *Na'á ma nofo mo ia.*
4. *'Oku mahu'inga 'a hoto ngāué.*
5. *Na'a nau talanoa mo ia.*
6. *'Okú te fie ako ka 'oku 'ikai te lava.*

Exercise 3

1. *te* (impersonal “one”)
2. *Kau* (first person singular, sentence-initial)
3. *ma* (dual for singular: I stayed with him)
4. *mo* (dual: you and her together)

5. 'ete ('e-class: work is something one controls/acts upon)

Exercise 4

1. 'Okú te fie 'alu ka 'oku 'ikai te lava.
2. 'Oku 'ikai totonu ke te tokanga pē kiate kita.
3. 'Okú te mā 'aupito kita.

Exercise 5

1. *ma* (we two, excluding you) refers to “I” alone. The speaker went to the market with the other person, so Tongan uses the dual to include both participants.
2. *mo* (you two) refers to “you” alone. The listener will study with the other person, so Tongan includes both in the pronoun.
3. *nau* (they, three or more) may refer to just two people. Because the third person (the one after *mo ia*) is also involved, Tongan counts everyone in the situation.

Chapter 52: Emotional Articles and Possessives

This chapter introduces emotional articles and possessives, words that signal feelings of pity, affection, endearment, or humility.

You already know the three neutral articles: indefinite *ha* and semi-definite/definite *e/he*. Tongan has a parallel set that does the same job but also carries emotional weight.

The emotional definite article: *si'i*

'Oku hela 'a si'i hōsí.

The poor horse is tired.

The word *si'i* replaces the ordinary definite article *e* and adds a feeling of pity, affection, or sympathy. The horse is not just “the horse.” It is “the poor horse,” the one the speaker feels sorry for.

Ko e fē si'i tamaiki 'a Tēvita?

Where are Tēvita's dear children?

Here *si'i* signals affection. The speaker is not making a neutral inquiry. The word “dear” or “poor” is built into the article itself.

The emotion *si'i* carries depends on context. It may suggest:

- **Pity:** the poor horse, the unfortunate child
- **Affection:** the dear children, the beloved family
- **Humility:** the humble servant (when referring to oneself or one's own things)
- **Endearment:** the little darling, the sweet one

'Oku fakamamahi 'aupito si'i mate 'a e fa'e mo si'i fānaú.

The unfortunate death of the mother and the poor children is very sad.

Si'i stands in the same position as any article: before the noun it modifies. It carries the definitive accent just as *e* does (note *hōsí* and *fānaú* with accent on the final vowel in the examples above).

Note:

The word *si'i* has other uses in Tongan. As a postposed adjective, it means “small” or “little” (*ha konga si'i* = a small piece). As a postposed adverb, it means “for a short time.” As a preposed article, which is the use taught here, it carries emotional colouring. Position tells you which function *si'i* is performing: before the noun = emotional article, after the noun = adjective.

The emotional indefinite article: *si'a*

Kuó ne lavea si'a tamasi'i?

Has a child been hurt? (poor thing)

Where the ordinary indefinite article *ha* is neutral (“a child”), *si'a* adds the same kind of emotional colouring as *si'i* but for indefinite nouns: “some poor child,” “some dear little one.”

Na'a nau 'omi ia ki 'api ke ne ma'u si'a me'atokoní.

They brought him home so he could have some food. (the poor fellow)

The speaker is not simply reporting a fact. The choice of *si’a* over *ha* reveals sympathy for the person being fed.

The relationship between the four articles forms a simple grid:

	Ordinary	Emotional
Definite	<i>e / he</i>	<i>si’i</i>
Indefinite	<i>ha</i>	<i>si’a</i>

Use *si’i* wherever you would use *e/he* but want to add feeling. Use *si’a* wherever you would use *ha* but want to add feeling.

Emotional definite possessive pronouns

Just as the ordinary articles have emotional counterparts, the ordinary possessive pronouns do too. These are the emotional definite possessives, built by prefixing *si’* to the regular possessive forms:

Person	’e-class	ho-class	Meaning
1sg	<i>si’eku</i>	<i>si’oku</i>	my (poor/dear)
2sg	<i>si’o</i>	<i>si’o</i>	your (poor/dear)
3sg	<i>si’ene</i>	<i>si’ono</i>	his/her (poor/dear)
1pl incl.	<i>si’etau</i>	<i>si’otau</i>	our (poor/dear)
1du incl.	<i>si’eta</i>	<i>si’ota</i>	our two (poor/dear)
1pl excl.	<i>si’emau</i>	<i>si’omau</i>	our (poor/dear)
1du excl.	<i>si’ema</i>	<i>si’oma</i>	our two (poor/dear)
2pl	<i>si’omou</i>	<i>si’omou</i>	your (poor/dear)
2du	<i>si’omo</i>	<i>si’omo</i>	your two (poor/dear)
3pl	<i>si’enau</i>	<i>si’onau</i>	their (poor/dear)

Person	'e-class	ho-class	Meaning
3du	<i>si'ena</i>	<i>si'ona</i>	their two (poor/dear)

These work exactly like the regular possessives you already know. The 'e-class/ho-class distinction follows the same rules: 'e-class for things you act upon or control, ho-class for things that characterise or shelter you. The only difference is the emotional layer.

'Oku nofo si'ene ta'ahine 'e taha 'iate au, ka kuó ne mālōlō si'ono foha 'e taha.

One of his poor little girls is staying with me, but one of his boys has passed away.

In this sentence, *si'ene* ('e-class) is used with *ta'ahine* (daughter), and *si'ono* (ho-class) is used with *foha* (son). The emotional possessive conveys the speaker's sympathy for the father whose children face hardship and loss.

'Oku tangi si'eku ki'i pēpē.

My poor little baby is crying.

Here *si'eku* ('e-class) expresses the speaker's tender feeling toward their own child.

Emotional indefinite possessive pronouns

The indefinite possessives also have emotional forms. These replace the ordinary indefinite possessives (*ha'aku*, *ha'ao*, *ha'ane*, etc.) and add the same emotional colouring:

Person	'e-class	ho-class	Meaning
1sg	<i>si'aku</i>	<i>si'aku</i>	my (poor/dear)
2sg	<i>si'ao</i>	<i>si'ao</i>	your (poor/dear)
3sg	<i>si'ane</i>	<i>si'ano</i>	his/her (poor/dear)
1pl incl.	<i>si'atau</i>	<i>si'atau</i>	our (poor/dear)

Person	'e-class	ho-class	Meaning
1du incl.	<i>si'ata</i>	<i>si'ata</i>	our two (poor/dear)
1pl excl.	<i>si'ama</i>	<i>si'ama</i>	our (poor/dear)
1du excl.	<i>si'ama</i>	<i>si'ama</i>	our two (poor/dear)
2pl	<i>si'amou</i>	<i>si'amou</i>	your (poor/dear)
2du	<i>si'amo</i>	<i>si'amo</i>	your two (poor/dear)
3pl	<i>si'anau</i>	<i>si'anau</i>	their (poor/dear)
3du	<i>si'ana</i>	<i>si'ana</i>	their two (poor/dear)

Notice that in the indefinite emotional possessives, the 'e-class and ho-class forms are identical for most persons. This is the same pattern as the ordinary indefinite possessives.

Na'e 'ikai si'ano faingamālie.

He never had a chance. (poor him)

Na'e 'ikai si'ane 'amanaki.

He had no idea. (poor him)

Both sentences use third-person singular emotional indefinite possessives. In the first, *si'ano* (ho-class) pairs with *faingamālie* (opportunity, something that comes to you). In the second, *si'ane* ('e-class) pairs with *'amanaki* (expectation, something you hold). The speaker's sympathy for the person is carried entirely by the possessive form.

Na'e 'ikai si'aku pa'anga ke fakatau mai ha me'akai.

I had no money to buy food. (said humbly, with self-pity)

Here the emotional indefinite possessive *si'aku* replaces the neutral *ha'aku*, adding a note of humility or self-deprecation.

The exclamatory idiom with *ka*

One fixed expression worth recognising uses the conjunction *ka* (but) between two *ko e* clauses to create an exclamation of magnitude:

Ko e tangi ka ko ha tangi!

What a tremendous cry!

The structure literally says: “It was a cry, but it was a cry!” The first clause uses *e* (semi-definite: it was a cry as opposed to a shout or a call). The second uses *ha* (indefinite: it was a cry singled out from all other cries). Together they produce emphasis: not just any cry, but an extraordinary one.

Ko e 'ofa ka ko ha 'ofa!

What a wonderful love!

Ko e momoko ka ko ha momoko!

It is terribly cold!

This idiom is common in spoken Tongan. Its force depends on the distinction between the semi-definite *e* (this kind of thing, as opposed to other kinds) and the indefinite *ha* (one of its kind, standing out from all others of the same kind).

Idiomatic *me'a* (exclamatory)

Me'a faka'ofa'ofa ko e haká.

The dance was a beautiful thing.

When something is remarkable or superlative, Tongan uses *me'a* (*thing*) followed by the appropriate modifier. The structure is *me'a* + modifier + *ko e* + noun. This construction conveys admiration, wonder, or emphasis.

Me'a mālie ko e hivá.

The song was a wonderful thing.

This is an evaluative idiom, not a literal statement about a “thing.” It is Tongan’s way of exclaiming about the quality of an experience.

Words to Learn

New grammar words (memorize how these work):

Tongan	Function	English
<i>si'i</i>	emotional article (definite)	the (with pity, affection, or humility) (also “small” (Ch 16))
<i>si'a</i>	emotional article (indefinite)	a (with pity or affection)
<i>si'eku</i>	emotional possessive ('e-class)	my (poor/dear)
<i>si'oku</i>	emotional possessive (ho-class)	my (poor/dear)
<i>si'o</i>	emotional possessive	your (poor/dear)
<i>si'ene</i>	emotional possessive ('e-class)	his/her (poor/dear)
<i>si'ono</i>	emotional possessive (ho-class)	his/her (poor/dear)
<i>si'etau</i>	emotional possessive ('e-class)	our (inclusive, poor/dear)
<i>si'otau</i>	emotional possessive (ho-class)	our (inclusive, poor/dear)
<i>si'emaui</i>	emotional possessive ('e-class)	our (exclusive, poor/dear)
<i>si'omau</i>	emotional possessive (ho-class)	our (exclusive, poor/dear)

Tongan	Function	English
<i>si'omou</i>	emotional possessive	your (plural, poor/dear)
<i>si'enau</i>	emotional possessive (‘e-class)	their (poor/dear)
<i>si'onau</i>	emotional possessive (ho-class)	their (poor/dear)

New vocabulary (memorize these meanings):

Tongan	Type	English
<i>faka’ofa’ofa</i>	adjective	beautiful, admirable
<i>afā</i>	noun	storm, cyclone
<i>faka’ofa</i>	adjective	miserable, wretched
<i>faingamālie</i>	noun	chance, opportunity
<i>pango</i>	noun/adjective	pity, pitiable
<i>foha</i>	noun	son

Exercises

Exercise 1: Translate Tongan to English

1. *'Oku tangi si'i pēpē 'a Mele.*
2. *Na'e 'ikai si'ane loto ke foki ki 'api.*
3. *Kuó ne lavea si'a tamasi'í?*
4. *'Oku nofo si'eku ki'i fānau 'iate ia.*
5. *Na'e 'ikai si'ano pa'anga ke totongi 'a e koloa ko iá.*
6. *Ko e māfana ka ko ha māfana!*

Exercise 2: Translate English to Tongan

1. The poor dog is hungry.
2. His dear mother is ill.
3. She had no food. (poor her)
4. My poor little child is tired.
5. Their unfortunate house was destroyed.
6. What a tremendous storm!

Exercise 3: Choose the correct emotional form

Select the appropriate emotional article or possessive for each blank.

1. 'Oku puke ___ foha 'o Sione. (Sione's poor son is sick.) (*si'i* / *si'a* / *si'ono*)
2. Na'e 'ikai ___ faingamālie ke ha'u. (She never had a chance to come.) (*si'ane* / *si'eno* / *si'ano*)
3. 'Oku fiefia ___ fānau 'a 'Ana. ('Ana's dear children are happy.) (*si'a* / *si'i* / *si'ene*)
4. Na'e 'ikai ___ me'atokoni ke kai. (They had no food to eat, poor them.) (*si'anau* / *si'enau* / *si'a*)
5. 'Oku hele'i ___ hōsí. (The poor horse is limping.) (*si'a* / *si'i* / *si'eno*)

Exercise 4: Transform neutral sentences to emotional

Rewrite each sentence replacing the ordinary article or possessive with the emotional equivalent.

1. 'Oku puke 'a e tamasi'í. → (the poor child is sick)
2. Na'e 'ikai ha'ane faingamālie. → (he never had a chance, poor him)
3. 'Oku tangi 'eku pēpē. → (my poor baby is crying)
4. Na'e mālōlō hono fa'ē. → (his poor mother passed away)
5. Na'e 'ikai ha'aku pa'anga. → (I had no money, said humbly)

Exercise 5: Identify the emotional force

For each sentence, explain whether the emotional form expresses pity, affection, humility, or endearment.

1. 'Oku hela si'i hōsí.

2. *Ko e fē si'i fānau 'a Pita?*
3. *Na'e 'ikai si'aku tohi ke lau.*
4. *'Oku tangi si'eku ki'i pēpē.*
5. *Na'e 'ikai si'ano faingamālie.*

Exercise 6: Translate into English

1. *Me'a mālie ko e haká.*
 2. *Me'a faka'ofa'ofa ko e ngāué.*
 3. *Me'a lelei ko e akó.*
 4. *Me'a mālie ko e va'ingá.*
 5. *Me'a faka'ofa'ofa ko e fakatahá.*
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Answers

Exercise 1

1. Mele's poor baby is crying.
2. He had no desire to return home. (poor him)
3. Has a child been hurt? (poor thing)
4. My dear little children are staying with him/her.
5. He had no money to pay for those goods. (poor him)
6. What tremendous warmth!

Exercise 2

1. *'Oku fiekaia 'a si'i kulií.*
2. *'Oku puke si'ono fa'ē.*
3. *Na'e 'ikai si'ane me'atokoni.*
4. *'Oku hela si'eku ki'i tamasi'í.*
5. *Na'e maumau si'onau falé.*
6. *Ko e afā ka ko ha afā!*

Exercise 3

1. *si'ono* (ho-class emotional definite possessive: son is a relative, ho-class)

2. *si'ano* (ho-class emotional indefinite possessive: opportunity comes to you, ho-class)
3. *si'i* (emotional definite article before a noun)
4. *si'anau* (emotional indefinite possessive, 3pl: “their,” used here because the possession is indefinite in a negative sentence)
5. *si'i* (emotional definite article: the specific horse)

Exercise 4

1. *'Oku puke 'a si'i tamasi'ŭ.*
2. *Na'e 'ikai si'ane faingamālie.*
3. *'Oku tangi si'eku pēpē.*
4. *Na'e mālōlō si'ono fa'ē.*
5. *Na'e 'ikai si'aku pa'anga.*

Exercise 5

1. **Pity.** The speaker feels sorry for the tired horse.
2. **Affection.** The speaker is asking about Pita's children with warmth and care.
3. **Humility.** The speaker is talking about their own lack (no book to read) with self-deprecation.
4. **Endearment.** The speaker is expressing tender feeling toward their own baby.
5. **Pity.** The speaker feels sorry for the person who never had a chance.

Exercise 6

1. The dance was a wonderful thing.
2. The work was a beautiful thing.
3. The studies were a good thing.
4. The game was a wonderful thing.
5. The gathering was a beautiful thing.